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Bible Knowledge

Form 1

Chapter 1

DIVISIONS OF THE BIBLE

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DIVISIONS OF THE BIBLE

OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, the student should be able to:

- 1.** state the meaning of the Bible
- 2.** identify divisions of the Bible
- 3.** identify the divisions of the books in the Old Testament
- 4.** name the divisions of the books in the New Testament

CONTENTS

- Meaning of the bible
- List books in the bible
- Classify books of the bible into
 - old testament
 - new testament
- identifying the divisions of the books of the Bible in the Old Testament and give examples of books for each division
 - Pentateuch books
 - Historical books
 - Wisdom books
 - Prophetic books
- identifying the divisions of books in the New Testament and give examples of book for each division
 - gospels
 - Letters
 - History
 - apocalyptic

The meaning of the bible

The word bible is derived from two words; ta Biblia in Latin which means books and biblos in Greek which means the book.

The bible can be defined in many ways such as;

- The bible is a library i.e. a collection of books about the word of God. there are many books in the bible different authors. This qualifies it to be called ta biblia in Latin which means books.
- However, the bible has got one main author who is god himself who inspired all authors to write what God himself would have written. this qualifies the bible to be called biblos in Greek which means the book
- The bible is therefore, the word of God
- The bible can also be defined as the holy book of the Christians religion consisting of the Old and New testament.

This is clearly expressed in 2 Timothy 3: 16-17 "All scriptures is inspired by God and is useful for teaching the truth, rebuking error, correcting faults, and giving instructions for right living, so that the person who serves God may be fully qualified and equipped to do every kind of good deed"

Divisions of the bible

The bible is divided into two main parts and each part is called testament.

- The two divisions are the Old Testament and the New Testament.
- The Old Testament has 39 books which the New Testament has 27 books.
- In total the bible has 66 books

Division of the Old Testament

- i. The Torah (the law) also known as the Pentateuch

- This division contains the laws of Israel.
- These include the first five books of the bible namely
 - Genesis
 - Exodus
 - Leviticus
 - Numbers
 - Deuteronomy
- ii. **Historical books**
 - This division contains the history of the Israelites. These books include;
 - Joshua
 - Judges
 - Samuel 1
 - Samael 2
 - 1 kings
 - 2 kings
 - I chronicles
 - 2 chronicles
 - Ezra
 - Nehemiah
 - Esther
- iii. **Wisdom books**
 - There are books that contain songs and words of wisdom for the Israelites Such as
 - Job
 - Psalms
 - Song of song s
 - Proverbs
 - Ecclesiastes
 - Prophetic books
- iv. **Prophetic Books**
 - These were books that were written by either major or minor writing prophets.
 - They are classified as major writing prophets or minor writing prophet depending on the length of the work they wrote
 - **Major prophets**

- Isaiah
- Jeremiah
- Lamentations
- Ezekiel
- **Daniel**
- **Minor prophe4ts**
- Hosea
- Jael
- Amos
- Obadia
- Jonah
- Micah
- Nahum
- Habakkuk
- Zephania
- Haggai
- Zecharia
- Malachi

Division of the New Testament

- There are four main divisions as well

i. The Gospels

- These contain the good news about Jesus' birth, life and ministry, death and resurrection. These are the first four books of the New Testament I e
- Mathew
- Mark
- Luke
- John

ii. History book

This is the book of that covers the events after the ascension of Christ i.e. the book of acts of apostles

iii. The letters or epistles

- These are letters of encouragement written by Paul and other apostles to Christ's follows for example
 - Roman s
 - Corinthians
 - 2 Corinthians
 - Galatians
 - Ephesians
 - Phillippians
 - Colossians
 - 1 Thessalonians
 - 2 Thessalonians
 - 1timothy
 - 2 timothy
 - Titus
 - Philemon
 - Hebrews
 - James
 - 1 Peter
 - 2 Peter
 - 1,2,3 john
 - Jude

iv. Apocalyptic (apocalypse)

- These contain wrings about the last days.
 - This book is Revelation

Note

The main different between the Old Testament and the New Testament is that

- the former was written before Christ and the later after Christ.
- There are 39 books in the Old Testament 27 in the New Testament
- Some of the books are not books in the actual sense of the word, but letters.

Unit reviewing questions

- Define the term 'bible'



- Explain how god communicate with people to day
- What biblical term is given to the following division:
 - (a)the first five books of the old testament
 - (b)the first four books of the new testament
 - (c)the last book in the bible
- List two examples of wisdom books
- Draw a tree diagram illustrating the division of the books of the bible in the old testament

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Bible Knowledge Form 1

Chapter 10

THE PROPHETS

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THE PROPHETS

OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, the student should be able to:

1. state the meaning of the term 'prophet'
2. analyse the work of prophets Elijah and Elisha
3. analyse the works of prophets Amos, Ezekiel and Haggai

CONTENTS

- Meaning of prophets
- roles of prophets
 - foretelling future events
 - advising
 - teaching the word of God
 - mediation
- Elijah and Elisha(pre-exilic)
 - narrating stories about Elijah and Elisha
 - discussing the works of Elijah and Elisha
 - comparing and contrasting the works of Elijah and Elisha
- Amos (pre-exilic), Ezekiel (exilic), Haggai (post-exilic)
 - discussing the messages of the prophets Amos, Ezekiel and Haggai
 - comparing and contrasting the works of the prophets, Amos (pre-exilic period), Ezekiel (exilic period) and Haggai (post-exilic period)

6.1 The Prophets and their roles

Meaning of the term prophet

The term prophet comes from the two Greek words: *pro* which means before and *phetes* which means to speak. Therefore, a prophet is a man

or a woman appointed by God to speak to the people on His behalf. This implies that a prophet knows the will of God.

Roles of prophets

- Teaching the word of God as God command them
- Foretelling what will happen in the future
- Advising the people on the will of God
- Acting as mediators between two conflicting parties
- Condemning moral and social evils, personal sins, oppression and injustice in society (Isaiah 1: 16 – 17; Amos 2:16 – 8)
- Etc., etc.

Do we have prophets today?

The answer is yes. However, some prophets are true and others are false prophets. A true prophet is the one chosen by God while a false prophet is self – made prophet. A true prophet is known by what he / she says and does

6.2 The Works of the Prophets Elijah and Elisha

Elijah the Prophet (1Kings 17: 1 – 24; 18, 19)

Elijah was a prophet of Yahweh. He appeared as a prophet in the Northern Kingdom during the reign of King Ahab of Israel (869 – 850 BC). As a king, Ahab was no better than Jeroboam who had ruled 60 years before him. He tolerated corruption and idolatry. Ahab married a Phoenician woman called Jezebel. Elijah was from Tishbe in Gilead.

Prophet Elijah and the drought (1 Kings 17: 1 – 24)

- Drought can be defined as a situation whereby an area experiences a prolonged dry spell (or no rain) for a year or more than that
- Elijah told Ahaz that there was going to be drought for two or three years until he said otherwise
- Then God asked Elijah to go and hide near the brook of Cherith, east of the Jordan
- The brook supplied water to Elijah and the ravens (birds) brought him bread and meat every morning and every evening

Elijah and the Widow of Zarephath

- After a while, the brook of Cherith went dry and God told Elijah to go to Zarephath a town near Sidon. God had commanded a widow who lived there to feed him
- Elijah went there and as he came to the gate of the town, he saw a widow gathering firewood
- Elijah asked her to give him water and bread
- The widow responded that she had no bread but a handful of flour in a bowl and a drop of olive oil in a jar – just enough to make bread for herself and her son. That would be their last meal and they would starve to death
- Elijah told her that she should make the first loaf for him and the rest for herself and the son
- Elijah went further saying God had told him that the widow's bowl will not run out of flour or the jar run out of oil before God himself sends rain
- The widow went and did as Elijah had told her, and the flour and the oil did not last. They had enough food for many days

One day the widow's son fell ill, he got worse and worse and finally he died. She said to Elijah, "Man of God, why did you do this to me? Did you come here to remind God of my sins and so cause my son's death?"

Elijah Raises the Son of the Widow. (1 Kings 17: 19 – 23)

- Elijah said, Give the boy to me
- He took the boy from her arms
- Carried him upstairs to the room where he was staying
- Laid him on the bed
- Then he prayed aloud
- O Lord my God, why have you done such a terrible thing to this widow?
- She has been kind enough to take care of me, and now you kill her son!
- Then Elijah stretched himself out on the boy three times

- And prayed, O Lord my God, restore this child to life
- The Lord answered Elijah's prayer
- The child started breathing again and revived
- Elijah took the boy downstairs to his mother and said to her, Look, your son is alive
- She answered, "Now I know that you are a man of God and that Lord really speaks through you."

Elijah and the Prophets of Baal (1Kings 18: 1 – 40)

Through the years of drought, Elijah was expecting to see if Ahab and Israel would repent. But instead of repenting, Ahab blamed Elijah for the drought and wanted to kill him. During this time, some of Yahweh's prophets were killed by Jezebel. Those who survived escaped into the wilderness and were kept alive by Obadiah. Obadiah was in charge of the palace but a devout worshipper of the Lord. He took a hundred of prophets of the Lord and hid them in caves in two groups of 50 each and provided them with food and water.

As Ahab and Obadiah were looking for grass, but in different places, to keep the horses and the mules alive, Obadiah met Elijah and recognized him. Elijah told Obadiah that he was going to meet the king the next day.

King Ahab meets Prophet Elijah (1Kings 18: 16 – 24)

- King Ahab met Elijah and recognized him as a trouble maker. King Ahab said, "So there you are – the worst trouble maker in Israel!"
- Prophet Elijah denied being a trouble maker but he said the trouble maker of Israel was the king himself and his father because they were disobeying God's commands and worshipping the idols of Baal

The contest on Mount Carmel

- Prophet Elijah asked King Ahab to assemble all the people of Israel for him on Mount Carmel together with 450 prophets of Baal and 400 prophets of the goddess Asherah who were supported by Jezebel

- These were to provide two bulls. One was to be prepared by them, and laid on the wood as for sacrifice but no fire was to be set. Elijah was also to prepare the other bull and put it on the wood without setting it on fire
- The prophets of Baal were to call upon their god, and Elijah was to call upon the name of his God. The God who would respond with fire would prove that He was the true God
- The prophets of Baal called on their gods to send fire but there was no response. Then Elijah mocked them saying
 - Pray louder! He is a god
 - May be he is daydreaming or relieving himself
 - Or perhaps he has gone on a journey
 - Or maybe he is sleeping and you've got to wake him up!
- They prayed louder and cut themselves with daggers but there was no response
- Elijah on his part prayed and fire from God came down and burnt the sacrifice
- The people shouted that Yahweh was God
- Yahweh's power was seen and Elijah commanded that the false prophets be killed
- And the drought ended on that day.

Elijah on Mount Sinai) 1Kings 19: 1 – 19)

Ahab told his wife Jezebel about what had happened at Mount Carmel. She was not convinced and got furious especially when she learnt about the killing of the false prophets. She vowed to kill Elijah in their revenge. When Elijah learnt about the plot, he fled for his life to the wilderness of Beersheba in the kingdom of Judah.

Then God told Elijah to go to Mount Sinai, the Holy Mountain of God. It was at this mountain where God had revealed Himself to Moses and where the covenant had been made. While on this mountain Elijah experienced the presence of God like Moses. God appeared to him neither in the earthquake, wind nor lightning but in the soft whisper of a voice

When Elijah heard the voice, he covered his face with his cloak and went out of the cave and stood at the entrance of the cave. The Lord said, "Return to the wilderness near Damascus, then enter the city and anoint Hazael as King of Syria, anoint Jehu as King of Israel and anoint Elisha son of Shaphat from Abel Meholah to succeed you as prophet..." These two kings were to bring judgement on Ahab's family.

Reasons why Elijah faced danger and hostility

- He confronted king Ahab and many Israelites concerning their worship of Canaanite god (Baal)
- He challenged the Israelites against corruption which had then become widespread
- He prophesied about drought which struck the land of Israel since Ahab and the Israelites refused to change from the corrupt ways

The Relevance of Elijah's message to Christians today

- Modern times are full of corruption and worship of idols which is wrong. Like Elijah, we should be strong in faith and not shut our eyes to the evils, but should try to end them
- Corruption which existed during the time of Elijah still exists today. The sins of jealousy, hatred and greed lead to corrupt dealings and actions, for example, lying, stealing and murder. So whenever we face corruption, we should remember the Ten Commandments given to Moses at Mount Sinai
- To become like Elijah we need to be attentive to God's voice. Elijah listened and obeyed God and God used him
- Christians should pray constantly when in problems like Elijah did, and should speak out for the rights of the poor, discourage bearing of false witness like in Jezebel's case and let God deal with sinners.
- Like Elijah we should be ready to carry out the task given to us even in dangerous moments

The Call of Elisha (1Kings 19 – 21)

Background

Elisha's father was a wealthy farmer, a man whose household was among those who had never bowed to Baal. Theirs was a home where God was honoured. Elisha was well disciplined and brought up in the life of simplicity and obedience to his parents and God. This prepared him for the high position he was to occupy

The Call of Elisha

As soon as God had commanded Elijah to anoint Elisha as his successor

- Elijah left and found Elisha ploughing with a team of oxen
- There were eleven teams ahead of him
- And he was ploughing with the last one
- Elijah took off his cloak and put it on Elisha
- Elisha then left his oxen, ran after Elijah, and said
- Let me kiss my father and mother goodbye
- And then I will go with you
- Elijah answered, "All right, go back I'm not stopping you!"
- Then Elisha went to his team of oxen, killed them
- And cooked the meat using the yoke as fuel for the fire
- He gave the meat to the people, and they ate it
- Then he went and followed Elijah as his helper.

Note

- When Elijah took off his cloak (mantle) and put it on Elisha, Elisha understood the gesture as a call to discipleship
- Elisha burnt the plough equipment to prevent any thought of ever returning to this occupation
- His slaughtering of oxen and giving the meat to the people meant that they ate and blessed him, as they gave him best wishes for his new job

Elijah is Taken up to Heaven (2 kings 2: 1 – 18)

- The time came for the Lord to take Elijah up to heaven in a whirlwind

- Elijah and Elisha set out from Gilgal and on the way Elijah asked Elisha to stay there for the Lord had ordered him to go to Bethel. Elisha refused to leave Elijah and so they went to Bethel
- The same thing happened at Bethel and Jericho. Then they went together to River Jordan
- When the prophets were asking Elisha if he knew that the Lord was going to take his master away from him that day, Elisha responded by saying , "Yes I know but let's not talk about it"
- When they arrived at the River Jordan, Elijah and Elisha stood by the river, and the 50 prophets who accompanied them from Jericho stood a short distance away
- Then Elijah took off his cloak, rolled it up, and struck the water with it, the water divided, and he and Elisha crossed to the other side on dry ground.
- There Elijah asked Elisha what he wanted Elijah to do for him before he was taken away
- Elisha answered, "Let me receive the share of your power that will make me your successor.
- Elijah said, "This is a difficult request to grant. But you will receive it if you see me as I am being taken away from you. If you don't see me, you won't receive it."

How Elijah was taken up

- They kept talking as they walked on; the suddenly a chariot of fire pulled by horses of fire came between them, and Elijah was taken up to heaven by whirlwind. Elisha saw it and cried out to Elijah, "My father, my father! Mighty defender of Israel! You are gone!" And he never saw Elijah again
- So Elijah was taken directly into heaven by the Lord in a chariot of fire that appeared as a whirlwind. Elisha was left to carry on with the work that Prophet Elijah had begun

Elisha Cures Naaman (2 Kings 5: 1 – 27)

Elisha continued serving God after the departure of Elijah. He performed many miracles including healing Naaman

Naaman and the Israelite Girl

Naaman was the commander of the Syrian army. He was loved by the king of Syria, but he was suffering from a dreaded skin disease (leprosy). He was a great soldier and through him the Lord had given victory to the Syrian forces.

In one of their raids against Israel, the Syrians had carried off a little Israelite girl, who became a servant of Naaman's wife. One day she said to her mistress, "I wish that my master could go to the prophet who lives in Samaria; he would cure him of the disease." When Naaman heard this he went to the king and told him what the girl had said. The king gave him permission to go to the king of Israel with the letter which he wrote to him. The letter that Naaman took read, "This letter will introduce my officer Naaman. I want you to cure him of his disease."

King of Israel received the Letter from the King of Syria through Naaman

Upon receiving the letter, the king of Israel had no idea on what to do when he read the letter. He was sure that the king of Syria was looking for an excuse to start a war. In desperation, he tore his clothes. Unlike the slave girl, he either did not know or did not believe that prophets in Israel could cure the dreaded skin disease (leprosy)

Elisha's Intervention

When the man of God, Elisha, heard what had happened, he came to the King's rescue and invited Naaman to himself. So that he could appreciate that there is a prophet in Israel. "Why are you so upset? Send the man to me and I will show you that there is a prophet in Israel" (2Kings 5:8) Elisha took this as an opportunity that other countries should know God.

When Naaman arrived at Elisha's home, Elisha did not even bother to meet Naaman. Instead he sent his servant (Gehazi) to tell him to go and wash himself seven times in the River Jordan, and he would be completely cured of his disease.

Naaman's reaction

Naaman left in rage, saying

- "I thought that he would at least come out to me, pray to the Lord his God
- Wave his hand over the diseased spot, and cure me!
- Besides, aren't the rivers Abana and Pharpar, back in Damascus, better than any river in Israel? I could have washed in them and been cured!"

Possibly Naaman reacted in this way because he was an important official and was used to be treated with great respect, so he was angry to receive so little care and attention

People's Thoughts are not the Thoughts of God

Naaman wanted to design God's salvation to suit him as it is the case nowadays. The message of salvation sounds like foolishness to those who are sinning. God had said that he would heal Naaman if he bathed the River Jordan. Naaman would not have been healed if he had bathed in another river.

Naaman is healed

His servants went to Naaman and said, "Sir, if the prophet had told you to do something difficult, you would have done it. Now why can't you just wash yourself, as he said, and be cured?" Following this, Naaman was humble enough to swallow his pride. He went down to the Jordan, dipped himself in it seven times, as Elisha had instructed and he was completely cured. His flesh became firm and healthy, like that of the child.

Reactions of Naaman after he got healed

He went to Elisha, this time he met the prophet and said that he was convinced that there is one God, and this is the God of Israel. He offered some gifts to Elisha, but Elisha denied any gift from Naaman.

Then he took some soil from Israel to his country and declared that he would be worshipping God only. Naaman was aware that if one worships God he / she should not worship other gods. However, looking at the nature of his job (commander of the Syrian army), he would be

accompanying the king of Syria to the shrine of their god Rimmon and bow down with their officials. He made it clear that he would not be able to avoid doing that, even though he was a believer in the God of Israel

Spiritual Growth is Gradual (Slow but Sure)

Elisha understood Naaman's problem and assured him of a pardon by saying, "Go in peace." In saying this, Elisha was not accepting that Rimmon was worthy of worshipping but was recognizing Naaman's level of spiritual growth. When we deal with people, it is important to remember that spiritual growth is gradual and that we should not expect perfection as soon as someone comes to faith.

The sin of Gehazi (greed)

Gehazi was a servant of Elisha and was not happy seeing Naaman going without paying anything to Elisha. He gave in to greed and ran after Naaman, told him a lie and got himself some gifts. Gehazi asked Naaman to give him three thousand pieces of silver and two changes of fine clothes. Naaman instead gave him six thousand pieces of silver and two changes of fine clothes.

Elisha's reaction to Gehazi's greed

Elisha told Gehazi that it was wrong to collect money from Naaman. "... this is not the time to accept money and clothes, olive groves and vineyards, sheep and cattle,

or servants." Elisha then told Gehazi that since he took money from Naaman, he had also taken his disease of leprosy. "And now Naaman's disease will come upon you and your descendants will have it forever!" (2Kings 5: 27). This happened that way.

Note that Gehazi was punished because of his greed. Even today, greed is costing people a lot. We hear stories of people stealing money from public coffers and companies and they end up being imprisoned. All these happen because of greed.

6.3 The Prophet Amos in the Pre – exilic Period

Amos and Amaziah (Amos 7: 10 – 15)

Bethel was the main place of religious activities in Israel. It was established by Jeroboam, to prevent the people from the North from going to Jerusalem for their religious festivals. Associated with Bethel was gold bull worship. It was here that Amos, from the Southern Kingdom, went to do his prophetic duties. Amaziah was the priest at Bethel. He was in good terms with King Jeroboam of Israel.

Amos' Message to the People of Israel

Amos called for justice to flow like a stream in Israel. He said that if the people do not listen they will be taken into exile

Amaziah's report to Jeroboam

Amaziah the priest sent a report to king Jeroboam that

- Amos is plotting against you among the people
- His speeches will destroy the country
- This is what he says
- Jeroboam will die in battle
- And the people of Israel will be taken away from their land into exile

Note that Amaziah suppressed part of Amos' message. He reported only the judgement and not the reasons for the judgement.

Reaction of Amaziah to Amos' message

Then Amaziah said to Amos: "that's enough, prophet! Go back on to Judah and do your preaching there. Let them pay you for it. Don't prophesy here at Bethel any more. This is the king's place of worship, the national Temple."

Amos' reaction to Amaziah warning

Amos answered that he was not a kind of prophet who prophesied for pay. He said that he was a herdsman and was taking care of fig trees. But the Lord took him from his work as a shepherd and ordered him to come and prophesy to his people Israel

Amos announced doom for Amaziah and Israel

Amos said to Amaziah that since you tell to stop prophesying, to stop raving against the people of Israel, the Lord says to you

- Your wife will become a prostitute on the streets
- Your children will be killed in war
- Your land will be divided upon and given to others
- You yourself will die in a heathen country
- And the people of Israel will be taken away from their own land into exile.
-

1.4 THE PROPHET EZEKIEL IN EXILIC PERIOD

Ezekiel was prophet who worked in exile in Babylon. The Israelites were taken into exile as a punishment from God for their sins. They stayed in exile for about 50 years. Later, God sent the prophet to tell them that their punishment was over and they should go back to their country. One of those prophet who brought the message of hope to the exile was Ezekiel. Before he was called to be a prophet, Ezekiel served as a priest. As a prophet his mission was to

- Explain the reasons for the captivity.
- Foretell Jerusalem's fall.
- Bring the exiled people back to God.
- Give the people hope through God's promise of restoration.

THE VISION OF THE VALLEY OF DRY BONES {EZEKIEL 37:1-28}

By the Holy Spirit, Ezekiel saw in a vision a valley full of bones which were very dry. God asked him "mortal man can these bones come back to life?" he replied "Sovereign, Lord only you can answer that" God said

Prophecy to the bones: "tell these dry bones to listen to the word of the lord. Tell them that, I the sovereign lord am saying to them. I am going to put breath in to you and bring you back to life. I will give you sinews and muscles, and cover you with skin. I will put

breath into you and bring you back to life. Then you will know that I am the Lord”

So Ezekiel prophesied as he was instructed. While he was speaking, he heard a rattling noise, and the bones began to join together. While he watched, the bones were covered with sinews and muscles and then with skin. But there was no breath to the bodies.

God said to Ezekiel, “Mortal man, prophesy to the wind. Tell the wind that the sovereign Lord commands it to come from every direction, to breathe into these dead bodies, and to bring them back to life.”

Ezekiel prophesied as was told. Breath entered the bodies, and they came to life and stood up. They were enough of them to form an army.

God Explains the Meaning of the Vision

God said to Ezekiel, “Mortal man the people of Israel are like these bones. They say that they are dried up, without any hope and with no future (while in exile)., so prophesy to my people Israel and tell them that I the sovereign Lord, am going to open their graves, I am going to take them out and bring them back to the land of Israel ... I will put my breath in them, bring them back to life, and let them live in their own land. Then they will know that I am the Lord...”

Note that the bones were raised to life in two stages. The two stages stood for:

- Political restoration to the land and
- A spiritual restoration to faith (Ezekiel 37: 9 – 10)

The vision was given to assure the exiles that they would be restored by God’s power and again become a living community in the Promised Land, in spite of their hopeless circumstances

Judah and Israel in one kingdom (Ezekiel 37: 15 – 28)

Ezekiel was told by God to

- Take two sticks and write on one stick:” The Kingdom of Judah” and on the other, “The kingdom of Israel”

- Hold the two sticks end to end in his hand so that they look like one stick.

Meaning

- God will rescue his people from exile, unite them and bring them back to their own land
- They will no longer be divided into two kingdoms
- They will be my people and I will be their God
- They will live on the land I gave to my servant Jacob and will be under one ruler
- I will establish them and increase their population
- I will place my temple there to be among them

1.5 Prophet Haggai in Post – Exilic Period

When the Jews returned from the exile in Babylon, they constructed the foundation of the Temple and then abandoned the construction. They were busy building their houses instead of building the Temple. Because they did not build the Temple, they had a lot of problems. The prophet Haggai was sent by God to tell the people that they should rebuild the Temple.

God commands to Rebuild the Temple. (Haggai 1: 1 - 15)

- When Darius was a governor of Persia, God sent Haggai to the returned Israelites with this message
- The people are saying this is not the right time to rebuild the Temple but it's not true
- People are busy building their houses while neglecting the Temple
- The people are experiencing poor harvest because they are not rebuilding the Temple
- Prophet Haggai delivered the message to two officials namely: Zerubbab, the governor of Judah and Josiah, the high priest
- When the people got the message, they obeyed the message and rebuilt the Temple

The Glory of the New Temple (Haggai 2: 1 – 9)



There was a general observation that the New Temple was not as beautiful as the Old one, which was built by King Solomon. Much as that was true, the new Temple was part of God's plan to establish his presence on the earth for the benefit of all nations. The prophet advised the people that they should not worry that their Temple is a poor one, for if God wanted a temple like that of King Solomon, he could have arranged that people should construct a temple similar to that since all the wealth of the earth belong to God

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Bible Knowledge Form 1

Chapter 2

TYPES OF LITERARY FORMS OF THE BIBLE

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TYPES OF LITERARY FORMS OF THE BIBLE

OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, the student should be able to:

1. describe types of literary forms of the Bible

CONTENTS

- identifying and describe the types of literary forms of the Bible
 - narratives
 - Poetry
 - Songs
 - Oracles
 - parables

Literary forms of the bible

- This is the literature text
- As such just like other literature books it is filled with many kinds or types of language
- It has narratives, poetry, songs, oracles, and parables among other literary forms

(a)narratives

- Narratives are account (stories) of what happed in the past about nation or a person.
- This is the most comm0n literary6 form in the bible since god acts in the arena of human history

Examples of narratives are

- The story of Jacob and Laban
- The story of Israel's deliverance from Egypt
- The congest of Canaan

- How Solomon built the temple

significance of narratives

- They pass on history from one generation
- One is able to deduce that God controls human history

(b) Poetry

- Poetry is the collection of poems. It promotes the listener leader's imagination or emotion in so doing it is the most effective way of communicating Gods message
- Although some books are fully poetry. e.g. Psalms, song of songs, Lamentation; a large portion of the prophetic literature (e.g. most of Isaiah, Jeremiah, Hosea, Joel, Amos, Micah, obadiah, Nahum) contain poetry.

(c) songs

- A song of short piece of music with words that you sing
- The songs are used convey messages to the Almighty God

Significance of poetry songs: They are used for

- Praising God
- Entertaining people during ceremonies
- Conveying messages to the authorities
- Composing songs

(d) oracles

- An oracle simply means a speech, delivered by a human being, that claims to be a message from god
- Oracles are prophecies made on behalf of god
- They are normally warning issued to people on what would happen in the future because of disobeying god
- They are used to predict the future
- Normally they begin with "the Lord says... or end with the Lord has spoken. e.g. Isaiah 1:18,6,8,40:1.

Significance of oracle

- They are used by god to address his people

(e) Parables

- A parable is imaginary story with some teaching about the Kingdom of God
- A parable is normally used to teach a truth or to answer a question
- The lesson in a parable is usually made at the end.

Significance of parable

- Attracts the attention of the listening
- Listeners understand the message easily
- Listeners remember the message easily
- Avoids debates and discussions

Unit reviewing questions

- Briefly explain any three literary forms in the bible
- List two examples of each of the following literary form in the bible
 - (1) poetry and songs
 - (2) parables

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Bible Knowledge Form 1

Chapter 3

THE PATRIARCHS

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THE PATRIARCHS

OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, the student should be able to:

1. explain the meaning of the term 'Patriarch'
2. describe important events in the lives of the patriarchs
3. discuss the Hebrews' slavery in Egypt
4. narrate the call of Moses
5. describe the work of Moses

CONTENTS

- meaning of the patriarch
- identify the patriarch
 - Abraham
 - Isaac
 - Jacob
 - Joseph
- discussing the important events in the lives of the patriarchs
- Moses
 - discussing the Hebrews' slavery in Egypt
 - discussing the call of Moses
 - discussing the work of Moses
 - Miracles in Egypt
 - Crossing the Red Sea

2.1 Abraham as the Patriarch

Meaning of patriarchs

- Literary patriarchs refer to the great great grandparents of a particular group of people
- A patriarch is a male head of the family or community that people have a lot of respect for
- The opposite patriarch is matriarch with a female head of the family or community

Note

- In the bible the patriarchs refer to biblical figures regarded as fathers/ ancestors of the Jewish race
- These patriarchs are Abraham, Isaac, Jacob and Joseph.
- They are identified as the ancestors of the Jewish because of two reasons:
 - (1) their physical link as a family
 - (2) the promises God made to these men when the foundations of the nation of Israel
- E.g. to Abram God said I will bless, give you and many observable important events in the lives of the patriarch include; (see p.9-10)

Gods call to Abraham

Abraham`s historical background (Genesis 11:27-32)

Abraham`s father was Terah, an Amorite who lived in Ur. Abram`s brothers were Nahor and Haran. Haran was Lot`s father and died in Ur. Abram married Sarai and she was not able to bear children. They lived in Ur in Babylon.

The people of Ur including the family of Terah worshipped the moon and gave human sacrifices. For example, after the king's death, household helpers or the king's wives would be sacrificed during the funeral ceremony.

When the Elamites suppressed the worship of moon and human sacrifices, Terah moved out of Ur in Babylon and went to settle in Haran in northern Mesopotamia where the worship of moon was possibly accepted. Terah died of Haran of the age of 205

Gods call to Abraham 12: 1-9

The Lord appeared to Abraham and said

- Leave your country, your relatives and your father's home
- And go to a land I am going to show you
- I will give you many descendant s who would become a great nation.
- I will bless you and make your name famous
- I will bless those who bless you and
- I will curse those who course you

How did Abram respond to the call?

- At the age of 75 years, Abram left from Haran to Canaan.
- He took with him Sarai his wife, Lot his nephew, all his slaves and the wealth he had required in Haran
- Note when they arrived at Shechem (at the sacred tree of Moreh|), the Lord appears to him and said "this the country that I am going to give to your descendants "he built an alter there

Abrams acts of faith

- When God called Abraham and asked to leave his home and go to an unknown land he obeyed
- When told him that he would have a child in hid old age, he believed
- Abraham also showed faith in God by getting circumcised and doing the same to his son Isaac
- When god sked him to offer his son as a sacrifice, he obeyed

Hagar and Ishmael (Genesis 16:1-16)

Historical background

Sarai, Abrahams wife was barren and could not have children. This forced Sarai to ask Abram to have sexual intercourse with her Egyptian slave girl, named Hagar with an intention that Sarai and Abraham could have a child through her, according to their tradition and customs.

The birth of Ishmael

- Abram had intercourse with Hagar and she became pregnant
- When she found that she was pregnant, she became proud and despised Sarai
- In retaliation, Sarai treated Hagar so cruelly that she run away

The angel of God meet Hagar 16:7-16

- The angel met Hagar at a spring in the desert on the road to Shur.
- The angel said, "Hagar, slave of Sarai where have you come from and where are you going?"
- She answered "I am running away from my mistress"
- He said "go back and be her slave"
- I will give you many descendants
- You are going to have a son and you will name him Ishmael because God has heard your cry of distress

What did the angel say concerning Ishmael?

- He will live like a wild donkey
 - He will be against everyone
 - Every one risky be against him
 - He will live apart from all his relatives
- Hagar called the Lord who had spoken to her "A God who sees"

She events back and bore Abram a son. she named him Ishmael. Abram was 86 years old at the time

Think ??

How dangerous can this practice be to Malawians today?

The covenant

- Covenant is a legally agreement based on faith between two parties.
- In a covenant both parties have a duty to perform
- This is because a covenant usually consists of a promise, a sign and a ceremony
- Thus if one party fails to perform its duty the other party is also legally accepted not to fulfil its duty

The covenant between God and Abram

- When abeam was 99 years old, the Lord appeared to him and said
- I am the Almighty God, obey me and always do what is right
- I will make my covenant with you and give you many descendants
- Abraham bowed down with face touching the ground.
- I will make this covenant with you: I promise that you will be the ancestor of many nations
- Your name will no longer be Abram, but Abraham
- Because I am making you ancestor of many nations

Promises to Abraham

- I will give you many descendants
- Some of them will be kings
- You will have so many Descendant s that they will become nations

Duties and promises

- I will keep my promise to you and to your descendants in future generations as an everlasting covenant.
- I will be your God and the God of your descendant
- I will give to you and to your descendants, this land in which you are now a foreigner
- The whole land of Canaan will belong to your descendant's forever

Appeal to Abram to observe circumcision as a sign of the covenant.

God said to Abraham

- You must also agree to keep the covenant with me
- Both you and your descendants in future generation

- you and your descendant must all agree to circumcise every male among you
- From now on you must circumcise every baby boy when he is eight days old
- Circumcision will be a physical sign to show that there was a covenant between Abraham and his descendant

God asked Abraham to change his wife's name

- God said Sarai should be called Sarah because she would be a mother of nations
- A son was promised to Sarah through an angel and his name would be Isaac
- Upon hearing this Abraham laughed because he could not believe that a man of 100 years (Abraham) could impregnate of a woman of ninety (Sarah)
- God assured Abraham that it would be possible and his son would be Isaac, Isaac means laughter
- God emphasized that he would fulfil his covenant through Isaac and not Ishmael

Gods message to Abraham about Ishmael

- God will bless him and give him many descendants
- He will be father of twelve princes
- God will make a great nation of his descendant

The Abraham reaction to covenant

Abraham obeyed God's covenant and on that day he circumcised himself, Ishmael and all other males in his household. Abraham was 99 years old and Ishmael was 13 years old

2.2 Isaac the Second Patriarch

The birth of Isaac (Genesis 21:1-8)

- The Lord blessed Sarah and she became pregnant
- She bore a son to Abraham and Abraham named Isaac which means laughter)

- When Isaac was eight day old Abraham circumcised him as God had commanded
- Abraham was 100 years old when Isaac was born

Reaction of Sarah

She said "God has brought me joy and laughter. Everyone who hears about it will laugh with me

Hagar and Ishmael are sent away (Genesis 21:9-21)

- One day Sarah asked Abraham to send Hagar and Ishmael way
- This was because Sarah did want Ishmael to get any part of Abraham's wealth, which Isaac should inherit

God said to Abraham

- Don't be worried about the boy and your slave
- Do whatever Sarah tells you
- It is through Isaac that you will have descendants I have promised
- I will also give many children to the son of the slave woman, so that they will become a nation he two is your son

Hagar and Ishmael in the desert of Beersheba

- They run out water and water
- Hagar left the child under a bush and sat down about a hundred metres away
- I can't bear to see my child die and she began to cry
- God heard the boy crying and from heaven the angels spoke to Hagar
- Why are troubled about Hagar
- Don't be afraid, God has heard the boy crying
- Get up go and pick him up and comfort him
- I will make a great nation out of his descendants
- God open her eyes and she saw a well
- She went and filled the leather bag with water and gave some to the boy
- God was with the boy as he grew up, he lived in the wilderness of Paran

- He became a skillful hunter
- His mother found an Egyptian wife for him

SACRIFICE

Sacrifice in the Old Testament was understood as killing an animal and burn it as an offering to God

An altar was used to make a sacrifice.

God commands Abraham to offer Isaac as a sacrifice (Genesis.22:1-19)

Background

After Isaac was born, Abraham possibly began to wonder whether his new God was like the gods of

the moon worshippers who always wanted something in return. Since God has blessed Abraham with a son- Isaac in his age, would be also want something in return?

Then

God tested Abrahams faith by asking him to offer Isaac as sacrifice to God

Abraham responded positively by taking Isaac to the land of Moriah to offer him as a sacrifice

God said to Abraham

- Take your only son Isaac to the land of Moriah and offer him as a sacrifice
- Next day Abraham took firewood, a knife and live coals of fire together with Isaac and two servants and went to the land of Moriah
- It took 3 days for Abraham to reach the land the Moriah
- When they reached the land of Moriah. Abraham said to his servants "stay here with the donkey.
- The boy and I will go over there and worship and the will came back to you
- Abraham carried a knife and live coals for starting fire
- He asked Isaac to carry wood

- On their way to sacrifice, Isaac realized that an animal for sacrifice was missing.
- then he asked to his father:
- "father I see that you the coal and the wood but where is the lamb for the sacrifice?"
- In this answering, Abraham said "God himself will provide one."
- When they reach the place where God told Abraham to offer Isaac
- Abraham built an altar and arranged wood on it.
- Abraham tied Isaac and placed him on wood on an altar.
- Then he picked up the knife to kill him

(a) relate God reaction and promises to Abraham.

(b) what did Abraham offer and what was his reaction.

(c) what was the purpose of God test to Abraham?

(d) if you were Isaac how would you feel about your father.

LOOKING FOR A WIFE.

- Everywhere in the world people are free to get married.
- The constitution of the republic of Malawi section 22 unit 3 says "all men and woman have the right to marry and found a family."
- There are different ways of getting a wife /husband to marry.
- The most common ways are direct or indirect approach or even arranged marriages etc.

A WIFE FOR ISAAC (Genesis 24:1-9)

- Abraham wanted his son Isaac to get married to a wife from his home village
- He did not want Isaac to get married to Canaanite women
- By this time Abraham was very old and to fulfil this, Abraham called his oldest servants –Eliezer- who was in charge of all that he had.
- He asked the servant to make a vow before God that he would help Abraham to get a wife for Isaac from Haran among Abraham's relatives.
- The servant placed his hands in Abraham's thighs and made vow.

Abraham's servant goes to Haran. (Genesis 24:10-31)

The servant took ten of his master's camels and went to the city where Nahor lived in northern Mesopotamia. When he arrived, he made the camel kneel down at the well outside the city. And he prayed

- Lord God of master, Abraham
- Give me success today
- And keep your promise to my master
- Here I am at the well where the young women of the city will be coming to get water.
- I will say to one of them please, lower your jar and let me have a drink.
- If she says, drink and I will also water your camels, may she be the one you have chosen for Isaac.
- If this happens, I will know that you have kept your promise to your master.

The servant and Rebecca

- Before the servant finished praying.
- Rebecca arrived with a jar of water on her shoulder.
- When the servant asked her for water.
- Rebecca responded exactly in way the servant had prayed.
- When she had finished, the man took an expensive gold ring and put it on her nose and put two gold bracelets on his arm

Then the servant asked who she was.

- I am Rebecca, the daughter of Bethuel son of Nahor and Milcah (Nahor was the brother of Abraham)
- The servant knelt down and worshipped the Lord for leading him straight to him master's relatives
- Rebecca ran to her mother's house and narrated the whole story
- Then Laban (Rebecca's brother) ran off to the well where the servant was.

Laban welcomed the servant 24:31-32

- Laban welcomed the servant and invited him to go to his home

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- The man went into the house and Laban unloaded the camels
- Then
 - he gave camels straw and folder.
 - He brought water for the servant and his men to wash their feet
 - He gave them food
- However, the servant said, he would not eat until he had said the purpose of his visit
- Laban allowed him to do so
- Then the servant introduce himself as the servant of Abraham
- He told them that God had blessed Abraham with riche and a son
- My master asked one to make a vow to find a wife for his non among his relatives
- When I arrived at the well, I prayed for the success of my mission and he cited the prayer to them and how it was fulfilled
- Laban and Bethuel answered since this matter comes from the lord, it is not for us to make a decision
- Here is Rebecca, take her and go. Let her become the wife of your master's son
- The servant knelt down and worshipped the lord and gave them gift such as;
 - Clothing
 - Silver
 - Gold jewelry
 - Expensive gifts to Laban and her mother

Then

- The servant¹ and the men ate the food and drank and spent the night there.
- The following day the servant asked Rebecca`s parents to let them go
- The parents asked Rebecca if she was ready to go or to spend a few day and say goodbye to her friends first
- She told them she was ready
- So before she left the parents blessed her
 - May you sister, become the mother of millions

- May your descendants conquer the cities of their enemies
- Then they started off
- They found Isaac in the field in the wilderness of the well of the living one who sees me?
- When Rebecca learnt that he was Isaac, she covered her face with scarf and was taken into his house and she became his wife
- Isaac was comforter for the loss of his mother.
- Abraham died at the age of 175 and was buried at Machpelah cave

2.3 Jacob as the Third Patriarch

The Birth of Esau and Jacob 25:19- 35

- Isaac was 40 years old when he married Rebecca
- Like Sarai Rebecca was beautiful and also barren
- Isaac prayed to the lord for her
- And Rebecca become pregnant
- She was going to have twins
- Before they were born they struggled against each other in her womb
- She said, why should something like this happen to me?
- The lord answered her
- Two nations are within you
- You will give birth to two rival peoples
- One will be stronger than the other
- The older will serve the younger.
- When time came to give birth, she had twin sons
- The first one was nerdish and his skin was like a hairy robe
- So he was named Esau
- The second one was born holding on tightly to the heel of Esau
- So he was named Jacob (

Note

- Isaac was 60-year-old when the boys were born
- The two nations within Rebecca's womb are
 - i. Israelites (Jacob`s descendants)
 - ii. Edomite's (Esau's descendants}
- The order child (Esau will serve the younger (Jacob)

Their boyhood

Esau grew up as hunter and was loved most by Isaac because he enjoyed eating the meat he brought. Jacob was quiet and mostly in doors and was loved most by her mother (Rebecca) because he used to assist in the household chores.

Esau sells his right as the first born son gen 25;27-34

- One day while Jacob was cooking some bean says
- Esau came in from hunting
- He was hungry and said Jacob
- I'm starving; give me some of that red stuff (that is why he was a called Edom)
- Jacob answered, 'I will give you it to you if you give me your right as the first born son
- Esau said "all right! I am about to die; what good will my might do me... then?"
- Jacob answered "first make a view that you will give me your right"
- Esau made the vow and gave him right to Jacob
- Then Jacob gave him some bread and some of the soup
- He ate and drunk and then got up and left

Note

- Esau as the first born had the right to be blessed by his father
- But he cared less of his right and so exchanged it with bean soup
- This would fulfil the order will serve the younger
- Do we have people who sale their right to cast today? how?

Isaac blesses Jacob 27:1-45

- When Isaac grew old, he became blind
- -As such he could identify his sons by using senses of
 - (1) hearing: their voices were different
 - (2) touch: feeling their bodies as Esau was hairy while Jacob was not
 - (3) smell: produced unique ordour

- When Isaac wanted to bless Esau before he died, he said to Esau
- You see I am old and may die soon
- Take your bow and arrows go out into the country and kill an animal for me.
- Cook me some of that tasty food I like, and bring it to me
- After I have eaten it I will give you my final blessing before I die
- However, Rebecca did not want see Isaac blessing Esau but Jacob

Reasons

- Jacob was her beloved son
- She did not like the Canaanite women Esau had married
- Thus Rebecca called Jacob and told him what Isaac was planning to do as she overheard their conversation

Rebecca advice to Jacob

- Go to the flock
- Pick out two fat young goats
- So that I can cook them and make some of that food your father likes so much
- **You can take it to him to eat, and he will give you his blessings before he dies**

Jacob`s reactions

- He feared that if his father would touch his body which was smooth and find out that he was deceiving Isaac, he will bring a curse on himself instead of a blessing.
- His mother said let any curse against you fall on me, my son just do as I say.
- When Jacob brought the goats to her, she prepared food for Isaac.

what did Rebecca do so that Jacob looked like Esau?

- (i) She put the skins of the goats on his arms and on the hairless part of his neck
- (ii) She took Esau's best clothes and put them on Jacob (to smell like Esau)

Then

- ❖ Jacob went gave him the food and asked him to eat so that he can bless him
- ❖ Isaac wondered because he had been so fast, but he said God was with him.
- ❖ Isaac also wondered because the voice was like that of Jacob but he verified by touching him and then smelling him as he kissed him

Then he blessed Jacob as follows 27:28-29

- May God give you dew from heaven and make your field fertile
- May he give you plenty of corn and wine
- May nations be your servants
- May people bow down before you
- May your mother's descendants bow before you
- May those who curse you be curses
- May those who bless you be blessed

Esau begs for Isaac s blessing

- ❖ As soon as Isaac finished him blessing and Jacob left, Esau arrived
- ❖ He prepared food and gave it his father
- ❖ Then Isaac began to shake and tremble all over because to realized that Jacob had deceived him and stolen Esau's blessings
- ❖ When Esau leant about it, he cried out loudly and bitterly
- ❖ Esau pleased to be blessed but Isaac said to him
- No dew from heaven for you
- No fertile fields for you
- You will live by your sword
- But be your brother's slave
- Yet when you rebel, you will break away from his control

- ❖ Esau hated Jacob so much so that he planned to kill him after his father's death
- ❖ Rebecca advise him to go to Haran.
- ❖ To run away from the hot anger of Esau and
- ❖ To marry one of his relatives (to convince Isaac)

Jacob's Dream at Bethel (Genesis 28:10-22)

- ❖ After Jacob was blessed, he was commanded to go to Haran to take a wife from there
- ❖ On his way, he stopped at Bethel for the night.
- ❖ He lay down to sleep using a stone as a pillow

Jacob Had This Dream

- ❖ He saw a stairway reaching from earth to heaven
- ❖ The angels were going up and coming down on it
- ❖ And the Lord was standing beside him (Jacob)

God's message to Jacob

- ❖ I AM THE Lord the God of Abraham and Isaac
- ❖ I will give to you and to your descendants this land on which you are lying
- ❖ They will be as numerous as the specks of dust on the earth
- ❖ Through you and your descendants I will bless all the nation
- ❖ I will be with you and protect you wherever you go
- ❖ I will bring you back to this land
- ❖ I will not leave you until; I have done all that I have promised you

Jacob's Reaction to God's Message

- ❖ Jacob woke up and said;
- ❖ The Lord is here! He is in this place, and I didn't know it
- ❖ What a terrifying place this is
- ❖ It must be the house of God
- ❖ It must be the gate that opens into heaven
- Then
- ❖ He took the stone he used as a pillar and set it up as a memorial
- ❖ He named the place Bethel the name was changed from Luz to Bethel
- ❖ Bethel means house of God or dwelling place of God

Jacob made a vow to God

- ❖ Jacob vowed that if you will be with me and protect me on the journey I am making and give me food and clothing and if I return safely to my father`s home then you will be my God. I will worship you and give a tenth of everything you give me.

Children born to Jacob gen 29:31-35,30:1-24

Jacob proceeded with his journey after communicating with God at Bethel. Eventually he reached Haran. There, he first met Rachel, Laban`s daughter. Later he met Laban and the family.

After working for Laban, he married Leah and Rachel – both Laban`s daughters and Zilpah + Bilhah were given as servant to them respectively.

Jacob loved Rachel more than Leah. When the Lord saw this, he made it possible for Leah to have children but Rachel remained childless.

Leah gave the following sons; Reuben, Simeon, Levi and Judah. Up to this time Rachel had no children. As a result, she gave her slave maid Bilhah to Jacob so that she could have children through her. It happened like that, Bilhah gave birth to Dan and Naphtali.

When Leah saw that she had stopped having children, she gave her slave Zilpah to Jacob as her wife so that Leah could have more children. Zilpah bore Jacob two sons and Asher.

Then Rachel gave Leah to Jacob in exchange with her son`s mandrakes. Jacob had sexual intercourse with Leah and she became pregnant. she gave birth to a son whom she named Issachar. she gave birth to another son whom she named Zebulun. Finally, she gave birth to a daughter whom she named Dinah.

Then God remembered Rachel, she became pregnant and gave birth to a son whom she named Joseph. she became pregnant again and she gave birth to a son on their way back to Canaan. Soon after giving birth she died. However, before she died she named her son Benoni but Jacob named him Benjamin. In total Jacob had 12 sons and one daughter

Draw the table of his children as on page 24

Note

At Jabbok, Jacob struggled with God, thus his name was changed to Israel.

Jacob named the place Peniel which means face God. (read Genesis .32:22-31)

Joseph and his brothers gen .37:1-36

Joseph was one of the 12 sons of Jacob. Joseph was the most beloved soon of Jacob. **reasons**

- ❖ He was the first born son from his beloved wife Racheal
- ❖ He used to bring bad reports to his father about what his brothers were doing.
- ❖ To show his love, Jacob made a beautiful long robe with full sleeves for him

His brothers hated Joseph because of the following:

- ❖ He was loved most by their father
- ❖ He used to bring bad reports to their father about what they were doing
- ❖ His dreams which implied that they will bow down to him as their king

Joseph's two dreams (Genesis 37:5—8)

First dream

- ❖ He and his brothers were in the field tying up sheaves of wheat
- ❖ When Joseph's sheaf got up
- ❖ And stood up straight
- ❖ His brothers' sheaves formed a circle round his
- ❖ And bowed down to Joseph sheaf
- ❖ Joseph shared the dream to his brothers

Reaction of his brother

Do you think you are going to be a king and rule over us? They hated him even more

Second dream (Genesis 37:9-11)

- ❖ he saw the sun, the moon and the eleven stars bowing down to him

Reaction off his parents and brothers to the dream

- ❖ he told his dream to his brothers and his father also.
- ❖ his father scolded him
- ❖ what kind of a dream is this?
- ❖ Do you think that your mother, brothers and I are going to come and bow down to you?
- ❖ His father kept thinking about the whole matter

Joseph is sold Egypt 37:12-36

- ❖ One-day Joseph's brother's went to Shechem to take care of their father's flock
- ❖ From Shechem they proceeded to Dothan.
- ❖ Jacob sent Joseph to Shechem to check if his brothers were safe and if the flock was all right
- ❖ Joseph did not find them at Shechem and he went to Dothan where he found them
- ❖ When they saw him at a distance, they conspired to get rid of him
- ❖ Here comes a dreamer, come on now, let's kill him and throw his body into one of the dry wells.
- ❖ We can say that a wild animal killed him
- ❖ Then we will see what becomes of his dreams
- ❖ Reuben tried to save Joseph by suggesting that they should just throw him into a dry well where there was no food so that he should starve to death.
- ❖ He said this, planning to save him from there and send him back to his father.
- ❖ Indeed, when Joseph came, they stripped off his long robe and threw him into the dry well.
- ❖ However, when they saw a caravan of Ishmaelite's from Gilead to Egypt, Judah proposed to sell Joseph to them

- ❖ They all agreed with him and sold him at twenty pieces of silver.
- ❖ The Israelites took him to Egypt.
- ❖ in Egypt the Midianites sold Joseph to Potiphar, one of the king's officers, who was the captain of the palace guard

One sin leads to another

Now that Joseph was sold, the brothers had to lie to their father, about what had happened to Joseph. So they took Joseph's robe, slaughtered a goat and dipped the robe in the blood so that it would appear that Joseph was killed by a wild animal. They reported the news to their father. Jacob took his clothes in sorrow and put on sackcloth. He mourned for his son for a long time and no one could comfort him.

Joseph in Egypt

Background information gen 39: 1-18

In Potiphar's house, Joseph proved to be a highly principled person. He also demonstrated administrative genius.

The Lord was with Joseph and made him successful ...Vs.2

Because of Joseph, the Lord also blessed the household of Potiphar and everything that he had in his house and in the field

Potiphar was pleased with Joseph and as a result he

- made him his personal servant
- Put him in charge of his house and everything he owned.

Joseph was well built and good looking. This made Potiphar's wife to be attracted to him. Due to the intrigues of Potiphar's wife, he was falsely accused and imprisoned

While in prison the Lord was with Joseph since he was made in charge over other prisoners

Still in prison Joseph interpreted the dreams of chief baker and wine Stewart. The wine Stewart was released from prison and he was reinstated as wine Stewart in the king's palace.

Joseph interprets the king's dreams (Genesis: 41: 1-36)

In the Old Testament, dreams were often a medium through which God spoke to individuals

However, dreams in the Old Testament were at times predictive, as in pharaoh's case

The king of Egypt had two dreams and he did not know their meanings

The first dream

In the dream, the king was standing by the river Nile

- ✓ He saw seven cows, fat and sleek, came up out of the river and began to feed on the grass
- ✓ Then seven other cows thin and bony, came up and stood by the other cows on the river bank
- ✓ Later, the thin cows ate up the fat ones

The second dream

After the first dream the king fell asleep again and had this dream

- ✓ Seven ears of corn, full and ripe, were growing on one stalk
- ✓ The seven other ears of corn sprouted, thin and scorched by the desert wind
- ✓ Finally, the thin ears of corn swallowed the full ones.

Joseph interpreters the dreams of the kings

- ✓ The magicians and the wise men failed to interpret the king's dreams
- ✓ Then the wine steward remembered Joseph how he interpreted his dream and that of the chief baker
- ✓ He recommended that Joseph could interpret the dream.
- ✓ Joseph was brought before the king and the king asked him if he could interpret the dream
- ✓ Joseph said, only God can, tell me your dreams
- ✓ The king told him the dreams as stated above
- ✓ Joseph said the two dreams have the same meaning
- ✓ The seven fat cows and the seven ears of corn full and ripe refer to the seven years of abundant crops in Egypt.

- ✓ These will be followed by
- ✓ The seven thin cows and the seven other ears of corn sprouted, thin and scorched by the desert wind referring to the seven years of famine after years of abundant
- ✓ The repetition of the dream meant that the matter is fixed by God and will make it happen in the next future

Joseph s advice to the king

- ✓ Choose someone with wisdom and insight and put him in charge of the country
- ✓ Appoint other officials to take a fifth of the crops during the year of plenty
- ✓ Store them so that the food could be used during the years of famine

Joseph is governor over Egypt

- ✓ At the age of 30, Joseph was made governor. The king and his official appointed Joseph to be the governor of Egypt and in charge of food.
- ✓ Joseph was second in command
- ✓ He was appointed after realizing that God's spirit was with him.

How the king crowned Joseph as governor?

- ✓ The king removed from his finger the ring engraved with the royal seal and gave Joseph
- ✓ He gave Joseph a fine linen robe
- ✓ He placed a gold chain round Joseph s neck
- ✓ He gave him an Egyptian name Zaphenath Peneach
- ✓ Asenath was given to Joseph as a wife
- ✓ Asenath was the daughter of Potiphera – a priest I the city of Heliopolis

Joseph brothers go to Egypt .to buy corn gen 42:1-24

When hunger broke out in Canaan Jacob sent his sons (Joseph's brothers) to Egypt to buy corn. The ten brothers went to Egypt while Benjamin (Joseph's full brother) remained at home because Jacob feared that

something might happen to him. The ten brothers met Joseph in Egypt but they did not recognize Joseph, yet Joseph recognize his brothers.

Upon meeting Joseph, the ten brothers bowed down before him with their faces to the ground. This situation reminded Joseph of the two dreams he had in Canaan. Joseph did not let them know that he was Joseph. Instead he accused them of being spies who had come to find out where their country was weak. The brothers denied of being spies. We are honest men. There were twelve of us, one is dead and the youngest is with our father.

Joseph kept them in prison for three days. The brothers felt that they were suffering because of what they did to Joseph. After three days, Joseph told them that he was a God fearing man. As such he would release them and let them take some corn to their starving families.

However, he told them that he would keep Simeon in prison until they brought their youngest son. This will prove that you have been telling the truth, and I will not put you to death. Joseph gave orders to fill his brothers' packs with corn, to put each man's money in his sack, and to give them food for the journey. This was done

On the way, one of them realized that his money had been returned. They were all stunned. When they came to their father Jacob in Canaan, they told him all that had happened. Jacob was not ready to release Benjamin to go to Egypt despite Reuben pledging his two sons should he fail to bring back Benjamin.

Note

- Judah pledged his own life and Jacob let his sons go to Egypt for the second time together with Benjamin
- It was during this time that Joseph revealed himself to his brothers
- He told them that there were five more years of famine to come
- As such he advised them to take their father and families so that they should settle in Egypt
- They went back to Canaan and convinced Jacob that his son was alive and had become a ruler in Egypt.
- They told him that his son wanted him to go and settle in Egypt.

- God promised Jacob that he would be with him in Egypt and he would make him a great nation
- As they came to Egypt, Joseph went to meet them; He advised them to tell the king that they were shepherds by occupation so that they should settle in Goshen which was fertile and well-watered. This happened
- These are the names of the sons of Israel who went to Egypt with Jacob, each with his family: Reuben, Simeon, Levi, Judah, Issachar, Zebulun, Benjamin, Dan, Naphtali, Gad, and Asher. In total Jacob's descendants were seventy including Joseph.

Lessons from the story of Joseph

- Joseph's story illustrates the way God can work through circumstances and even through evil actions of human beings to accomplish good
- His brothers sold him as God's plan of sending Joseph ahead of them
- His interpretation of Pharaoh's dreams through God's intervention provided the opportunity for his release from prison and ascent to authority (Governor)
- God worked through Moses to keep the covenant God made with His people. For example, God told Abraham that his family would reside in Egypt for 400 years before being given the Promised Land (Genesis 15:13). God used Joseph to move the whole family into Egypt
- In Egypt the children of Israel lived in isolation in the region of Goshen. There they remained separate - a people set apart for God
- Jacob was 130 years old when he went to Egypt and he died at the age 147
- Joseph buried his father in Canaan at Machpelah cave as Jacob had instructed
- Joseph and his brothers came back and continued to live in Egypt
- Joseph died at the age of 110 years. They embalmed his body and kept it
- The age of the patriarchs closes with the death of Joseph. Joseph and all his generation, his brothers and all their generations died.

2.5 The Work of Moses

Hebrew Slavery in Egypt

Background Information

As seen above Joseph and all his generation; his brothers and all their generations died. However, the Israelites continued to multiply. On the other hand, the Pharaoh under whom Joseph had worked, who loved him and invited his family to settle in Egypt also died. This king who loved Joseph was one of the foreign Hyksos kings of Egypt. The Hyksos were Semitic people who had ruled from 1700 – 1550 BC. The Pharaoh might have loved the Israelites because they too were Semitic

Later, however, the Egyptians regained their independence and a new line of Egyptian rulers came into power. The new king of Egypt did not Joseph. He feared that the Israelites had become too many and strong; and being Semitic they were likely to join Egypt's enemies and fight against them. Although the Israelites had stayed in Egypt for a long time (about 400 years), they still preserved their way of life which was different from the Egyptians

Hebrew slavery in Egypt (Exodus 1:8 – 22)

The new king of Egypt decided that the Israelites population should be controlled so as not to pose a threat to the Egyptians. The new king deployed three methods of reducing the Israelites and these were:

1. Hard labour

The Israelites were given hard labour so that they should become weak and tired and hence have no time to produce children. They were forced to build two cities of Ramses and Pithom. Unfortunately, the more they worked the more they multiplied

2. Killing of male babies during birth

When the king realized that though the Israelites were given hard labour they were still having children. He came up with another idea. The king commanded the midwives Shiphrah and Puah to kill all Israelite baby boys during birth. However, the midwives did not take the king's order because they feared God. When they were asked why they were not killing the baby boys. They gave a lame excuse

that Hebrew women give birth easily and their babies are born even before either of us gets there

3. Throwing male babies into River Nile

Finally, the king ordered that all baby boys born to the Israelites should be killed by throwing them into River Nile, only baby girls should live. It was after this ruling that Moses was born.

The Birth of Moses (Exodus 2:1 – 10)

- A man from the tribe of Levi married a woman from his own tribe
- She bore him a son
- When she was what affine baby he was, she hid him for three months
- When she could not hide him any longer, she took a basket made of reeds and covered with tar to make it watertight
- She put the baby in it and then placed it in the tall grass at the edge of the river
- The baby's sister stood some distance away to see what would happen. Then
- The king's daughter came down to the river to bathe
- While the servant walked along the bank, the princess saw the basket in the tall grass and she sent a slave woman to get it
- She opened it and saw a baby boy; he was crying and she felt sorry for him
- This is one of the Hebrew babies, she said and then
- His sister Miriam asked her, "Shall I go and call a Hebrew woman to act as a wet nurse
- Please do so. The girl went and brought the baby's own mother
- The princess said to the woman; Take this baby and nurse him for me, and I will pay you
- She took the baby and nursed him.
- When the child was old enough she took him to the princess who adopted him as her son
- She said to herself, I pulled him out of the water and so I name him Moses

The call of Moses

- When Moses discovered that Moses had killed an Egyptian who was ill-treating the Israelites he fled to the land of Midian.
- Moses married Zipporah the daughter of Jethro
- Jethro was the priest of Midian
- Moses was taking care of the sheep and goat of his father in law, Jethro
- One day Moses took the animals to Sinai, near the holy mountain of God

Moses saw a miracle at Sinai

- The angel of God appeared to Moses. The angel was in a form of flame of fire, coming from the middle of a bush.
- Moses saw that the bush was on fire but that it was not burning up
- This was a strange to Moses and he wanted to go closer to the burning bush and see what was happening

What God said to Moses

- God said to him
- Do not come any closer
- Take off your sandals because you are standing on holy ground
- I am the God of your ancestors, the God of Abraham, Isaac and Jacob
- In response Moses was afraid to see God so he covered his face

God gives Moses a mission

- God asked Moses to go to the king of Egypt and tell him to release the Israelites and that Moses should lead the people to the promised land
- By then the Israelites were treated harshly/cruelly by the Egyptians because Joseph was dead and the king who knew Joseph was also dead
- God had heard the prayers of the Israelites and so had sent Moses to take them to the promised land which was spacious and fertile.
- God said by then the promised land was occupied by the following people: The Canaanites, the Hittites, the Perizzites, the Hivites and the Jebusites, the Amorites

Moses conversation with God (Exodus 3:11-22)

Moses began to excuse that he cannot carry out the mission as follows

First he said I am nobody. How can I go to the king and baring the Israelites out of Egypt? This shows that Moses did really have faith in God.

In response god assured Moses that God will be with him and as a proof that I have sent you, you will worship me on this mountain when you bring the people out of Egypt

Secondly Moses said suppose the people ask me what is the name of the god who has sent you?

What can I tell them?

God said "I am who I am "in short the name is "I am "the Hebrew word "I am "is *ehyeh* from which developed the name Yahweh

The name implies that God has always been and will always be

I am who I am or Yahweh is the God of Abraham, Isaac and Jacob.

God asked Moses to go to the leaders of Israel and tell them that I, the lord appeared to you, tell them that I have come to them and have seen what the Egyptians are doing to them. I have decide that I will bring them out of Egypt –where they are treated cruelly and will take them to a rich and fertile land.

God advises Moses to go to the king of Egypt together with the leader of Israel ad tell him to allow the Israelites to go away

God made it clear that the king will not be willing to release the Israelites unless he would be forced to do so.

God assures Moses that he would use his king would allow them to go.

As they go out they will carry Egyptian clothing, gold and silver jewelry.

As Moses' doubts continued to trouble him as to how successful he would be in Egypt, being a poor speaker, God assured him that he would be with him. And Aaron, his brother would be his spokesperson Moses no longer felt weak after God's assurance. God was therefore, able to use him as

he would do with so many other after Moses. Like Moses, many others have seen God's vision, heard his call and were directed to some action.

Lessons from this story

- The transformation of Moses teaches us that with God we can achieve the unexpected. (Moses was transformed into a strong personality, ready to lead the Israelites out of Egypt.
- Moses learnt from his call that God was concerned about the welfare of his people. He is ready to support those trust him.
- God was concerned about the misery of his people in Egypt. Similarly, he is aware of the distress of all his people. In times of trouble, his people must cry to him that he might mercifully intervene on their behalf. whether our circumstance come from people, Satan sin or the world, God's comfort, grace and help will always meet our needs (Romans 8 :32) In God's times he will rescue us (Genesis 15:13)

The work of Moses (Exodus 7: 8 – 12 :15)

a) Aaron stick: exodus 7: 8 -13

God sent Moses to Pharaoh to request the release of the Israelites. since Moses felt inadequate in talking so Aaron his older brother was to speak to Pharaoh on behalf of Moses.

When Moses and Aaron first went to Pharaoh and were asked to perform a miracle they did. Aaron threw his stick (staff) down before Pharaoh and it turned into snake. The king wondered and he called his magicians and wise men, and using their magic they did the same thing. They threw down their sticks and the sticks turned into snakes.

Finally, Aaron 's stick (snake) swallowed all the snakes of the magicians. This showed that God is the greatest than the wise men and the magicians.

However, the Pharaoh was not impressed or moved by this miracle. As result, he refused to let the people of Israel leave Egypt. From then on, God enabled Moses and Aaron ten signs in form of plague as described below

B) the disasters strike Egypt ex 7:14-12:51

The king of Egypt was very stubborn and did not want to release the Israelites who were working as slaves to the Egyptians. God gave Moses to perform miracles (plagues) with an intention to force the king to allow the Israelites to go back to their land as God commanded them

Note:

Egyptian magicians were able to perform some of the miracle and couldn't perform other miracles

Some were performed at the king's palace other at the river Nile. The following were the miracles which Moses performed

- Blood
- Frogs
- Gnats
- Flies
- Death of animals
- Boils
- Hail
- Locusts
- Darkness
- The death of first born sons

(Read from the Bible on their details)

Note

It was after the tenth disaster that Pharaoh released the people of Israel. The disaster was the death of first born sons and their animals. Before this disaster Moses ordered the Israelites to kill a lamb or young goat and put the blood on door posts. When the angel of the Lord would be killing the first born sons of the Egyptians and their animals, the blood on door posts would be a sign to the angel that the house belongs to an Israelites. As such the angel would pass-over that house and not kill the first born sons and animals from that house.

This was called Passover. That evening the people were supposed to roast the meat of a lamb or young goat and eat it with unleavened

bread (bread without yeast) the unleavened bread symbolized that the people of Israel were pure and at the same time it symbolized that they left Egypt in a haste /hurry.

At midnight, the angel of the Lord passed through out Egypt and killed all first born sons of humans and animals. Only the Israelites were exempted from this disaster. This forced the king to release the Israelites because even his first born son who was supposed to be the heir to the throne also died.

Note:

Since that time Passover is commemorated every year among the Israelites. It is also called the feast of unleavened bread.

Department and crossing the red sea (Exodus 14 :1 – 31)

The Israelites started their exodus from Rameses and then camped at Sukkoth. The shortest route to Canaan passed through Egyptian territories.

As such they would have to fight with Egyptian soldiers to get passage. Moses feared that the people might get frustrated and demoralized and turn back to Egypt.

So they took the longest route through the red sea. Moses took with him the body of Joseph just as Joseph had instructed his brothers. During the day, God led the people by a pillar of cloud and during the night the Lord led them through a pillar of fire.

After some times the Pharaoh began to feel that he should not have released the Israelites since they were useful as workers .Thus he changed his mind and organized his army and sent them after the Israelites .When the Israelites saw the approaching Egyptians ,they panicked because before them lay the red sea and there seemed to be no way of crossing it .Moses remained calm and told them people to put their trust in God for he would find a way for them to escape from the Egyptians .As Moses foresaw, God instructed him what to do so as to cross the sea .Moses did it

The crossing of the red sea

- Moses held out his hand over the sea

- The Lord drove the sea back with a strong east wind
- If brew all night and turned the sea into dry land.
- The water was divided.
- And all the Israelites went through the sea on dry ground.
- With walls of water on both sides.
- The Egyptians pursued them and went after them into the sea with all the horses, chariots and drivers.
- Just before down the Lord looked down from the army of the Egyptian and threw them into panic.
- He made the wheel of the chariot get stuck and they moved difficult.
- The Egyptians said.
- The Lord is fighting for the Israelites against us let's get out of here.
- The Lord said to Moses hold over your hand over the sea and the water will come back over the Egyptians, and their chariots and drivers.
- Moses did so and at day break the water returned to its normal level.
- The Egyptians tried to escape from the water, but the Lord threw them into the sea
- The water returned and covered the chariots the derivers and all the Egyptians army not one of them was left but the Israelites walked through these on dry ground with walls of water on both sides.
- When the Israelites saw the they were filled with -awe of Lord -faith in the Lord and in the servant Moses This happed in 1447 BC.

Lessons from this story

- Moses stand out as a man of faith, patience, persistence and courage these are good qualities of both a good loader and an ordinary person.
- God saved Israelites through blood and water explain

Life of the Israelites in the desert, 16:1-36

The life of the Israelites in the desert was a tough one for example

(a) While in the desert of Shur the Israelites found bitter water at a place called Marah (in Hebrew, it means bitter). The water was made fit to drink when Moses put a wood given by the Lord into the water.

(b) Then they came of Elim where they found twelve springs of water

© While in the desert of sin, the Israelites complained that they had no food. They even remembered about the meat and onions of Egypt.

Moses responded to the people demands by praying to the Lord. The Lord gave them manna (in Hebrew it means "what is it?" and quails (a type of birds) at Twi light.

Rules for collecting manna from heaven.

They were supposed to collect two litres per member of a household every day.

On the sixth day they had to collect twice as much so that the other two litres should be used on the seventh day which was Sabbath (day of rest and worship).

Note that some Israelites disobeyed the rules.

They collected more than two litres and kept some however the next day it was found rotten.

Others did not collect twice as much on the sixth day on the 7th day they not find any.

The people of Israel ate manna for the rest of their lives in the desert (about 40 days) Moses was then told to put two litres of manna in a jar and to keep it in the Lord covenant for future generations to see what their ancestors ate while in the desert.

(D) From the desert of sin, the Israelites camped at Rephidim, which is in the southern part of the Sinai Peninsula.

At this place there was no water to drink. As usual, the Israelites turned on Moses and blamed him for their plight "give us water to drink" exodus 17: 2 others said, "Why did you bring us out of Egypt to kill us with thirst".

In his answering Moses advised the people to trust God by not putting him to the test

Moses prayed to God for water and God answered his prayer.

God told Moses to take some leaders of the Israelites and go ahead of the people to mount Sinai.

God asked Moses to strike the rock with the same stick which he struck the Red Sea.

When Moses struck the rock, water came out for the people to drink.

Moses named the place "Massa and Meribah" in Hebrew meaning testing and complaining

Unit reviewing exercise

- (1) Define the term patriarch.
- (2) Relate down the four patriarch.
- (3) Relate the call of Abraham
- (4) Describe how tested his Abraham faith.
- (5) narrate how Jacob sold his birthright
- (6) suggest reasons why Pharaoh of Egypt was stubborn to release the Israelite.

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Chapter 4

THE COVENANT

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THE COVENANT

OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, the student should be able to:

1. define a covenant
2. explain the importance of the Covenant at Mount Sinai
3. discuss the death of Moses

CONTENTS

- Meaning of the term covenant
- The ten commandments
- Importance of the covenant at Mount Sinai
- Death of Moses
 - Discuss the death of Moses
 - Transition of leadership after the Death of Moses

The message of the term covenant

A covenant is a strong binding agreement between two or more people who were separated before. It usually consists of a promise a sign and a ceremony.

For example, Abraham was promised to be given many descendants. To show to the descendants belong to God he was asked to they have all males circumcised as a sign that they belong to God.

The covenant at mount Sinai (Exodus 19:1-24.)

From Rephidim the Israelites camped at the foot of mount Sinai and Moses was invited by God so Moses went up the mount to communicate with God. God wanted to renew his covenant with his people whom he identified the descendants of Jacob. God presented the term of the covenant to Moses so that he should present them to the people.

Israelite were as land to obey God and keep his covenant. only them would they be Gods people the chosen people.

The Israelites will serve God as priests: a priest has access to God and acts an intermediary between the and God this implies that the Israelites will know the will of God and have, they were to enlighten the worth concerning God.

Israel would be a holly nation. Then

Moses went down and explained what God said to the leaders of the people, who then explained it to the people. The Israelites unanimously accepted God's terms which demanded obedience and total consecration: "we will do everything that the Lord has said" Exodus 19:8.

God wanted the Israelites to trust Moses as God's instrument. So God planned to appear to Moses before them all. He asked Moses to tell the people to purify themselves for two days before worship. They were asked

to purify themselves by washing their clothes, refraining from sexual intercourse and by not crossing the boundary to see God face to face.

These actions (washing themselves and refraining from sexual intercourse) symbolized the attitude of their heart and total consecration to God.

On the third day, there was thunder and lightning and a thick cloud appeared and a very loud trumpet blast was heard. All these signified the presence of God. All the people in the camp trembled with fear. When Moses spoke to God, He answered with thunder. Moses and Aaron were allowed to go on the mountain while the people were not to cross the boundary as God spoke to the people.

The ten Commandments (Exodus 20: 1 – 17)

God is addressing all the Israelites since they accepted to be God's people and obey Him. In His speech, God began with a reminder of the historical link between Him and the Israelites: "I am the Lord your God who brought you out of Egypt, where you were slaves".

Then God gave them laws to help them live as a Holy nation. The main laws which God gave Moses are known as the Ten Commandments. The Greek name for them is the Decalogue. The ten commandments were written on a stone tablet and are grouped into two. The first group of the ten commandments set out man's duty towards God. The second group of commandments deal with man's duty towards his fellow men. In between these two groups of commandments is a commandment dealing with man's duty to his parents.

A. Relationship between a person and God; the first four commandments

1. You shall have no other gods except me/ Worship no god but only the true God.
2. Do not make images of anything in heaven or on earth or in water and worship them
3. Do not misuse God's name
4. Observe the Sabbath and keep it Holy

B. Relationship between a person and his / her immediate family; the fifth commandment

5. Respect your father and mother

C. Relationship between a person and the society

6. Do not commit murder

7. Do not commit adultery

8. Do not steal

9. Do not accuse anyone falsely

10. Do not covet; this commandment emphasizes on not coveting or craving what belongs to another

Death of Moses and Leadership Transition (Deuteronomy 34: 1 - 12)

Background

When old people are about to die, they give their last wishes and concerns which should be respected. otherwise an impending calamity would occur.

Towards the end of his leadership, Moses gave a very important sermon. (Refer to Deuteronomy 30: 15 – 20). The Israelites were asked to make a good choice between life and death. The way of life resulted from obedience to God while death resulted from disobedience to God

Moses died soon after this sermon. God took him from the plains of Moab to Mount Nebo where the Lord showed him the Promised Land. The Lord told him that he would not enter the Promised land because he had sinned against God. So Moses died in the land of Moab. Deuteronomy 34: 6. Tells us that God Himself buried Moses in the valley of Moab. So nobody knows the exact burial place

Moses was 120 years old when he died. The Israelites mourned for Moses for 30 days in the plain of Moab.

Transition of Power from Moses to Joshua

Joshua, son of Nun was filled with wisdom, because Moses had appointed him be his successor

Before died the people of Israel obeyed Joshua and kept the common that the Lord had given them through Moses. There was a smooth transition of power from Moses to Joshua.

Note that when a leader dies, there is need to have a smooth transition of power from one person to another. Does this happen in our political life today?

Joshua Succeeds Moses (Joshua: 1 – 24)

After Moses died, God told Joshua that he would lead the Israelites across the River Jordan into the Promised Land of Canaan. He assured Joshua that he would be with him. God would not let any man stand against Joshua. He told Joshua to be strong and determined for it was through him that the Israelites would inherit the Promised Land. He was also required to be faithful to the covenant to enable God to work through him.

Joshua Sends Spies into Jericho (Joshua 2:1 – 24)

The Israelites camped at Acacia and from there Joshua sent two spies to go and explore the land of Canaan especially the city of Jericho. A prostitute named Rahab accommodated the two spies in Canaan. When the king of Jericho learnt about it, he was not happy. He sent a word to Rahab asking her to bring the men before the king because they were spies. "The men in your house have come to spy out the whole country! Bring them out!" Rahab lied to the king that the two men visited her but she didn't know where they came from. They left her house before sunset. This was just a lie because Rahab had taken the two spies up on the roof of the house and hidden them under some stalk of flax.

Agreement Between Rahab and the Two Spies from Joshua

Rahab knew that the Lord had given Canaan into the hands of the Israelites since everyone was afraid of them. So she asked the spies to do her a favour of not killing her together with her family when they would be destroying Canaan. The two spies promised to spare Rahab and her family on the condition that Rahab would not tell anyone about them.

Rahab was staying in a house built into the city wall, so she let the men down from the window by a rope and let them go as the men guarded

the gates. The men asked her to tie the red cord to the window she let them down so that they should identify her house easily when they would be invading the city. She was asked to invite her family members to stay there so that they would be spared.

The spies went back to Joshua and told him everything that had happened. They said that they were sure that the Lord had given them the Country of Canaan because all people there were terrified of them.

Unit Review Questions

1. What is the meaning of the Covenant?
2. Discuss the importance of the Covenant at Mount Sinai to the Israelites
3. List down the ten commandments

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Chapter 5

ENTRY INTO THE PROMISED LAND

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ENTRY INTO THE PROMISED LAND

OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, the student should be able to:

1. describe Israel's entry into the Promised Land under Joshua

CONTENTS

- Preparation for entry into Canaan
- Entry into the Promised Land under Joshua

Israelites Entry into the Promised Land (Joshua 3: 1- 17; 4: 1 – 24)

- From the camp at Acacia the Israelites went to the Jordan where they camped waiting to cross it.
- Three days later the leaders directed the people to follow the priest carrying the Covenant Box who would lead their way (Joshua 3:1 - 3)
- The people were commanded to purify themselves because God was going to perform miracles among them (Joshua 3: 5)
- Joshua was magnified and made commander – in – chief (Joshua 3: 7 – 8)
- Public notice was given on what God wanted to do

The People of Israel cross the Jordan River (Joshua 3: 14 – 17)

- It was harvest time, and the river was in flood
- When the people left the camp to cross the Jordan
- The priests went ahead, carrying the Covenant Box
- As soon as the priests stepped into the river
- The water stopped flowing and piled up, far upstream at Adam, the city beside Zarethan
- The flow downstream to the Dead Sea was completely cut off
- And the people were able to cross over near Jericho
- While the people walked across on dry ground, the priest carrying the Covenant Box stood on the dry ground in the middle of the Jordan
- Until all people had crossed over

Memorial Stones Are Set up (Joshua 4: 1 – 24)

- God asked Joshua to ask twelve people; one from each tribe, to collect a stone out of the middle of the Jordan, from the very place where the priests were standing

- And then carry those stones with them to where they would camp that night and pile them as a memorial pillar
- That pillar would remind the future generation that the Covenant Box and the Israelites crossed the River Jordan on dry ground because of God
- Then the Israelites camped at Gilgal, where they put the twelve stones as a memorial pillar. The stones are still there today
- Note that before the priests moved out of the river, Joshua also set up twelve stones in the middle of the river Jordan, where the priest carrying the Covenant Box stood. (these stones are still there)

Uses of the Memorial Stones at that time

- To remind the future generations about God's salvation and His grace towards His people
- To provide an occasion for parents to teach their children about God's power and faithfulness

Uses of Memorial Stones/ structures today in Malawi

- To remind Malawians of the important moments that the nation went through and are therefore
- A source of national pride and respect.

The Fall of Jericho (Joshua 6: 1 – 27)

The city of Jericho was a fortress with thick walls. The city was believed to be protected by the gods of the Canaanites. The capture of Jericho would be the key to Joshua's victory. It would demonstrate that the Israelites' God was superior to the Canaanite gods.

The people of Jericho knew that enemies (Israelites) wanted to attack them. Thus the gates of Jericho were kept shut and guarded to keep the Israelites out. No one could enter or leave the city. Then the Lord said to Joshua, "I am putting into your hands Jericho, with its king and all its brave soldiers" God gave these instructions to Joshua in order to conquer Jericho

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- You and your soldiers should march round the city once a day for six days. Seven priests each carrying a trumpet, are to go in front of the Covenant Box
- On the seventh day, you and your soldiers are to march round the city seven times while the priests blow the trumpet. Then they are to sound one long note. As soon as the people hear it, all the people are to give a loud shout and the city wall will collapse. Then the whole army will go straight into the city
Joshua called the priests and said to them
- "Take the covenant Box, and seven of you go in front of it, carrying trumpet" then he ordered the people to start marching round the city, with an advance guard going ahead of the LORD'S Covenant Box
- Then they started marching. First in line was the advance guard, then the priest who were blowing the trumpets. Behind these came the priests who were carrying the Covenant Box, followed by the rearguard. All this time the trumpets were sounding. But Joshua had ordered the people not to shout and not to say a word until he gave the order for them to. In this way, they marched around the city once a day for six days as the Lord had commanded
- On the seventh day, they got up at daybreak and marched seven times around the city in the same way – but this was the only day they marched round it seven times. the seventh time round, when the priests were about to sound the trumpets, Joshua ordered the people to shout and he said
 - The Lord has given you the city!
 - The city and everything in it must be totally destroyed as an offering to the LORD
 - Only the prostitute Rahab and her household will be spared, because she hid our spies
 - Nobody should take anything that is to be destroyed; if you do, you will bring trouble and destruction on the Israelite camp
 - Everything made of silver, gold, bronze or iron is set apart for the Lord. It is to be put in the Lord's treasury

Destruction of the City of Jericho

- So the priests blew the trumpets, as soon as the people heard it, they gave a loud shout, and the walls collapsed. Then all the army went straight up to the hill into the city and captured it. They killed everyone in the city; men and women, young and old. They also killed the cattle, sheep and donkeys.
- Joshua then ordered the two men who served as spies to go into Rahab's house and bring her and her family out as you promised her. So Rahab and all her family were taken to safety near the Israelite's camp.
- Then they set fire to the city and burnt it to the ground along with everything in it, except the things made of gold, silver, bronze and iron
- Finally, Joshua issued a solemn warning, "Anyone who tries to rebuild the city of Jericho will be under the Lord's curse. For example, will lose his eldest son or his youngest son

Unit Review Questions

1. Who succeeded Moses as the leaders of the Israelites
2. Explain how Israelites prepared to enter into Canaan
3. Explain the role of Rahab in the entry into the Promised Land
4. Relate how the Israelites conquered the city of Jericho

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Chapter 6

JUDGES

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Compiled By: Peter Chitaya

JUDGES

OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, the student should be able to:

1. describe the role of the judges
2. describe the following judges
 - a. Deborah
 - b. Gideon
 - c. Samson

CONTENTS

- Role of judges
- Deborah
- Gideon
- Samson

Introduction (the role of Judges)

- The book of judges is a history of Israel during the government of the judges who were occasionally deliverers. They were raised by God to rescue Israel from their oppressors to reform the state of religion and to administer justice.
- The book of judges covers the extended period from the conquest of Canaan to the establishment of a monarchy. It was generally a period of moral decay.
- The judges were military leaders who led the struggle against various oppressors. They sought to influence the Israelites to stop idol worship
- A characteristic feature of the period is the trend that recurred as stated below
 1. Sin
- The Israelites turn to worship idols and desert their way of life
 2. Servitude
- Neighboring nations oppress the Israelites
 3. Supplication
- Under intense oppression people confess their sins and turn to God
 4. Salvation
- God hears their prayers and empowers a deliverer who drives away the oppressors
 5. Silence
- A period of rest follows during which the judges keep the people faithful to God.

Note: these repeated cycles take place as the territory of the future tribes sinks rather than grows

We will look into details of the following judges, Deborah, Gideon, Samson and Samuel.

DEBORAH (Judges 4 :1-24)

- After the death of judge Ehud, the Israelites sinned again before God: As a punishment, God let them to be conquered by king jabin of Canaan who ruled his country from the city of Hazor. Sisera was the commander of king Jabin`s army. Jabin ruled Israel with cruelty and violence for 20 years. Then the Israelites cried to God for help. That time, Deborah the wife of Lappidoth was a prophet and she was also serving as a judge. Deborah was judging cases between Raman and Bethel in Ephraim. One day Deborah called her army commander Barak, son of Abinoam. she told him the following;” the lord, the God of Israel, has given you this command, take ten thousand men from tribes of Naphtali and Zebulun and lead them to mount Tabor. I will bring Sisera, the commander of Jabin’s army, to fight against you at the river Kishon ... but I will give you victory over him.

Barak responded that he would go to war against Jabin`s army only if Deborah went with him. Barrack’s response showed that he was either afraid of Sisera or he doubted whether Deborah s message was true. Because of Barak’s doubt, Deborah said that she would go to war with Barak. However, she made it very clear that Barak would not get any credit for the victory because the lord would hand Sisera over to a woman

The war between the Israelite’s and the Canaanites

Deborah, as a judge, waged a war against the Canaanites with their king Jabin

When the camps fought all soldiers of jabin were killed except for Sisera who ran away to the tent of Jael (a woman) the wife of Heber. Jael welcomed Sisera in her tent. Sisera asked Jael to give him water. Jael gave him some milk and then he slept. As he was sleeping, Jael took a hammer and a tent peg and killed Sisera by driving the peg right through the side of his head and into the ground

When Barak came to look for Sisera, Jael showed a dead body of Sisera. Barak was convinced that God fought for them.

Gideon (Judges 6: 1-40)

Once again the Israelites sinned against God. As usual God let the people of Midian rule them. The Midianites were stronger than the Israelites and they ruled Israel for 7 years.

The Midianites could come and destroy the crops and animals like sheep, cattle, and donkeys for the Israelites. The Israelites cried to God for help. In response God sent them a prophet who reminded them that God loves them so much but they always sinned against God.

Then God sent his angel who went village of orphah and found Gideon the son of Joash from the clan of Abiezer. At that Gideon was threshing wheat by the winepress to hide it from the Midianites.

The angel message to Gideon (the call Gideon) 6:12-16

- The Lord's angel said the lord is with you brave and mighty man
- Gideon said to him
- If I may ask sir
- Why has all this happened to us if the lord is with us?
- What about all the wonderful things that our father told us the lord used to do
- Howe he brought them out of Egypt
- The lord has abandoned us
- And left us to the mercy of the Midianites
- Then the lord ordered him
- Go with all great strength and rescue Israel from the Midianites, I myself am sending you
- Gideon replied
- But lord, how can I rescue Israel?
- My clan is the weakest from the tribe of Manasseh
- And I am the least important member of my family
- The lord answered
- You can do it because I will help you.
- You will crush the Midianites as easily as if they were only one man.

Gideon's reaction

Gideon was not sure if he was talking with God and he asked for a proof or a sign that it was God who was speaking to him. In addition to that he asked if it was possible for him to make a sacrifice for God

Gideon's sacrifice

- He brought meat and bread before the angel. He was advised to put them on the rock. The angel touched the meat and bread with his stick and fire came and burnt the meat and bread. Then the angel disappeared. Gideon then knew that indeed God was talking to him. Gideon built an altar there and called it "the lord is peace" this altar is still there up to now.

That night God asked Gideon to destroy his father's altar of Baal and destroy the symbol for the goddess Asherah. In response, Gideon with ten servants did what the lord told him to do. However, he did it during the night because he feared his father and all the people who were worshipping Baal and Asherah. After that Gideon built an altar for God and made a sacrifice

Next day people wondered who destroyed the altar of Baal and the symbol of Asherah. After investigations, they learnt that it was Gideon. So they asked Joash to bring his son, Gideon to be killed

But Joash said to them "are you standing up for Baal?"

Are you defending him? Anyone who stands up for him will be killed before morning. If Baal is a god let him defend himself. It is his altar that was torn down "from that time Gideon was called Jerubbaal-let Baal defend himself.

Gideon gathered soldiers in readiness to fight against the Midianites. Gideon asked God once again if they would win the battle. He therefore asked for a sign.

He asked God to rain dew on the wool and not on the ground and that happened.

- He asked God the next day to reverse this by raining dew on the ground and not on the wool and it happened that way
- Gideon was then assured that he would defeat the Midianites
-

Gideon defeats the Midianites (Judges 7 ;1-25)

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Gideon took 32,000 soldiers with him and camped at the spring of Herod. The Midianites camped by Moreh hill.

- God told Gideon that his soldiers were too many so much so that they may think that they had won by themselves, and give me no credit.
- Gideon as commanded by God announced that anyone who is afraid should go back so. 22,000 went back but 10,000 stayed.
- God said the men you have are still too many. Take them to the river and I will separate them for you there
- Gideon took them to the water and the lord said to him "separate everyone who laps up the water with his tongue, from everyone who gets down on his knees to drink"
- There were 300 men who scooped up water in their hands and lapped it. These were the ones who were chosen, the rest were sent back
- The lord said to Gideon that he will rescue Gideon and give him victory over the Midianites with the 300 men who lapped the water.
- Before he attacked the camp, God assured Gideon of victory
- God asked Gideon to take his servant Purah and to go to the camp of their enemies
- Gideon did so and he heard a man telling a friend about a dream. He was saying
- I dreamt that a loaf of barley bread rolled into the camp and hit a tent. The tent collapsed and lay flat on the ground"
- Another soldier interpreted it in this way; it's the sword of the Israelite, Gideon son of Joash! it can't mean anything else! God has given him victory over Midian and our whole army.
- When Gideon heard about the man's dream and what it meant, he fell to his knees and worshipped the lord.
- Then he went to the Israelite camp, divided the men into three groups and commanded them to attack the Midianites.
- During the battle the Midianite kings were killed: Oreb, Zeeb, Zebah and Zalmuna.
- Finally, the Midianites were defeated.

Samson

The Israelites sinned again and god invited the philistines to rule them. the philistines ruled Israel for 40 years. the Israelites cried to god for help when they were tired of oppression from the philistines. god heard their prayer and appointed Samson Tobe a judge and lead them to fight against the philistines.

The birth of Samson judges 13: 1- 25

An angel of god visited the wife of Manoah from the tribe of Dan in zorah. the angel said to her that an although she was barren, she would soon be pregnant and give birth to a son. the woman was advised that once pregnant, not to drink any wine or beer and not eat forbidden food because the baby to be born would be dedicated to god as a Nazi rite.

When Manoah got the news from his wife, he prayed to god and asked the angel to come again and tell them what they should do with the boy. the angel came, advised the wife of Manoah to follow all what he said

When Samuel was born he was dedicated to God as a Nazirite just as the angel had commanded

Nazirites

These were Israelites who were consecrated to the services of god

Qualities of Nazirites

- They did not drink beer or wine
- They did not cut his hair
- They did not touch dead bodies / corpses

Note that Manoah offered sacrifice to thank the lord for this

Samson at Gaza judge 16: 1-3

Gaza was the philistines cities.one day Samson want there where he met a prostitutes and sleep with her when the philistines learnt about it, they guarded the city gates so that they would kill Samson at day break.

But Samson woke up at mid night and took hold of the city gates and pulled it up and hooked it to the hill of in Hebron

Samson and Delilah judges 16:4-31

Samson fell in love with Delilah, one of the philistines. The five philistine's kings took it to be an advantage. They went to Delilah and asked her to betray Samson to reveal the secret of his strength so that the philistines should overthrow his power. She was promised eleven hundred pieces of silver from each of the five kings.

For three times Samson cheated her as follows;

- (i) If they tie me up with seven new bowstrings that are not dried out, I'll be so weak as anybody else
- (ii) If they tie me with seven new ropes that have never been used, I'll be as weak as anybody else.
- (iii) If you weave my seven locks of hair into a loam, and make it tight with a peg, I'll be as weak as anybody else.

Note that when Delilah tried any of these with the help of philistines none of them worked.

Samson could not be overpowered

Delilah kept on nagging Samson to tell her the source of his strength. Samson got tired with her and revealed everything about his strengths "my hair has never been cut

I have been dedicated to God as a Nazirite. If my hair is cut, I would lose my strength and be as weak as anybody else."

Delilah with the assistance from the philistines shaved Samson and he lost his power. The philistines captured him, removed his eyes and took him to Gaza as a prisoner. Samson was grinding at the mill in the prison but his hair started growing again.

Death of Samson

- The five philistine's kings and 3000 philistines met together to celebrate and offer sacrifices to their god Dagon, whom they

believed gave them victory over Samson. Samson was brought in to entertain them in that building

- Then Samson with the keep from the boy who was leading him by hand touched the two pillars that had up for his strength and god gave him. He Pushed the Two Pillars and Shouted: 'LET ME DIE WITH THE PHILISTINES '. the building fell down and killed every one who was in that building including Samson. Samson killed more people at his death than he had killed during his life
- His family came and took his body and buried it in the tomb of his father Manoah, between zorah and eshtaol. Samson ruled Israel for twenty years

Review exercise

1. Give two duties of judges.
2. Who was the husband of Deborah?
3. Relate the death of Samson
4. Describe the how the Midianites troubled Israelites.
5. For how long did the philistines rule Israel.
6. From which tribe was Samson?
7. Explain the danger of intermarriage with heather people.
8. Narrate how Dalilah betrayed Samson
9. Describe the death of Samson
10. What lessons can we learn today from the death of Samson

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Chapter 7

THE STORY OF RUTH

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THE STORY OF RUTH

OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, the student should be able to:

1. narrate the story of Ruth

CONTENTS

- discussing the story of Ruth
- describing the importance of the story of Ruth

Introduction

The story of Ruth took place during the time of judges. Ruth, a Moabite by nationality, married to an Israelite. When the husband of Ruth Died, Ruth left her country and went with her mother- in law to Israel despite letting her to stay with her people. Ruth showed loyalty to her and a deep devotion to God of Israel.

Ruth married Boaz, one of her late husband's relatives as it was the custom of that time and two became grandparents of King David

Elimelech and Naomi in Moab (Ruth 1: 1 – 22)

Elimelech and Naomi had two sons Mahlon and Chilion. Elimelech and his family moved from Bethlehem in Judah to live for a while in the country of Moab because there was famine in Judah.

Mahlon and Chilion married Moabite women. Mahlon married Ruth and Chilion married Orpah.

Elimelech died in Moab and left his wife and his two sons with daughters' in – laws. About ten years after the death of Elimelech, Mahlon and Chilion also died and left Naomi and her two daughters in – law.

Sometime later, Naomi heard that there was good harvest in Judah and she planned to go home. Naomi asked Orpah and Ruth to go back to their mothers because Naomi had no sons who could marry them. Orpah agreed to go back to her mother.

However, Ruth insisted that she would go with Naomi to her home

- Don't ask me to leave you!
- Let me go with you
- Wherever you go, I will go
- Wherever you live, I will live

- Your people will be my people
- Your God will be my God
- Wherever you die, I will die, and that is where I will be buried
- May the Lord's worst punishment come upon me if I let anything but death separate me from you

Upon reaching Bethlehem people were excited to see Naomi. Is it really Naomi, they exclaimed

Naomi said that do not call me Naomi. From now on my name is Marah because the Lord has made my life bitter by taking away from me, my husband and the two sons.

Naomi and Ruth arrived in Bethlehem when barley harvest was just beginning. The barley is not tobacco but a food crop like maize.

Ruth works in the field of Boaz. (Ruth 2: 1 – 23)

Boaz was a rich man and a relative of Elimelech.

One day with permission from Naomi, Ruth went to the fields to gather the corn that harvest workers left (kukakhunkha / kuvutula). Ruth accidentally was picking up the corn which the harvest workers left in the field of Boaz, who was a relative to her late husband.

Ruth Meets Boaz

Boaz met Ruth in his fields and he was kind to her.

How Boaz Showed Love to Ruth

- Boaz welcomed Ruth to work in his field and not to anyone else
- Boaz ordered his workers not to molest her
- He permitted Ruth to drink from the water jars that Boaz's workers had filled
- He gave her some food (bread, sauce and roasted grain)
- Boaz instructed his men to pull out some corn from the bundles and leave it for her to pick up

Ruth bowed down with her face touching the ground and wondered why Boaz was so kind to a foreigner. Boaz explained that he had full account

of her story and admired her faith in the God of Israel. That day Ruth gathered 10 kilogrammes of corn and Naomi was so excited.

When Naomi learnt that she was working in Boaz's field, she revealed to Ruth that Boaz was a close relative of theirs, one of those responsible for taking care of them. Ruth worked with Boaz workers until all the barley and wheat had been harvested and she continued living with her mother – in – law.

Ruth finds a husband (Ruth 3:1-18)

-Naomi said to Ruth that I must find a husband for you, so that you will have a house of your own.

- then Naomi asked Ruth to wash herself, perfume yourself and dressed in her best clothes.

After that Naomi advise Ruth to go where Boaz would be threshing barley, but let him know you are there until he has finished eating drinking .be sure to asleep go and lift the covers and lie down of his feet.

Ruth followed the advice and went to Boaz. Ruth told Boaz plainly that because should marry her "... so please marry me "(Ruth 3:9) Boaz promised to ask a certain man who was closer relative to Ruth's late husband to marry Ruth. if that man would turn down the offer then Boaz would marry Ruth. Ruth explained everything to Naomi who asked her to be patient.

Boaz marries Ruth 4:1-22

Boaz met Elimelech's nearest relative the man whom Boaz had mentioned to marry Ruth. Boaz asked the ten leaders of Bethlehem town to be witnesses when he was asking the nearest relative of Elimelech to buy a field from Boaz and take Ruth as a wife. The man refused to buy it because he knew that in that way his sons would not inherit it.

Then the man said to Boaz who was the next close relative to Naomi "you buy it, I would rather not ". he took off his sandal and gave it to Boaz. This was a Jewish custom on how to settle the matter of land ownership.

Boaz said that “you are all witnesses today that I have bought from Nomi everything that belonged to Elimelech and to his sons Chilion and Mahlon. In addition, Ruth the Moabite, Mahlon’s widow becomes my wife. This will keep the property in the dead’s man’s family and his family line will continue among his people and in his town. You are witness to this today”

Following that development Boaz bought Naomi’s field and married Ruth. Boaz and Ruth had a baby son and named him Obed. When Obed grew up he became the father of who was the father of king David.

Review Exercise

1. mention the family members of the family of Naomi.
2. Explain the problem which Naomi encountered in Moab.
3. state the reason why Elimelech and his family moved to Moab.
4. why did Naomi say that she should be called Marah.
5. explain the connection between Ruth and king David.

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Chapter 8

THE STORY OF SAMUEL

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THE STORY OF SAMUEL

OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, the student should be able to:

1. relate the birth of Samuel
2. narrate the call of Samuel

CONTENTS

- discussing the birth of Samuel
- discussing the call of Samuel

1.5 THE BIRTH OF SAMUEL

Elkanah and his family (1 Samuel 1:1-8)

- Elkanah was the father of Samuel; he was from the tribe of Ephraim and was living in the town of Ramah. Elkanah was the son of Joroham.
- Elkanah had two wives namely; Hannah and Peninnah. Peninnah had children but Hannah was barren. Despite this, Elkanah loved Hannah very much and tried to assure her of his loving care.
- Elkanah was a devout man who every time went to worship and sacrifice to the lord in Shiloh .it was at Shiloh where the tent of meeting (temple)had been set up after the conquest of the promised land.
- Each time they went to worship the lord Peninnah used mock Hannah for being childless. these insults pained Hannah most to the extent of crying and not eating.
- At Shiloh Eli was the priest of the lord and his two sons Hophni and Phinehas were also serving as priest

Hannah and Eli (1 Samuel 1: 9 -18)

- One day Hannah prayed in the house of God at Shiloh. By then Eli was sitting in his place by the door and he was looking at Hannah as she was praying. In her prayer Hannah made a solemn promise,

'almighty lord, look at me your servant! see my trouble and remember me ' do not forget me! if you give me a son, I promise that I will dedicate him to you for his whole life and that he will never have his hair cut."

- As Hannah prayed, her lips moved but no words were heard. Eli thought she was drunk and said to her stop making a drunken show of yourself! Stop your drinking and sober up!

In response Hannah politely answered that she was not drunk but she was desperate and she was praying to God

Eli pronounced a benediction on her "go in peace, and may the God of Israel give you what you have asked him for "

From that time Hannah was very happy and she ate assuming that God had listened to her prayer, and that all her problems of being barren and Peninnah laughing at her were gone.

Note

- Hannah prayed silently because she wanted only God's attention not human sympathy. she did not beg Eli, the man of God to pray for her because she knew how to go beyond priests to meet God directly

Samuel s birth and dedication 1 Samuel 1:19-28

- From Shiloh, Elkanah and his two wives, Hannah and Peninnah went back to their home to their home at ramah.at Ramah, Hannah became pregnant and gave birth to a son and he was named Samuel. Samuel means 'I asked the lord for him 'this means that Hannah asked for a child from God. This happened at Shiloh in the house of.
- Hannah nursed Samuel very well as a baby. when she weaned him Hannah took Samuel to Eli at Shiloh and dedicated him to god .in other words Hannah gave Samuel to Eli to be living in the house of God for his entire life." so I am dedicating him to the Lord. as long as he lives he will belong to the Lord "(1samuel 1:28)

The call of Samuel ,1 samuel3:1-22



Samuel was serving the Lord at Shiloh under the direction of Eli. they were sleeping in the house of God Samuel was sleeping in the sanctuary where Covenant Box was.

One-day God called Samuel by name and Samuel did not realize that God was calling him, instead he was responding to Eli "yes sir you called me here I am "Eli said," I didn't call you, go back to bed "this happened for three times.

On third time, Eli advised Samuel to answer to the call in this way:" speak Lord your servant is listening "when the Lord called Samuel for the fourth time Samuel responded as Eli advised.

God message to Samuel

God would punish Eli's family because of his sons' sins

- they speak evil things against God
- they slept with woman who worked at the gate of the temple.
- they had no respect for meat offered to God as sacrifice

In the morning Samuel shared his vision with Eli and Eli said "he is the Lord he would do whatever seems best to him "Samuel continue to live at Shiloh with Eli and God was with him. All the Israelites were listening to what Samuel was telling them.

Review Exercise

1. Who were the parents of Samuel?
2. What made Eli to suspect that Hannah was drunk.
3. Describe the prayer of Hannah.
4. Explain the circumstances surrounding the birth of Samuel.
5. Narrate the birth of Samuel.
6. Describe the call of Samuel.
7. Why was not Eli bothered with Gods message through Samuel.

8. What character does Eli display as a father, is this good for the development of the child?

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Chapter 9

THE MONARCHY

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THE MONARCHY

OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, the student should be able to:

1. state the reasons for the rise of the monarchy
2. describe the reigns of Kings Saul, David and Solomon
3. identify the strengths and weaknesses of the Kings Saul, David and Solomon
4. explain events that led to the division of the kingdom

CONTENTS

- reasons for the rise of the monarchy
- reigns, achievements, strength and weakness of Kings
 - King Saul
 - King David
 - King Solomon
- Events that led to the division of the kingdom

The Period Before the Kings

Before Israel started having kings, it had judges who were leaders in the various areas the Israelites had settled. They tried to uphold the Covenant way of life and also acted as leaders in various other activities. Deborah, Gideon and Samson were some of the judges. Samuel was the last great judge of Israel. He was also a priest and a prophet.

During the time of Samuel, there was a lot of corruption in Israel resulting from the worship of the Canaanite gods. People did not behave according to the covenant laws given by God to Moses. An example of the extent of corruption can be seen in Hophni and Phinehas the sons of Eli as seen above.

Note: - there are different types of governments today like democracy, theocracy, monarchy and

Military.

Theocracy is a system of government ruled by God while Monarchy is a system of government ruled either by a queen or a king (Cite examples of such countries today)

5.1 The Rise of Monarchy

Reasons for the rise of monarchy in Israel. (1kings 8: 1 – 22)

The leaders of the Israelites went to Samuel and asked him to anoint a king for them so that

- They would be like other nations which had kings
- The king could lead them into battles and bring them victory
- Through the king, they could have proper leaders because some leaders were not doing their duty. For example, people were tired of the behaviors of Samuel's sons, Joel and Abijah, who were auxiliary judges when Samuel was old but were dishonest as they accepted bribes and hindered justice.

Samuel's reaction

- The Israelites had God as their king, therefore demanding for a human king was like rejecting God as a king
- He even felt that they had rejected him as God's representative
- Then Samuel prayed about it
- God said to Samuel that the Israelites had rejected Him and not Samuel because God was the king of the Israelites and by asking for a king it was like rejecting God.

What God said the kings would do?

Israel as a nation was a theocracy; a nation that was ruled by God Himself and not by a human being. Before he anointed the king they were asking for God told Samuel to warn the people on how the king would treat them.

So Samuel went to the people and said, this is how your king would treat you:

- He will make soldiers of your sons; some of them will serve in his war chariots, others in his Calvary, and others will run before his chariots
- Your sons will have to plough his fields and harvest the crops
- He will make their daughters work for him by making perfumes, cooking and baking.
- He will take the best fields, vineyards and olive groves from the people and give them to their officials
- He will take the best servants and animals and make them work for him
- He will take a tenth of your flock
- He will make all the Israelites slaves of the king

People did not listen but insisted that Samuel should appoint a king for them. God advised Samuel to find a king for the people.

Lesson:

- People should react in a responsible manner to bad leadership
- Vandalism and loss of lives should always be avoided when people are expressing their disappointments with the leadership at any level.

5.2 The First king of Israel

The first king of Israel was Saul. The choice of Saul as a king of Israel happened in a surprising way. God sent Samuel to anoint Saul as king.

Saul Meets Samuel (1 Samuel 9: 1 – 27; 10: 1 – 16)

What do we know about Saul?

- He was the son of Kish and the grandson of Abiel
- He was from the tribe of Benjamin (the smallest tribe in Israel)
- He was a handsome young man and a head taller than anyone else in Israel

Where did Saul and Samuel meet?

They met in the land of Zuph. Saul went there with a servant to look for his father's lost donkeys. While Samuel went there to offer sacrifice to the Lord and to anoint a man from the tribe of Benjamin whom God had chosen as the king of Israel.

After searching for the donkeys for a long time, the servant suggested to meet Prophet Samuel for help. (A prophet was also called a seer). Saul went to him and asked, "Is there a seer here?" Samuel said, "I am the seer. Go on to the place of worship. Both of you are to eat with today. Tomorrow I will answer all your questions. As for your father's lost donkeys, they are found and now he is worried about you. But, who is it that the people of Israel want so much? It is you, you and your father's family

Saul's response

Saul felt unworthy of being a leader for two reasons

- He belonged to the tribe of Benjamin, the smallest tribe in Israel
- His family was the least important one in the tribe. (Thus he wondered why Samuel talked to him in that way)

Samuel Anoints Saul

Saul ate with Samuel and then went to bed. At dawn, Samuel called to Saul on the roof to get up and he would send him away. Saul got up and they started off together. When they arrived at the edge of the road, Samuel said to Saul, "Tell the servant to go on ahead of us."

Then Samuel took a jar of Olive oil and poured it on Saul's head, and kissed him and said, "The Lord anoints you as ruler of his people, Israel"

Signs given to Saul by Samuel to prove that he was anointed as King

- i. Near Rachel's Tomb at Zelzah
Saul will meet two men. They will tell him that your father's lost donkeys have been found. Now your father is worried about you.
- ii. At Tabor under the sacred tree

Saul will meet three men. One will be leading three goats, the other will be carrying three loaves of bread and the other will be carrying a leather bag full of wine. They will greet you and offer you two loaves which you must accept.

iii. At the Hill God in Gibeah

At the entrance of the town, Saul will meet a group of prophets coming down from the altar on the Hill. They will be playing harps, drums flute etc. they will be dancing and shouting. Suddenly the Spirit of the Lord will take control of you and will join in their dancing.

Note that when Saul left, he experienced everything that Samuel told him. It was at Gilgal that Saul was acclaimed as king.

Saul Defeats the Ammonites (1Samuel 11: 1 – 15)

Saul's first challenge was to battle the Ammonites to rescue the people of Jabesh in the territory of Gilead. This is how it happened:

- King Nahash of Ammon led an army against the town of Jabesh in Gilead
- The men of Jabesh asked for a treaty to accept him as their leader
- Nahash agreed on condition that he would take out everyone's right eye
- The men of Jabesh called for a grace period of seven days to find out if someone can help them
- The messengers went to Gibeah where Saul lived
- When they told the news, people started crying
- Saul heard this when he was coming from the field
- The spirit of the Lord took control of him
- He cut his oxen into pieces and sent this message
- Whoever does not join Saul and Samuel will have this done to his oxen
- (Saul invoked Samuel's authority because he felt that his own status was not sufficient to make people obey since Saul was living a simple life and not as a king)

- So 300,000 men from Israel and 30, 000 men from Judah joined Saul and Samuel and they
- defeated the Amalekites.

The War Against the Amalekites (1 Samuel 15:1 – 9)

God instructed Saul as follows:

- "Go and attack the Amalekites and completely destroy everything they have. Do not leave a thing; kill all the men and women, children and babies; the cattle, sheep camels and donkeys"
- God ordered this because the Amalekites prevented the Israelites to pass through their land when they were coming from Egypt
- The Kenites, however, were warned to run away from the Amalekites so that they should not be killed together with the Amalekites
- The Kenites were spared because their ancestors were kind to the Israelites when they came from Egypt
- 200, 000 soldiers from Israel and 10,000 soldiers from Judah attacked the Amalekites and defeated them
- However, they captured King Agag alive and spared him
- They also spared best animals to be offered as a sacrifice to God
- This was disobedient because God had made it clear that all the Amalekites together with their animals must be killed

Saul is Rejected as King (1 Samuel 15: 10 – 35)

- Saul was rejected as king because of his sins
- God sent Samuel to condemn Saul because he disobeyed God's command by sparing King Agag and the best animals
- When Samuel asked Saul why he disobeyed God's command, Saul said that his men spared the best animals so as to offer them as a sacrifice to the LORD
- Then Samuel said, "Which does the Lord prefer; obedience or offerings and sacrifices? It is better to obey him than to sacrifice the best sheep to him. Rebellion against him is as bad as witchcraft, and

arrogance is as sinful as idolatry. Because you rejected the Lord's command, he has rejected you as king." (1 Samuel 15: 22 – 23)

- Saul thought that he could be forgiven. However, Samuel told him that there was no hope for that. God had decided to choose someone else and he would not change his mind
- Samuel demanded that King Agag should be brought to him and Agag came trembling. Samuel killed Agag in front of the altar of God in Gilgal
- After killing Agag, Samuel left and never saw Saul again. Samuel exercised death penalty

Death Penalty Today

Death penalty is a threat to human rights. "Every human being has a right to life." And there is no exception for this. However, some countries use death penalty to discourage people who are fond of killing others to stop from that behaviour

5.3 The Second King of Israel

David is Anointed King (1 Samuel 16: 1 – 13)

- God asked Samuel not to keep on grieving over Saul for he had rejected him as king. Instead God asked him to get some olive oil and go to Bethlehem, to a man named Jesse and anoint one of his sons as king
- Samuel expressed fear that should Saul hear about it he would be killed by Saul. However, God told him that he should take a calf to Bethlehem, tell the leaders that you want to offer sacrifice to the Lord and invite the family of Jesse. Samuel did so.
- Before the sacrifice, Samuel saw Jesse's son Eliab and said to himself, "This man standing here in the Lord's presence is surely the one he has chosen." But the Lord said to him, "Pay no attention to how tall or handsome he is. I have rejected him, because I do not judge as people judge. They look at the outward appearance, but I look at the heart"

- Then Jesse called his son Abinadab and brought him to Samuel. But Samuel said, "No, the Lord hasn't chosen him either" Jesse then brought Shammah. "No, the Lord hasn't chosen him either." Samuel said. The same was said to the seven sons of Jesse.
- Samuel asked, "Have you any more sons?" Jesse said there was still the youngest but was out taking care of the sheep. Samuel ordered that the boy should come for they would not offer the sacrifice until he came.
- Jesse sent for him and he came. He was a handsome, healthy young man and his eyes sparkled. The Lord said to Samuel, "This is the one anoint him!" Samuel took the olive oil and anointed him in front of his brothers. Immediately the Spirit of the Lord took control of him and was with him from that on. Samuel returned to Ramah after anointing David as king.

David Defeats Goliath (1 Samuel 17: 1 – 58)

Goliath challenges the Israelites

Goliath was from the city of Gath. He was very tall about 3 meters. He wore bronze armour that weighed about 57 kilograms, a bronze helmet. His legs were also protected by a bronze armour. His spear was as thick as the bar on a weaver's loom and its iron head weighed 7 kilograms.

Goliath challenged the Israelites to choose one person who could fight against him, on condition that, if Goliath had won, then the Israelites would be slaves for the Philistines. Likewise, if an Israelite won all the Philistines would as well be slaves of the Israelites. When Saul and his men heard this, they were terrified. Goliath challenged the Israelites every morning and evening for forty days

David asks to face Goliath

Jesse asked David to go and see how his brothers were faring at battle and to give them some food. When he arrived there Goliath, as usual, came to the battle line and challenged the Israelites. By then, Saul had promised that any man who would defeat Goliath

- Would be given a great reward
- Would be given his daughter to marry
- His family would not pay taxes

David learnt about these from several men. Then David asked King Saul to permit him to face Goliath because he was defying the army of the living God. King Saul at first refused but later he was convinced that David could do something to Goliath. He offered his sword and armour to David. David tried them but refused to use them saying he was not used to them. As a result, he opted to Goliath without any protection. He simply took his shepherd's stick and five smooth stones from the stream and a sling (caltapult)

David and Goliath Challenge each other

Goliath said to David, "What's that stick for? Do you think I'm a dog? Come on , I will give your body to the birds and animals to eat"

David answered, "You are coming against me with sword, spear and javelin, but I come against you in the name of the LORD'S Almighty, the God of Israelites armies, which you have defied ... I will defeat you and cut off your head. And I will give the bodies of the Philistines to the birds and animals to eat. Then the whole world will know that Israel has a God..."

David Defeats Goliath

Goliath started walking towards David. David ran quickly towards the Philistine battle line to fight him. He put his hand into his bag and took out a stone, which he slung at Goliath. It hit him on the forehead and broke his skull, and Goliath fell face downwards on the ground. Then David ran to him, stood over him, took Goliath's sword out of its sheath, and cut off his head and killed him.

After killing Goliath, Abner, the commander of Saul's army took David to appear before the King. King Saul asked him who his father was. David told him that he was the son of Jesse from Bethlehem.

David becomes King of Israel and Judah (2 Samuel 5: 1 – 10)

The leaders of all the tribes of Israel went to David at Hebron and gave three reasons why David should become their king. The reasons are:

- All the Israelites, both, in the North and South were of the same flesh and blood and thus were related
- David had demonstrated his military prowess during Saul's reign and thus had met an important requirement for kings at that time
- God had promised David that he would rule Israel

David was 30 years old when he became a king. He ruled in Hebron over Judah for seven and half years. After the death of Saul, David became the king of both Israel and Judah for 33 years. In total David was a king for 40 years.

When David became king of Israel, Jerusalem city belonged to the Jebusites. King David and his men attacked Jerusalem. The Jebusites said to him, "you will never get in here, even the blind and the crippled could keep you out." But David conquered the fortress of Zion and named it Jerusalem, the David's city. Then David moved from Hebron to Jerusalem.

David's Desire to build the Temple (2 Samuel 7: 1 – 17)

When King David ruled as king, Nathan was the prophet of God. One-day King David said to Nathan that he was living in a good palace made of cedar yet God's Covenant Box was kept in a tent. Nathan answered him that he should do whatever he had in mind because the Lord was with him. But that same night the Lord said to Nathan:

- Go and tell my servant David that you are not the one to build a temple for me to live in
- From the time I rescued the people of Israel from Egypt until now, I have never lived in a Temple
- I have travelled round in a tent and I have never asked any of the leaders that I appointed why they had not built me a temple made of cedar.

However, because of planning to build a temple God said to David

- I will make you as famous as the greatest leader in the world

- Your people will no longer be oppressed
- I will keep you safe from all your enemies
- I will give you many descendants
- I will make one of your sons king and will keep his kingdom strong
- He will be the one to build the temple for me
- I will make sure that his dynasty continues forever. Your dynasty will never end.

David and Bathsheba (2 Samuel 11: 1 – 27)

David sent out Joab with his officers and the Israelite army to fight against Rabbath Ammon and the Ammonites. David himself stayed in Jerusalem.

One day as King David was walking on the palace roof, he saw a woman taking a bath. She was very beautiful. David sent for her and when she came, David learnt that she was Bathsheba, daughter of Eliam and the wife of Uriah (the Hittite). Uriah was one of David's soldiers and that time was not at home.

King David seduced her and they had sexual intercourse. After sometime Bathsheba became pregnant. Her life and David's reputation were seriously endangered. So King David invited Uriah who by then was in a war fighting against the Ammonites. David attempted both by suggestion and intoxication to get Uriah to sleep with his wife but Uriah refused saying it was against their tradition, "When your friends are in camp you do not sleep with your wife."

When these plans failed, King David wrote a letter to Joab and sent it by Uriah. He wrote; "Put Uriah in front line, where the fighting is heaviest, then retreat and let him killed." Joab obeyed and Uriah got killed. When Bathsheba heard that her husband had been killed she mourned for him. When the time for mourning was over King David married her and she gave birth to a son. God was not happy and the son died. It was through Bathsheba that King David bore Solomon who succeeded him

(One sin leads to another sin. Discuss)

5.4 The Last King of the United Kingdom of Israel

Solomon is Made King (1 Kings 1: 11 – 53)

After the death of Absalom, Adonijah (the son of David and Haggith) was the eldest surviving son. He felt that he would succeed David as King. As such, he talked with Joab and Abiathar the priest and they agreed to support him. But Zadok the priest, Benaiah, Nathan the prophet, Rei and David's bodyguard were not on Adonijah's side.

One day Adonijah offered a sacrifice of sheep bulls, and fattened calves at Snake Rock and proclaimed himself as King. Nathan was not happy and took action

He went to Bathsheba and asked her, "Haven't you heard that Adonijah has made himself king. And king David doesn't know anything about it. If you want to save your life and the life of Solomon, I would ask you to go at once to King David and ask him, Your Majesty, didn't you solemnly promise me that my son Solomon would succeed you as king? How is it then, that Adonijah has become king?"

Nathan told her that while she would be speaking to David, he would come in and confirm the story. Bathsheba took the advice of Nathan and concluded her story to David by saying, "If you don't make a decision, as soon as you are dead, my son Solomon and I will be treated as traitors."

King David's Reaction (1 Kings 1: 28 – 53)

At that time, the King was old and weak, but could still act quickly when action was needed. Prophet Nathan arrived as Bathsheba was talking to the king and she confirmed her story. Then King David called Zadok the priest, Nathan the prophet and Benaiah the commander of bodyguard. David instructed them to place Solomon on the King's own mule and take him to the Spring of Gihon where Zadok and Nathan were to anoint him as king using holy oil.

Zadok and Nathan represented two key offices in Israel; the prophet communicated the will of God to the people, and the priest communicated the needs of the people to God. The priest and the prophet together were to anoint Solomon to emphasize the unity of their choice.

- Mules: were peaceful animals used by kings and princes
- Spring of Gihon: the main source of water for the entire city of Jerusalem, and thus an important public space.

King Solomon Asks for Wisdom (1 Kings 3: 1 – 28)

One-day king Solomon went to Gibeon to offer sacrifice because that was where the most famous altar was located. That night the Lord appeared to him in a dream and asked him, "What would you like me to give you?"

Solomon asked for wisdom so as to rule over the people with justice and to know the difference between good and evil. God was pleased with his request and so he gave him wisdom. In addition, he also promised to give him honour, wealth / riches and long life, on condition that he would obey God and keep God's commandments and laws.

King Solomon Judges a Difficult Case

The first execution of Solomon's wisdom was when two prostitutes quarreled over ownership of a baby. The two prostitutes came and presented themselves before King Solomon. One woman accused the other of stealing her baby and the other denied. In his judgement, king Solomon said that the child should be cut into two and each woman should be given half of it.

The real mother, her heart full of love for her son, said to the king, "Please, your majesty, do not kill the child! Give it to her." But the other woman said "don't give it to either of us, go ahead and cut it in two."

Then Solomon said, "Don't kill the child. Give it to the first woman- she is its real mother." When the people of Israel heard of Solomon's decision, they were all filled with deep respect for him.

Solomon Turns Away from God (1 Kings 11: 1 – 13)

Introduction

God commanded the Israelites to avoid intermarriages with other tribes which worshipped idols. This was because when people of different beliefs get married, one may give up his / her belief and join the belief of the other partner. Sometimes, they both give up their beliefs and adopt new ones.

Solomon turns away from God

King Solomon married many foreign wives. He had wives from Egypt, Moab, Hittite, Ammon, Edom and Sidon. In total Solomon had 700 princesses and 300 concubines. These women forced King Solomon to turn away from God and he started worshipping idols. Some of the foreign gods which King Solomon was worshipping so as to please his wives were: Astarte, the goddess of Sidon; Molech, the disgusting god of Ammon; and Chemosh, the disgusting god of Moab.

King Solomon built altars of gods everywhere so that his foreign wives could burn incense and offer sacrifices to their gods. (Most men are weak at the tears of women. Discuss)

God's intervention

God appeared twice to King Solomon warning him of worshipping idols but King Solomon could not listen to God.

God's punishment to king Solomon. (1 Kings 11; 9 – 13)

God said to Solomon that because you have deliberately broken your covenant with me and disobeyed my commands

- I promise that I will take the kingdom away from you and give it to one of your officials
- However, for the sake of King David
- This will not happen during your life time but during the reign of your son
- God will not take the whole kingdom away from him; instead he will leave him one tribe

Then Ahijah the prophet met Jeroboam, the son of Nebat and one of the officials of Solomon. Ahijah prophesied to Jeroboam that he would rule over the ten tribes of Israel. When Jeroboam heard of this prophecy he impatiently led unsuccessful rebellion against Solomon. He fled to Egypt and remained there in exile till the death of Solomon.

5.5 The Northern Tribes Revolt (Division of the Kingdom of Israel)

Rehoboam and Jeroboam

Rehoboam was one of king Solomon's sons and he was the heir to the throne. Jeroboam was one of the king Solomon's officials who was promised to rule over ten tribes. As seen above, Jeroboam had ran away from king Solomon and went to Egypt. After the death of Solomon, Jeroboam heard that the people wanted to crown Rehoboam to be a king so he came back to Israel.

Division of the Kingdom (1 Kings 12: 21 – 23)

The people of the northern tribes in companion of Jeroboam went to Rehoboam and said, "Your father Solomon treated us harshly and placed heavy burden on us. If you make these burdens lighter and make life easier for us, we will be your loyal subjects."

Rehoboam Response

He asked the people to give him three days, "Come back in three days and I will give you my answer. Rehoboam consulted older men who advised him to consider about the people's request if he wanted them to serve him loyally. Rehoboam ignored the advice, and consulted the young men who had grown up with him, "What do you advise me to do?" he asked. They replied, "This is what you should tell them, My little finger is thicker than my father's waist! My father placed heavy burdens on you, I will make them even heavier. He beat you with a whip, I'll flog you with a
horsewhip."

After three days the people came back to listen to Rehoboam's answer. Rehoboam communicated to the people the advice from the young men.

When the people heard what Rehoboam had said, they shouted, "Down with David and his family! What have they ever done for us? People of Israel, let's go home! Let Rehoboam look out for himself!" This is how the people of Israel rebelled with Jeroboam as the king of the northern kingdom with eleven tribes. While Rehoboam became king of Judah with one tribe.

Note that the northern tribes established their own kingdom called Israel while the southern kingdom took the of Judah. This is how the kingdom of Israel got divided.

Jeroboam Turns Away From God

King Jeroboam was not happy to see his people going to Jerusalem in Judah to offer sacrifices in the Temple. He strongly feared that as the people did so, they would transfer their allegiance to King Rehoboam of Judah, who would in turn kill him. Thus he established Bethel and Dan as places of worship for the people of the north. He made two bull calves of gold and placed one in Bethel and the other in Dan and said, "... here are your gods who brought you out of Egypt worship them." So the people sinned by worshipping them.

Worship at Bethel is Condemned

Jeroboam instituted a religious festival on the 15th day of the 8th month. On that day, King Jeroboam used to go to Bethel to offer a bull as a sacrifice. This was bad because the king had no authority to institute a special day of a religious festival in the worship of God. The king started his own religion, he was worshipping idols.

5.6 The Strength and Weaknesses of the Kings

Strengths of the Kings

Kings of Israel	Where to identify strengths	Identify the strength
Saul	1 Samuel 11: 1 - 15	
David	1 Samuel 17: 1 – 58, 2 Samuel 7: 1 - 17	
Solomon	1 Kings 3: 1 – 28	

Weaknesses of the kings

Kings of Israel	Where a weakness case can be identified	Identify the weakness
Saul	1 Samuel 15: 10 – 16	
David	1 Samuel 11: 1 – 27	

Solomon	1 Kings 11: 1 – 13, 1Kings 12: 1 - 33	
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Strengths of King Saul

- He was the first king of Israel, anointed by Samuel when the people of Israel wanted a king
- He fought a successful war against the Ammonites
- He fought a successful war against the Philistines (though part of that success was due to David)
- He fought a successful war against the Amalekites (successful in the military sense but failed in the religious sense)

Weaknesses of King Saul

- He offered a sacrifice on behalf of the army before engaging in the war instead of Samuel. 1 Samuel 13: 8 – 14. This was wrong because Saul was not a priest nor a prophet
- Instead of destroying all the animals and the people of Amalek as God commanded, Saul spared best animals and the life of king Agag (1 Samuel 15: 7 – 25)

Strength of King David

- He defeated Israelites enemies, for example, the Philistines, Moabites, Ammonites, Edomite
- He expanded his kingdom after defeating the enemies
- He improved the economy of Israel because he made it a policy to tax all the nations he defeated
- He united the Israelites, after ruling for seven and half in Judah, the people of Israel accepted David as their king too
- He captured Jerusalem from the Jebusites
- He established Jerusalem as a capital city, a political and religious Centre

Weaknesses of King David

- He committed adultery with Bathsheba, Uriah's wife
- He arranged Uriah's death
- He failed to discipline his sons Ammon (2 Samuel 13: 14 – 29) and Absalom (2 Samuel 16 – 17, 18: 14 – 15)
- David ignored the advice of Nathan the prophet and took a census which resulted into a plague

Strength of King Solomon

- Diplomacy: Solomon was diplomatic. He married foreign wives so as to maintain peaceful relations with surrounding nations
- Defense: He built a strong professional army to make sure that Israel would be well protected in case of attack. The army had heroes and chariots
- Civil Service: Solomon had a well-organized civil service and administrative system
- Music: He was a talented musician and he composed 3,000 proverbs and over 1,000 songs
- He built the temple of the Lord

Weaknesses of King Solomon

- He married foreign wives who forced him to start worshipping idols
- He used forced labour to complete building projects e.g. the temple
- He heavily taxed the people in order to run the country
- He broke the sixth commandment when he killed his half-brother Adonijah

Topic Review Exercise

1. Define the terms Monarchy and Theocracy
2. Name the Israelite king who defeated the Ammonites
3. Name the parents of King Solomon
4. Describe the main strength of King David
5. Explain how the following people displayed elements of democracy in their activities:
 - i. Rehoboam

- ii. Soldiers from Judah
- 6. From the story of northern tribes asking Rehoboam to treat them fairly, Rehoboam's refusal and the reaction of the people; what lessons can the following people learn today
 - i. Politicians (Members of Parliament)
 - ii. Parents
 - iii. You as learners
- 7. Between Rehoboam and Jeroboam who was a better King? Give reasons for your answer.

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Bible Knowledge Form 2

Chapter 1

THE EARLY LIFE OF JESUS

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THE EARLY LIFE OF JESUS

OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, the student should be able to:

1. define the term 'Gospel'
2. describe the early life of Jesus Christ

CONTENTS

- meaning of the term 'Gospel'
- identifying the Gospels
- early life of Jesus Christ
 - narrating the birth of Jesus Christ
 - baptism of Jesus Christ
 - significance of the baptism of Jesus Christ
 - temptations of Jesus Christ

Introduction

The life of Jesus Christ is very important to Christians. Jesus Christ is the son of God who was sent to save all mankind from the danger of sin and its consequences, death (i.e. eternal separation from God). The important events in the life of Jesus include: His birth, teachings, death, resurrection and ascension. In our course we shall examine some of these events.

1.1 The Gospel and Birth Stories

By the end of this chapter, the students must be able to:

- Define the term "gospel"
- Describe the early life of Jesus Christ; the birth of Jesus

The meaning of the term "Gospel"

The story of Jesus as the messiah and Saviour is told in the Gospels. The word "Gospel" means "Good News". The gospels therefore, tell of the good news of how Jesus came to save the Israelites and mankind as a whole. The gospel can also be defined as any book in the Bible with stories

about Jesus Christ from his early life up to either the resurrection or ascension. There are four gospels Matthew, Mark, Luke and John narrating the same story but from slightly different angles. In this chapter, we shall focus on the story of Jesus as told in the gospels of Matthew and Mark.

The Early Life of Jesus; the Birth of Jesus Christ

Matthew starts his gospel by tracing the ancestry of Jesus Christ. From this, we learn about some of the important ancestors of Jesus such as David and Abraham.

Significance of the family tree of Jesus

- It shows that Jesus was indeed the Promised Messiah born from David's lineage as it prophesied by Isaiah
- It also showed that Jesus had a royal or kingly descent as a descendant of King David
- It shows that Jesus was one of the Israelites, a descendant of Abraham, one of the great patriarchs

The Birth of Jesus Christ (Matthew 1: 18 – 25)

- This was how the birth of Jesus Christ took place
- His mother Mary was engaged to Joseph
- But before they were married, she found out that she was going to have a baby by the Holy spirit
- Joseph was a man who always did what was right
- But he did not want to disgrace Mary publicly
- So he made plans to break the engagement privately
- While he was thinking about this, an angel of the Lord appeared to him in a dream and said, "Joseph descendant of David, do not be afraid to take Mary to be your wife for it is by the Holy Spirit that she has conceived. She will have a son, and you will name him Jesus because he will save people from their sins."
- Now all this happened in order to make what the Lord had said through the prophet (Isaiah) come true
- "A young virgin will become pregnant and have a son, and he will be called Immanuel" (which means God is with us) Isaiah 7 : 14

- So when Joseph woke up, he married Mary as the angel of the Lord had told him to do.
- But he had no sexual relationship with her before she gave birth to her son.
- And Joseph named him Jesus

Main Points

- Joseph was born from David's lineage. His father Joseph was David's descendant and therefore Jesus was indeed the Promised Messiah
- The word Messiah means the anointed one
- Jesus birth through a virgin was prophesied by Isaiah (At that time virginity was highly valued in the Jewish tradition. It was a shame and disgrace if one was not a virgin before marriage)
- Joseph exercised self-control when he learnt about Mary's pregnancy in the sense that
 - i. He did not want to put Mary to shame by publicizing that she was pregnant
 - ii. Instead he planned to leave her secretly
 - iii. Joseph never had sexual intercourse with Mary until the baby was born
- Jesus means God saves or God is my Salvation
- Emmanuel means God is with us.

Visitors from the East (Matthew 2: 1 – 12)

In most of our societies today, the birth of a child is such a big blessing. The mother and the child are rewarded with gifts. This practice was the same when Jesus was born.

- Jesus was born in the town of Bethlehem in Judea, during the reign of King Herod the Great
- As soon as he was born some men who studied the stars came from the East to Jerusalem and asked
- "Where is the baby born to be the king of the Jews? We saw his star when it came up in the east, and we have come to worship him."

Reaction of Herod when he heard about this

- He was very upset

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- He called the chief priests and the teachers of the Law and asked them
- Where will the Messiah be born?
- "In the town of Bethlehem in Judea" they answered, as it was prophesied by Micah (Micah 5:2)
- So Herod called the men to a secret meeting and found out from them the exact time the star had appeared

Then he sent them to Bethlehem with **these instructions**

- Go and make a careful search for the child
- When you find him, let me know
- So that I too may go and worship him

When the visitors from the east started their journey to Bethlehem, the star appeared again and guided them where Jesus was born. When they found him

- They knelt down and worshipped him
- They gave Jesus the following gifts
 - i. Gold : a gift for the king
 - ii. Frankincense : gift for a priest
 - iii. Myrrh : gift for someone who is to die

After that they returned to their country by another road since God had warned them in a dream not to go back to King Herod as he had planned to kill the baby.

Main Points

- The men from the east are also known as the Magi / astrologers
People who study the stars. They were possibly priests or Kings of Persia
- Christians should learn to worship God with joy and gladness as the men from the east did.

Review Questions

- Describe what happens in your community when a girl gets pregnant before marriage
- Explain any two prophecies that were fulfilled by the birth of Jesus
- How did Joseph exercise self control when he learnt about Mary's pregnancy?
- How can self control help today's young people?
- Explain the meaning of the gifts offered to Jesus
- Why was Herod annoyed to hear of the birth of the king of the Jews?

The Role of John the Baptist

- He prepared the way for the coming of the Messiah
- He ushered people to the Messianic age
- He bore witness to Jesus as the Messiah
- He was the link between the Old Testament and the New Testament
- He acted as a forerunner or precursor of Jesus
- He broke the period of prophetic silence that lasted over 400 years between Malachi and himself
- He baptized Jesus in the River Jordan
- He condemned the Pharisees for their hypocrisy and the Roman authorities for their arrogance and evil

John's preaching (Mark 1:1 – 8)

John was preaching in the desert of Trans Jordan and his message was

- Turn away from your sins and be baptized
- And God will forgive your sins

Many people from the province of Judea and the city of Jerusalem went to hear John. They confessed their sins, and he baptized them in the River Jordan

- John wore clothes made of Camel's hair, with a leather belt round his waist
- His food was locusts and wild honey
- He announced to the people that the man who would come after him was greater than he was:
- He was not even good enough to bend down and untie his sandals
- He baptized them with water, but he will baptize them with the Holy Spirit

Note that his preaching in the desert was the fulfillment of the prophesy of Isaiah 40: 3; "a voice cries out, prepare in the wilderness a road for the Lord! Clear the way in the desert for our God!" John had a duty to clear the way for Jesus Christ, whom he said was greater than himself.

Below are some of the **differences** between John's preaching and how people preach today

- John did not follow people when he was preaching; instead people were following him to hear the message. Today's preachers follow people in buses market places and other public places
- John was baptizing people who were willing to be baptized without giving them special teachings for a certain period of time. Today, it takes years for one to be baptized because preachers demand that you should go for special church teachings for a period of time.

However, some of their **similarities** are as follows

- John the Baptist asked people to repent their sins; preachers today do the same thing
- John asked people to be baptized; preachers today do the same

1.2 Jesus Christ Prepares for his work

The Actual Baptism of Jesus (Mark 1: 9 – 11)

- Baptism comes from a Greek word meaning to deep in water. John was baptizing people as a symbol of repentance for their sins
- Before Jesus began his public ministry, he went from Nazareth to Galilee and he was baptized by John in the River Jordan

What happened at his baptism?

As soon as he came out of the river Jordan

- The heavens opened
- The Holy Spirit descended on Him in the form of a dove
- A voice came from heaven saying, "You are my own dear son, I am pleased with you" Mark 1:11

Reasons why Jesus received the baptism of repentance yet he was sinless.

- He got baptized because he had taken upon Himself the sins of humankind and repented on their behalf
- He wanted to identify himself with the sinful nature of humankind
- He wanted to set an example to his followers so that they could emulate him
- His baptism was a sign that marked the end of John's ministry as the Messiah had come and people had heard the voice of God saying that He was His son. It also marked the beginning of Jesus' own public ministry

Significance of Jesus' baptism

- It demonstrated Jesus' humility
- The voice that was heard put the confusion that was there as some people thought that was the messiah
- Jesus received the power of the Holy Spirit which was necessary for his ministry

Relevance of Jesus' baptism to Christians today

- It helps Christians to be baptized and identify themselves with the Christian church
- Baptism makes a believer a child of God
- Christians receive the Holy Spirit through baptism
- Baptism cleanses Christians and prepares them for the Kingdom of God
- Christians are united to God the Father, the Son and the Holy spirit through baptism

Temptations of Jesus Christ (Matthew 4: 1 – 11)

Soon after baptism, the Spirit led Jesus into the desert. The main aim was to prepare for his public ministry through prayer. He stayed there for forty days and forty nights without food, and Jesus was hungry. Then the devil came to him and tempted him

Note

- The number 40 stands for a complete period of time. It entails that Jesus stayed in the desert for a complete period of time for him to prepare for his public ministry
- After that Jesus was tempted by the devil. He was tempted as the Messiah. Thus the temptations are also known as Messianic temptations
- The devil tempted Jesus to achieve his goal of saving mankind in a wrong way other than as the suffering servant as God had planned.
- A temptation is a strong feeling of wanting to do something contrary to what you are supposed to do. Or. Temptations refers to be under the influence of the devil to do a sinful thing
- The temptations were three fold

The First Temptation (Matthew 4:3)

Order these stones to turn into bread

- The devil came to Jesus and said, "If you are God's son, order these stones to turn into bread"

Note

- As Jesus was reflecting on how best he could save mankind, the devil came in with a temptation
- He was suggesting to Jesus to make his life easier and get a following by offering himself and the people food. Then he would bribe people into following him. That was in line with people's expectation at that time namely that a good leader should provide people with food and entertainment
- Jesus could see through the temptation, so he rejected it, even though he was hungry

- Thus in his answering, Jesus Christ quoted the Old Testament and said, The Scripture says *"Human beings cannot live on bread alone, but need every word that God speaks"* (Deuteronomy 8:3)
- This implied that human beings cannot find fullness of life in material things alone.

The Second Temptation (Matthew 4: 5 – 6)

If you are God's son throw yourself down; angels will take care of you

- The devil took Jesus to Jerusalem, the Holy city, set him on the highest point of the Temple (pinnacle) and said to him
- If you are God's son, throw yourself down for the scripture says, "God will give orders to the angels about you. They will hold you up with their hands so that not even your feet will be hurt on the stone"

Note

In this temptation, Satan wanted Jesus to throw himself from the pinnacle of the Temple that was 95 meters into the Kendron valley below. This was a temptation to do something spectacular and raise sensation in people that Jesus was not an ordinary but a divine person. In so doing people would be bound to follow whatever he says.

In his answering, Jesus said, "But the scripture also says, *Do not put the Lord your God to the test*" (Deuteronomy 6:16)

The Third Temptation (Matthew 4: 8 – 9)

(... Kneel down and worship me...)

- The devil took Jesus to a very high mountain and showed him all the kingdoms of the world in all their greatness
- "All this I will give you" the devil said, "If you kneel down and worship me"

Note

Here the devil was actually asking Jesus to use worldly power and influence, when to do so would have meant idolatry.

Jesus answered, *"Go away, Satan!"* the scripture says, *"Worship the Lord your God and serve him only."* (Deuteronomy 6:13)

After these the devil left Jesus Christ and the angels came and helped him.

Once again note that the temptations of Jesus did come in quick succession like scenes in play. Rather Jesus retired to a lonely place for 40 days reflecting on how he could save mankind. The devil proposed three wrong ways of saving mankind but Jesus rejected them knowing that God had sent him to save people as a suffering servant.

Significance of temptations of Jesus to Christians today

- If Jesus was tempted, Christians should expect temptations in their daily life
- Christians should be encouraged that if Jesus overcame temptations, they too can overcome them
- Christians should be careful with false preachers who use the Bible for evil purposes like the devil
- Christians should learn that when they are in problems, they should solve them using the teaching of the Bible
- Christians should learn that it is not sinful to be tempted and God does not tempt someone beyond his / her strength to defeat them

REVIEW QUESTIONS

- What do you understand by the term baptism?
- List down any two things that happened when Jesus was baptized
- Explain what prompted Jesus to receive the baptism of repentance yet he was sinless
- Relate the temptation in which the devil used the scripture.
- How did Jesus overcome the temptations
- Describe any two significance of the temptations of Jesus to the Christians today
- Give some ways in which Christians can be tempted today.

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Bible Knowledge

Form 2

Chapter 2

THE MINISTRY OF JESUS CHRIST

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THE MINISTRY OF JESUS CHRIST



OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, the student should be able to:

1. describe how Jesus began His ministry
2. describe the ministry of Jesus Christ

CONTENTS

- how Jesus Christ began His ministry
- rejection of Jesus at Nazareth
- work of Jesus Christ

1.1 The Teaching of Jesus Christ / The work of Jesus Christ

The beginning of the ministry of Jesus Christ

The call of the disciples (mark 1: 14 – 20)

After John the Baptist had been arrested by Herod Antipas, Jesus began preaching the Good News from God. He went to Galilee and proclaimed that

- The right time has come and the Kingdom of God is near
- Turn away from your sins and believe the Good News

Meaning of the this message

- The right time has come: means time of deliverance by God has come
- The Kingdom of God is near: means the rule of God was about to be established by Jesus. And the Kingdom of God was the central teaching of Jesus Christ
- Turn away from your sins and believe the Good news: means repentance is the only condition for salvation

As Jesus passed along the shore of Lake Galilee, he saw two fishermen, Simeon and his brother Andrew, catching fish with a net. Jesus said to them, "come on with me, and I will teach you to catch people." At once that left their nets and went with him.

He went a little farther on and saw two other brothers James and John, the sons of Zebedee. They were in a boat getting their nets ready. As soon as Jesus saw them, he called them. They left their father Zebedee in the boat with the hired men and went with Jesus.

Note that the first four disciples had a lot in common such as

- They were a pair of brothers: Peter and Andrew & James and John
- They were all fishermen by profession
- They were called to be fishers of people or catch people meaning to win people into the Kingdom of God
- They all responded to the call with promptness.

The Parable

- Jesus Christ used parables in his teaching
- A parable is an earthly story with heavenly meaning. In parables concrete realities of everyday life are used to illustrate their teaching on the meaning of the sacred history.

-

Aim of teaching in parables

- To attract attention of the audience
- To provoke interest
- To make people understand the message easily
- To make people remember the message easily
- To avoid debates and discussions

The parable of the Sower (Mark 4: 1 – 20)

Jesus said the parable of the sower when he was in a boat in the Lake Galilee and the crowd stood on the shore at the water edge. Jesus Christ said this parable

- A man went to sow corn
- He scattered the seed in the field, that fell on different places as follows;
 - a. Along the path; the birds came and ate the seeds
 - b. On the rocky ground where there was little soil; the seeds soon sprouted, because the soil wasn't deep. Then when the sun came up, it burnt the young plants, and because the roots had not grown deep enough, the plants soon dried up.
 - c. Among thorn bushes; the thorn bushes grew up and choked the plants, and they did not produce any corn
 - d. In good soil; the plants sprouted, grew and produced corn; some had thirty grains, others sixty and others a hundred.

Some people went to Jesus Christ and asked him the **meaning of the parable of the sower**.

- The sower is Jesus (today any preacher) who teaches the word of God
- The seeds he was sowing refer to the word of God from his mouth to the people who listen to Him.
- In Palestine, one of the methods of planting was by broadcasting in which seeds fell anywhere as mentioned in the parable
- The different places that the seeds fell on represent the various hearts of the people that receive the word that Jesus preaches to them
- The seeds that fell on the path represent the people who hear the word and do not take care of it. As soon as they hear the message, Satan, represented by the birds in the parable, comes and takes it away.
- Other people are like the seeds that fell on rocky ground. As soon as they hear the message, they receive it gladly but it does not sink deep into them and they do not last long. So when trouble or persecution comes because of the message, they give up at once.
- Other people are like the seeds that fell among the thorn bushes. These are the ones who hear the message, but the worries about this life, the love for riches, and all other kinds of desires crowd in and choke the message and they do not bear fruits
- Other people are like seeds that fell on good soil. They hear the message, accept it and bear fruits. For example they repent and also preach and change the behavior of others.

Jesus is rejected at Nazareth (Mark 6: 1 – 6)

- At the beginning of his ministry, Jesus taught and performed miracles in the temple, synagogue as well as in the open space. Many of his home town had heard about the miracles and wonders performed by Jesus elsewhere. They expected him to perform even more miracles and wonders in Nazareth.

- However on one Sabbath when Jesus was teaching in the synagogue at Nazareth, the people who heard him were amazed and said, "Where did he get all this? What wisdom is this that has been given him? How does he perform miracles?" (Mark 6: 2 – 3)
- They wondered where he got all he was teaching them
- They were amazed at the great wisdom he had
- They wondered how he could perform miracles

Then

- They discussed among themselves and started digging Jesus' family background
- The people recognized Jesus as one of them as they said
- "Isn't he the son of the carpenter and Mary?
- And the brother of James, Joseph, Judas and Simeon?
- Aren't his sisters living here?"

They knew his parents and relatives very well. As such they could not expect or believe Jesus to do anything different from what people in their community could do. So they rejected him.

Jesus' reaction to his rejection at his home

- Jesus said to them, "prophets are respected everywhere except in their own hometown and by their relatives and their family" Mark 6: 4
- Jesus was not able to perform any miracle there, except that he placed his hands on a few sick people and healed them
- Jesus was greatly surprised to see that people from his own hometown had no faith

The people underrated that Jesus, the son of Joseph a carpenter and Mary could be the messiah. Thus they rejected him.

The Mission of the 12 disciples (Mark 6: 7 – 13)

Then Jesus went to the villages round Nazareth, teaching the people. Then Jesus called the twelve apostles and sent them out two by two.

What was their mission?

They were sent to do the following:

- Preach so that people should turn away from their sins
- Cast out demons
- Heal the sick by rubbing olive oil on them

Instructions given to them

- Do not take anything with you on your journey: no bread, no beggar's bag, no money in your pocket, no extra shirt
- Take a stick
- Wear sandals
- Wherever you are welcomed, stay in that house until you leave that place
- Wherever people do not welcome you or listen to you, leave that place and shake the dust off your feet. "a sign of warning and judgment to them."

Significance of the instructions given to them

- To assure them that God would provide them with all their needs
- To let them travel faster and lighter since their mission was urgent
- To save time so there was no need to negotiate with people
- Riches can prevent someone from preaching
- To warn the people that by refusing them, they reject Good news of salvation and hence will not enter the Kingdom of God. (dust off your feet)

Note;

Apostles were asked to heal the sick by rubbing olive oil on them. Today, pastors use Holy water/ anointed water to heal the sick, to bless buildings, to chase away witches and wizards (some churches use olive oil)

However, do not misapply anointing water / oil by using it as a form of fetish (charm), like non – believers (Pagans)

1.2 The Miracles performed by Jesus Christ

Meaning of Miracles

- A miracle is an act which does not follow natural rules and is attributed to the work of God.
- Jesus performed miracles that included; healing, exorcism. Resurrection and nature
- In this section we analyze some of these miracles

Possible reasons why Jesus performed miracles

- To show that the kingdom of God was in control
- To satisfy people's needs to be healed in case of healing miracles
- Out of pity of those who suffered

Note that Jesus did not perform miracles so as to show off his talents or to entertain his audience

A. The healing of Simon's mother – in – law (Mark 1: 29 – 31)

- After leaving the synagogue in Capernaum, Jesus and his disciples went to the house of Simon and Andrew. He went with the two disciples; James and John.
- Simon's mother- in – law was sick in bed with fever. As soon as Jesus arrived, he was told about her. He went to her, took her by the hand and helped her up. The fever left her, and she began to wait on them.
- We presume that she gave them some food as the Jewish people had a special way of welcoming people in their homes. For example washing the dust off their feet and hands. Then they were given food to eat.

After healing Simon's mother – I – law, people brought to Jesus all the sick, and all those who had demons. Jesus healed many who were sick with all kinds of diseases and drove out many demons. Jesus commanded the demons to keep quiet and they did so as they knew that He was the Son of God, the Promised Messiah

Although Jesus was the son of God, he prayed a lot. For example after the events, and long before daylight, Jesus went out of the town to a lonely place, where he prayed. Simon and others disciples looked for Jesus

found him where he had withdrawn Himself to pray. They told him that many people were looking for him. He told them he had to leave and go to the neighbouring towns so that he could proclaim the message of the Good news there also.

B. The healing of a man with a dreaded skin disease (leprosy) (Mark 1: 35 – 45)

- Leprosy was a deadly skin disease that was feared among the Jews just as it was in Africa
- The Jews believed that the disease was contagious and made one to be unclean and unfit of any human contact
- Thus the victim was supposed to be isolated and stay in the bush until healed
- While going for quarantine, the victim was supposed to
 - i. Wear torn or sack clothes
 - ii. Cover the upper lip with a piece of cloth
 - iii. Attach bell to their legs that gave a warning sound as they approached others
 - iv. Shout, "Unclean! Unclean!" so that others should not come into contact with them
 - v. Even food was served to them at a distance
- Once they were healed, they were supposed to
 - i. Go and show themselves to the priest for examination since it was the priest who would certify a person healed and allow him back into society and temple
 - ii. Be purified as the law of Moses required
 - iii. Be given a certificate that he / she was really cured and purified.

How Jesus healed such a man.

- One day a man suffering from a dreaded skin disease came to Jesus, knelt down, and begged him for help
- If you want to, he said, you can make me clean
- Jesus was filled with pity, and stretched out his hand and touched him
- I do want to, he answered, be clean

- At once the disease left the man , and he was clean
- Then Jesus ordered the man
 - i. Not to tell anyone about the miracle
 - ii. To go to the priest and let him examine you
 - iii. To offer the sacrifice that Moses ordered

In spite of the stern order not to spread the news about it, the man went away and began to spread the news everywhere.

Main points

- The man said, if you want to, you can make me clean. He felt unworthy of being helped
- Jesus broke the Jewish law by touching the untouchable; he became unclean
- Jesus fulfilled the Jewish law by sending the man to the priest
- Jesus demanded for secrecy because the time had not yet come for Jesus to be declared Messiah

C. Healing of the paralysed man (Mark 2: 1 – 12)

- In Mark 2 1 – 12, Jesus had returned from proclaiming the word of God. He was at Capernaum in someone's house. Many people heard that he was back and they flocked to him in so large numbers that they filled the room completely
- Jesus was preaching the message to them when four men arrived carrying a paralysed man on a mat to Jesus
- Because of the crowd, they could not get the man to him
- So they made a hole in the roof right above the place where Jesus was
- When that had made an opening, they let the man down, lying on his mat
- Seeing how much faith they had, Jesus said to the paralysed man, "My son, your sins are forgiven"
- This angered some teachers of the law who were there and they questioned in their hearts

- "How does he dare to talk like this? This is blasphemy! God is the only one who can forgive sins!"
- Note that blasphemy (i.e. insulting God) was a very serious offense/sin in the Jewish religion. Only God could forgive sins. No person could compare himself with God. Whoever did so, committed blasphemy and was supposed to be stoned to death.
- Jesus knew what they were thinking, so he said to them
- "Why do you think such things? Is it easier to say to this paralysed man, "Your sins are forgiven" or to say, "Get up, pick up your mat and walk?"
- Then Jesus said to them, "I will prove to you that the son of man has authority on earth to forgive sins," so he said to the paralysed man, "I tell you, get up, pick up your mat, and go home."
- The paralysed man got up, picked up his mat, and hurried away.
- The people were amazed and praised God: "we have never seen anything like this"

Main Points

- When Jesus said your sins are forgiven, he was accused of blasphemy
- To say your sins are forgiven is easier since forgiveness of sins takes place in one's secret heart and in addition Jews believed God was punishing the man because of his sins
- While to say get up and walk can be verified physically
- Jesus healed the man because of the faith of the four men

D. Healing on the Sabbath (Mark 3: 1 – 6)

- Jesus was in a synagogue where there was a man with a paralysed hand. Some people were there who wanted to accuse Jesus of doing wrong. So they watched him closely to see whether he would heal the man on the Sabbath.
- Jesus said to the man, "Come here to the front." Then he asked the people, "What does our law allow us to do on the Sabbath? To help or to harm? To save someone's life or to destroy it?"

- The people did not answer him because they were in dilemma. Jesus was angry as he looked round at them, but at the same time he felt sorry for them, because they were so stubborn and wrong.
- Then Jesus said to the man, "stretch out your hand" he stretched it and it became well again
- Upon seeing this, the Pharisees left the synagogue and met at once with some members of Herod's party, and they made plans to kill Jesus

Lessons learnt

- Sabbath was the Holy day for the Jews. On this day, no one was allowed to do any work it was a day of resting as well as a day of worship. Even healing which was not out of emergency was regarded as work and hence forbidden. Thus people were watching closely to see if he would heal the man on the Sabbath
- By healing the man on the Sabbath Jesus teaches that
 - i. The Sabbath was made for man, therefore, man is the master of the Sabbath
 - ii. Doing charitable work / helping the needy on the Sabbath is more important than observing the Sabbath rules
 - iii. Sabbath is a holiday but they can do private work

E. Choosing of the twelve apostles (Mark 3: 13 -19)

As his popularity kept growing and tension with Jewish authorities worsening, Jesus began to get more focused on His ministry. He went up a hill and chose among his disciples the twelve whom he named apostles. Among them

- Simon (the brother of Andrew) whom he gave the name Peter meaning the rock
- James and John sons of Zebedee whom Jesus nicknamed Boanerges "men of thunder"
- Judas Iscariot, the one who betrayed Jesus
- Others were: Andrew, Phillip, Matthew, Thomas, James, Bartholomew, Theudas and Simon the zealot

Possible reasons for choosing the twelve apostles

- To be his closest friends / disciples
- To give the special training of proclaiming the gospel as he was to die
- To send them out as missionaries
- To lay the foundation of new Israel or a new people of God
- They were from all walks of life to symbolize that the Kingdom of God was universal

Note

- A disciple is a follower of Jesus
- An apostle is someone chosen and sent out as a missionary

F. Calming the storm (Mark 4: 35 – 41)

- After teaching people in parables till evening, Jesus Christ suggested that they should cross to the other side of the lake Galilee. They agreed and so they (disciples) left the crowd and got into the boat in which Jesus was already sitting. Then they sailed off
- Suddenly a strong wind blew up, and the water began to spill over into the boat, so that it was about to fill with water. Jesus was in the back of the boat, sleeping with his head on a pillow
- The disciples woke him up and said, "Teacher, don't you care that we are about to die?"
- Jesus stood up and commanded the wind, "Be quiet!" and he said to the waves, "Be still." The wind died down and there was a great cal. Then Jesus said to his disciples, 'why are you frightened! Have you still no faith?"
- But they were terribly afraid and said to one another, "Who is this man? Even the wind and waves obey him!"

Lessons

- Jesus had power over nature. (This is a nature miracle)
- Jesus was a truly human being who could feel tired after working and then fall asleep
- The disciples displayed lack of faith in Jesus as the son of God
- God's Kingdom is more powerful than Satan's

G. Healing a man with evil spirits (Mark 5: 1 – 10)

- Jesus and his disciples arrived well on the other side of the lake Galilee in the territory of Gerasa. The first person to meet Jesus and his disciples there was a man coming from the burial caves, full of evil spirits (mob0. Apparently the man was mad.

Characteristics of madness in this man (mob)

- He was living among the tombs
- He had extraordinary powers: he could break chains if tied and could smash the irons on his feet
- He was too strong to be controlled
- He was cutting himself with stones
- Day and night he wondering among the tombs and the hills screaming

How did the man react when he saw Jesus at a distance? (Their conversation).

- He ran towards him, fell on his knees before him and screamed in a loud voice
- "Jesus son of the Most High God! What do you want with me? For God's sake, I beg you, don't punish me!" (He said this because Jesus was saying, "Evil spirit come out of this man!")
- Jesus asked what was his name
- He answered that he was Mob (meaning there are so many of us)
- And Mob kept on begging Jesus not to send the evil spirits out of that region
- The evil spirit begged Jesus to send them into the pigs which were feeding on the hillside
- Jesus let them go into the pigs
- The evil spirits went out of the man, and entered the pigs
- The whole herd (about 2, 000 pigs) rushed down the side of the cliff into the lake and was drowned.

Reactions of the people

- Those who were attending to the pigs ran to the nearby villages and explained what they saw. When the people came to see what had

happened, they were amazed to see the man sitting next to Jesus and in his normal senses.

- They misunderstood the destruction of the herd. Possibly, they mistook Jesus' act as based on Jewish attitude towards unclean animals. So they asked him to leave their territory. The healed man asked to go with Jesus but he was told to go and show himself to his family and spread the news about salvation among his people

Main Points

- Jesus was more powerful than the evil spirits or the kingdom of God is greater than that of Satan
- Evil spirits recognized Jesus as the son of god and feared his power of exorcism
- The presence of pigs indicated that Jesus was in a gentile territory

H. Jairus' Daughter and the woman who touched Jesus' Cloak (Mark 5: 21 – 43)

- After healing Mob at the territory of Gerasa, the people asked Jesus to leave their place. Jesus accepted and left the place crossing the lake into Galilee
- When he arrived in Galilee, he found that people were waiting for him. Whilst there Jairus arrived

Who was Jairus?

- An official of the local synagogue
- Had a daughter who was 12 years and was sick

When he arrived, he threw himself down at Jesus' feet and asked him earnestly "My little daughter is very ill. Please come and place your hands on her, so that she will get well and live." Jesus accepted and they started the journey to Jairus' house. The people were crowding him from every side.

The cure of a woman from a severe flow of blood (hemorrhage)

- There was a woman who had suffered terribly from severe bleeding for twelve years
- Many doctors tried to treat her but in vain

- She spent all her money, but instead of getting better, she got worse all the time
- She had heard about Jesus, so she came in the crowd behind him, saying to herself, "If I just touch his clothes I will get well."
- So she touched his cloak and her bleeding stopped at once
- At once Jesus knew that power had gone out of him
- So he turned round in the crowd and asked, "Who touched my clothes?"
- The disciples answered, "You see how people are crowding you. Why do you ask who touched you?"
- The woman realized what happened to her, so she came, trembling with fear, knelt down at his feet and told him the whole truth
- Jesus said to her, "My daughter, your faith has made you well. Go in peace, and be healed of your trouble."

Why did the woman touch Jesus secretly?

- She was ashamed to talk about her disease publicly
- She feared the crowd would blame her for making Jesus Unclean since her disease made her unclean and unfit of any human contact
- She had faith that by a mere touch she would be cured of her disease

Jesus raises the daughter of Jairus

- While Jesus was talking to the woman, some messengers came from Jairus' house and told him, "Your daughter has died, why bother the teacher any longer?"
- However Jesus told him that, "Do not be afraid, only believe"
- Then they went ahead to the house of Jairus with Peter, James and John
- When they arrived at Jairus' house, Jesus saw the confusion and heard all the loud crying and wailing. He went in and said to them, "Why all this confusion? Why are you crying? The child is not dead – she is only sleeping!"
- They all laughed at him that he doesn't know how a dead person looks like.

- Then Jesus asked everyone to leave the room where the dead child was.
- He then took the child's father and mother, and his three disciples and went into the room where the child was lying.
- He took her by the hand and said to her, "Talitha Koum" which means, "Little girl, I tell you to get up" she got up at once and started walking around
- They were amazed. But Jesus gave them strict orders not to tell anyone and he said, "Give her something to eat."

Why are these stories recorded together?

They have common features such as

- Sex** : both concern female
- Age** : The woman suffered for 12 years and the girl was 12 years when she died
- Faith** : The woman was healed because of her own faith; and the child was raised because of her father's faith
- Kneeling before Jesus:** Both the Jairus and the woman knelt before Jesus
- Physical contact:** the woman touched Jesus and Jesus touched the child

I. The Feeding of the five thousand (Mark 6: 30 – 44)

- After sending the Apostles on a mission and when they came back, Jesus took the disciples to a lonely place by boat so that they could share their experiences and rest
- To their surprise, people knew that they were going to a lonely place and so they travelled on land and arrived at the lonely place first while the disciples were still sailing on the boat
- Upon arrival at the place they were so surprised to see many people waiting for them. When Jesus saw the great crowd, his heart was filled with pity because they were like sheep without a shepherd
- Though tired, Jesus started teaching them many things until in the evening (Mark 6:34)

- Then the disciples went to Jesus and asked him to send the crowd away so that they could find food and lodging; since they were at a remote place
- However, Jesus had a different idea, "You yourselves give them something to eat" (Mark 6: 37))
- The disciples made it clear that they needed to spend 2000 silver coins to buy food for the people who were there
- Jesus asked his disciples to check how many loaves of bread and fish they had. After checking, they reported that they had five loaves of bread and two fish

Jesus multiplies fish and bread

- Jesus told his disciples to make people sit in groups of fifty and hundred on the green grass
- Then Jesus took the five loaves and the two fish, looked up to heaven, and gave thanks to God, he broke the loaves and gave them to his disciples to distribute to the people. He also divided the two fish among them all
- Everyone ate and had enough. Then the disciples took up twelve baskets full of what was left of the bread and fish
- The number of men who were fed was 5, 000.

Main Points

- The miracle was a sign of God's Kingdom where God takes care of His people
- God can feed His people miraculously and it reminded them of how God fed the Israelites with Manna and Quails in the desert for 40 years
- Sharing is important
- Prayer is important in our lives
- If you are stranded, pray and God will help you

- Jesus was concerned with people's both spiritual and physiological needs

J. Walking on the water (Mark 6: 45 – 52)

- After feeding 5, 000 men, Jesus sent the crowd away. But he asked his disciples to get into the boat and go ahead of him to Bethsaida
- Then he went to a hill to pray
- When evening came, the boat was still in the middle of the lake and the disciples were straining at the oars because they were rowing against the wind
- Sometime between three and six o'clock in the morning, he came to them walking on the water. He was going to pass them by, but they saw him walking on the water. The disciples thought it was a ghost and they were terrified
- Jesus spoke to them at once, "Courage!" he said. "It is I. Do not be afraid!" Then he got into the boat with them and the wind died down
- The disciples were completely amazed by His power over creation, including the feeding of the 5,000 men whose real meaning they could not understand / or grasp it.

Main point

- Jesus had power over nature. This is a nature miracle

K. The Syro – Phoenician Woman (Mark 7: 24 – 30)

- When Jesus went into the Phoenician territory near the city of Tyre, he went into a house and did not want anyone to know he was there. However, he could not stay hidden.
- A woman, whose daughter had an evil spirit, heard about Jesus and she went to him at once and fell at his feet and begged him to drive the demon out of her daughter. (The woman was not a Jew, she was a Syro – Phoenician)
- Jesus expressing the current Jewish attitude towards Gentiles answered the woman, "Let us first feed the children. It isn't right to take the children's food and throw it to the dogs."

- But the woman replied, "Sir, even the dogs under the table eat the children's leftovers!" this was a mark of faith from the woman and Jesus was convinced of her faith.
- Thus Jesus said to her, "Because of that answer, go back home, where you will find that the demon has gone out of your daughter."
- She went home and found her child lying on the bed; the demon had indeed gone out of her.

Main appoints

- Children refer to Israelites as God's chosen people
- Dogs refer to gentiles / non Jews
- The story is a reminder that salvation is universal as was proclaimed by many prophets; but first to the Jews and then to the gentiles
- Faith is needed for one to be healed
- People should not give up if the first chance fails. Things do not always work to people's expectations.

L. Healing the blind man (Mark 8: 22 – 26)

- Jesus came to Bethsaida, where some people brought a blind man to him and begged him to touch him
- Jesus took the blind man by the hand and led him out of the village
- After spitting on the man's eyes, Jesus placed his hands on him and asked him; "Can you see anything?"
- The man looked up and said, "Yes. I can see people but they look like trees walking about."
- Jesus again placed his hands on the man's eyes. This time the man looked intently, his eyesight returned, and he saw everything clearly
- Jesus then sent him home with the order, "Don't go back into the village"

Review questions

1. Relate how Jesus healed the following
 - a. The blind man at Bethsaida
 - b. The woman who suffered from severe bleeding
 - c. Mob at Gerasa

2. Give any two reasons why Jesus demanded Messianic secret
3. What are miracles
4. Why was Jesus performing miracles?
5. Narrate any story which shows that Jesus had power over nature
6. Why did teach using parables? Give any three reasons

1.3 Jesus Christ's Identity

A. Peter's declaration about Jesus Christ (Mark 8: 27 – 38; 9: 1)

- Jesus and his disciples went away to the villages near Caesarea Philippi. Jesus wanted to know from his disciples about his identity among the people and themselves. Thus on the way he asked them, "Tell me who do people say I am?"
- The disciples told him that
 - i. Some say that you are John the Baptist
 - ii. Others say that you are Elijah
 - iii. While others say that you are one of the prophets
- Then Jesus put a decisive question, "What about you, who do you say I am?"
- Peter answered, " You are the Messiah"
- Jesus ordered them that , "Do not tell anyone about me" Note that Peter's answer on behalf of the apostles is a declaration of his faith that Jesus is the messiah
- Jesus ordered them not to publicize his identity because Jews had wrong expectation of the messiah. They were expecting a political

Messiah and as such they would proclaim him their king a thing which would lead to his death earlier before accomplishing his mission

- Then Jesus explained to them that he was the suffering Messiah when he said to them, "The son of man must suffer much and be rejected by the elders, the chief priests and the teachers of the law. He will be put to death but three days later he will rise to life."
- Jesus was trying to prepare them for his suffering that lied ahead. Like other Jews apostles including Peter did not expect the messiah, the liberator of the Jews to suffer
- So Peter took Jesus aside and began to rebuke him for saying he would suffer and be rejected by the Jewish authorities
- Jesus realized that Peter had become a devil's advocate, so he rebuked him too saying, "Get away from me Satan. Your thoughts do not come from God but from human nature."
- Then Jesus called the crowd and his disciples and began to stress that tragedy lied ahead. Anyone willing to follow him must be prepared for the suffering and willingly accept it

'One must forget self, carry his cross then follow me. Anyone who wants to save his life will lose it, but whoever loses his life for me and the gospel will save it... If a person is ashamed of me and of my teaching in this godless and wicked day, then the son of man will be ashamed of him when he comes in the glory of his father with the holy angels.'

B. The Transfiguration (Mark 9: 2 – 13)

- Six days later, Jesus took Peter, James and John and led them to a high mountain (Hermon) to pray.
- While there, Jesus changed his appearance, and his clothes became shinning white – whiter than anyone in the world could wash them.
- Then the three disciples saw Moses and Elijah (great prophets) talking with Jesus.

- Peter spoke up and said, "How good it is that we are here! we will make three tents, one for you, one for Moses and one for Elijah."
- The disciples were so frightened that they did not know what to say
- Then a cloud appeared and covered them with a shadow, and a voice came from the cloud saying
- "This is my own dear son, Listen to him."
- The disciples took a quick look round but did not see anyone except Jesus
- As they came down from the mountain, Jesus ordered them not to tell anyone about what they had seen, until the son of man has risen from death
- They obeyed but discussed among themselves and wondering what rising from the dead meant.
- Note that the word transfiguration refers to the change in appearance of Jesus.

Importance of the transfiguration in the ministry of Jesus

- The transfiguration gave Jesus encouragement and assurance that his coming suffering and death were in accordance with God's will to save mankind (Learnt from the Jesus' discussion with Moses and Elijah)
- Moses and Elijah represented the law and prophets and these will now be fulfilled by Jesus. (In other words Jesus fulfills the Old testament promises)
- The transfiguration also confirmed that Jesus was indeed the son of God as the voice from the cloud confirmed
- The appearance of Moses and Elijah who had died long time ago proved that there was life after death
- The dazzling brilliance of Jesus' body confirmed that Jesus was Holy and glorious
- Elijah was expected by the Jews to return and appear together with the Messiah. His presence confirmed to the apostles that Jesus was indeed the promised Messiah as Peter had declared six days ago

The words that were heard from the clouds were similar to the ones which were heard from heaven during the baptism of Jesus

Jesus demanded for secrecy about his identity for fear of being killed prematurely

C. The Journey to Jerusalem (Mark 10: 32 – 34)

Jesus speaks the third time about his death

- As Jesus and his disciples were going to Jerusalem, he took his twelve disciples aside and talked to them about his death. Jesus said that he would be handed over to the chief priests and the teachers of the law and he would be condemned to death in Jerusalem. They would hand him over to the gentiles, who would mock, spit, whip and kill him. However, three days later Jesus would rise to life.

Note

- By saying this Jesus was simply preparing his disciples for his death
- Similarly in our societies
 - i. old people when they sense the nearing of their death, they talk about it to their children in order to prepare them psychologically for what is to come
 - ii. Likewise, the human rights activists when threatened to be killed for telling the truth, they prepare their children for their death

D. Request of James and John (Mark 10:35 – 45)

- James and John, sons of Zebedee, went to Jesus and asked him to do them a favour.
- Jesus replied by asking them what it was that they wanted him to do for them

- They answered, " When you sit on your throne in your glorious kingdom, we want you to let us sit with you, one on your right and one at your left
- Jesus told them that that they did not know what they were asking for
- Then he asked them if they could drink the cup of suffering that he might drink and if they could be baptized as he had been baptized
- James and John answered that they could do that
- Then Jesus said to them, ".. I do not have the right to choose who will sit at my right and my left. It is God who will give these places to those for whom he has prepared them"
- When the other ten disciples heard about it, they became angry with James and John because they noted selfishness in the two. The two could have asked something for the whole group.
- Jesus then called them together and taught them what it meant for one to be great. It meant that one had to be a servant in order to be the greatest. For Example, Jesus did not come to be served but to serve
- Jesus defines greatness as servant hood. He also defines being first as being the least as a slave. Slaves were looked down upon as misfits or socially inferior people.

Lesson

Selfishness is bad; people should not just think of themselves but consider others

Humility is good, whoever wants to be a leader must be a slave of all

Review questions

1. Explain the identity of Jesus according to different people who were visited by the disciples
2. Relate Peter's declaration about Jesus
3. Describe any three significance of the transfiguration
4. Why did Jesus predict about his death
5. what was the request of James and John
6. why were the other disciples angry with their request

1.4 The Triumphant Entry into Jerusalem

A. Triumphant entry into Jerusalem (Mark 11: 1 -11)

- The passion (Suffering and death) of Jesus Christ started with the triumphant entry into Jerusalem. Jesus entered into Jerusalem on Sunday, was crucified and died on Friday, and resurrected on Sunday. Others refer to this as the Holy Week.
- As Jesus and his disciples approached Jerusalem near the towns of Bethphage (House of figs) and Bethany (House of the poor), they came to Mount of Olives. Jesus sent two of his disciples with this instruction:
 - "Go to the village there ahead of you. As soon as you get there, you will find a colt tied up that has never been ridden. Untie it and bring it here. And if someone asks you, why you are doing that? Tell him that the master needs it and will send it back at once.'
- So the disciples went and found a colt out in the street, tied to the door of a house. As they were untying it, some of the bystanders asked them, "What are you doing untying the colt?" They answered just as Jesus had told them, and the bystanders let them go.
- The disciples brought the colt and out of excitement, people threw their cloaks on the colt and Jesus sat on it. Many people threw their cloaks on the road, while others cut branches in the fields and spread them on the road.
- Both those who were in front and those who followed behind began to shout; "Praise God! God bless him who comes in the name of the Lord! God bless the coming Kingdom of King David, our father! Praise God!"
- Jesus went into the Temple, looked at everything but since it was late, he went out to Bethany with his twelve disciples

Main Points

- Jesus entry from Mount of Olives while riding on a colt was prophesied by Zechariah (Zechariah 9: 9, 14:4). When the Messiah comes he will enter Jerusalem riding on an ass from Mount of Olives. Possibly Jesus dramatized his entry into Jerusalem to show that:

- i. He was indeed the Promised Messiah
- ii. He was a peaceful (humble) Messiah by using a colt. Otherwise Kings used to ride on horses if going to war
- The spreading of the cloaks showed that Jesus was welcomed as their king and messiah.
- People sang and praised him as the king who came in the name of the Lord
- People sang praises to God in heaven just as angels sang when he was born. This was evidence that he was the messiah
- Jesus did not ask the people to hide his identity as the messiah because the time for secrecy was over. People had to know the truth and was no longer afraid

B. Cleansing of the Temple (Mark 11:15 – 19)

The Temple had seven divisions including the court of men, the court of women, the court of priests, the court of the gentiles, the Holy place and the Holy of Holies. Note that it was the court of the gentiles which was also used as a market place.

Purpose of the market

- To sell birds and animals for sacrifice since priests did not allow birds and animals bought elsewhere for sacrifice
- To exchange Greek and Roman currency with Jewish currency which was acceptable for use in the Temple

Note that the merchants took advantage of the restriction attached to their business as a result

- They overcharged the prices of birds and animals
- They charged exorbitant commission when exchanging money

On Monday, Jesus and his disciples moved from Bethany to Jerusalem. In Jerusalem, Jesus entered the Temple and drove out all those who were selling and buying. He overturned the tables of money changers and the stools of those who sold pigeons

To justify his action, Jesus quoted the scripture from the book of Jeremiah, "It is written in the scriptures that God said 'my Temple will be called a house of prayer for the people of all nations but you have turned it into a hideout for Thieves!" (Mark 11: 17)

The chief priests and the teachers of the law were not happy with these words and his action. So they began looking for some way to kill Jesus Christ. The chief priests and the teachers of the law were afraid of Jesus because the whole crowd was happy with what Jesus was doing.

Review Exercise

1. Describe the triumphant entry into Jerusalem
2. Who prophesied this entry
3. What was the significance of Jesus' entry from Mount of Olives while riding on a colt?
4. Relate how Jesus cleansed the Temple
5. Give the meaning of the following names:
 - Bethsaida
 - Bethany
 - Bethphage

1.5 The Plot to Kill Jesus Christ

A. Plot to Kill Jesus (Mark 14: 1 – 2)

The chief priests and teachers of the law wanted to arrest Jesus secretly before the festival of Passover and unleavened bread which were two days ahead. They feared to arrest him when they were having a feast as people would riot since Jesus was loved so many people mainly the poor

B. Jesus is Anointed at Bethany

- Jesus went to Bethany and stayed at the house of Simon who once suffered from a dreaded skin disease and who was healed by Jesus. While Jesus was eating, a woman came in with an alabaster jar full of a very expensive perfume made of pure nard. She broke the jar and poured the perfume on Jesus' head.
- Some of the people there became angry and said to one another, "what was the use of wasting the perfume? It could have been sold

for more than (300) three hundred silver coins and the money given to the poor! And they criticized her harshly”

- Jesus rebuked them saying, “Leave her alone! Why are you bothering her? She has done a fine and beautiful thing for me. You will always have poor people with you, and any time you want to, you can help them. But you will not always have me. She did what she could; she poured perfume on my body to prepare it ahead of time for burial. Now, I assure you that wherever the gospel is preached all over the world, what she has done will be told in memory of her”

Main Points

- We should offer the best to God and our friends; not keeping the best for ourselves or sell and offer things of low quality to God and our friends. (The perfume was worthy what a labourer could earn in a year)
- We should learn to prioritize things which are important to us. That is to say we should concentrate on one thing at a time and the other later. (You will always have poor people with you, and any time you want to, you can help them, but you will not always have me)
- We should not accuse people before we understand why they are doing or behaving in a particular way
- Although Jesus’ body was not anointed when he died, according to the Jewish custom, the woman already prepared Jesus’ body before burial

C. Judas Iscariot agrees to betray Jesus (Mark 14: 10 – 11)

- The chief priests wanted to send soldiers to arrest Jesus secretly. However, most soldiers could not identify Jesus. They needed someone to show them Jesus, to ensure that they arrest the right person. Coincidentally, Judas went to the chief priests in order to betray Jesus to them. They were pleased to hear what he said and they promised to give him money. So Judas watched for an opportunity to hand him over
- Note that Judas, possibly, did not want Jesus to be killed. He thought that after showing them who Jesus was, Jesus would run

away as he did at Nazareth when people wanted to kill him. What he wanted was money.

- On the contrary, Jesus did not run away from them and they arrested him. That was why Judas felt guilt conscious and committed suicide
- (In Psalm 41: 9, it was said that the Messiah would be betrayed by his own friend Judas fulfilled this)

Lessons from the passage on the betrayal of Jesus

- People should find good ways of getting money.
Practices such as selling expired items are bad and are similar to what Judas did
- Cheating does not pay
Judas wanted to cheat the chief priests by robbing them some money but in the end he did not enjoy the money he received instead he killed himself

D. The Lord's Supper (Mark 14: 12 – 31)

- Jesus ate the last supper on Thursday, a day before his death. On that Thursday, it was the first day of the festival of the unleavened bread when the lamb for Passover meal was killed.
- On that day, Jesus sent two of his disciples with these instructions; "Go into the city, and a man carrying a jar of water will meet you. Follow him to the house he enters, and say to the owner of the house: "The teacher says where is the room where my disciples and I will eat the Passover meal? He will show you a large upstairs room, prepared and furnished, where you will get everything ready for us"
- The disciples went into the city and found everything just as Jesus had told them. Then they prepared the Passover meal
- (It seems Jesus had made a prior arrangement for the venue because it was not common in Palestine for men carrying a jar of water. Men carried water in bags made of animal skins)

What happened during the Supper?

- **Jesus predicted that one them (Judas) would betray him**

- In the evening, Jesus arrived with his twelve disciples. While they were at table eating, Jesus said to them, "I tell you that one of you will betray me – one who is eating with me." The disciples were upset and began to ask him one after the other. "Surely you do not mean me, do you?"
 - Jesus answered, "It will be one of you twelve, one who dips his bread in the dish with me. The son of man will die as the scriptures say he will; but how terrible for that man who betrays the son of man! It would have been better for that man if he had never been born!"
- i. Bread and wine were eaten and drank**
 - While eating, Jesus took a piece of bread, gave a prayer of thanks, broke it and gave to his disciples saying, "Take it, this is my body."
 - Then he took a cup, gave thanks to God, and handed it to them, and they all drank from it. He told them, "This is my blood which is poured out for many, my blood which seals God's covenant. I tell you, I will never again drink this wine until the day I drink new wine in the Kingdom of God"
 - Then they sang a hymn and went to the Mount of Olives.
- ii. Jesus predicted Peter's denial (Mark 14: 27 – 31)**
 - Jesus predicted that all his disciples would run away and leave him alone
 - Jesus said, that would happen to fulfill what was written in the scriptures that the shepherd would be killed and the sheep would be scattered
 - Jesus went further saying after his resurrection he would go to Galilee ahead of his disciples
 - Peter declared that even if all would leave Jesus, he would not
 - Jesus told him that before the cock crows twice that night, he would say three times that he didn't know him.
 - Peter strongly insisted that he could not deny that he did not know Jesus even if it meant to die with Jesus

- All other disciples assured Jesus of the same thing

Jesus prays in Gethsemane (Mark 14: 32 – 42)

- Thursday night after last supper, Jesus took his disciples to a place called Gethsemane to pray
- When they arrived there, he said to his disciples, "sit here while I pray". Then he took Peter, James and John and went further to pray. Distress and anguish came over him. "The sorrow in my heart is so great that it almost crushes me. Stay here and keep watch"
- He went a little further on, threw himself on the ground, and prayed; "Father, my father! All things are possible for you. Take this cup of suffering away from me. Yet not what I want, but what you want."
- Jesus returned to the three disciples and found them sleeping. He said to Peter, "Simon, are you asleep? Weren't you able to stay awake even for one hour?"
- He again said to them, "Keep watch and pray that you will not fall into temptations. The spirit is willing, but the flesh is weak."
- Jesus left them again to pray alone. He repeated the same prayer: "... take this cup of suffering away from me. Yet not what I want, but what you want."
- After praying alone, he went to his disciples and found them sleeping again. And they did not know what to say to him,
- When he found them sleeping for the third time, he said to them, "Are you still sleeping and resting? Enough! The hour has come! Look, the son of man is now being handed over to the power of sinners. Get up, let us go. Look, here is the man who is betraying me!"

1.6 The Arrest and Trial of Jesus Christ

A. The Arrest of Jesus (Mark 14: 43 – 53)

- Jesus was still speaking to the disciples when Judas arrived. With him was a crowd armed with swords and clubs. They were sent by the chief priests, teachers of the law and the elders

- Judas had agreed on a sign with them saying, "The man I kiss is the one you want. Arrest him and take him away under guard."
- As soon as they arrived, he went up to Jesus and said, "Teacher!" and kissed him. So they arrested Jesus and held him tight.
- One of his disciples standing near, drew his sword and struck at the High Priest's slave (Marcus), cutting off his right ear
- Jesus said to them, "Did you have to come with swords and clubs to capture me, as though I were an outlaw? Day after day, I was with you teaching in the Temple, and you did not arrest me. But the scripture must come true."
- All the disciples left him and ran away. A certain young man (Mark) dressed only in a linen cloth, was following Jesus. They tried to arrest him, but he ran away naked leaving the cloth behind.

B. Jesus' Trial (Mark 14: 53 – 72; 15: 1 – 15)

Jesus was tried before the Jewish Council and Pilate

The Jewish council

- This was the Jewish High Court. There were 71 members of the council and it was headed by the High Priest. Members of the council were the chief priests (Sadducees), the elders and the teachers of the law (Pharisees). The council had no powers to pass death sentence. It was the governor (at that time Pilate) who could give death sentence.

i. Jesus' trial before the Council (Mark 14: 53 – 65)

- Jesus was arrested at Gethsemane at night as he was praying. From Gethsemane, Jesus was taken to the house of the High Priest to be judged.
- That was where the chief priests, teachers of the law and the elders had gathered
- Peter followed at a distance and stayed away from where Jesus was and sat down with guards by the fire.

- The council tried to find some charges against Jesus with an intention to kill him but they could not find any. Many witnesses told lies against Jesus, but their stories could not agree
- Others said, "we heard him saying, "I will tear down this Temple which men have made, and after three days I will build one that is not made by men" (Mark 14: 58)
- The High Priest asked Jesus to respond but Jesus did not even say a word.
- Then the High Priest asked him again, "Are you the Messiah, the son of the Blessed God?"
- In his response Jesus said, "I am and you will see the son of man seated on the right of the Almighty and coming with clouds of heaven!"
- Upon hearing this, the High Priest tore his robes and said, "We do not need any more witnesses! You heard his blasphemy. What is your decision?"
- They all voted against him; he was guilty and should be put to death
- Some started to spit on him; they blindfolded him and hit him saying, "Guess who hit you!" The guards also took him and slapped him

Peter Denies Jesus (Mark 14: 66 – 72)

- As Peter was warming himself by the fire in the courtyard, one of the High Priest's servant women came by
- When she saw Peter warming himself, she looked straight at him and said
- You too were with Jesus of Nazareth
- But he denied it, "I don't know ... I don't understand what you are talking about"
- He answered and went out into the passage. Just then a cock crowed.
- The woman saw him there and began to repeat to the bystanders
- He is one of them! But Peter denied it again

- A little while later, the bystanders accused Peter again, "You can't deny that you are one of them, because you, too, are from Galilee"
- Peter said, 'I swear that I am telling the truth! May God punish me if I am not! I do not know the man you are talking about!'"
- Just then, the cock crowed a second time
- Peter remembered Jesus' words, "Before the cock crows twice, you will say three times that you do not know me."
- And he broke down and cried.

Why did Peter deny Jesus?

- He was afraid to be arrested and suffer with Jesus as well. He lacked courage for this
- He did not pray enough as he was sleeping so he gave in to the temptation

ii. Jesus' trial before Pilate (Mark 15: 1 – 15)

- Early in the morning on Friday, the Jewish Council met and agreed that Jesus must be killed.
- Following that development, they sent him to Pilate so that the death penalty should be given. Remember the council had no powers to pass death sentences. Such powers were with Pilate as a Governor
- Pilate asked Jesus, "Are you the King of the Jews?"
- Jesus answered, "So you say"
- The chief priests accused Jesus of many things but Jesus could not defend himself. He didn't say any word and this amazed Pilate who was expecting Jesus to defend himself

Jesus is sentenced to death

- It was a custom that every Passover festival Pilate should set free any one prisoner the people of Israel asked for
- At that time a man named Barabbas was in prison with the rebels who committed murder in a riot
- The crowd gathered and began to ask Pilate for the usual favour

- Pilate asked them. "Do you want me to set free for you the king of the Jews?"
- The chief priests stirred up the crowd to ask Pilate to set Barabbas free for them instead of Jesus
- Pilate asked the crowd what he should do with the one whom they called the King of the Jews
- They shouted back, "Crucify him!"
- But what crime has he committed? Pilate asked
- They shouted all the louder, "Crucify him!"

Pilate wanted to please the crowd so he set Barabbas free for them. Then he had Jesus whipped and handed him over to be crucified.

Note:

- Pilate was morally corrupt. He knew very well that Jesus was innocent and that the Jews wanted to kill him out of jealousy, but he failed to act because he wanted to please the Jews even if it cost the life of an innocent person.
- The weakness of Pilate was clearly demonstrated when he handed Jesus over to be crucified
- It is not good to misuse one's responsibility for the sake of buying cheap popularity; Judges should learn to be just.

1.7 The Death and Resurrection of Jesus

A. The soldiers mock Jesus (Mark 15: 16 – 20)

When Pilate handed Jesus over to them, the soldiers

- Put a purple robe on Jesus
- Made a crown of thorny branches and put it on his head
- Mocked him by saying , "Long live the King of the Jews"
- Beat him over the head with a stick
- Spat on him
- Fell on their knees and bowed down to him
- (Note that these are some of the ways through which the soldiers violated the rights of Jesus)

After mocking him, they took off the purple robe and put his own clothes back. Then they led him out to be crucified

B. Jesus is crucified(Mark 15: 21 – 32)

- Jesus was asked to carry his cross but since he was badly beaten, he could not manage to carry it
- On the way they met a man named Simon, who was coming into the city from the country
- The soldiers forced him to carry Jesus' cross
- (Simon was from Cyrene, a port in Libya in North Africa. He was the father of Alexander and Rufus – church fathers)
- With the help of Simon, Jesus arrived at Golgotha with his cross. Golgotha means , “The place of skull”
- There they tried to give him wine mixed with a drug called myrrh, but Jesus would not drink
- (it was a practice that when they want to execute a person, they used to give him / her a narcotic potion containing myrrh to dull their sensitivity to the excruciating pain of execution)
- Then the soldiers crucified Jesus around 9:00 am and divided his clothes among themselves by throwing a dice to see who would get which piece of cloth
- Anybody who is crucified on the cross, his / her accusation was written on top of the cross. In case of Jesus it was written: “The King of the Jews”
- He was crucified together with two bandits one on his right and the other on his left.

While on the cross, people passing by shook their heads and hurled insults

- “Aha! You were going to tear down the Temple and build it up in three days. Now come down from the cross and save yourself
- The chief priests and the teachers of the law also jeered at Jesus saying to each other
He saved others, but he cannot save himself. Let us see the Messiah, the King of Israel come down from the cross and we will believe him

- The bandits also insulted him

C. The Death of Jesus

- Jesus was crucified around 9:00 am and at 12:00 noon, the whole country was covered with darkness, which lasted for three hours
- At 3:00 pm Jesus cried out with a loud shout, "Eloi, Eloi, Lema Sabachthani?" which means, "my God, my God why did you abandon me?"

Reactions of the people

- Some did not understand the word "Eloi", they thought he was calling Elijah
- One of them ran up with a sponge, soaked it in cheap wine, and put it on the end of the stick. Then he held up to Jesus' lips and said, "wait let us see if Elijah is coming to bring him down from the cross"
- With a loud cry, Jesus died.

What happened when he died?

- The curtain at the Temple was torn into two
This signified the end of the Old Covenant and the rejection of the Temple and its worship. All people can now come to meet God who is not confined in the Temple.
- The army officer who was guarding Jesus said, "This man was really the son of God"

Some women were there, looking on from a distance. Among them were Mary Magdalene, Mary the mother of James and Joseph, Salome and other from Jerusalem.

D. The burial of Jesus (Mark 15: 42 – 47)

- It was a custom that anyone who is crucified should be buried the following day. The aim was to give chance to other people to see that once they commit a similar offence, they would be crucified.

- Jesus died at 3: 00 pm and the next day, which would start at 6: 00 pm, was a Sabbath day which coincided with the Passover celebrations that year. And according to Jewish religion they were not allowed to bury a person on the Sabbath
- It was for this reason that, towards evening, Joseph of Arimathea made arrangements for the burial of Jesus

Note that Joseph of Arimathea was

- A respected member of the Jewish Council that judged Jesus' case
- Waiting for the kingdom of God to come
- (possibly a secret disciple of Jesus)

When he saw that Jesus had died

- He went boldly in the presence of Pilate and asked him for the body of Jesus and bury it the same day he was crucified
- Pilate was surprised to hear that Jesus was already dead. He called the army officer who was guarding Jesus and after verifying with him that Jesus had indeed died sometime , Pilate allowed Joseph to have the body
- Joseph bought a linen sheet, took the body of Jesus down, wrapped it in the sheet, and placed it in the tomb which had been dug out of solid rock. Then he rolled a large stone across the entrance of the tomb
- The women who were following Jesus saw where Jesus was buried

E. Resurrection and Appearance of Jesus (Mark 16: 1 – 20)

- It was a Jewish tradition that a dead body was smeared with perfume to preserve it from producing bad smell. This was because the dead bodies were not buried in the soil as we are doing today, but they were placed in man- made cave which was called a tomb. If perfume is not applied, then the bad smell could be felt by people passing by.
- However, Jesus' body was not smeared with perfume because he was buried late in the evening of Friday and the hours of the

Sabbath were about to be observed. They had to bury him in haste, hence not enough time to anoint him.

- Mary Magdalene, Mary mother of James and Salome could not go to anoint the body of Jesus on the Sabbath. They waited for the Sabbath to be over. Then they bought spices so that they would go to anoint the body of Jesus
- When the Sabbath was over, very early on Sunday morning, the women went to the tomb so as to anoint the body of Jesus.
- On the way they said to one another, "who will roll away the stone for us from the entrance to the tomb." (It was a very large stone)
- Then they looked up and saw that the stone had already been rolled back
- So they entered the tomb where they saw a young man sitting on the right, wearing a white robe – and they were alarmed.

The man's / angel's message to the women

- "Do not be afraid / alarmed
- I know you are looking for Jesus of Nazareth who was crucified
- He is not here – he has been raised
- Look, here is the place where they put him
- Now go and give this message to his disciples including Peter
- He is going to Galilee ahead of you, there you will see him , just as he told you

So they went out and ran from the tomb, distressed and terrified. They said nothing to anyone because they were afraid

Jesus' appearances

First, to Mary Magdalene (Mark 16: 9 – 11)

- After Jesus rose from death early on Sunday , he appeared first to Mary Magdalene from whom he had driven out seven demons
- She went and reported to the other disciples ,who were still mourning and crying, but did not believe her

- Possibly they were thinking that Jesus could not appear first to a woman but to a man because they had a tendency of underrating women as some people today

Second, to the two disciples (Mark 16: 12 – 13)

- After appearing to Mary, Jesus appeared in a different manner to two of them while they were on their way to the country
- They returned and told the others, but they would not believe

Third, to the eleven disciples (Mark 16: 14 – 18)

- Finally, Jesus appeared to the eleven disciples as they were eating
- He scoulded them, because they did not have faith and they were too stubborn to believe those who had seen him alive

Then he said to them

- "Go throughout the whole world and preach the gospel to the whole human race. Whoever believes and is baptized will be saved. Whoever does not believe will be condemned
- Believers will be given the power to perform miracles; they will drive out demons in my name; they will speak in strange tongues. If they pick up snakes or drink any poison, they will not be harmed; they will place hands on sick people who will get well."

The Ascension (Mark 16: 19 -20)

- After Jesus had spoken to his disciples, he was taken up into heaven and he sat at the right hand of God
- The disciples went and preached everywhere. The Lord worked with them everywhere they went. He confirmed his word by the signs and miracles they performed

The Ascension (Luke24: 50 – 53)

- Jesus and his disciples went to Bethany where he blessed them
- As he was blessing them, Jesus was taken up t heaven as they were seeing

- The disciples worshipped him and went back to Jerusalem
- They were filled with great joy and spent their time in the Temple praising God

REVIEW QUESTIONS

1. Describe the Lord's supper
2. Explain the symbolism of Jesus' words in the Lord's supper
3. Why did Judas betray Jesus?
4. Draw any two lessons from what Judas did
5. What was the reason given for crucifying Jesus
6. Who buried Jesus?
7. Why was Jesus body not anointed?
8. Who was the first person to see Jesus after resurrection?
9. Explain how the Roman soldiers violated the rights of Jesus



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Chapter 3

JESUS CHRIST AND THE OLD TESTAMENT

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JESUS CHRIST AND THE OLD TESTAMENT

OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, the student should be able to:

1. illustrate how the scriptures show the link between the Old and the New Testaments
2. describe the relationship between Jesus' teaching and the Old Testament

CONTENTS

- identifying biblical passages showing the link between the Old and New Testaments
- discussing how the Old Testament links with the New Testament
- discussing the relationship between Jesus' teachings and the Old Testament
- discussing how Jesus Christ fulfills the Old Testament concepts of Servant, Lord and Messiah (the anointed one)

Biblical passages showing the link between the Old and New Testaments



There are many passages in the Bible which are showing the link between the Old and the New Testaments. Some of them are as follows:

A. The birth place of Jesus Christ / messiah

- Prophet Micah prophesied that the Messiah would come from Bethlehem which is the city of David (Micah 5:2)
- In the New testament, Jesus was born in Bethlehem where his parents had gone for the census (Luke 2: 1 – 7)
- The birth of Jesus in Bethlehem is the fulfillment of the prophecies made in the Old Testament

B. Parents of Jesus

- Isaiah prophesied that a virgin would give birth to a son whose name would be Immanuel meaning God is with us (Isaiah 7: 10 – 17)
- Jesus was born by a young virgin who was betrothed to Joseph, meaning that that she was only engaged to Joseph and not married. The angel had to inform Joseph about the Holy conception and advised him to still marry her. (Matthew 1 18 – 25)

C. The mission of Jesus

- Prophets in the Old Testament prophesied the mission of Jesus which included: to bring good news to the poor, to comfort the mourners, to heal the broken hearted and to give sight to the blind.
- Jesus did the following as part of his mission: he proclaimed liberty to the captives and recovery of sight to the blind. For example the blind man at Bethsaida; he comforted the mourners when he raised the daughter of Jairus
- Isaiah in the third and fourth Servant songs describe that Jesus would save people as a suffering servant. He would be beaten, spat in his face, pulled his beard, rejected, led off to and be crucified.
- This was fulfilled when Jesus was rejected by his own people – the Jews. They humiliated him and later arrested him. They

accused him falsely beat him and killed him by nailing him on the cross.

D. The Transfiguration of Jesus

- During the transfiguration of Jesus, Moses and Elijah from the Old Testament appeared with Jesus.
- They were discussing how Jesus would fulfill his mission of saving people by dying on the cross in Jerusalem
- The presence of Elijah was a justification that all what was said by the prophets in the Old Testament was fulfilled in Jesus
- Moses on the other hand represented the laws in the Old Testament. That is to say Jesus did not come to break the law but to fulfill it
- In short the presence of Moses and Elijah signified that Jesus is the fulfillment of the Old Testament

Relationship between Jesus' teaching and the Old Testament

There are links between the teaching of Jesus and the Old Testament. Some of the similarities are as follows:

A. Jesus taught us to use the scriptures when we are tempted by the devil.

- Remember that when Jesus was tempted by the devil, he used the book of Deuteronomy to defeat the devil (e. g. Deuteronomy 8:3)

B. Jesus' teaching was the continuation of the teaching of prophets in the Old Testament

- In Mark chapter 4, Jesus taught using the parable of the sower. Later some people came to him with his disciples and asked him the meaning of the parable. In his response Jesus said
- "you have been given the secret of the Kingdom of God, but others who are on the outside, hear all things by means of parables, so that, "they may look and look , yet not see, they may listen and listen , yet not understand. For if they did, they would turn to God and he would forgive them." 9mark 4; 11 – 12)

- The same words are found in the book of Isaiah (Isaiah 6: 9 – 10). In this passage, God was calling prophet Isaiah to give his message to his people. However, it mentioned that even if people would not listen the preacher should continue preaching.
- The same principle was the one Jesus taught his disciples and those who came to him: that people hear the good news of salvation but some could not believe in the message. However this should not discourage the preachers. Rather they should keep on preaching the word.

C. Jesus used parables in his teaching just as people in the Old Testament did

- Prophet Isaiah used parables in his teaching for example, the parable in the vineyard in Isaiah 5: 1 – 7.
- Similarly, Jesus used parables in his teaching, for example the parable of the sower in Mark 4: 3 – 20.
- This method is greatly used by most preachers today.

Jesus Fulfills the Old Testament concepts of Servant, Lord and Messiah as follows:

- The Old Testament prophesied the coming of the deliverer who would save the Jews from their sufferings. The deliverer was given different titles such as the prince of peace, wonderful counselor, messiah, servant of the Lord and many others.

Identifying the identity of Jesus

Passage from the Bible	Titles given to Jesus
Isaiah 42: 1 – 4 and Matthew 12 :17 - 21	Servant
Acts 2: 36 and Acts 3: 17 ff	Lord and Messiah
Acts 17: 3	Messiah

How Jesus fulfills the concepts of Servant, lord and Messiah

A. Jesus Christ is the Servant of God (Isaiah 42: 1 – 4 and Matthew 12: 17 – 21)

- Jesus proved beyond doubt in Matthew 12: 17 – 21 that he was God's servant. This prophesies was made by prophet Isaiah in

the Old Testament. Prophet Isaiah gave the qualities of God's servant in Isaiah 42: 1 – 4

- All these qualities are repeated in Matthew 12: 17 – 21 with Jesus as the servant. He fulfilled all these qualities

B. Jesus Christ is the Lord (Acts 2: 36 and Acts 3: 17 ff)

- Peter, in his speech on the Pentecost day, preached to the people that Jesus who was rejected and crucified, was the one that God made Lord and Messiah (Acts 2: 36)
- After healing a lame man at Beautiful Gate, Peter preached in the Temple that the lame man was healed through the belief in the name of Jesus Christ (Acts 3: 17 ff)

C. Jesus is the messiah(Acts 17: 3)

- Jesus came to save human kind. He died on the cross for the sins of everybody; Similarly we were saved by his blood
- In the New Testament, many people agreed that Jesus is the Messiah. For example Paul in Thessalonica said that Jesus Christ is the Messiah (Acts 17: 3)

REVIEW EXERCISE

1. What do you think is the relationship between the Old and New Testaments in scripture? Give evidence

2. Describe the relationship between Jesus Christ's teaching and the Old Testament
3. Explain how Jesus fulfilled the following concepts
 - a. Messiah
 - b. Lord
 - c. Servant
4. Using Bible verses as examples, point out some of the prophecies of the Old Testament that were fulfilled in the New testament through Jesus

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Chapter 4

BELIEFS ABOUT GOD

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BELIEFS ABOUT GOD

OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, the student should be able to:



1. describe biblical beliefs about God

CONTENTS

- **Biblical beliefs about God**
- God is Spirit
- God is Creator
- God is Saviour
- God is Judge
- God is Father
- God is Provider

3.1 Biblical beliefs about God

People hold different beliefs about God. In most cases name a name which a society identify God with is reveal what that society believe about God. For example some communities believe He is the Father, provider and sustainer of every creature. Likewise, Christians hold various beliefs about god and Jesus Christ.

The table below identifies God based on the scriptures

The Verse from the Bible	Identity of God
John4: 24	Spirit
Genesis1:1- 3 & John 1: 3	Creator
Exodus 14:28- 20 & Isaiah 43: 3	Saviour
Matthew 3:9 -10	Judge
Luke 11: 2	Father
Genesis 22: 13 – 14 & Exodus 16: 4 - 5	provider

The following are some of the biblical beliefs about God

A. God is Spirit (John 4: 24)

- God is spirit without fresh. This identity of God is drawn from the Holy Trinity, whereby Christians believe in "God the Father, the Son and the Holy Spirit"
- John 4: 24 say, "God is the Spirit and only by the power of His Sp[irit can people worship Him as He really is." The Holy Spirit leads Christians to all the truth, reveals God's nature and character, His love for people, His mercy and holiness
- Note that since God is Spirit, all language about him is anthropomorphic. Anthropomorphism is the attribution of human features and behaviours to non- human being..The attribution of human feelings to non – human being is anthropothism. There is no other way to speak about God apart from through the eyes of human beings.

B. God is the creator (Genesis 1: 1- 3 and John 1: 3)

- Genesis 1: 1 points out that from the beginning, God created the heavens and earth. He also created everything in the universe.

God was simply using words to create. Genesis 1:3 says “then God commanded, “Let there be light” and light appeared”

- John also says that God was the one who created everything out of nothing and He owns everything.
- Now, if God is the only creator then He is the only being who is in – charge of creation. Human beings have no right to kill or destroy the environment without seeking consent from God. Our duty as human beings is to assist God in protecting the environment

Human activities not accepted by God as the creator

- Killing a person (before birth, during birth or after birth), since every human being has a right to life
- Careless killing of God’s creation for even small animals have the right to life
- Setting bush fire which destroys vegetation, animals and their habitat
- Careless cutting of trees without replacing them which promotes soil erosion
- Poor farming methods which promote soil erosion

Human activities which could help to conserve God’s creation

- Planting vegetation (trees and grass) around school and church buildings and our homes
- Practicing good farming methods which conserve soil fertility
- Throwing litter in dust bins or rubbish pit to preserve the beauty of the environment

C. God is Saviour (Exodus 14: 28 – 29 and Isaiah 43: 3)

- Throughout the history of human beings, God has been saving them from any bondage.
- For example, He set the Israelites free from Egyptian slavery through Moses; He set them free through Cyrus when they were in bondage in Babylon. Finally He sent his own son , Jesus Christ,

to die for the sins of humankind; and everybody was saved by the blood of Jesus

- Today, God is still saving people from sufferings through prophets and men and women of God who pray for the sick and are they healed.

D. God is Judge (Matthew 3: 9 -10)

- God is a just and a righteous judge. Every human being shall be judged according to his / her actions. The wicked shall be punished for their sins and the righteous (faithful) shall be rewarded accordingly. Matthew expresses this by saying "the axe is ready to cut down the trees at the roots. Every tree that does not bear good fruit will be cut down and thrown in the fire"
- Since God is the only just judge, there is no need for us to judge others. Our duty is just to assist others to behave according to the will of God

E. God is father (Luke 11: 2)

- Jesus told his disciples to refer to God as their father. He said to them, when you pray say this, "Father (Abba), may your Holy name be honoured...."
- Father is a child's word of respect for a parent who sustains and cares for his family in every detail. (It is in this context that some other people refer to God as a mother)
- Unlike earthly fathers, God has all the resources to give his children if they ask earnestly in prayer.
- God is our father full of mercy and love. He is compassionate just as a father is with his own children
- The main point here is that Christians should view God that He works as a father (or mother) does at family level

F. God is provider (Exodus 16: 4 – 5)

- In a family, the father is usually the head. A good father works hard and toils to ensure that his family is well fed, dressed and has good health. Good fathers are responsible, caring and loving to their families

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- Just as a father takes care and provides for his children, God does so for his people. For example
 - i. He provided a lamb to Abraham to God instead of his son Isaac (Genesis 22: 13 – 14)
 - ii. When the Israelites grumbled and complained about suffering with hunger, in the wilderness, the Lord provided them with manna and quails and he also provided them with a day of rest as they collected the food (Exodus 16: 4 – 5)
 - iii. He provides good things to both the righteous and the wicked.

Since we know that God is the provider, we should not, therefore, ask witch doctors to protect us with charms. We should believe that god provides protection to all His people.

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Chapter 5

BELIEFS ABOUT JESUS CHRIST

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BELIEFS ABOUT JESUS CHRIST

OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, the student should be able to:

1. describe biblical beliefs about Jesus Christ
2. explain the significance of the Biblical beliefs about Jesus Christ

CONTENTS

- discussing the biblical beliefs about Jesus Christ and its significance
 - Incarnation
 - Messiah
 - Saviour
 - King
 - Resurrection
 - Ascension

3.2 Biblical Beliefs about Jesus Christ and their significance

Some Christians believe in the Holy Trinity; where we have God the Father, God the son and God the Holy Spirit. Jesus Christ is the son, and like His Father, Jesus Christ is God.

These are some of the biblical beliefs about Jesus Christ and their significance

A. Jesus incarnate / incarnation (Matthew 123 and John 1:14)

- Jesus incarnate means Jesus (God) made man. This reality that God himself became man for our salvation is what is referred to as incarnation. It literary means becoming flesh
- Matthew 1: 23 confirms the incarnation of Jesus as it states, " A virgin will become pregnant and have a son, and he will be called Immanuel" which means God is with us. This means that Jesus was God among the people. He just took upon himself the human body.
- John in his gospel begins by saying, "In the beginning the word already existed the word was with God, and the word was God." He makes a climax of this in John 1:14 when he said "the word became a human being and, full of grace and truth, lived among us..."
- It should, therefore, be understood that Jesus was 100 % God and at the same time 100% human being. For example, he had divine powers to perform miracles, to forgive sins, and to command nature and it could listen to Him. At the same time, he was just like any other human being except for sin. For example at some time he got angry and wept.

Importance of this belief

- It helps people to appreciate how God planned to save them. God sent his only son to save them through suffering. He felt pain when people tortured him. He suffered on the cross to save them.

- As God himself, he had all the powers to fight back against those people who arrested him, but he did not do that because he had to fulfill God's plan of saving people. Remember his prayer before he was arrested "... however not my will but your will be done"

B. Jesus the Messiah (Luke 9: 20)

- The word Messiah is taken from the Hebrew word Mashiah which means the anointed one. In Greek it is "Christos" from which comes the English word "Christ"
- In the Old Testament, the word Messiah was used to refer to those who did God's work like Kings and the priests. They were anointed by prophets to show that they had been set apart to do God's work. For example, Moses anointed sons of Aaron to serve as priests and Samuel anointed King Saul and David to rule over the people of Israel.
- In Luke 9:20 Jesus asked his disciples who they said he was. Peter said that He was the Messiah, the son of God. Jesus acknowledged Peter's answer. This meant that Jesus was anointed by God to do his work. He was anointed to liberate humankind. Jesus was born among the Jews as a Messiah but some did not believe him.

Importance of Jesus being the Messiah

- This helps people to understand the love of God. He sent the Messiah to liberate them. This is a proof that God is caring for His people

C. Jesus as the Saviour (John 3: 16 -17)

- Jesus Christ died on the cross for the sins of the humankind and people are saved by the blood of Jesus Christ.
- John 3: 16 – 17 states that God loved the world so much that he sent his only son, Jesus Christ, so that anyone who believes in Him should be saved. "
- It can therefore not be denied that Jesus Christ is the Saviour of humankind.

Importance of Jesus Christ being the Saviour

- If Jesus Christ saved people by his death and resurrection, then people should not sin again
- If people are sinning then it is like demanding that Jesus should be killed again

D. Jesus the King (John 1:49)

- In the New Testament, Jesus is referred to as Lord about six hundred times.
- Lord was the title that was used by Greeks to refer to earthly kings and masters
- In Greek translation of the Old Testament, the word Lord is used to refer to God
- Christians believe that Jesus was the king of kings
- For example Nathanael in his conversation with Jesus Christ declared that Jesus Christ is the king of Israel; "Teacher, you are the son of God! You are the king of Israel!" (John 1:49)
- Thus when they call Jesus Lord, they confess that He is God and give Him respect and obedience

Importance of Jesus Christ being King

- If Jesus Christ is the king of kings, then all kings on the earth rule on behalf of Jesus
- In this way, the rulers on earth should rule with consciousness because there is a greater king watching what they are doing
- This helps the kings to respect human rights of their subjects

E. Belief in the resurrection (Luke 24: 1 – 8)

- Christians believe that Jesus Christ was killed and after three days God raised Him to life. Many people in the Bible proved this beyond reasonable doubt.
- Luke 24 1 – 8 states that, very early on Sunday some women took some spices to the tomb of Jesus Christ to anoint his body. They found the stone rolled away from the entrance to the tomb and when they went in they did not find the body of the Lord Jesus

- They stood there puzzled about this, when suddenly two men dressed in bright shining clothes stood by them and said to them, "Why are you looking among the dead for the one who is alive? He is not here; he has been raised. Remember what he said to you while he was in Galilee "The son of man must be handed over to sinners, be crucified and three days later rise to life". The women remembered his words and went back to inform the rest
- Later Jesus appeared to some disciples for 40 days which proved beyond doubt that he was alive
- So, the empty tomb, the angels' word to the women and the appearances of Jesus to the disciple served as testimony of the resurrection of Jesus

Importance of the resurrection of Jesus Christ

- It is the core or cornerstone of Christian faith; as Paul said if Jesus Christ had not been raised from the dead, the Christian faith would have been in vain
- It gives hope to the Christians that there is life after death. He died and God raised him; he set a precedence that all humankind shall resurrect on the judgement day . through Jesus Christ's death and resurrection, he restored the hope for life after death
- The plan for salvation was made in such a way that Jesus Christ should die and resurrect so that humankind could be saved. The death and resurrection of Jesus Christ were the conditions of salvation. If Jesus was not raised then the whole humankind would not have been saved

F. Belief in the ascension of Jesus Christ (Matthew 16:19, Acts 1: 6 – 19)

- Ascension comes from the word to ascend. It means to go up or to rise. After resurrection, Jesus appeared to his disciples for 40 days which proved beyond doubt that he was alive.
- Then he took his disciples too Bethany (according to Mark) / to Mount of Olives (According to Acts)
- As he spoke to them he was taken up to heaven on clouds and sat at the right side of God (Mark 16:19)



Before Jesus ascended to heaven, he gave his disciples these instructions

- Be in Jerusalem
- Wait for the coming of the Holy spirit
- That power will help you to witness for me here in Jerusalem, all Judea, Samaria and to the end of the world (Acts1:6 – 10)

Importance of the ascension of Jesus

- Jesus went up to heaven to prepare a place for the righteous people.
- He said in his father's house, there is enough space for everybody who is righteous

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Chapter 6

BIBLICAL PRACTICES

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BIBLICAL PRACTICES

OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, the student should be able to:



1. identify biblical practices
2. explain the importance of biblical practices
3. describe the Lord's supper
4. explain the meaning of the term 'prayer'
5. explain the meaning of the term 'fasting'
6. identify aspects of prayer
7. give reasons why people pray today
8. define worship
9. identify ways of worship in old testament and early Christian community
10. Explain why people worship

CONTENTS

- Discussing biblical practices and their importance

- naming
- circumcision
- baptism
- Holy Communion
 - narrating the Lord's supper
- Prayer
 - meaning of prayer
 - key points of prayer
 - analysing the Lord's prayer
 - thanksgiving
 - asking for the will of God
 - request for provisions
 - forgiveness of sins
 - protection from temptations
 - glorifying God
 - why people pray today
- Fasting
 - Meaning of fasting
 - Importance of fasting as an aspect of prayer
- Worship
 - meaning of worship
 - why people worship
 - ways of worship
 - worship as practised in the Old Testament
 - worship as practised by the early Christian Community
 - common features of worship in the Old Testament and the early Christian Community

3.3 Biblical Practices

The following are some of the biblical practices which are presented in the Bible: naming, circumcision, baptism, Holy Communion, prayer, fasting, worship.

A. Naming ceremony (Luke 2: 21)

- Names are very important in many communities. A name has a meaning attached to it. To have a name, is one of the human rights which every person enjoys since the time of Adam. In most cases a gives one identity.
- Jewish children were named according to prevailing circumstances. The naming was usually done on the eighth day after the child's birth. In most cases a baby was named after his father or a name was taken from any of his / her father's relative. Jesus was given the name that the angel had given his mother during annunciation. Jesus means God saves.

Importance of naming ceremony

- It is one way of respecting human rights i.e. right to a name
- It gives one identity
- It portrays a special meaning surrounding the birth of a particular child

B. Circumcision (Luke 2: 21)

- Circumcision is the removal of the foreskin of a man's penis. The Jews practiced circumcision because it was a sign of belonging to God as it is stated in Genesis 17: 9 – 14
- When God made a covenant with Abraham, circumcision was given as the sign of the covenant. Thus Abraham was circumcised when he was 99 years and Ishmael was 13 years when he was circumcised (Genesis 17: 23 – 27)
- Then God commanded Abraham to have all male babies circumcised on the eighth day after birth. For example Genesis 21: 4 says that: "and when Isaac was eight days old, Abraham circumcised him as God had commanded."
- Nowadays circumcision is practiced not only among the Jews but also Muslims and Christians.

Importance of circumcision

- From the time of Abraham, circumcision was used as a sign of belonging to God. Anyone who was not circumcised was considered as an outcast among the Jews
- A male who was not circumcised could not be allowed to go to the Temple or synagogue
- It promotes hygiene in male genitals as a result their sexual partners are protected from cervical cancer.
- Circumcision also helps to reduce the spread of HIV and AIDS. There is a scientific evidence of this (though not 100%). Of late Malawi government has realized the importance of circumcision and campaigns are everywhere encouraging people to be circumcised.

C. Baptism (Matthew 3: 1 – 7)

- The word baptism literary means dipping in water
- This was a symbol of cleanliness or purity

Thus baptism can be defined as a

- Christian religious rite consisting of immersion in or sprinkling with water as a sign that the subject is cleansed from sin and constituted as a member of the church
- Religious sacrament marked by the symbolic application of water to the head or immersion of the body into water and resulting in admission of the recipient into the community of Christians
- Christian sacrament signifying cleansing and rebirth. Baptism symbolizes that one dies to the old sinful life and rises with a new cleansed life. Thus according to Paul baptism is a symbol f death and resurrection

Categories of baptism

The Bible has a record of the following categories of baptism

i. Baptism of gentiles

- Gentiles were people who were not Jews, and they were worshipping idols. They were regarded as unclean so when they were converted to Judaism, they had to be made clean by being

baptized. Following this argument the Jews as God's chosen people were not baptized because they were clean.

ii. Baptism of Jews

- Judaism was the only religion which was worshipping one true God before and during the time of Jesus Christ. As a result, the Jews claimed that there was no need to baptize fellow Jews
- However, John the Baptist argued that the Jews must be baptized because the Jews were as unclean as the gentiles due to their sinfulness (unfaithfulness to God)
- Thus his message was turn away from your sins and be baptized. Most Jews as descendants of Abraham – God's chosen people - found this teaching shocking.

iii. Baptism of Jesus

- Jesus was not a sinner but his baptism was a sign that he accepted and started his mission in obedience to God, his father.
- (Refer to notes on the significance of Jesus' baptism for more information)

iv. Baptism after Pentecost

- It is a baptism in the name of Jesus Christ; and faith in Jesus Christ is a condition.
- Believers of God through his son, Jesus Christ, are baptized as a sign of belonging to the family of God.
- The baptism is made using "holy" water in the name of the father, the son and the Holy Spirit.
- In this way, they acknowledge to be always under the authority and power of God the father, the son and the Holy Spirit.
- Through baptism Christians profess one Lord, one faith and one baptism
- Before Pentecost, John was baptizing people in the river Jordan. However, after Pentecost people were baptized everywhere. For example, Phillip baptized the Ethiopian Eunuch using water they found as they were walking (Acts 8:36)

Importance of baptism

- After repentance a baptism is demanded as a condition of being accepted in Christianity

D. Holy Communion (Exodus 12: 1 – 28; Mark 14: 22 – 28)

- In mark 14: 22 – 26 Jesus Christ celebrated his last supper with his apostles.
- In the gospel according to Luke, the Lord's supper is covered in chapter 22: 14 – 23
- In verse 19, Jesus Christ says "... Do this in memory of me."
- The Christians today celebrate the Holy Communion because Jesus Christ asked them to celebrate the Holy Communion in memory of Him
- Different groups of people have given the celebration different names. Some call it the Lord's supper, the Breaking of Bread, Mass, the Eucharist or Holy Communion
- Again, different Christians differ on the frequency of celebrating the Holy Communion. For example, some do it once a year, others four times a year; others do it on daily basis. All these are correct as long as they do it to remember Jesus Christ

Importance of the Holy Communion

- It is one way of worshipping God
- It is one of the sacraments in most Christian churches
- It encourages people to repent their sins since it is taken with clean hearts
- It emphasizes that the eating and drinking is an act of fellowship which unites Christians with each other and with Christ as the head.

The Lord's Supper (Exodus 12: 1 – 28, Mark 14: 22 – 26)

- The Lord's Supper was instituted by Jesus when he celebrated the Passover meal with His apostles, before his death. The meal was celebrated on Thursday night.

Note

- During the Passover ceremony, each family sacrificed a lamb and the blood was put on door posts of the house.

- The rest of the lamb was eaten (roasted) by the whole family while standing up, and dressed as if to go on a journey
- Unleavened bread, bitter herbs and wine were taken in commemoration of the Passover from Egypt
- When Jesus and his disciples were having the last Supper the following transpired , Mark chapter 14
- Verse 22: while they were eating, Jesus took a piece of bread, gave a prayer of thanks, broke it, and gave it to his disciples. "Take it," he said, "this is my body"
- Verses 23- 25: then he took a cup, gave thanks to God, and handed it to them; and they all drank from it. Jesus said, "This is my blood which is poured out for many, my blood which seals God's covenant. I tell you, I will never again drink this wine until the day I drink the new wine in the Kingdom of God."
- Verse 26. Then they sang a hymn and went out to Mount of Olives

The Lord's Supper symbolizes

A. Deliverance from the bondage of sin through the sacrifice of Jesus Christ

- During the last supper Jesus indicated that his death was a sacrifice similar to the animals whose blood sealed the covenants like that of Mount Sinai
- Jesus' death was going to replace the sacrifice of the Old Law and deliver men not from physical captivity like that of Egypt but from the bondage of sin

B. Making a new covenant between God and people

- This new covenant was made by all and that the Lord had accomplished through the life, teaching death and resurrection of Jesus.
- In saying that the wine was the blood of the covenant Jesus meant that He was bringing men into new relationship with God.
- This was prophesied by Jeremiah (31: 31 – 33)

C. Fellowship of Christ's family with one another and with Christ as head

- When Christians gather together in Holy communion, they share in the blood of Christ and are made new members who are God's people – they are a new Israel

Note that the Lord's Supper was taken by Jesus and his disciples on the night of Thursday in the Holy week. After taking this Supper Jesus did not eat anything until his death; that is why it is also called the Last Supper.

3.4 Prayer, Fasting and Worship as biblical practices

Prayer, fasting and worship have common features; in short all of them have something to do with praising God

A. Prayer

Prayer can be defined in many ways such as

- It is an instrument that is used to communicate with God spending time with him ; alone or with others
- Prayer is communication / conversation with God through which we establish or build friendship and better relationships between God and ourselves

In Matthew 6: 6 -8 Jesus teaches Christians how to pray in secret. He discourages loudness that amounts to babbling when praying, thinking that God listens to many words. In quietness, that father knows what we require from him.

The key points of prayer

A good prayer has the following aspects of prayer or characteristics

A. Adoration

- This is exalting the greatness of the Lord, the creator. In prayer, one must first all respect and admire God because He is worth of worshipping

- For example, "... I praise you God because of your Holy name, God you are worth to be praised because you sustain life to all your creation..."

B. Thanksgiving

- In prayer one needs to thank God for His free gifts such as the gift of life

C. Intercession

- A prayer should have an aspect of intervention;
- it should offer mediation services between a sinner and the super Being

D. Confession

- In prayer one must acknowledge that he / she is a sinner and must show willingness to repent just as the tax collector prayed
- "... God, be merciful to me a sinner." Luke 18: 13

E. Supplication

- An aspect of request and appeal should be seen in prayer.
- God is our Father and we should channel all our petitions to God through Jesus Christ
- In the New Testament, there is a lot of vocabulary on supplication like; ask, beseech, plead, entreat, cry out etc.

The Lord's Prayer (Luke 11: 1 – 4; Matthew 6: 9- 13)

One of the disciples of Jesus asked him to teach them how to pray. In his response Jesus taught that when they want to pray, they should pray like this

- Our Father in heaven
- May your holy name be honoured'
- May your Kingdom come
- May your will be done on earth
- As it is in heaven
- Give us today the food we need
- Forgive us the wrongs we have done
- As we forgive the wrongs others have done to us
- Do not bring us to the hard testing
- But keep safe us from the Evil One

Aspects of prayer in the Lord's Prayer

The Lord's Prayer can be analyzed by looking at the following aspects

Aspects of a prayer	Corresponding part of the lord's Prayer
Thanksgiving	"Our in heaven May your holy name be honoured"
Asking the will of God	"May your will be done on earth as it is in heaven"
Request for provision	"Give us today the food we need"
Forgiveness of sins	"Forgive us the wrongs we have done, as we forgive the wrongs that others have done to us"
Protection from temptations	"Do not bring us to the hard testing, but keep us safe from the Evil One"
Glorifying God	The prayer should be used in adoring and elevating God as we worship Him and Him alone

Why People pray today

People pray for different reasons and some of them are as follows

i. For thanksgiving (Philippians 4:6 and Psalms 8:1)

- There is need to thank god because He is good all the time. This is a reason we have to thank God. Psalms 118: 1
- Sometimes we ask God to give us our needs and when those things are given, then we offer thanksgiving prayer to God. Philippians 4: 6 says' "Do not worry about anything, but in all your prayers ask god for what you need, always asking him with a thanksgiving heart.

ii. For guidance (Acts 1: 24 – 26)

- People pray to ask God to guide them on their day to day undertaking. For example, apostles prayed so that God should guide them to choose the right person to replace Judas. "Lord,

you know the thoughts of everyone, so show us which of these two you have chosen.” (Acts 1 : 24)

iii. For wisdom (I Kings 3: 4 – 9)

- People pray asking for wisdom from God to help them to govern people with wisdom and kindness
- This is very common to people who are charged with a new responsibility
- For example when King Solomon was appointed as king of Israel, he asked for wisdom to rule the Israelites with justice

iv. For protection (Genesis 32: 9 -12)

- People pray to God for protection
- For example when people are travelling by car, airplane, ship etc, they pray for God’s protection so that they should travel and arrive safely to their destinations
- Even when Jacob was about to meet his brother Esau, he prayed for God’s protection (Genesis 32: 8 -12)

v. For adoration (Psalms 117: 1 -2)

- People pray to admire God for his eternal love.
- God is worth to be worshiped so it important to fulfill our requirement of praising God.
- Psalms 117 1 – 2 agrees, “Praise the Lord, all nations ... his love for us is so strong and his faithfulness is eternal

vi. For worship (Isaiah 1: 11 -16; Psalms 95: 1 – 6; Proverbs 3:9)

- God created us to worship him.
- Psalms 95: 6 invites everybody to bow down and worship the creator
- Proverbs 3:9 adds that when we are worshipping we should also make an offering to God.
- We can offer material things, our services or our hearts

Other reasons why people pray include:

- To request for favours
- To confess and seek for forgiveness
- To strengthen our faith and give ourselves hope
- To get consolation when we feel troubled

- To get healed from physical, spiritual and emotional ailments
- To emulate Jesus who is our role model; he Himself prayed.
- etc

Fasting

Fasting is the practice of abstaining from food for various reasons. Fasting goes together with praying.

Reasons for fasting

a. Religious reasons

Fasting as an aspect of prayer is very important because people fast for the following reasons

- As a way of doing self- punishment (penance) for sins. As they fast they confess and seek for forgiveness
- As a means of asking God for a special favour like to have a child, to find employment, to find a spouse etc
- As a means of preparing prayer and meeting God
- To show obedience to the church rules that demand fasting

b. Protesting reasons (hunger strike)

- Some people fast as a way of protesting to something and this is called hunger strike
- This is common in developed country
- People can protest over many issues like; poor working conditions in work places, poor diet in boarding schools, serious violations of human rights in the country etc

c. Health reasons

- other people fast for health reasons
- For example, if a patient is going for an operation fasting is demanded on the day of operation
- Similarly when a person is going for diabetes testing, he / she is advised not to eat anything

Note

Some people who suffer from certain diseases are prone to refrain from eating certain food so as to maintain their health. For example

Disease	Food which a patient should refrain from
High blood pressure	Boiled eggs, animal fats
Diabetes	Bananas, sugarcane, salty foods
Obesity	Meat, fats, boiled eggs

Worship

Worship means respect for or honour to a thing or person. Divine worship is the honour by which human beings recognize the excellence of God and their dependence on him (God is sole creator and sustainer of the universe). Or worship is an act of submitting ourselves to God and giving Him the highest honour and respect. It is adoration. When we adore God, we worship Him.

Ways of worship (Psalms 95 & Deuteronomy 16: 5 – 6)

There are many ways of worshipping and some of them are as follows:

- Through prayer
- Singing joyful songs of praise (Praise to God through songs)
- Kneeling down before God
- Bowing down before god
- Obeying God's command
- Through fasting
- Doing charitable work
- Through tithes and offerings
- Through reading the Bible (Scripture reading)
- Living a purposeful life
- Preaching

Reasons for worship today

People worship for different reasons and some of them are as follows

- For thanksgiving
- To pay back respect to God who created them

- As a route of what they do on the Sabbath or a day of prayer
- To obey the demands of their parents or masters
- For protection
- With friends so that they should have a colourful burial ceremony

Worship as practiced in the Old Testament (Isaiah 45:23, 1 Samuel 1: 10 – 17, 2 Samuel 7: 18 -27, Deuteronomy 32: 43, Genesis 20: 7 and Genesis 47: 31)

Isaiah 45: 23

Isaiah emphasized on the worship of one true God, Yahweh, He condemned the worship of idols made from wood. He said that their idols cannot save them but God can. God told them that his promises were true and could never change. Since God was faithful to his people, the people were expected to worship him alone and vow to be loyal to him.

1 Samuel 1: 10 – 17

In this passage Hannah a solemn prayer to God. She asked God to at her as His servant. She requested God to her a son and promised that she would dedicate him to God for his whole life. When Eli learnt that she was not drunk he assured her that she would be given what she was asking for. Indeed she was given what she asked the Lord for. In this context prayer is seen as an element of worship.

2 Samuel 7: 18 – 27

Worship in the Old Testament was conducted in the tent of meeting which was also called the Tabernacle. David went into the tent of the Lord's presence, sat down and prayed.

After King Solomon built the Temple for God, worship was done in the Temple. Worship was done in humility to God. King David

emphasised the worship of God alone. He condemned the worship of idols.

When David was promised that he and his descendants would rule over Judah forever, he prayed a prayer of thanksgiving.

Deuteronomy 32: 34

This passage shows that singing formed part of worship in the Old Testament. In the song Moses worshipped the Lord by citing all the things that the Lord had to the people of Israel.

Genesis 20: 7

This entails that in worship, prophets interceded for people, in prayer.

Genesis 47: 31

When Jacob was dying, he asked Joseph, his son, to vow to bury him among his fathers. Joseph vowed to do exactly that. This vowing is an act of worship.

Worship in the early Christian Community

The following were the elements of worship among the early believers

- ✓ they shared their belongings
- ✓ they ate together
- ✓ they prayed together
- ✓ they spent their time teaching people
- ✓ they performed miracles and wonders
- ✓ they could sing hymns so as God to help them (Paul and Silas)they enjoyed the good will of all people
- ✓ accepting suffering for the sake of Jesus is an of worship
- ✓ they worshipped in the Temple

Common features of worship in the Old Testament and early Christian Community

- **Sharing (Exodus 12: 1 -4 vs. Acts 4: 32 – 34)**

Sharing was an important element in the Old Testament worship as well as in the early Christian community

For example in the exodus event, the Israelites were asked to prepare meals and take it as families. Similarly in Acts of the Apostles the believers shared with one another whatever they had.

Those that owned fields and houses had to sell them and the income was shared amongst them depending on one's needs.

- **Praying together (Isaiah 56:7 vs. Acts 1: 4 – 15, 2: 1)**

Isaiah describes the Temple as a house of prayer for all people: Jews and Gentiles alike. The people will be united and do things together.

In Acts of the Apostles, the believers also gathered together, praying together.

- **Offering (Isaiah 1: 13 vs. Acts 21: 26)**

In Isaiah, God calls upon the people to repent truly so as to accept their sacrifices

In Acts, Paul joined the men in the ritual of purification to prove that he never taught against the Law of Moses

In both cases the sacrifices are offered and the need for a pure heart is emphasized.

- **Fasting (Isaiah 58: 6 – 9 vs. Acts 13: 2 – 3)**

Fasting is the practice of abstaining from food as a sign of humbling and dedicating oneself to God

However Isaiah taught that fasting should aim at removing injustice and oppression of the poor people. This should be done by sharing food and clothes to those in need.

Fasting in Acts 13: 3 -5 increased the prayers of the believers. The apostles gained courage to witness for Jesus through prayer and fasting.

In Antioch the prophets and teachers prayed and fasted and then sent Barnabas and Saul on the mission as instructed by the Holy Spirit. They went off, taught and preached boldly and won a lot of people to the Lord.



In the Old Testament fasting was to help people to dedicate themselves to God and similarly in the New Testament fasting was a means of dedicating oneself to God.

Review Exercise

1. Define the following terms
 - i. Prayer
 - ii. Fasting
 - iii. Worship
2. Discuss various aspects of prayer
3. What aspects of prayer are found in the Lord's Prayer?
4. Why is it important for Christians to pray today?
5. List down different forms of worship
6. Why do Christians worship?

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Bible Knowledge

Form 2

Chapter 7

CONTEMPORARY CHRISTIAN ISSUES

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CONTEMPORARY CHRISTIAN ISSUES

OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, the student should be able to:

1. discuss how people contract HIV and AIDS and STIs
2. explain Christian ways of preventing HIV and AIDS and STIs
3. suggest Christian response towards people infected and affected by STIs including HIV and AIDS
4. identify gender issues in the Bible
5. analyze the role of men and women in the Bible
6. discuss the effects of drug and substance abuse
7. discuss the prevention of drug and substance abuse from a Christian perspective

CONTENTS

HIV and AIDS and STIs

- ways of contracting HIV and AIDS and STIs
- Christian ways of preventing HIV and AIDS and STIs
 - Abstinence
 - self-control
 - love
 - faithfulness
- Christian response to STIs including HIV and AIDS towards the infected and the affected

Gender issues in the Bible

- Discussing gender issues in the Bible
 - discipleship

- fellowship
 - leadership
- place of men and women in the Bible
 - men and women were created as equals
 - God blessed men and women
 - both men and women were given authority over God's creation
 - Jesus appeared first to a woman after resurrection

Drug and substance abuse

- the effects of drug and substance abuse
- preventing drug and substance abuse from a Christian perspective

4.1 HIV and AIDS and STIs

- Acquired Immune Deficiency Syndrome (AIDS) is caused by a virus known as Human Immunodeficiency Virus (HIV). HIV is a virus that leads to AIDS.
- HIV destroys the body's immunity i.e. the white blood cells such that any disease can easily attack the body
- Note that people infected with the HIV virus may remain healthy for sometime before showing symptoms of the disease.
- This depends on how well a person feeds, their immunity and personal response to the disease
- When the body's defense system has been weakened by HIV a person suffers from a range of diseases and is referred to as an AIDS patient

Ways of Contracting HIV and AIDS and STIs

- People contract HIV and AIDS in different ways. It is wrong to think that every person who is HIV positive contracted it through unprotected sex.
- There are three main ways of contracting HIV namely:

a. Unprotected sexual intercourse

- HIV is mainly spread through unprotected sexual intercourse with an infected person. The spread of HIV is made easier by the presence of STIs especially those that cause genital ulcers (wounds).
- Body movements during sex make the vagina and penis to have scratches, cuts and blisters. And it is through these openings that HIV moves from one person to another.

b. Blood to blood contact

- HIV lives in blood. Blood to blood contact as a means of transmitting HIV can be done in several ways including:

i. Blood transfusion

- If a blood donor is infected and if the blood is not screened, HIV is transmitted through blood transfusion. This is why blood to be transfused to sick person should be screened thoroughly

ii. Unsterilized instruments

- If unsterilized instruments are used by more than one person and if one of the people is infected then HIV could easily be transmitted. This could happen at home, in schools or even in hospital. Some examples of these instruments are; needles, pins, razor blades, knives, syringe

iii. Road accidents

During road accidents people have cuts and in the process share blood. If one is HIV positive he / she may easily spread it to others. It is for this reason that anybody involved in road accident should seek for PEP services once they go to the hospital.

c. Infected mother to child

- It is possible for an infected mother to transmit HIV to her unborn child. The probability chance of an infected mother passing the HIV to a child is about 30%.
- The mother can transmit the HIV to child before birth, during birth and during breast feeding.

Sexually Transmitted Infections (STIs)

- Other serious diseases that are sexually transmitted include; gonorrhea, syphilis, herpes genitals and Hepatitis. These diseases may directly affect the sexual organs or other important parts of the body like the heart or brain

Christian ways of preventing HIV and AIDS and STIs

Most Christians do not agree with health personnel on the use of condoms as one way of preventing contracting HIV and AIDS and STIs. They believe prevention is better than cure. Thus some of the Christian ways of preventing contracting HIV and AIDS include:

a. Abstinence

- In 1 Thessalonians 4: 3 – 8, Paul teaches Christians that God is Holy and demands everyone to lead a life that is worthy of Him. He wants people to be holy and completely free from sexual immorality.
- Abstinence is the act of refraining from sexual activities completely. From a Christian point of view, this is the best way of preventing HIV/AIDS and STIs. As for married people, they should be faithful to each other.
- Church leaders should preach and guide the youth to abstain from indulging in sexual immoralities.
- The youth should be taught that strong feelings of love in the world mean nothing until two people – man and woman, have made a commitment to each other for the rest of their lives.

b. Self – control

- Self – control is one of the principles of life in Christianity. A person should not be defeated by a desire to have sex, which could lead to rape and prostitution.

- Instead self – control should be used to defeat sexual desires. We should learn to respect our bodies as well as other people's bodies because they are temples of God.

c. Love (Matthew 22: 34 – 40)

- Love is the most important thing in preventing HIV and AIDS. If a person has love, he or she cannot spread HIV or STIs to other people. Jesus commanded humankind to love one another.
- If you love your spouse you cannot go around with other people. If you love your friends you cannot take their children as your sex partners. If you love your fellow student you cannot ask him / her to have sexual intercourse with you for fear of contracting or spreading HIV.
- Love should be aimed at saving life of a fellow human being.

d. Faithfulness (Proverbs 6: 20 – 35 ; 7: 1 – 27)

- The book of Proverbs 6: 20 – 35 warns people to be cautious about desires. They should obey God's commandments and listen to the Christian teachings on sexual responsibility and discipline. Men and women are warned against adultery.
- The youth should follow good advice from parents who can keep them away from bad women and seductive words of other men's wives. They should not be tempted by women's beauty
- Adultery costs a person all he / she has, and destroys him / her. Prostitutes have killed many people; if anyone goes for adultery, he / she is on his/ her way to the world of the dead
- Married Christians are advised to be faithful to their partners. If all married people could be faithful to their spouses, the spread of HIV could be reduced

Note that HIV and AIDS pandemic is not a punishment from God as people think. It is like any other disease that people suffer from. The only difference is that up to now, HIV and AIDS has no cure.

Christian perspective on condom use

Some Christians believe that sex is a precious gift only to be enjoyed by married people and it should lead to procreation. Following this, the use of condoms to prevent new life is never allowed. Alternatively, natural

birth controls established by Billings are encouraged for child spacing and birth controls.

On the other hand, Christians are allowed to use condoms on critical situations mainly when someone's life is in danger. For example, if a couple goes for HIV test and the results show that one of the is positive and the other one is negative, the couple is allowed to use condoms in order to save the life of the one who is negative. Christians are therefore allowed to use condoms to save life and not as contraceptives / or as a means of not contracting diseases.

Other Christian denominations are silent on the use of condoms. This gives their followers a chance to decide whether to use them or not. However, others hold that allowing people to use condoms to protect themselves from contracting diseases is the same as encouraging them to commit adultery. Adultery is a sin and one the commandments of God forbids it.

Christian responses towards people infected and affected by STIs including HIV and AIDS

Firstly, Christians should have a positive attitude towards those suffering from HIV and AIDS and other STIs. They should care for them by providing both material and spiritual support. For example

- a. They should show love and concern for them. This is in line with Jesus' teaching that we should love our neighbor as we love ourselves. Matthew 22:39
- b. In Luke 10: 25 – 37, the story of the Good Samaritan teaches us how to care for the sick. Christians should look for means and ways of nursing and caring for the sick by providing material support such as medicine, clothes food and helping them to take their medication
- c. They should provide spiritual support to the sick by preaching to those affected and infected with HIV and AIDS and other STIs. They should visit and pray with them. They should pray in faith as prayers of faith save the sick as the Lord raises them. (James 5: 13 – 16)
- d. They should provide pastoral counseling so that HIV and AIDs patients can live with hope in God's everlasting and forgiving love

- e. They should ensure that the rights of those infected with HIV / AIDS are advocated. Nobody should be discriminated against because of being HIV positive
- f. Those who are affected should not get tired of helping the people under their care.
- g. They should also offer the physical support like bathing them, washing their clothes, leading them to the toilet and the like.

1.2 Gender Issues in the Bible

The Bible was written and set up in the background of a very patriarchal Jewish society. However, the Bible is gender sensitive as stories in it presents men and women as equals. The key areas under which gender issues in the Bible are highlighted are as follows:

a. Discipleship (Luke 8: 1 – 3)

- Luke teaches that Jesus had both men and women disciples. Among the women disciples were; Mary Magdalene from whom seven demons had gone out, Joanna the wife of Herod's steward Chuza. Susanna and many other women. These used their resources to help Jesus and his disciples. The Bible also tells us some of these women witnessed Jesus' suffering, death, burial and resurrection just like the apostles and other men. Mark records that after Jesus rose from the dead, he appeared first to Mary Magdalene, who went to other companions and preached the good news that Jesus Christ was risen

b. Fellowship (Acts 1: 12 – 14)

- After Jesus' ascension and as the disciples were waiting for the coming of the Holy Spirit, the women were not left out as disciples of Jesus. The women were among the disciples and they were all together devoted in prayer. This shows that both men and women can be very devoted in matters of prayer and fellowship.

c. Leadership (Judges 4: 4 – 24 ; Luke 2: 25 – 38)

- The Bible has a record of both men and women leaders. For example, Deborah was one of the women who had leadership role like men. She was a prophetess and a judge like prophetess

Miriam and Huldah. Deborah led her people to war against the Canaanites and came out victorious. She was a hero just like Joshua.

- In New Testament, both Simeon and Anna played prophetic roles in the life of Jesus. They predicted what Jesus' role would be in future. Mary and Joseph were amazed at what was said about Jesus.

Places of men and women in the Bible (the role of men and women in the Bible)

- In the Old Testament times of the Bible, issues of gender existed. For example, in the Jewish society, women were not recognized. In leadership roles, only men took the lead except in few cases where women such as Deborah are mentioned
- Similarly, in the New Testament many of the disciples of Jesus were men and the few women who were there were hidden in the background.
- In Proverbs 31: 10 – 31, women are presented as workers. Hard working women fill their homes with food and do other chores that bring profit to the home. Many women fear the Lord and would want to bring their households in the presence of the Lord.
- Again in the Bible, a woman is a channel of procreation. She is the one who carries the pregnancy and delivers children. She also nurses and nurtures children. For example, the mother Moses made a basket to hide her baby from being killed and later on found a way of nursing him herself. Ruth followed her mother – in – law Naomi to take care of her. Mary and Elizabeth took care of their children.
- Men in the bible are leaders e.g. Moses, Joshua, David, Solomon. They also take priestly jobs. They are also prophets although we have prophetess.

Despite these it should be noted that the Bible, first and foremost, depicts men and women as equals.

- For example Genesis 1: 26 – 27 says “Then God said, “And now we will make human beings, they will be like us, and resemble

us. They will have power over fish, the birds, and all animals, domestic and wild, large and small.” In addition to that Genesis 5: 2 compliment that: “He created them male and female”

As such the following are common in both men and women. They were both:

- Created by God
- Made in God’s image and they resemble God
- Made in charge over God’s creation
- Blessed by god
- Named human beings or humanity
- Co- creators
- Companions of each other

Since men and women are equal before God, they should be treated equally at any level in our society. Those who believe in God should be exemplary in practicing what the Bible teaches on the equality of men and women. This can be achieved by promoting education of a girl child.

1.3 Drug and Substance abuse

- The term drug refers to a chemical substance which when taken, goes into the body’s blood stream and causes changes in the functioning of the body.
- Some drugs are for curative use while others are misused to cause psychological changes in the body
- Examples of mostly misused drugs and substance include: alcohol, tobacco, bhang, heroin and cocaine.
- Drugs are mostly abused by youths. And drugs on humankind have both short – term and long – term effects
- In this subtopic, we will have a look at the general effects of drugs

Effects of drugs and substance abuse

a. It impairs the reasoning capacity of an individual (Genesis 19: 30 – 38)

- If people are drunk, their reasoning capacity is impaired and they may indulge themselves in immoral behaviours such as having unprotected sexual intercourse, which could result into contracting HIV.
- In Genesis 19: 30 – 38, Lot slept with his own biological daughters without knowing it due to intoxication.

b. It makes people to forget laws and ignore the rights of people (Proverbs 31: 4 – 7, Exodus 23: 2 and Psalms 1: 1 – 2)

- Proverbs 31: 4 – 7 advises kings that they should not drink wine or have a craving for alcohol because when they drink , they forget the laws and ignore the rights of other people
- In addition, this book makes it clear that alcohol is made for people who are in great pain, so that once they take it, they should be relieved of their pain

c. Fighting and robbery are the common characteristics of people who are under the influence of alcohol and drugs (1 Corinthians 15: 33 ; Proverbs 1: 10 – 19)

- Most people when intoxicated with drugs and substances tend to cause havoc.
- This is very common among the youth whose brains are not mature enough to withstand the influence of beer and other drugs and substances

Note

- Most youth indulge themselves in drug and substance abuse due to peer pressure
- However, people who are clever do not listen to their friends when they are forcing them to abuse drugs and substances. 1

Corinthians 15: 33 agrees that, "Do not be fooled. Bad companions ruin good character."

- Boys and girls are advised that, the problems they cause to others, one day they would bear the consequences.
- Proverbs 1:19 states that, "Robbery always claims the life of the robber – this is what happens to anyone who lives by violence"

d. It has healthy risks (Ephesians 5: 18)

- Some drugs may cause people to suffer from various diseases such as liver cirrhosis, cancer of throat, and psychological disorders e.g. aggressiveness, hallucinations and reduced listening ability.
- For instance on the wrappers of cigarettes it is clearly written that, "smoking is hazardous to life" yet people keep on buying and smoking.

e. It costs a lot of money (Isaiah 55:2)

- The Bible through Isaiah is teaching us that we should spend our money on important things which can help us.
- It is a sin to waste money on something that cannot satisfy our lives like chamba and beer.
- Drug and substance abuse cost people a lot of money because most abusers are addicted to them yet they have no health value.

Other effects are:

- Drugs may lead to unemployment as a person may lose his / her job to perpetual lateness and absenteeism because of alcoholism
- Drugs make students perform poorly in school as they can hardly pay attention in school or do their assignments
- It may lead to family break – ups since drug users fight a lot or quarrel and have no control over their emotions
- Drug and substance abuse can lead to school dropouts due to either poor performance or intolerance to school discipline
- Frequent use of drugs weakens the body's immune system making it prone to diseases



- Driving under the influence of alcohol or drugs leads to accidents and loss of life

Ways of Preventing Drug and Substance Abuse from a Christian Perspective

a. Civic education and literacy

- It is the responsibility of the church to give civic education on the dangers of drug and substance abuse to the youth.
- This helps the church as well as the nation to be assured of bright future

b. Being engaged in productive occupation (or using leisure time well)

- The church encourages that the youth should be engaged in meaningful occupation
- For example, engaging in entrepreneurship.
- It is not good to allow the youth to be bar men or bar girls, bottle collectors at a bottle store a receptionist at a rest house or minibus caller boys.
- Keeping oneself busy is very important since "an idle mind is the workshop of the devil"

c. Counseling

- It is important to give guidance and counseling to the youth at a church level on the dangers of drug and substance abuse
- These services can be provided to the youth through youth movements which exist at any church

d. Family help and interventions

- A family is a basic unit of the society as well as the church.
- If all the youth are guided at a family level then Malawi could have good societies
- The youth should learn to listen to the advice from their parents

REVIEW EXERCISE

1. What is HIV and AIDS?
2. Explain any two common ways of contracting HIV and AIDS and STIs.
3. Describe any four Christian ways of preventing HIV and AIDS and other STIs.
4. List down any three ways in which Christians can respond towards people infected and affected by HIV and AIDS.
5. Explain the role of women and men in the Bible in both the Old Testament and the New Testament
6. How did the women in the Bible times participate in the following:
 - a. Discipleship
 - b. Fellowship
 - c. Leadership
7. What is a drug?
8. Explain any four effects of drug and substance abuse
9. Suggest two reasons why the youth are involved in drug and substance abuse
10. Explain the importance of involving the youth in different activities at a church level.

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Bible Knowledge form 3 Chapter 1

USES OF THE BIBLE

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USES OF THE BIBLE

OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, the student should be able to:

- Explain the Bible as the inspired word of God
- Describe the uses of the Bible



CONTENTS

- Bible as the inspired word of God
- The uses of the Bible
 - worshipping
 - swearing
 - source of healing
 - meditation
 - preaching
 - academics
 - guidance and counselling
- story telling on the uses of the Bible



Introduction

You will recall that in your Junior Secondary, you learnt that the Bible is a library of many Holy writings of Scriptures. The Bible consists of the Old and New Testaments. There are 66 books; thirty – nine books in the Old Testaments and 27 books in the New Testament.

Bible as the Inspired Word of God

For the Bible to be as it is, it went through the process of canonisation which can be defined as a process of collecting authoritative books. In this process God was with the authors. He inspired the individual writers of the books of the Bible as well as those who selected the books that made the bible.

In 2 Timothy 3: 16, we read that, “All Scriptures is inspired by God and is useful for teaching the truth, rebuking error, correcting faults and giving instruction for right living.”

In 2 Peter 1: 20 – 21, we also read that, “Above all else, however, remember that none of us can explain by ourselves a prophecy in the scriptures. For no prophetic message ever came just from the human will, but people were under the control of the Holy Spirit as they spoke the message that came from God.”

This means that the word of God in the Bible was spoken and written by people using their own words, mouths and pen, although it came from God. The authors of the Bible were inspired by God Himself to write His word.

All believers must maintain a strong belief of the Holy Scriptures as inspired by God. Reasons:

Without a strong belief in the Holy Scriptures;

- One cannot be true to what Jesus, the Apostles and the Bible itself teaches about the scriptures
- The church has no true and sure foundation for its faith, no salvation, no message to preach without doubt, no sure

expectancy for baptism in the Holy Spirit and the working of miracles, and no hope for Christ's return

- Bible believers have no truth based on the activities of God Himself by which to judge and reject this world's ever changing values ungodly practices
- Christians will not be ready to withstand the difficulties of the last days
- The full authority and teachings of the Bible are weakened

Uses of the Bible

Since time immemorial, the Bible has been used by people in many ways as follows:

1. For worship

Worship is the expression of reverence and adoration for God. Christians read the Bible as an act of worship. The reading of the Bible teaches Christians how to worship God in truth and in Spirit. The Bible is used for worship through many ways such as praying and to follow the preacher and when the preacher retells the story.

2. For preaching and teaching

Christian Religious teachers use the Bible to explain God's message for the salvation of mankind. For example

- Theologically, they use it in preaching to explain great doctrines and truths such as baptism, forgiveness, perseverance, repentance and salvation
- Ethically, they use it to explain to their followers how to commit themselves to God, for example by following Biblical principles such as self – denial, Godly conduct, discernment of good and evil
- They also use it to teach lessons on practical living. For example they teach lessons on overcoming worries, temptations etc.

3. For meditation

Meditation means reflecting deeply on spiritual matters normally in a quiet manner. After reading the Bible, one needs to take time to think over what God teaches in the passage. In Joshua 1:8 God asks Joshua to read, study and obey the book of the Law. He assured him that if he does so he will be successful

4. For guidance and counselling

Guidance and counselling means assisting and giving advice and or helping people who face problems. The Bible is used by counsellors to help relieve people of their problems. People get pieces of advice on issues that affect their lives. For example

- Proverbs 29: 17 gives pieces of advice to parents on why they should discipline their children
- Proverbs 20:1 advises on the dangers of drinking too much alcohol

Note that wisdom books are normally used for guidance and counselling.

5. For singing

Singing refers to producing musical sounds with the voice. Some people use the scripture in the Bible to compose songs

6. For funeral rites

The Bible is used at funerals to comfort the bereaved and to strengthen their faith even if their beloved one is gone

7. For wedding ceremonies

When people are getting married, the pastor reads the scripture from the Bible to teach them the importance of marriage.

8. For administration of justice or swearing

The Bible is used when taking oaths in courts or taking offices by those appointed in public offices like judges, presidents, members of parliament, ministers, to show their commitment to their work.

9. For healing

When praying for the sick, Christians quote passages from the Bible which teach about healing (e.g. 2Kings 5: 1 -19; Luke 4: 31 – 36 etc). the Bible becomes a source of healing. Christians believe that they get healed through the faith in what the Bible teaches

10. For Academics

Teachers use the Bible as the resource book or text book when teaching

11. The Bible is also used by chaplains in war times **to strengthen the faith of soldiers** and that it is God who fights through His word.

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Bible Knowledge form 3

Chapter 10

THE MINISTRY OF JESUS CHRIST– DISCIPLESHIP AND TEACHINGS ABOUT SABBATH AND TAX

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THE MINISTRY OF JESUS CHRIST– DISCIPLESHIP AND TEACHINGS ABOUT SABBATH AND TAX

OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, the student should be able to:

- Distinguish a disciple from an apostle
- Analyse Jesus' teaching on discipleship
- Explain the mission of the twelve Apostles
- Describe teaching about the Sabbath
- State Jesus' teaching about paying tax

CONTENTS

- Discipleship
 - meanings of the terms 'disciple' and 'apostle'
 - difference between a disciple and an apostle
 - Jesus' teaching on discipleship
 - mission of the 12 disciples
- Jesus' teaching about the Sabbath
 - defining the term 'Sabbath'
 - describing Jesus' teaching about the Sabbath
- Jesus' teaching about paying tax
 - Jesus teaching on paying tax
 - Tax collectors as sinners
 - The importance of paying taxes today

Disciple and Apostle

The word disciple comes from the Latin word discipulus which means pupil or learner. In the Bible, the word refers to the people who followed and listened to the teachings of Jesus

The word Apostle comes from the Greek word Apostolos which means messenger. In the Bible it refers to the people that were chosen and sent as missionaries by Jesus

The difference between the disciples of Pharisees and of Jesus

Disciples of Pharisees	Disciples of Jesus
Disciples choose their masters	Jesus chose who to be his disciple
Were only men	Were both men and women
Were only men of good moral behaviour	Could be anybody; a sinner or not

Jesus' first Disciples Luke 5: 1 - 11

- The first disciples of Jesus were recruited at the sea of Gennesaret
- It was also called the sea of Galilee or Tiberias
- Jesus went there to preach
- On the occasion, Jesus noticed that some fishermen had failed to catch fish
- Jesus Called Peter (a professional fisherman, who knew his lake very well i.e. when to have a catch of fish or not)
- And asked him to let down his nets for a catch of fish

There are three reactions of Peter mentioned in this passage

Peter's first reaction

- He had some **doubts** with Jesus' request
- He doubted how they could catch fish during the day while night fishing had been unsuccessful
- However, Peter had confidence in Jesus' words and teaching
- Thus he let down his nets for a catch of fish
- The result was that they caught a large number of fish to the extent

that their nets were about to break

Note

- This made Peter realize that Jesus was not an ordinary man but a divine person
- Hence, Peter realized that he was in God's presence and consequently became aware of his sinfulness

Peter's second reaction

- Having realized his sinfulness, Peter **asked Jesus to go away from him because he was a sinful man**

Note

- His reaction was similar to that of Isaiah (Isaiah 6: 5)
- His reaction is a natural reaction of sinners in God's presence

Peter's third reaction

- It was that of **faith and total dedication to God**
- Jesus asked Peter to follow him
- Peter left everything and followed Jesus (i.e. radical discipleship)
- On the same occasion, Jesus called James and John sons of Zebedee
- They were all called to be **fishers of men** i.e. to **win people (Jews and gentiles alike) into the kingdom of God**

Importance of teaching from a boat

- A voice carries well over water, so the crowd could hear him well
- The crowd had a better view of Jesus
- The separation prevented disturbances; so Jesus could focus on teaching and the people on listening

Lessons about discipleship

- Without Jesus' call one cannot become a disciple. Jesus takes the initiative
- Anybody can be called to be a disciple (First disciples were enrolled from a group of fishermen)
- Jesus calls disciples not necessarily for their own salvation but rather to bring people into the kingdom

Lessons for Peter

- Peter must obey Jesus even when things look hopeless
- Peter's mission is to catch or to win people into the Kingdom of God
- The work of catching men is team work

- In the end the work will be successful

Lessons for early church

- Peter had a special position among his fellow apostles
- Great catch of fish refers to the great number of gentiles who would be converted Acts 2:41

The call of Levi Luke 5: 27 - 32

- Levi was a tax collector by profession
- At Jesus' time. All tax collectors worked for the Roman government
- Jews who were employed as tax collectors were hated by their fellow Jews because
 - They were regarded as **traitors**: This was because they worked in collaboration with the Romans – their enemies
 - They were regarded as **thieves**: This was because they cheated their fellow Jews by collecting more than what was legal
 - They were regarded as **unclean**: This was because of their association with the gentiles when collecting taxes and because of using denarius (Roman money) which was the only accepted money to be used for paying tax- yet to the Jews the money was defiling since it bore the image of the Emperor.

Due to these tax collectors were disliked and despised; however

- Jesus called Levi, one of the tax collectors, to be his disciple
- Levi accepted
- He left everything and followed Jesus
- Then he shared his food and joy with Jesus and others
- The Pharisees were amazed with this and asked Jesus' disciples why they ate and drank with sinners and outcasts
- Jesus answered on their behalf saying
- **People who are well do not need a doctor, but only those who are sick**

- I have not come to call respectable people to repent, but sinners

Lessons from Jesus' answer

- Jesus came to call sinners to repentance
- God accepts people who know that they are sinners

Note

The name **Levi** is the same as **Matthew** and means **God's gift**. He is possibly the author of the first gospel.

Jesus chooses the twelve apostles Luke 6: 12 - 16

Why did Jesus choose the apostles?

- Possibly the growing opposition from the Jewish leaders over fasting, his association with sinners, Sabbath observation etc prompted Jesus to make a fresh start with the twelve apostles
- Possibly he wanted them to be his intimate friends; He needed companions
 - Note that Jesus spent the whole night praying to God before he chose the apostles (Luke 6: 12). This was a sign that he was about to make a serious decision

Why did Jesus choose twelve apostles?

- The number 12 refers to the twelve tribes of God's chosen people
- Jesus fulfills the OT by bringing together a new people which will live with God in a new relationship (covenant)
- This will be a new Israel and will be founded on twelve apostles, leaders of God's new people
 - The twelve apostles will replace the twelve tribes of Israel as leaders of God's people
- As seen above, they were chosen to be his friends
- The number 12 also stands for completeness

Who were chosen as apostles?

- He chose Simon (Peter), Andrew, James son of Alphaeus, Simon (Patriot), Judas son of James, John, Phillip, Bartholomew, Matthew, Thomas and Judas Iscariot (who became the traitor)
 - Note that the fact that these apostles stayed together as one group despite their different experiences shows that it was a miracle

Jesus' teaching about discipleship Luke 9: 23 – 27

- After Jesus had revealed that he was a suffering servant, he pointed out that likewise his followers must suffer
- **Vs 23** teaches the cost of discipleship i.e. self denial / self forgetting and to take up one's cross and follow Jesus daily
 - Note that **cross** refers to **suffering**. Thus to carry the cross implies that
- A disciple has to put into practice all demands of the Kingdom of God at all costs
- A disciple has to accept suffering as part and parcel for witnessing for Jesus

The cost of a disciple Luke 14: 25 – 33

- Jesus told the crowd that whoever wants to become his disciple must be

- Ready to love him more than anyone else e.g. father, mother, wife children, brothers as well as themselves
- Ready to carry their own cross daily and follow Jesus. Cross stands for suffering. Therefore Jesus meant that they must be ready to suffer for the sake of Jesus

The would be followers/ disciples of Jesus Luke 9: 57 – 62

- Here Jesus warned the three disciples about the cost of discipleship
- To become a disciple might result into a conflict of loyalties
- To follow Jesus requires the highest loyalty
 - For instance
 - It may require from a man to **sacrifice security**
- The son of man has nowhere to lie down and rest vs. 58
- It may require a **choice between Jesus and duty towards parents**
 - The Jews had the custom that children must care for their parents until they die
 - Thus children had to remain at home and care for their parents until their death and burial
 - This was done in accordance with the forth commandment: Respect your father and mother
 - However Jesus sometimes requires a choice between good and best
 - Let the dead bury their own dead, You go and proclaim the Kingdom of God vs.60
 - This implies that Jesus, mission needs no postponement and has to take first priority
 - Parents and relatives take second place in the life of a disciple; a hard truth for those who are deeply attached to their kinsfolk
 - It may require to **concentrate on your task fully and with undivided feeling**
 - Anyone who starts to plough and then keeps looking back is of no use to the Kingdom of God vs. 62
 - There is need to follow Jesus whole heartedly

The Mission of the Twelve Apostles Luke 9: 1 – 6 **What was their Mission?**

- To preach the good news about the kingdom of God
- To heal the sick
- To cast out demons

Note

- Their mission involved soul and body showing Jesus' concern for the total person

Why did Jesus send them on this mission?

- To assist Jesus in his work
- He had many followers in different places, towns and village. He could not visit them all thus he needed the assistance of his apostles
- To let them practice proclaiming the good news about the Kingdom of God which will be their main task after Jesus' ascension
- To strengthen the bond of Christian communities
- To enable the apostles share in all aspects of Jesus' life

Jesus' instructions to the twelve

- Do not take anything for the journey; no stick, no beggars' bag, no food, no money, no extra shirt
- Stay wherever you are welcomed
- Leave the town and shake the dust off your feet wherever you are not welcomed

Significance of these instructions

- To let them have trust that God will provide all their needs like food, clothes etc.
- To let them have trust that God will protect them from any danger; no walking stick
- To let them travel lighter and faster since their mission was an urgent one
- To save time (stay wherever you are welcomed and leave if not welcomed). Do not look for better accommodation; their work is urgent
- To warn the Jews that if they do not accept their teaching, they prove themselves that they do not belong to God and so may reconsider their thoughts (to shake off the dust...)

Sabbath problem

- The word Sabbath literary means to- stop – in – order - to – praise- God
- To the Jews, Sabbath is the seventh day of the week in the Hebrew calendar whose first day is Sunday. Therefore Sabbath day is a Saturday

- Jews observed it as a day of rest and worship of God
- Any form of work was forbidden on this day
- Teachers of the Law listed 39 types of actions which were classified as work
- These included preparing food, making fire, walking more than 1250m, hand clapping, harvesting, healing while not an emergency etc
- Observing the Sabbath was a way for the Jews to show in public that they were pious Jews
- Breaking the Sabbath tantamount to ceasing to be a Jew
- The offender got one warning; if he broke the Sabbath again he / she was punishable by death

Jesus' attitude towards the Sabbath

- Jesus respected the Sabbath rules Luke 4:16
- However Jesus would break the rules especially if they would cause delay in relieving any suffering
- Jesus was convinced that human needs are more important than the law. The Law is for the good of human being
- Since it was his mission to establish the kingdom of God, Jesus preferred to do his healing work on the Sabbath
- Healing on the Sabbath was also a sign that he was the Lord of the Sabbath, the Messiah

Jesus and his disciples in a corn field Luke 6: 1 - 5

- Jesus was walking through a corn field on the Sabbath
- His disciples began to pick ears of corn, rub them in their hands and ate the grains
- Some Pharisees asked
- Why are you doing what our law says you cannot do on the Sabbath?
- Jesus answered them
- Haven't you read and heard what David did when he and his men were hungry
- He went to the house of God, took the bread offered to God, ate it and gave it also to his men
- Yet it was against our law for anyone except the priests to eat that bread
- And Jesus concluded, "The son of man is the Lord of the Sabbath" The question of the Pharisees; "Why are you doing what our law

says you cannot do on the Sabbath?"

- According to the Pharisees
 - picking of corn was like harvesting
 - rubbing them in their hands was like threshing
 - separating the grains from the husks was like winnowing
 - eating them presupposed that they had prepared food
 - all these were regarded as work and hence forbidden to be done on the Sabbath

In response, Jesus quoted what David did

- Note that to the Jews David was the ideal and the most righteous king
 - He was an example of a true Israelite
 - When David and his men were hungry, he asked the priest Ahimelech to give them some bread reserved by law to the priests (Lev. 24: 7 -9)
 - The priest agreed, judging that, in a case of need such a law could and should be suspended 1 Sam. 21: 2 - 6
 - And the Jews did not blame David for what he did (saving people's lives at the expense of the law)
 - His action shows that man's needs are more important than observance of ritual rules
- By quoting what David did, Jesus implied that he allowed his disciples to pick ears of corn on the Sabbath in order to satisfy their needs; they were hungry

Lessons

- Human needs are more important than observance of the Law
- Sabbath is made for man and not vice versa
- Jesus is the Lord of the Sabbath

Jesus heals a man with a paralyzed right hand Luke 6: 6 – 11

- On another Sabbath Jesus went into a synagogue and taught
- A man was there whose right hand was paralyzed
- Some teachers of the Law and Pharisees wanted a reason to accuse Jesus of doing wrong
 - Note that if Jesus would heal the man on the Sabbath, he would be accused of working since it was not an emergency case
- Jesus knew their thoughts and said to the man
- Stand up and come here to the front

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- The man got up and stood there
- Then Jesus said to them
- I ask you; what does our law allow us to do on the Sabbath?
- To help or to harm? To save someone's life or to destroy it?
- The question put them in dilemma
- By posing this question, Jesus tried to make his opponents realize that they were doing harm, by trying to prevent the healing while Jesus intended to help and save life
- Jesus looked around at them all and said to the man
- Stretch out your hand
- He did so and his hand became well again
- They were filled with rage and began to discuss among themselves what they could do to Jesus

Lessons

- Human needs are more important than observing the Sabbath
- Showing love and mercy towards a neighbour is more important than observing the law
- Jesus is the Lord of the Sabbath
- The Sabbath is made for man and not vice versa

Jesus heals a sick man (a dropsical man) Luke 14: 1 – 6

- One Sabbath Jesus went to eat a meal at the home of one of the leading Pharisees
- A man whose legs and arms were swollen was also there
- People were watching Jesus closely to see if he would heal him on the Sabbath
- Jesus asked the Pharisees and teachers of the law
- Does our law allow healing on the Sabbath or not?
- The question put them in dilemma
- Yes would have meant that it was lawful to heal the man and they would not blame Jesus
- No would have indicated that Jesus' opponents had no mercy for the sick
- As a result they said nothing
- Then Jesus took the man, healed him and sent him away
- Then Jesus said to them
- If anyone of you had a son or an ox that happened to fall in a well on a Sabbath, would you not pull them out at once on the Sabbath itself

- They were not able to answer him about this

Lessons

- Love and mercy towards the sick is more important than observing the Sabbath laws
- Sabbath is made for man and not vice versa

Jesus Teaching on paying tax

Jesus and Zacchaeus Luke 19: 1 - 10

- The name Zacchaeus means **clean**
- He was the was a chief tax collector
- As per his profession, the Jews considered him as a sinner and an outcast (See notes on the call of Levi Luke 5: 27 – 32)
- He lived in Jericho
- When Jesus was passing through Jericho, he longed to see Jesus
- Because of the crowd and that he was a short man, he climbed the sycamore tree so as to see Jesus
- When Jesus was him, he told Zacchaeus to hurry down because he had to stay at his house
- Zacchaeus hurried down and welcomed Jesus with great joy
- All the people who saw it started grumbling
- "This man has gone as a guest to the home of a sinner"
- At the house Zacchaeus repented

Signs of his repentance

- He called Jesus sir / Lord presupposing that he had become a disciple of Jesus
- He acted as a true disciple of Jesus i.e. he followed Jesus' advice: "make friends for yourself with worldly wealth" by giving away half of his riches to the poor
- His repentance was real because he paid back four times as much whatever he had acquired unlawfully
- Soon after Zacchaeus had shown these signs of repentance, Jesus announced that salvation had come to his house because he was also the son of Abraham i.e. one of God's chosen people

Lessons

- Jesus came to look and save the lost i.e. sinners
- The best use of money is to use it to make friends
- There is joy in heaven when one is saved
- Another lesson is found in the parable of the Gold Coins

The parable of Gold coins or the Royal Claimant Luke 19:11 - 27

Aim

- As they were close to Jerusalem, the disciples supposed that the kingdom of God was about to appear immediately
- In the parable, Jesus teaches about the coming of the kingdom of God and the disciples' role in that kingdom
- The parable also gives the last warning to the Jewish religious leaders
 - This is more of an allegory than a mere parable

Allegorical details	Meanings
A man of high rank	Jesus
His departure	Jesus' ascension
His absence	Time between ascension and Parousia
His return	Jesus' second coming (Parousia)
Servants	Disciples or Jewish leaders
Hostile citizens	Hostile Jews i.e. Jesus' opponents
Ten Gold Coins	The gift of the Holy Spirit or The gift of knowledge of scriptures

Lessons

- Disciples will be given the gift of the Holy Spirit so as to win people into the kingdom of God
- If they will use it for the intended purpose, they will be rewarded like the first two servants
- If they will misuse it, they will be condemned like the last servant
- If the gold coins represent the gift of knowledge given to the Jewish religious leaders, then the parable is a warning to the leaders because they were misusing their knowledge by misinterpreting the laws and hence making Jewish religion a burden on the people
- In the parable, the first two servants are rewarded because of their

- faithfulness, courage and activity and the third servant is condemned because of his unfaithfulness, cowardice and inactivity
- As regards Zacchaeus, the parable therefore teaches that he was saved because of his faithfulness, courage and activity
 - Jesus' second coming will be delayed
 - In the due course, the Christians have serious / great responsibilities
 - Again Jesus' second coming will mark final judgement on all people: some will be rewarded while others will be condemned

Paying Tax to the Emperor Luke 20: 19 - 26

- At the time of Jesus, the Jews were under the Romans
- To show their submission to the Romans, Jews had to pay tax to the Romans
- The recommended tax was one denarius per head per year
- The Jews resented this because
 - The money benefited their foreign oppressors
 - They had to use only the Roman money which was accepted for tax and yet to the Jews the money was defiling because it bore the image of a man (Tiberius)
 - Paying this tax was the acknowledgement of a foreign ruler which contradicted their faith that Yahweh alone was king of Israel
- The question Jesus was asked on paying tax to the emperor in Luke 20: 22 put Jesus in dilemma
- If he would speak against tax, he would be speaking against the emperor and so would be accused as rebel before Pilate
- If he would support it, he would lose the support of people who resented tax
 - Jesus responded by saying
 - Show me a silver coin
 - Whose face and name are these on it?
 - The emperor's they answered
 - Then Jesus said
 - Well then, pay the Emperor what belongs to the Emperor
 - And pay God what belongs to God
- **Implication of Jesus' answer**
- Cooperation with the Roman Emperor does not diminish God's kingship in Israel
- God is the Lord and the Emperor is in his service: God uses him to

fulfill his purpose just as he used Cyrus to rescue the Jews in Babylon

Note

- The fact that Jesus' opponents had a denarius shows that they were not serious about the defilement of the coin.
- They were using it daily (it was useful to them).
- They conceded that Caesar was their ruler and that they benefited from his rule

Why is important to pay tax today?

- Taxes help in the running of governments. Since Christians are also citizens of various governments and they benefit for them
- Government leaders are chosen by God. It is therefore the responsibility of Christians to obey their leaders as they obey God
- Jesus Himself taught that give to the Emperor what belongs to him and to God what belongs to Him. This means that it is a Christian responsibility to pay taxes

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Chapter 11

THE MINISTRY OF JESUS CHRIST—PRAYER

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THE MINISTRY OF JESUS CHRIST—PRAYER

OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, the student should be able to:

- Define prayer
- Analyse Jesus teaching on prayer
- Explain the importance of prayer

CONTENTS

- defining the term 'prayer'
- Jesus' teaching on prayer
- The importance of prayer

Prayer

Prayer is a communication process that allows us to talk to God. It is a one – on – one engagement with God through a conversation. It is an act of worship

Jesus' teaching on prayer (The Our Father) Luke 11: 1 - 4

- One day Jesus was praying in a certain place
- After he had finished praying, one of his disciples said to him
- Teach us to pray just as John taught his disciples
- In response Jesus taught them the prayer entitled "**The Our Father**"
- The Our Father was and still is **the model prayer**
- This is because it teaches **how to pray** and **what to pray for**

Jesus said when you pray say this (The main points of the Our Father)

- **Father (Abba)**
- i.e. establish a father and son / daughter relationship
- recognize God as your father when you start to pray to Him
- **May your Holy name be honoured**
- i.e. in prayer, people have to acknowledge God's holiness by worshipping and obeying him alone
- This is what Jesus himself did in the desert
- During his temptations he told the devil, "You shall worship the Lord your God and serve him only." Luke 4:8
- **May your Kingdom come**
- i.e. when praying, it is important to ask for the Kingdom of God to come
- This is because when one belongs to the Kingdom of God, he or she is likely to do God's will and not the will of the devil.
- (Note that in the Kingdom of God, there is no room for the devil)
- In prayer, therefore, one has to be ready to do God's will as he / she belongs to it
- **Give us day by day the food we need**
- **Daily food** represents **daily needs** for one to be happy and be saved
- Having recognize God as the father and expressed the will to belong to his kingdom, then one can ask for his / her needs

- Note that God knows each person's needs
- Thus if one asks Him for the right things, He is definitely to provide them all
- **Forgive us our sins**
- Note that in order to ask for forgiveness of sins, one has to be ready to forgive others
- Jesus' teaching was Love your enemies Luke 6: 27 and forgive others Luke 17: 3
- **Do not bring us to hard testing**
- To be tempted means to be under the influence of the devil (Satan) and the attraction of evil
- Temptations are therefore bad and evil but not sinful
- As such to tempt others is very bad
- It is important to pray not to be tempted so as to avoid to commit sins which come after giving in to the temptations

Jesus' Parables on prayer Luke 11: 5 – 13

- **The parable of a friend at mid – night Luke 11: 5 – 8**
- The parable teaches that there is need to pray with faith and perseverance

Note

- God does not only give what one has asked for but also what one needs most
- God does not give everything that one asks for but rather He gives a thing which is of value to him or her
- **The father and his son's needs Luke 11: 11 – 13**
- Here Jesus teaches that God is infinitely better and more loving than any human fathers
- Yet human fathers who are sinful give what is good for their children
- Thus one has to expect God to give what is best whenever he or she asks for something from Him
- In this view, one has simply to pray with perseverance and not pester or bother God
- He always gives what is best

Parables on proper practice of prayer Luke 18: 1 - 14

- In this passage Jesus describes how one has to pray i.e.
- One has to pray like a persistent widow Luke 18: 1 - 8

- One has to pray like a tax collector and not like the Pharisee Luke 18: 9 – 14

The Persistent Widow 18: 1- 8

- The widow suffered in order to obtain justice
- Although the unjust judge was unwilling to settle her case and did not fear God, he eventually answered her request because of her perseverance and he did not want to be pestered / bothered

Lessons

- Praying with perseverance and confidence is necessary especially when one suffers and is persecuted
- God is faithful and loves his people dearly and that he always answers people's prayers vs. 7 – 8
 - This parable is like that of a friend at mid night Luke 11: 5 – 8
 - Praying with perseverance is not a matter of bothering God till he gives in
 - Rather it refers to being faithful to God between ascension and parousia

The Pharisee and the tax collector Luke 18: 9 -14

- In this passage Jesus teaches about a true and a false prayer

A false prayer is like that of the Pharisee

Reasons

- The Pharisee did not go to pray to God
- He stood by himself
- The Pharisee is proud and self – righteous
- He boasts of his fidelity to the law and feels that his own efforts will earn him salvation and justification forgetting that salvation was a gift from God
- In the prayer, he compares himself with others and despises them as sinners
- He feels his justice and not God's is the motto to be followed by others

On the other hand, the tax collector's prayer (vs. 15) is a model of a true prayer

Reasons

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- He was aware of the presence of God
- Thus he stood at a distance
- He could not even raise his face to God
- He beat on his breast and said Have mercy on me a sinner

Note

- He is aware of God's presence
- He talks with God
- He admits his sinfulness
- He recognizes the need of God's mercy in order to be saved

Lessons

- For one to pray, he or she has to set one's life besides God
- No person who is proud can pray
- No person who despises others can pray

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Chapter 12

THE MINISTRY OF JESUS CHRIST—OTHER TEACHINGS

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THE MINISTRY OF JESUS CHRIST—OTHER TEACHINGS

OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, the student should be able to:

- Describe Jesus' other teachings
- Analyse what Jesus taught in other teachings

CONTENTS

- Fasting
- Forgiveness
- humility and hospitality
- social responsibility
- riches
- authority
- life after death
- the Messiah
- offerings
- end times
- His identity
- welcoming children
- women in service

Other Teachings of Jesus

While on earth, Jesus taught about various things. Some of His teachings included teachings on fasting, forgiveness, humility and hospitality, social responsibility, riches, authority, life after death, the Messiah, offerings end times, his identity, welcoming children , women in service and respect for the temple

Fasting Luke 5: 33 – 39

- Fasting is the practice of abstaining from food
- Jews were recommended to fast at least once a year i.e. on the day of atonement (which means bringing together)
- The Pharisees and the disciples of John fasted twice a week i.e. on **Mondays and Thursdays**
- The disciples of Jesus never fasted
- They were always eating and drinking
- Some people asked Jesus to explain why it was so
- Jesus answered using
 - The example of the wedding feast and
 - The twin parables of wine skin and clothes

The example of the wedding feast

- Jesus said to them
- Do you think you can make the guests at a wedding party go without food as long as the bridegroom is with them
- Of course not
- But the day will come when the bridegroom will be taken away from them
- Then they will fast

Jesus implied that

- The bridegroom is Jesus himself – the Messiah
- The guests are his disciples
- As such the disciples could not fast while Jesus was with them
- However, when Jesus will be taken away, that will be the right time for his disciples to fast
- It is for this reason that followers of Christ or Christians fast on Good Friday when they commemorate the death of Jesus

The twin parables of wineskin and clothes

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- Jesus also said to them
- No one tears a piece off a new coat to patch an old coat
- If he does, he will have torn the new coat
- And the piece of new coat will not match the old
- Nor does anyone pour new wine into used wine skins
- Otherwise the new wine will burst the skins
- The new wine will pour out and the skins will be ruined
- Instead new wine must be poured into fresh wine skins
- And no one wants new wine after drinking old wine
- The old is better he says

Jesus implied that

- His teaching about fasting is completely new (like a new coat and new wine)
- While the teaching and practice of fasting by the Pharisees and others was old teaching (like an old coat and old wine)
- Thus it was not proper to compare Jesus' teaching with the Pharisees'
- The old customs and practices taught by Pharisees are not good and applicable (or cannot match) to Jesus' new teaching
- Just as an old coat cannot match a new one
- The expression no one wants new wine after drinking old wine aimed at condemning Pharisees' closed minds. They were not open to receive Jesus' new teaching

Possible reasons why people fast today

- To fulfill religious obligations to fast on certain days
- To ask for a certain favour from God e.g. ask for a son, forgiveness of sins etc
- It is a way of protest e. g. hunger strike
- For health reasons
- To mourn over certain situations e.g. death of dear ones
- For merits

Forgiveness

Forgiveness is an intentional and voluntary process by which a victim undergoes a change in feelings and attitude regarding an offence that had been committed to him or her. In forgiveness, one lets go of negative emotions such as revenge, with an increased

ability to wish the offender well.

A sinful woman at Simon's house Luke 7: 36 – 56

- The Jews considered hospitality as a great virtue
 - **To show their hospitality, Jews had to treat their guests in the following ways**
 - Give them water to **wash their feet**
 - They had to be washed by the servants. The reasons for washing was to remove the dust since the roads were dusty and people were wearing sandals
 - To **kiss them**
 - This was their normal greeting. It was a sign of respect, affection and warm welcome
 - To **anoint them** with sweet oil
 - This was a sign of respect. It also made the guests clean and fresh
 - After these gestures, they could share meals together. During the meals anyone could enter the house to listen to the discussion among teachers of the Law
 - When Simon invited Jesus, he did not show any sign of hospitality and courtesy to Jesus.
 - **However, during the meal a woman walked in and showed her respect for Jesus. How?**
 - She wetted Jesus' feet with tears which was like washing the feet with water
 - She wiped them with her hair
 - She kissed Jesus' feet which was like welcoming someone with a kiss
 - She anointed Jesus' feet with oil as their custom of showing respect and refreshing guests
- Note**
- Although the woman was sinful and notorious (she was a prostitute), Jesus used her signs of love and repentance to remind his host of lack of hospitality
 - The parable of the two debtors teaches the relationship between forgiveness of sins and love of God i.e. the more one is forgiven, the more one loves God and vice versa
 - Having realized that her many sins had been forgiven, the woman

was very happy and grateful to Jesus. Hence her signs made towards Jesus

- Thus Jesus remarked that, "the great love she has shown shows that her many sins have been forgiven"
- By saying your sins are forgiven , Jesus was confirming what the woman knew already i.e. she was forgiven

Lessons

- Jesus had power to forgive sins
- Jesus was concerned with women salvation

Humility and hospitality

The parable of choosing one's place at feast Luke 14: 7- 11

- When they were in the house, Jesus noticed how some of the guests were choosing the best places
- So he told this parable to all of them
- When someone invites you to a wedding feast, do not sit down in the best place
- It could happen that someone more important than you has been invited
- And your host who invited both of you would have to come and say to you
- Let him have this place
- Then you would be embarrassed and have to sit in the lowest place
- Instead, when you are invited, go and sit in the lowest place
- So that your host will come to you and say
- Come on up, my friend, to a better place
- This will bring you honour in the presence of all other guests
- For all those who make themselves great will be humbled
- And those who humble themselves will be made great

Note

- This parable is also known as the parable on humility

Lessons

- The parable teaches that no one can be saved unless he / she is invited and then responds to that invitation with humility like the sick man
- The sick man knowing that he did not deserve to be invited sat at the lowest place
- Yet was the one who was healed by Jesus

- The parable was also a warning to the Pharisees who loved best seats in the synagogue and houses just because they were convinced that they will seat on best in the kingdom of God
- Here Jesus warns them that they may lose their position in the kingdom of God unless they change their attitude

The parable of inviting guests Luke 14: 12 – 14

- Jesus said to his host
- When you give a lunch or dinner, do not invite your friends or your brothers or your relatives or your rich neighbours for they will invite you back
- And in this way you will be paid for what you did
- When you give a feast; invite the poor, the crippled, the lame and the blind
- And you will be blessed because they are not able to pay you back
- God will repay you on the day the good people rise from death

Note

- Jews were recommended to do charitable works on Sabbath days
- As a way of observing that, Pharisees used to hold parties on Sabbath days and invite friends
- Unfortunately, they used to sideline the poor, the lame the blind, sinners and outcasts etc
- Instead , they used to invite the rich, friends , relatives etc whom they felt would be capable of organizing parties and invite them as well
- Jesus condemned them for such reasoning and instead asked them to invite those whom they used to sideline like the sick man

Lesson

- Acts of charity should be done in a selflessness attitude i.e. they should help others without expecting anything in return

The parable of the great feast or banquet Luke 14: 15 – 24

- One of them said, how happy are those who will sit down at the feast in the kingdom of God
- imagine this speaker munching his food at the table where Jesus had just “sinned” by caring a dropsical man on this Sabbath
- and think of the Pharisees who had just heard Jesus’ parable on choosing places which made them understand that they should not take it for granted that the best places in God’s kingdom are for

them

- while they enjoy their food, Jesus tells another parable to warn them that they will have no place at the banquet in heaven in spite of their charitable works
- it appears that they have not learnt the lesson from the parable of inviting guests
- they could not imagine that God would invite the outcasts of Israel, the poor, the crippled, the lame, and the blind including the man just healed at the table

Note

- Jesus addressed the parable of the Great Feast at the Pharisees who condemned him because of his table fellowship with sinners
- Read the parable in Luke 14 : 16 – 24
- The parable of the great banquet is an allegory rather than a mere parable, because the meaning is only if one knows what the various elements of the story stand for e.g.
- The first invited: i.e. those within his kingdom whom he wanted to share his feast with stand for the pious Jews
- The second invited: i.e. those who were in the streets and alleys like the poor, the crippled, the blind, and the lame stand for Jewish outcasts
- The third invited: i.e. those who were out of the country roads and lanes stand for the gentiles

Lesson

- The parable is a warning and a judgement
- You will not enter the kingdom of God as you do not allow God to love the lost
- Salvation will go to fellow Jews whom you think unfit, ; and even to the gentiles rather than to you who are the first invited

▪ **The parable is like the story of God's invitation in Isaiah 55**

▪ **Similarities**

- Everybody is invited: Jews and gentiles alike
- The guests need no money or merits
- The banquet is free; it is not earned by good works

▪ **Differences**

- Jesus' invitation is more urgent than the one in Isaiah

- Through him the kingdom is breaking in
- The banquet is about to start
- The decision must be taken now

Social Responsibility

Social responsibility is an ethical theory, in which individuals are accountable for fulfilling their civic duty. The actions of an individual must benefit the whole society. Jesus while on earth taught about social responsibility in His parables.

The Rich man and Lazarus Luke 16: 19 – 31

The rich man

- He is sometimes named Dives (the Latin for "Rich man")
- He is a symbol of selfish and self – righteous people

Lazarus

- It is a Hebrew name which means "He whom God helps"
- He is a symbol of poor people

Note

- When the rich man died, he was buried in Hades i.e. sheol / abyss / underground world
- At first Jews felt that the spirits of those who died; good or bad went there to lead a half life
- Paradise and Gehenna are later theological development
- When Lazarus died, he was carried by angels to sit beside Abraham at the feast in heaven
 - While in great pain in Hades the rich man
- Looked up and saw Abraham with Lazarus at his side
- So he called out
- "Father Abraham! Take pity on me and send Lazarus to dip his finger in some and cool my tongue, because I am in great pain in this fire"

Abraham said

- Remember my son, that in your life time you were given all the good things
- While Lazarus got all the bad things
- Now he is enjoying himself here, while you are in pain
- Besides all that, there is a deep pit lying between us, so that those who want to cross over from here to you cannot do so, nor can anyone cross over to us from where you are

The rich man said

- Then I beg you, father Abraham, send Lazarus to my father's house
- He should warn my five brothers so that they will not come to this place of pain

Abraham said

- They have Moses and prophets to warn them
- If they cannot listen to them, they will not be convinced even if someone were to rise from death
- Abraham implied that the need of caring or helping the poor as the stepping stone to the kingdom of God is already stipulated in the Old Testament
- For example, Deuteronomy 26: 12 commands to give 10 % of the crops to the poor and Isaiah 1:17 teaches that God is not pleased with the worship if justice for the fatherless and widows is neglected
- If the brothers listen to scriptures and obey God's word by taking care of the poor they will not land up in Hades

Reactions of Jewish leaders

- Pharisees, teachers of the law and Sadducees did not like the parable
- This was because they believed that riches were a sign that you have found favour with the Lord and as a result you are blessed
- While poverty was a sign that God is not happy with you and you are not justified
- Thus to them teaching that the poor were blessed (6: 20; 6: 24) and will enter the kingdom of God like Lazarus was subversive
- The Sadducees had an added reason to dislike the parable
- It mentioned life after death, whereas they believed and taught that that there is no life after death
- The teachers of the law also felt offended / criticized
- According to their teaching, Lazarus was unclean and unfit to be with God
- This was because the dogs came and licked his sores which according to their teaching make a person unclean

Lessons

- If the rich do not help the poor to bridge the gap between them,

the gap will remain even after death. However the rich will find themselves on the wrong side

- There is need to use one's riches to help others
- No sign or miracle will save the brothers; if they refuse to listen to Moses and prophets

Riches

Riches are the wealth of the world. Jesus had a lot of teachings and warnings to make about the riches of this world

The rich Young Ruler Luke 18: 18 – 30

The Rich Man

- He was probably a member of the local Sanhedrin (i.e. Jewish Council)
- As such was a person of social and religious importance
- The ruler's question in vs. 18 is typical of a pious Jew
- His main concern was to know how to observe the law in practice so as to be ensured of salvation
- A similar question was asked by a teacher of the law in Luke 10: 25

Possible reasons for asking the question

- He might have heard that the self- righteous attitude of the Pharisee is unacceptable to God

Thus he wanted to know what sort of change of heart was needed for one to be saved

- Although he might have learnt that he had to be like a child in order to be saved, he still wanted to know and learn more about discipleship

Vs. 19 "No one is good except God alone"

- Here Jesus teaches that only God is perfectly good and the source of all goodness
- Although Jesus was the son of God and indeed God himself, he did not want to be called "good" because he knew that the ruler regarded him as a mere man
- Thus if the ruler wanted to flatter Jesus, he is warned not to use the term "good" in a thoughtless way by reminding him of God's perfect goodness
- When the ruler was told to sell all he had and give the money to the poor in order for him to enter the kingdom of God, he was very sad

because he was very rich

- Then Jesus said, "How hard it is for rich people to enter the Kingdom of God! It is much harder for a rich person to enter the kingdom of God than for a camel to go through the eye of the needle"

Lessons

- Undue attachment to riches can hinder someone from being saved
- Total and actual renunciation of one's possessions will be rewarded with eternal life
- Riches / wealth can cause someone to have a false idea about oneself and salvation
- One should use money to make friends

Authority

Authority refers to the power or right to give orders, make decisions, and enforce obedience to subordinates.

Jesus' Authority Luke 20:1 – 8

- Jesus' authority was challenged by the chief priests, teachers of the law and leaders of the people
- They asked Jesus
- "Tell us, what right have you to do these things? Who gave you this right?"
- **These things include:**
- Jesus' entry into Jerusalem as the messiah
- Cleansing the Temple
- Teaching the crowd in the Temple
- The Jewish leaders wanted to know if Jesus had the authority to do these things
- The question put Jesus in dilemma
- To say he got his authority from God (i.e. he was the messiah)' they would have accused him as a rebel before Pilate
- To say that he got it from man, people would have lost interest in Him
- Any answer would have led to Jesus' undoing, thus he answered with a counter question and a parable of the wicked tenants

A counter question

- Jesus answered them with a counter question
- "Tell me, did John's right to baptize come from God or from man?"
- Jesus implied that he got his from where John got his right to

baptize people

- The question put the Jewish leaders in dilemma also
- If they admitted that John's right came from God, they would have also admitted that Jesus was the Messiah and that his authority came from God as John had prophesied
- If they said John's right came from man, the crowd would have considered them as liars and as a result stone them to death
- To be on the safer side, they answered that they did not know
- Their answer, however, showed that they were not fit to be leaders

Reasons

- Everybody would see that John was a man of God except them (leaders) – hence how could they lead others if they did not see the truth
- John was a prominent religious figure and if the leaders did not recognize that, how could they lead others religiously
- The answer they gave was out of fear; and so how could leaders who fear people lead them

Life after Death

The Question about the Resurrection Luke 20: 27- 40

- The Sadducees, unlike the Pharisees, did not believe in the resurrection of the dead (i.e. an eternal life after death)
- Since they believed in the Torah only, their aim here is to show the Law (the Pentateuch) for them makes no provision for the resurrection of the dead
- They based their argument on the law of the Levirate marriage (Deuteronomy 25: 5 – 10)
- This law obliges a man to marry his brother's widow so as to give his dead brother legal descendants
- According to them , this would produce an absurd and impossible situation in life after death, such as the one they imagined

In response Jesus proved life after death on two grounds

- **"they will be like angels" vs. 36**
- The Sadducees have a wrong idea of resurrection
- They think of it as the body returning to former life
- This shows that they have a low idea of the power of God
- God does not simply bring the dead back to their old life; he does more
- He creates new life, perfect life, life without death. People will be

like angels

- Since there will be no death, there is no need for marriage whose main goal is to prolong human life
- **Moses clearly proves that the dead are raised to life vs. 37**
- Like the Sadducees, Jesus based his argument on the authority of Moses
- Moses (Exodus 3: 6) spoke of God as the God of Abraham, Isaac and Jacob
- At the time Moses said this, those ancestors had died more than 500 years ago
- But they could not really be dead because God is a God of the living and not of the dead
- This proves that there is resurrection

Note

- The Pharisees applauded Jesus' answer on the resurrection
- This was because they too believed in life after death but could not prove it in the Torah in the manner Jesus did it.

The Messiah

The Question about the Messiah Luke 20: 41 – 44

- **The title "David's son"**
- It was in Jerusalem, at the beginning of Jesus' last week
- Jesus posed a question to some teachers of the law and the other leaders
- How can it be said that the Messiah will be a descendant of David? Vs. 41 – 44
- Jesus did not expect an answer; rather the question was meant to make them think
- David called his son, the future messiah, Lord
- By calling his son, Lord, David indicates that the messiah would be greater than himself, would achieve more than just freedom from Roman rule, do more than restoring the old glory of David's reign
- The question was a challenge to the leaders
- They should begin to wonder, "Who is the messiah? What kind of the messiah?"
- If they changed their idea of the messiah, they could have judged Jesus' case more prudently; unfortunately they did not

Offerings

The poor widow's offering Luke 21: 1 - 4

- Note that teachers of the law were honoured as they went about in long robes; they were greeted with respect in the market places and given the best seats in the synagogues
- The widow, on the other hand, was not honoured
- Her misfortunes i.e. her widowhood and poverty were seen as signs of God's displeasure
- Here Jesus honours her because she put in all the living she had
- Her total giving foreshadows Jesus' total gift of himself only a few days later

Lesson

- God values the gift which cost the giver a sacrifice rather than the gift which does not cost the giver some sacrifice
- The woman expresses her deep piety (respect for God) and hence worthy to be emulated

End Times

Apocalyptic Literature (Discourse) Luke 21: 5 – 38

- This is the type of literature that was developed by the Jews and their neighbours around 2 BC
- It is a special type of writing
- Apocalypse means revelation
- Apocalyptic passages reveal the last thing, the eschaton and therefore are also called eschatological writings
- There are few passages in Luke that talk about the last things e.g. Luke 9: 26; 12: 32; 12: 35- 48; 17: 22 – 37; 21: 5 – 38
- In Old Testament, the book of Daniel and in the New Testament the book of Revelation talk about last things

Aim of the literature

- To denounce the oppressive rulers that God would punish them
- To encourage those who suffer or are persecuted not to lose hope but instead to persevere because things will be well in the end

The main points of Jesus' apocalyptic discourse

- The consequences of the rejection of Jesus by the leaders
- God will vindicate his rejected son
- Jesus will strengthen his disciples when they are rejected because of him

- **Verses 5 – 7 Jesus speaks of the destruction of the Temple**
- Some of the disciples were admiring the Temple since it was well decorated with fine (marble) stones and gifts offered to God
- At that same time, Jesus foretold its destruction saying
- All this you see, time will come when not a single stone here will be left in its place : everyone will be thrown down
- **Troubles and Persecutions verses 7 – 19**
- The disciples of Jesus asked him when will the Temple be destroyed and what will be the signs of the end of the world
- Jesus told them that he did not know but there will be many signs such as
 - False Christs i.e. people will come and say “I am he”
 - Wars and revolutions
 - Countries will fight each other
 - Kingdoms will attack one another
 - Terrible earthquakes
 - Famine
 - Plagues
 - Strange and terrifying things coming from the sky

Note

- Before these things take place
- You will be arrested and persecuted
- You will be handed over to be tried in synagogues and be put in prison
- You will be brought before kings and rulers
- When such things happen to you, do not worry about how you will defend yourselves

Reasons

- I will give you such words and wisdom that none of your enemies will be able to refute or contradict what you say
- Not a single hair from your head will be lost

Other signs

- You will be handed over by your parents, your brothers, your relatives, and your friends
- Some of you will be put to death
- Everyone will hate you because of me

How the disciples should look at the persecutions

- Those who persevere will share in Jesus’ glory at the end of time

- Through the persecution the church will grow, because it gives the disciples opportunities to witness before synagogues, kings and governors
- Persecutions are a sign of the coming of the kingdom of God
- Persecutions give the opportunity to forgive
- **Jesus speaks of the destruction of Jerusalem Luke 21: 20 – 24**
 - Jesus said, “When you see Jerusalem surrounded by armies, then you will know that it will soon be destroyed” then
 - Those in Judea must run away to the hills
 - Those in the city must leave
 - Those who are out in the country must not go into the city

Reasons

- Those will be the days of punishment
- It will be terrible for women who are pregnant and for mothers with little babies
- Terrible distress will come upon this land
- Some will be killed by sword
- Others will be taken as prisoners to other countries
- The heathen will trample over Jerusalem until their time is up
- **The coming of the son of man Luke 21: 25 – 28**
- **Signs of the coming of the son of man**
 - Strange things happening on the sun, moon and stars
 - Sea will roar like a lion
 - Countries will despair
 - People will be afraid and start fainting
 - Then the son of man will appear on the clouds
- **Need to be watchful (Lesson of fig tree)**
 - New leaves is a sign of the beginning of summer season
 - Similarly the signs seen above are simply signs of the coming of the kingdom of God
 - As such people should be alert and watchful or else the day will get them like a trap

His Identity

Peter's Confession / Profession of Faith Luke 9: 18 – 21

- Jesus asked his disciples, **"Who do people say I am?"**
 - The disciples answered
 - Some say that you are **John the Baptist**
 - Others say that you are **Elijah**
 - Others say that you are **one of the old prophets**
- People suggested these names because they thought Jesus was a forerunner of the Messiah. Nobody thought he could possibly be the Messiah, since he was doing nothing to deliver them from the Romans
- Then Jesus **asked his disciple who they thought he was**
 - Peter answered on their behalf; **You are God's messiah** i.e. the anointed one

Probable reasons why he brought up the question of his identity

- Jesus wanted to **assess the impression** he had on the people during his ministry in Galilee i.e. do people and the apostles recognize him as the messiah or not
- As he was about to go Jerusalem, he wanted his disciples to be aware that **he was going there as the messiah**
- Once they knew that he was the Messiah, he could **clarify what sort of the messiah he was** i.e. a suffering Messiah and not a political one

The Transfiguration Luke 9: 28 – 36

- Transfiguration refer to the change in appearance of Jesus
- This happened possibly on Mount Hermon near Caesarea Philippi
- It happened eight days after Peter's profession of faith
- Peter, James and John witnessed Jesus' transfiguration
- During the transfiguration, Moses and Elijah appeared and talked with Jesus about Jesus' death and resurrection in Jerusalem

Significance of the appearance of Moses and Elijah and their conversation with Jesus

- **To strengthen the apostles' faith**
- Jews believed that when the Messiah comes, he would appear together with Moses and Elijah

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- Peter had just confessed that Jesus was God's Messiah
- Thus the appearance of Moses and Elijah will strengthen the apostles' faith that Jesus is indeed the Promised Messiah
- **To show that Jesus is the real Promised Messiah**
- For the same reason as seen above
- **To show that Jesus fulfills the Old Testament prophecies**
- This is because Moses stands for the Laws and Elijah stands for the prophets
- Together they represent the Old Testament Scriptures (Jews used to listen to them since God spoke through the Old Testament Scriptures)
- Now the people are told to listen to Jesus, the realization of all and even more than what Moses and Elijah stood for
- **To show that Jesus will share the fate of all prophets (i.e. he will as well suffer and be put to death)**
- This is deduced from the discussion between Jesus and Moses & Elijah vs. 31
- This encouraged Jesus to accept his death as God's will

Note

- The cloud signified God's presence
- The word from heaven asked the disciples to listen to Jesus as the Messiah / the son of God
- Similar words were spoken at Jesus' baptism/ Differences are???????
- Peter's proposal to build three booths possibly aimed at prolonging God's glory
- He did not know what he was saying
- This is because God's glory will be fully established after Jesus' suffering, death and resurrection

Welcoming Children

The Master and the Children Luke 18: 15 - 17

- Some people brought their babies to Jesus
- They wanted Jesus to place his hands on them i.e. to bless the babies
- The disciples of Jesus scolded the people from doing so

- Jesus told the disciples to let the people bring their babies to him
- For the kingdom of God belongs to people such as the children

Implication

- A true disciple must be like a child i.e. he / she
 - Should have unquestioning trust in God
 - Should totally depend on God
 - Should have ability to forgive and forget completely
 - Should serve others without expecting merits

Women in service

The women disciples Luke 8: 1- 3

- In Jewish society, women were undervalued. They were regarded as inferior to men. Thus
 - They could not give testimony in court
 - In the Temple they were assigned the same place with children and slaves
 - Girls were not obliged to go to school
 - They were not obliged to pray
 - They could not become disciples of rabbi

In this passage Luke teaches that

- Jesus had women disciples like Joana, Mary Magdalene, and Suzanna
- These and other women used their own resources to help Jesus and his disciples

Lesson

- Jesus made no distinctions between men and women as far as salvation and discipleship were concerned. All need to be saved and bear witness to Jesus' name

Jesus visits Martha and Mary Luke 10: 38 – 41

- Martha and Mary came from the village of Bethsaida
- They were friends of Jesus
- When Jesus visited them on his way to Jerusalem
- Martha received Jesus as a **guest** for whom she cared
- Mary received Jesus as **teacher** to whom she listened as a disciple

Note

- Jesus recommended Mary's attitude because listening to Jesus is more important than caring for him as a guest especially at this time

- when Jesus was going to Jerusalem where he would die
- Jesus does not totally condemn Martha's service since practical help is very important expression of love
- One ought to praise God and at the same time serve others

Lesson

- Physiological needs can hinder / prevent someone from entering the Kingdom of God

Respect for the Temple

Jesus in the Temple Luke 19: 45 – 46

- The Temple had seven major divisions including
 - The court of the Gentiles
 - The court of women and children
 - The court of men
 - The court of priests
 - The Holy place
 - The Holy of Holies
- The Temple was a very busy place
 - It was a place of worship
 - In addition, the court of the gentiles was also used as a market place

Purpose of the market

- **To sell birds and animals for sacrifice**
 - According to their law, only birds and animals bought at the Temple were acceptable for sacrifice
 - Birds and animals bought elsewhere were not accepted
 - People were forced to buy them at the Temple although the prices were considerably high
- **To exchange money**
 - Only the Jewish money was acceptable for offering / sacrifice
 - As such money changers exchanged Roman coins for the Jewish ones
 - And the money changers often took exorbitant commission

Note

- All these were controlled by the Temple authorities
- As such the Temple authorities were running a profitable business

- in the name of the Temple and God
- When Jesus entered the Temple, he saw trade going on
- He noticed that the situation was not conducive to prayer and worship
- **He could not imagine a true prayer mingled with**
- The loud and profane bidding of sellers
- The mooing of cattle
- The bleating of sheep
- The clicking of money
- Knowing that the traders had no right to be where they were but were just allowed by the chief priests because of the profits that made , Jesus drove them out and threw away the tables

Reasons for doing this

- Commerce in the temple disturbed prayers
- The merchants / traders cheated the people
- The Temple authorities made money in the name of God's Temple

Note

- As he drove them out Jesus said
- "It is written in scriptures; God said my Temple will be called a house of prayer but you have turned it into hideout for thieves"
- In so doing Jesus posed himself as the Messiah, the son of his father in whose house he was
- The words spoken implicitly show that Jesus was the son of God

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Bible Knowledge Form 3

Chapter 13

THE PASSION OF JESUS CHRIST

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THE PASSION OF JESUS CHRIST

OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, the student should be able to:

- Describe Jesus entry into Jerusalem
- Analyse the events leading to the suffering, death, resurrection and ascension of Jesus

CONTENTS

- triumphant entry into Jerusalem
- explaining why Jesus drove the merchants out of the Temple
- events leading to the death and ascension of Jesus Christ:
 - the death predictions of Jesus Christ
 - the betrayal of Jesus Christ
 - the Lord's Supper
 - events on Mount of Olives
 - the arrest of Jesus Christ
 - Peter's denial
 - trials of Jesus Christ
 - crucifixion
 - death and burial
 - resurrection
 - ascension

Triumphant Entry into Jerusalem Luke 19: 28 – 40

- Jesus came all the way from Galilee and entered the city of Jerusalem from Mount Olives
- Mount Olives is situated between Bethany (meaning House of the poor) and Bethphage (meaning House of figs)
- He was riding on an ass (a colt)
- A big crowd was following him
- They spread their cloaks on the road for Jesus to walk on them
- They also praised God for all the great things that they had seen through Jesus saying
 - God bless the king who comes in the name of the Lord! Peace in heaven and glory to God

Significance of the following:

- **Entering Jerusalem from Mount Olives and riding on an ass / colt**
 - This shows that Jesus was the Promised Messiah
 - It was prophesied that when the Messiah comes he will enter Jerusalem from Mount Olives (Zechariah 14: 4) and that he will ride on an ass (Zechariah 9: 9)
 - This is exactly what Jesus did; he dramatized his entry into Jerusalem to show that
 - He was the Promised Messiah
 - He was a peaceful Messiah (unlike using a horse which symbolized power and war, an ass symbolizes powerlessness and peace)
- **Spreading the cloaks on the road**
 - This shows that Jesus was welcomed as a king
 - The gesture was done during the coronation of a king
- **Asking Jesus to command his disciples to be quiet**
 - This shows that the Pharisees were jealous; they did not want the people to praise Jesus
 - Or the Pharisees saw Jesus' entry as a political demonstration and so were afraid that the Romans would think that the Jews were rebelling which would eventually lead to the massacre of the Jews
- **Saying if they keep quiet the stones themselves will start shouting**
 - Here Jesus teaches that God's plan cannot be changed and will never fail
 - Even Jesus himself cannot change it by imposing silence or avoiding all risks

- So the people have to praise God and proclaim that Jesus was the Messiah
 - **Not demanding Messianic secret**
- This shows that the time for secrecy is over and the people had to know the truth
 - **Saying the master needs it**
- This shows that there was a prearrangement between Jesus and the owner of the colt / ass
 - **Riding on a new colt**
- This shows that Jesus was a new king

Jesus weeps over Jerusalem Luke 19: 41 – 44

- When Jesus saw the city, he wept over it
- This was so because he knew that
 - The inhabitants of Jerusalem would not believe that Jesus was the Messiah; they would be ignorant of God's visit to them through Jesus
 - The city of Jerusalem would soon be destroyed as a result of rejecting and killing him
- The destruction was prophesied by Micah (3: 12) and Isaiah (29: 3)
- This happened in 70 AD when the Roman soldiers destroyed the city and the Temple marking the end of Jerusalem as a Jewish religious centre

Events that led to the suffering, death, resurrection and ascension of Jesus

A. Death predictions

Jesus predicts his suffering and death Luke 9: 21 – 22

- As soon as Peter had confessed that Jesus was God's Messiah, Jesus gave them strict orders not to publicize it
- Then Jesus said to them
- The son of man must suffer much; He will be rejected by elders, the chief priests and teachers of the Law. He will be put to death but three days later will be raised to life.

Reasons for demanding Messianic secret

- He did not want the people to regard him as a political Messiah as they expected
- He feared some people would rebel against the Romans hoping that

Jesus as their expected liberator would set them free from the Romans, a thing which would have led to the massacre of many Jews

- He feared to be arrested and put to death by the Romans before accomplishing his mission (i.e. it was too early and unsafe to publish his identity)
- Jesus first wanted to clarify and convince his disciples that he was a suffering messiah and not a political one before publishing his identity

Note

- Jesus' prediction of his suffering and death indicates that Jesus is a suffering Messiah

Jesus predicts his death Luke 9: 43 b - 45

- This was the second prediction
- It happened soon after the cure of an epileptic man
- It is the shortest of all the three prediction
- Jesus simply says the **son of man** (referring to **himself**) is going to be handed over to the power of men
- The disciples did not understand what Jesus meant because of their lack of faith

Jesus Predicts his Suffering Luke 18: 31 – 34

- This was the third prediction
- The first was soon after Peter's declaration of faith
- The second was soon after the healing of an epileptic boy
- The second was the shortest
- In all the predictions, Jesus refers to himself as the son of man who will suffer
- The first prediction says that Jesus will be rejected and put to death by the Jewish rulers but will rise again after three days
- In the third prediction, Jesus mentions the place where this will happen i.e. in Jerusalem
- It is in Jerusalem that everything the prophet wrote about the son of man will be fulfilled
- This probably refers to what was prophesized in the servant songs of Isaiah
- The mockery, shameful treatment, spitting etc implicitly point to

- treatment of Jesus by the Jews before Pilate
- Three days after his death, he will rise again
- Although Jesus' predictions were very clear, his disciples did not understand
- They lacked faith (may be because of their wrong conception of Messiah) which caused their blindness

B. Betrayal

The Plot against Jesus Luke 22: 1 – 6

- This happened during Passover celebrations which combined two feasts namely the **unleavened bread** and **Passover**
- **Unleavened bread**
- This was originally a feast of thanksgiving for the harvest and lasted one week.
- It was later combined with the Passover feast and took on another meaning
- **The Passover Feast**
- This was a Jewish feast commemorating Jews' deliverance from Egyptian slavery.
- During the feast, Jews also looked forward to their final deliverance by the Messiah
- **Preparations for the feast**
- Meaning of the Passover was taught in all synagogues
- Bridges were maintained
- Roads were cleared
- Wayside tombs were painted white

Note

- When the Jews were about to celebrate the feast of Passover, the teachers of the law and the chief priests were trying to find a way of putting Jesus to death secretly
- They wanted to do it secretly because they were afraid of the people who followed Jesus
- **How the Passover was celebrated**
- A one year old lamb without spots was sacrificed at the Temple
- Its blood was sprinkled on the doorposts
- Then it was taken home for the feast.
- At home, ten or twenty people gathered in one house
- The father presides over the feast

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- He opens the feast with a prayer of thanksgiving for the feast
- First hand washing
- Then he takes a cup of wine and blesses it
- Everybody drinks the wine of the first cup
- Second hand washing
- He blesses the unleavened bread and gives it to the people to eat together with bitter herbs and roasted meat
- The herbs were chewed slowly and meditatively recalling the hardships their ancestors went through while in Egypt
- Then the youngest son asks the father why this meal was different from others and why during the night
- The father answers him by reading Exodus chapter 12
- Then all sing the paschal hymn
- Third hand washing
- They all drink the third cup of wine in expectation of their deliverance by the Messiah

Judas betrays Jesus

- Possible reasons why Judas betrayed Jesus
- **Temptation:** Satan tempted him and he gave in
- **Greed:** he wanted more money. Although not likely since as the treasurer he had easy access to the money and the idea of payment came from the chief priests and officers and not from Judas
- **Disillusionment:** As a Zealot, Judas was expecting a political Messiah (political liberator). Thus when Jesus spoke of his own suffering and death, he felt betrayed and disillusioned. He was so frustrated that he decided to betray Jesus
- **Self – preservation:** As Jesus seemed to be losing, Judas chose the winning side to save himself
- **Ambition:** Perhaps he hoped that Jesus would sneak away from his enemies miraculously. Hence his messianic power would be revealed and the kingdom established, in which he i.e. Judas would enjoy and share in Jesus' glory

C. The Lord's Supper

Jesus prepares to eat the Passover meal Luke 22: 7 – 13

- Jesus sent Peter and John to prepare a Passover meal
- He told them to go to Jerusalem without giving an exact place
- The sign of a man carrying a jar of water shows a pre – arrangement

as a secret signal to ensure that Jesus' enemies would not know that he was in town that evening

- They were told that after being shown a large furnished room upstairs, get everything ready for us. i.e.
 - Buy a lamb and sacrifice it at the Temple
 - Take it to the room
 - Buy wine, bitter herbs, unleavened bread
 - Remove leavened bread
 - Water be available

Jesus' last supper Luke 22: 14 – 38

- Jesus celebrated his last supper together with his twelve disciples (apostles)

What happened during the meal?

- **Jesus fasted**
- I will never eat it ... (22: 16), share it among yourselves (22: 17), I will not drink this wine (22: 18)
- Jesus fasted as a sign of the coming of the kingdom of God which will be fully established through Jesus' own suffering, death and resurrection

▪ **Jesus established a new covenant 22: 19 – 20**

- At first, God made a covenant with the Israelites through Moses
- Through his death and resurrection, Jesus establishes a new covenant i.e. a new bond between God and the people
- The new covenant is between God and all mankind; Jews and gentiles alike while the old was between God and the Israelites only
- The new covenant was established through Jesus while the old was through Moses
- The new is a closer relationship, like the bond between father and child
- **Bread and wine were eaten and drank respectively**
- During Jewish Passover celebrations, bread symbolized life as a gift from God and wine symbolized joy and happiness
- While during Jesus' last supper, bread symbolized Jesus' body and wine symbolized Jesus' blood

Note

- The **symbols** used namely
 - Breaking the bread (i.e. Jesus' body) and
 - Separating the bread (i.e. Jesus' body) from wine (i.e. Jesus' blood)

point to

- Jesus' death
- Take this and eat it; this is poured out for you.
- This shows that Jesus gives his life for others
- Do this in memory of me vs. 19
- Jesus tells the apostles to do the same i.e. the disciples should eat Jesus' body and drink his blood during their gathering
- This marked the beginning of Eucharistic celebrations

- **Jesus predicted that one of them will betray him Luke 22: 21 – 22**
- Jesus said, the one who betrays me is here at table with me
- The son of man will die as God has decided
- But how terrible for that man who betrays him!
- This does not mean that God wanted Judah to sin
- It means that God is in control of all that happens
- It also emphasizes a warning to all Christians that table fellowship with Jesus is not a guarantee of salvation

- **An argument broke out about greatness**
- An argument broke out among them as to which one of them should be thought of as the greatest
- Jesus told them not to confuse greatness with recognition
- Thus he told them that the greatest among them should be like the youngest and the leader should be like a servant
- Just like Jesus was serving them although he was their master
- In vs. 28 – 30, Jesus points out that through his death Jesus will receive power to rule
- And the disciples who are discouraged now that Jesus' case has made such a bad turn are promised a share in his power to rule
- **Jesus predicts Peter's denial Luke 22: 31- 34**
- Jesus told them that Satan will tempt all of them such that they will deny him
- However, he assured Peter that he had prayed for him so that his faith will not fail and that when he comes back to Jesus, he must strengthen his brothers
- Peter expressed that he was ready to go to prison with Jesus and die with him
- But Jesus told him that the cock will not crow that night until he had

said three times that he did not know Jesus

- **A different missionary style was announced Luke 22: 35 – 38**

- During his ministry in Galilee, Jesus was so popular and as a result his followers were well received
- They were provided their needs and hence did not need purse, beggar's bag, extra shirt or money
- But from the time of his arrest, Jesus will be looked upon as a criminal
- So his followers must be ready for a hostile reception, ready to suffer
- Thus Jesus said, whoever has a purse or a bag must take it; and whoever has no sword must sell his coat and buy one
- His saying was not literal since he taught love for enemies
- Rather he was emphasizing that there is a crisis and disciples must stand firm to their faith
- However, the disciples did not understand what Jesus implied as they said
- "Look! Here are two swords, Lord!"
- So Jesus stopped the conversation as hopeless by saying; "It is enough"

- **He shared the fate of criminals Luke 22: 37**

- Jesus quoted from the forth servant song (Isaiah 53: 12b) and identified himself with this figure

- **Was Jesus' last supper a Passover meal?**

- It was not a Passover meal but he celebrated it as if it were a Passover meal
- This was on Thursday night and Passover was to start on the following Friday night
- It is necessary to note that the last supper was the fulfillment of all the Passover fests. How?
- Through Jesus' exodus, which he anticipates at the last supper, mankind will pass from the slavery of evil to the freedom of kingdom
- Jesus' passage from death to life will give everlasting life and perfect joy
- The Israelites sacrificed bread and wine and a lamb; Jesus gives himself as a sacrifice

D. Events on Mount Olives

At Mount Olive Luke 22: 39 – 53

- **When they arrived at mount Olives**
- Jesus asked his disciples to pray so that they would not fall into temptations. Then
 - He went off from them about the distance of a stone's throw
- **Whilst there he knelt down and prayed**
- During his prayer, he was tempted. Note that in the prayer Jesus said
 - Father, if you will, take this cup of suffering away from me
 - The cup of suffering refers to his imminent sufferings and death
 - Therefore, Jesus as a normal human being wanted to live, as such the thought of his imminent death was appalling
 - Thus he was tempted not to go through sufferings and death ; take this cup of suffering away from me
 - However, Jesus did not give in to the temptation for he said, "However not my will, but your will be done"
 - This shows that Jesus accepted death in obedience to the will of his father
 - This acceptance and total trust gave Jesus complete self –control; while he himself suffered, he could remain attentive to the plight of others as shown in 22: 61; 23: 28; 23: 34; 23: 43
- **Jesus was arrested**
- After his prayer, Jesus went back to his disciples and found them asleep, worn out by their grief
- Jesus said to them
- "Why are you sleeping? Get up and pray that you will not fall into temptations"
- As he was still speaking, an armed crowd from Roman soldiers arrived, led by Judas
- Judas gave the soldiers the sign of a kiss in order to betray Jesus
- Judas kissed Jesus and Jesus said to Judas, "Is it with a kiss that you betray the son of man?"
- One of the disciples wanted to defend Jesus. He cut off the right ear of the slave of the high priest
- However, Jesus did not want violence; He touched the man's ear and healed him
- Jesus said to the crowd, "Did you have to come with swords and

- clubs, as though I were an outlaw?
- I was with you in the Temple everyday, and you did not try arrest me. But this is your hour to act, when the power of darkness rules.”
- It was dark. Literary. Also symbolically; evil is dark, sunless, joyless
- To arrest Jesus in darkness was a sign that his opponents did not act in truth and justice

E. Peter’s Denial

Peter’s denial of Jesus Luke 22: 54 – 62

- Jesus’ prediction of Peter’s denial in Luke 22: 31 – 32 is fulfilled now as described in 22: 54 – 62

Probable reasons why Peter denied Jesus

- Fear to be arrested
- It appears he had not understood Jesus’ tacking on fear and persecution
 - overconfidence
- Peter lacked courage and confidence at this moment possibly because he was too sure of himself; too self confident
- He did not pray enough
- He was sleeping when Jesus had asked him to pray for God’s strength not to fall into temptation

Note

- The men who were guarding Jesus mocked him and beat him
- They blindfolded him and asked him
- “Who hit you? Guess!”
- And they said many other insulting things to him

F. Trials of Jesus

The Four Trials of Jesus Luke 22: 66 – 23; 25

The First Trial (Before the Sanhedrin) Luke 22:66 – 71

- Early in the morning Jesus was tried before the Sanhedrin in the court room located on the Temple premises

Sanhedrin

- The word Sanhedrin comes from the Greek word “synedrion” which means “council”
- It acted as a “parliament” for national affairs
- It was also the High Court, judging cases according to Jewish Law
- It was composed of a chairman (the High Priest, of the Sadducee

party) plus 70 other members: the elders, the chief priests (Sadducees) and teachers of the Law (mostly Pharisees)

- In total, the council had 71 members

Rules for conducting a trial

- An accuser had to make a complaint
- Supported by at least two eye witnesses
- A witness or a Lawyer had to be called to defend the accused
- Death sentence could be passed only one day after the trial and never in the night
- A person could not be convicted on his own testimony
- Court hearing were not allowed during the week of the celebration of Passover
- The suspect was not supposed to be ill- treated until proved guilty

Accusations made against Jesus before the Jewish council

- They asked Jesus, "Tell us are you the Messiah?"
- Jesus told them that, "If I tell you, you will not believe and if I ask you a question, you will not answer (as it happened in Luke 20: 3 – 8)
- Jesus implied that their question is pointless as they won't believe.
- So instead of giving a direct answer he hints that he is the glorified son of Man, as described in Daniel 7: 13 – 14
- Note that when they asked him if he was the son of God; he said, "so you say"
- To the Jews claiming to be the son of God was blasphemy i.e. an insult to God
- The penalty for blasphemy was to put that person to death

The Second trial (Before Pontius Pilate) Luke 23: 1 – 5

- Why did they present Jesus' case to the governor?
- The Jewish Council needed Pilate's approval of a death sentence
- They wanted to see Jesus crucified; the Roman punishment for non – Roman criminals
- Jesus' death on a tree was to be a sign of God's curse on him (refer Deuteronomy 21: 23) a proof that he could not be a Messiah

Accusations levied against Jesus before Pilate

- Preventing people from paying tax to the Emperor
- Claiming that he was the Messiah, a King
- Starting / inciting riots among the Jews

Note

- Pilate would have been indifferent to a charge against Jesus based on the Jewish religion; blasphemy was not a crime against the state (political reasons)
- Thus the Jewish council twisted a religious accusation of blasphemy against Jesus into political reasons as seen above so as to involve the Romans
- However, in spite of Jesus' admission that he was the king of the Jews, Pilate did not find a crime in him; he knew that Jesus had not posed a political threat

The Third Trial (Before Herod Antipas) Luke 23: 6- 12

- From Pilate Jesus was sent to Herod
- Herod was the ruler of Galilee where Jesus carries out his mission
- Herod was in Jerusalem for the Passover feast
- By sending Jesus to Herod, Pilate hoped to get rid of the case and hence remain popular with the Jewish subjects

Treatment which Jesus got at the court of Herod

- Herod and his soldiers mocked Jesus
- They put a fine robe on him
- They sent him back to Pilate
- They treated him with contempt
- The way Herod mocked Jesus shows that he did not take Jesus' claim to be the Messiah / or king of the Jews seriously.
- Jesus had been active in his jurisdiction. i.e. Galilee; apparently Herod had never : "caught" Jesus in subversive activities
- Before Herod, Jesus remained quite, silent, did not answer to any question

Possible reasons why Jesus made no answer to the questions posed by Herod

- Herod did not take him seriously
- Herod sought entertainment not truth
- Jesus identified himself with the servant of the Lord in Isaiah 53: 7

The Fourth Trial (Before Pilate) Luke 23: 13- 25

- Jesus was sent back to Pilate
- **When Pilate received Jesus back from Herod, he tried to save Jesus in the following ways:**
- For five times he declared Jesus innocent (Verses 4,7,14,15,and

22)

- He tried to effect a compromise, he had Jesus whipped / scourged and tried to release him (vs. 16)
- He at first refused to release Barabbas Vs.20 after he had appealed to the Jewish Passover clemency
- At Passover the Jews had a right to demand the release of a prisoner of their own choice
- Pilate asked the Jews whom to set free for them between Jesus (who was innocent) and Barabbas (a popular rebel leader)
- The people demanded for the release of Barabbas and that Jesus should be crucified

Pilate was suspicious of Jesus' accusers because

- Jews were against the Roman Government, so it was strange that they accused a fellow Jew of being against Roman rule
- He must have had information that there was no crime (against Roman rule) in him
- He knew that these leaders were jealous of Jesus

Pilate's dilemma

- The demand of the Jews to have Jesus put to death put Pilate in dilemma in the sense that
 - Letting Jesus go would cause a rebellion (riot) by the Jews
 - Condemning Jesus would be against Roman law since he was innocent of any crime against the state

What forced Pilate to pass a capital sentence on Jesus?

- He wanted to improve his strained relationship with Jews as he had made some mistakes causing serious unrest among the Jews such as
 - He allowed army standards into the temple. They bore the image of the Emperor, and so were unclean. This made the Jews furious as it made Temple worship unclean
 - He used the Temple money to build an aqueduct
 - He was afraid that the Jews could report him to Rome, at the Emperor

Importance of the four trials for the early church

- Both Herod and Pilate had declared Jesus innocent
- Pilate had even tried to save the founder of Christianity
- Pilate had acted under pressure of the leaders and crowd

In what ways did the Jewish council violate the Jewish Laws in the trial of Jesus?

- His case was heard during the week of the celebration of Passover

- There were no eye witnesses
- He was convicted on his own testimony
- They started ill – treating him before he was even found guilty
- Death sentence was passed on the very same day of hearing his case

G. Crucifixion of Jesus (Jesus goes to the skull (Golgotha) Luke 23: 26 – 43)

- After Pilate had passed a death sentence on Jesus, he handed Jesus over to the soldiers to do what they wanted
- The soldiers led Jesus to the skull so as to crucify him
- They made him carry his own cross

On the way to the skull Jesus met the following:

▪ Simon of Cyrene

- He was a Jew living in Diaspora, at Cyrene now Tripoli in Libya
- He had gone to Jerusalem for the Passover feast
- He was the father of Alexander and Rufus, probably church leaders
- The soldiers seized him and made him help Jesus carry the cross behind him

▪ Wailing women of Jerusalem

- Jesus told the weeping women not to weep for him but for themselves and their children
- For the days are coming when people will say
- How ;lucky are the women who never had children, who never bore babies, who never nursed them
- That will be the time when people will say to the mountains "Fall on us!" and to the hill "Hide us!"
- For if such things as these are done when the wood is green what will happen when it is dry?

Note

- Jesus is "green" wood i.e. innocent, as Pilate himself repeatedly declared
- Yet the Romans destroyed him
- How much more terrible will be that fate of Jerusalem, it being "dry" wood i.e. guilty of rebellion

Jesus, innocence stressed by Luke

- Jesus referred to himself as the green wood
- Pilate, declared him innocent (5 times)
- Herod (Luke 23: 15)

- One of the two criminals (Luke 23: 41)
- The centurion at the cross (Luke 23 ; 47)

At the Skull or Golgotha Luke 23: 32 – 49

- When they arrived at the Skull, Jesus was crucified
- Crucifixion was a form of execution (i.e. the lawful killing as punishment)
- To the Romans it was a shameful thing because those who were crucified were either slaves or worse criminals
- Jesus was crucified on a cross shaped like a
- His arms were outstretched and nailed on the horizontal bar while his legs were tied and nailed on the vertical bar and then the cross was planted
- Crucifixion aimed at prolonging death as a punishment since one would die out of starvation and pain
- Two other men, both criminals were also crucified together with Jesus: one on his right and the other on his left

Words spoken by Jesus from the cross

- **Forgive them father! They do not know what they are doing vs. 34**

- "Them" refer to the Jews
- Jesus practiced what he taught i.e. love your enemies ... pray for those who ill – treat you Luke 6: 27 – 28
- Jesus was imitated by Stephen Acts 7: 60

- **Today you will be with me in Paradise vs. 43**

- Paradise is a Persian word which means a garden / park belonging to a Persian king
- It refers to either the "place" where the blessed await the resurrection or heaven itself
- The criminal hopes just to be remembered but he gets more, he will be there

- **Father, into your hands I place my spirit**

- It's the evening prayer for the Jews taken from Psalms 31: 5
- In this way Jesus expresses his trustful commitment to God's will and his conscious voluntary acceptance of his death by using the words of vs. 5

Words spoken by other people

- While Jesus was on the cross a number of people spoke different words
- Some were sympathizing while others were not sympathizing with Jesus
- **The Jewish Leaders**
- He saved others, let him save himself if he is the messiah whom God has chosen
- **The soldiers**
- Save yourself if you are the king of the Jews
- **The inscription**
- This is the king of the Jews
- **One of the criminals**
- Aren't you the messiah? Save yourself and us!
- **The other criminal**
- Don't you fear God?
- You receive the same sentence as he did
- Ours, however, is only right because we are getting what we deserve for what we did
- But he has done no wrong
- "Remember me, Jesus, when you come as a king"
- **The army officer**
- Certainly he was a good man

G. Jesus' death and burial

Signs of Jesus' death and its meaning

- **Darkness**
- It was about twelve o'clock when the sun stopped shining and darkness covered the country until three o'clock in the afternoon
- It looks as if evil has won; however universal darkness is also a symbol of God, the Lord who controls history
- It signifies judgement; from now on people will be judged according to their attitude towards Jesus
- Judgement here is universal, on Jews and gentiles alike
- **The curtain hanging in the Temple was torn into two parts**
- The double curtain separated the Holy place from the Holy of Holies
- Only the High priest was allowed to enter it, and only once a year
- The tearing of the curtain meant that
- The Jewish way of worshipping God has come to an end. The time

of the Temple is over

- The Holy of Holies is open; from now on all people have direct access to God through Jesus
- The barrier between Jews and gentiles is demolished. They are no longer separated as clean and unclean

The Burial of Jesus Luke 23: 50 – 56

The Jewish burial customs

- The body was washed
- Anointed and perfumed with myrrh / spices
- Wrapping the body in clothes for the grave
- Sometimes binding the hands and feet with clothes (bandage)
- Covering the face with a cloth
- The burial took place on the day of death

Note

- Poor Jews dug a grave, usually outside town
- Richer Jews had a grave cut out in a rock, closed with a rolling stone
- It was Joseph of Arimathea who took care of Jesus' burial

• Joseph of Arimathea

- He was a good and honourable man
- He was a member of the Jewish council
- He was waiting for the Kingdom of God to come
- Possibly a secret disciple of Jesus
- He went into the presence of Pilate and asked for the body of Jesus
- He took the body down, wrapped it in a linen sheet, and placed it in a tomb which had been dug out of solid rock and which had never been used

Note

- Some women went with Joseph and saw the tomb and how Jesus' body was placed in it
- Jesus died on Friday and the Jewish Sabbath began at sunset of the Friday
- Work stopped at sunset
- No wonder the women had no time to anoint the body of Jesus
- They had to wait until the Sabbath was over

• Possible reasons why Joseph of Arimathea took good care of Jesus' body

- To express that he did not agree with the verdict of his fellow members of the Jewish council
- To obey the law that the body of an executed criminal be buried before sunset (Deuteronomy 21: 22 – 23)
- Being a secret disciple of Jesus, he wanted to show a true discipleship

I. The resurrection of Jesus Luke 24: 1 - 49

- Very early on Sunday morning the women went to the tomb
- Among the women were Mary Magdalene, Mary the mother of James, Salome and Joanna
- Their main aim was to anoint the body of Jesus, which they did not do on Friday
- Note that the women were carrying the spices which they had prepared to anoint the body of Jesus
- **Evidence or signs of the resurrection of Jesus**
- **The empty tomb vs. 2**
- The women found the stone rolled away from the entrance to the tomb
- So they went in but they did not find the body of Jesus
- All gospels and Jesus' enemies agreed that the tomb was found empty

Note

- For those who had faith in Jesus' teaching that he would rise after three days, the empty tomb was indeed a sign of Jesus' resurrection
- However, those who did not believe in the resurrection maintained that the disciples of Jesus had taken the body away
- **The testimony of the two angels vs. 4 – 8**
- Suddenly two men (i.e. angels) in bright shining clothes stood by them and said
- Why are you looking among the dead for the one who is alive?
- He is not here; he has been raised.
- Remember what he said to you while in Galilee
- The son of man must be handed over to sinners, be crucified, and three days later rise to life
- The women remembered his words and returned to the other disciples

Note

- The women reported what they had seen to Peter and the other

apostles

- They did not believe the women's message
- To show that even Peter did not believe the women, he got up and ran to the tomb to check for himself

- **Why did the not believe the women?**

- Unlike the women, they did not remember Jesus' words which they had not understood anyhow
- They had failed to learn from the OT that Christ had to suffer these things and enter his glory 24: 26
- The testimony of women had no value

- **Appearances (to Cleopas and his friend and to the disciples)**

- **First appearance Luke 24: 13 – 35**

- Luke says on that same day, two disciples of Jesus were going to Emmaus, about 11 kilometers from Jerusalem
- They were Cleopas and his friend (possibly his wife)
- They were talking to each other about all the things that had happened

- As they talked and discussed, Jesus himself drew near and walked along with them

- They saw him but they did not recognize him

- **Possible reasons why they failed to recognize him**

- Jesus had died; not in the least did they expect that he was alive
- Jesus must have looked different from the way he had looked before his death

- Their expectation about Jesus did not go beyond hoping that he would redeem Israel i.e. restore it as a nation

- They had failed to learn from scripture that in God's plan the Christ must suffer ... to enter into his glory 24:25

- Jesus disguised himself as a visitor who knew nothing about what had happened in Jerusalem

Note

- Read the conversation between Jesus and the two disciples on their way to Emmaus in Luke 24: 17 – 27

- **How did they eventually recognize Jesus?**

- They arrived to the village they were going
- Jesus acted as if he were going farther
- They held him back saying stay with us the day is almost over and

it is getting dark

- He went to stay with them
- He sat down to eat with them, took the break, and said the blessing
- Then he broke the bread and gave it to them (the gesture of Jesus' last supper)
- Then their eyes were opened
- And they recognize him
- But he disappeared from their sight
- **Reactions of the two disciples to their recognition of Jesus**
- They said to each other:
- Wasn't it like fire burning in us when he talked to us on the road and explained the scriptures to us?
- They got up at once and went back to Jerusalem
- They told the disciples that
- The Lord is risen indeed! He has appeared to Simon
- Then they explained to the disciples what had happened on the road and how they recognized Jesus when he broke the bread
- **Lessons from the story of Disciples to Emmaus for the church**
- Faith in the resurrection is a gift from God and the risen Lord
- This faith is confirmed and sustained by Peter and the Apostles, the church which
- Through the Spirit of Jesus teaches the true meaning of scriptures and
- Gathers around the table of the Lord for the breaking of bread to celebrate and strengthen the resurrection faith
- Jesus is always present, but his presence can be seen only through the eyes of faith

- **Second appearance (Sunday late evening) Luke 24: 36 – 49**
- While Cleopas and his friend were telling the disciples that Jesus had appeared to them, suddenly the Lord himself stood among them and said
- "Peace be with you"
- **Reactions of the disciples**
- They were all terrified, thinking that they were seeing a ghost
- **But Jesus assured them that it was He and not a ghost by**
- Showing them the scars in his hands and feet
- Asking them to feel his body which had both flesh and bones since

- a ghost does not have flesh and bones
- Taking a piece of cooked fish and eating it in their presence

K. Farewell Instructions (Mission or sending to all nations) Luke 24: 44 - 49

• Whilst in the upper room, Jesus gave the following instructions to his disciples

- Witness to the death and resurrection of Jesus (understood in the light of scriptures as explained by Jesus)
- Preach that people should repent
- Announce forgiveness
- Go to all nations beginning in Jerusalem
- Not to leave Jerusalem before they have received the Holy Spirit
- **The main points of farewell instructions**
- Through his suffering and resurrection, Jesus has fulfilled what was written about him in the OT scriptures (i.e. Moses, Prophets and Psalms)
- The scriptures have foretold that in his name; repentance and forgiveness must be preached to all nations i.e. the mission is universal
- The disciples are sent to witness to all this
- To help them in their mission, they will receive the Holy Spirit, promised long ago (Acts 2: 16)

Note

- The gospel starts and ends in Jerusalem (Luke 1: 14)
- The gospel starts and ends with joy
- They went back into Jerusalem, filled with great joy Luke 24: 52
- **Reasons why they were joyful**
- They knew Jesus lives and remains with them
- They are again a community after having been scattered at Jesus' arrest
- They have been given a marvelous purpose; being witness of the good news of Jesus and the kingdom of God
- They had been promised the Holy Spirit
- They knew evil had been defeated and mankind saved through Jesus

Note

- Jesus last appeared to his disciples at Bethany



- There he promised them power after the Holy Spirit had descended upon them
- When Jesus was taken away from them, they went back to Jerusalem to wait for the Holy Spirit

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Bible Knowledge form 3

Chapter 2

THE WORK OF PROPHET ISAIAH - FIRST (PROTO) ISAIAH

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THE WORK OF PROPHET ISAIAH - FIRST (PROTO) ISAIAH

OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, the student should be able to:

- Explain the meaning of the term prophet
- Describe the roles of prophets
- Analyse the work of First (Proto) Isaiah

CONTENTS

- Meaning of the term 'prophet'
- The roles of the prophets
- Analyse the work of First (Proto) Isaiah
 - The work of First (Proto) Isaiah
 - call of the prophet Isaiah
 - social, religious and political sins of Israel
 - the Messiah and the New Jerusalem
 - Prophet Isaiah and King Ahaz
 - Prophet Isaiah and King Hezekiah
 - The main message of First Isaiah
 - rebuked sins
 - called for repentance
 - predicted judgement
 - gave message of hope

The Meaning of a prophet

The word prophet originates from two Greek words Pro (meaning behalf) and Phetes (Meaning to speak). Thus a prophet can be defined as a person who speaks on behalf of God. This shows that a prophet knows the will and purpose of God. In most cases, prophets speak by divine inspiration and foretell the future.

Points to note

- Prophets are called by God to speak on his behalf
- They reveal the truth about God
- They exhort leaders and people to be faithful to the covenant they made with God
- They observe the socio- political aspects of religious situations and say what God thinks about them
- Their dress was sometimes distinguished, for instance, Elijah wore 'a cloak made of animal skins, tied with a leather belt' (2 Kings 1:8)
- Prophets became popular when priesthood became corrupt
- True prophets were distinguished from the false prophets by the formula of their message from God, 'thus says the Lord'
- Bands of prophets were scattered all over and were associated with worship centres such as Gilgal, Bethel and Jericho

Roles of the Prophets

- They reveal the nature and attributes of God to people e.g. in the vision and call of Isaiah
- They communicate the laws of God to the people
- They speak against moral and social evils, personal sins, oppression and injustice in the society (Isaiah 1: 16, 17 ; Amos 2: 6 – 8)
- They foretell God's judgements that would befall the people because of Israel's sins
- They encourage people that despite failures and the punishment that sin brings, God will not abandon them
- They provide messages of hope to the people

- They take over the roles of the priesthood when they become corrupt people
- They interpret what God is doing and what he is about to do for them
- They propagate patriotism by urging people to fight for their country and their God
- etc.

The work of First (Proto) Isaiah (Isaiah 1 – 39)

Historical context of Isaiah

The knowledge about Isaiah is scanty. Most of what is known about Isaiah comes from the first Isaiah i.e. chapters 1 – 39. From this part we learn that:

- Isaiah was the son of Amoz
- His boyhood coincided with the ministry of the prophet Amos in the North
- He was called to be the prophet in the year that King Uzziah died i.e. 742 or 740 BC
- By the time this time he was 20 years old
- He carried out his prophetic work among his own people of Judah
- His wife was a prophetess
- They had two sons with symbolic names: Shear Jashub and Quick Loot Fast Plunder
- Possibly he was coming from a well to do family because of his access to the kings

Authorship

- The whole book of Isaiah is believed to have been written by Isaiah Amoz (Isaiah of Jerusalem)
- However, the events of the whole book cover a period of 250 years
- Thus some scholars of the Bible believe that the book has got more than one author.

Division of the Book

The book has got **three main** divisions

- Proto or First Isaiah: Chapters 1 - 39

- Deutero or Second Isaiah: Chapters 40 – 55
- Trito or Third Isaiah: Chapters 56 – 66
-

Proto (First) Isaiah (1 – 39)

- In this part, Isaiah prophesied to the Jews when they were in **Judah before exile**.
- This part is believed to have been written by Isaiah Amoz
- In this part, Isaiah used to warn the Jews to stop their sins failing which they would be taken into exile as a punishment

Deutero (Second) Isaiah (40 – 55)

- In this part, Isaiah prophesied to the Jews when they were in **Babylon in exile**
- This part is believed to have been written by an unknown person who is referred to as Isaiah of Babylon
- In this part, the prophet used to comfort the Jews who were suffering in exile

Trito (Third) Isaiah (56 – 66)

- In this part, Isaiah prophesied to the Jews when they were in **Judah after exile**
- This part is also believed to have been written by another person
- In this part, the prophet used to condemn the sins of the Jews which made God not to fulfill the promises he made to them while in exile.

1. The Vision and call of Isaiah (6: 1 – 13)

A. What is a (prophetic) vision?

- It is something which God makes someone (e.g. a prophet) to **see** and **hear** in his or her mind when revealing a certain truth.

B. Where did the vision take place?

- Possibly in the Temple
- This is suggested so because Isaiah uses words which are connected with the temple worship such as temple foundation, altar, burning coal etc

C. When did this vision take place?

- In the year that king Uzziah died i.e. 742 or 740 BC. This was a year of crisis.
- This was because the people relied on Uzziah
- With his death, they felt that it was the end of their peace and prosperity
- They felt God would no longer bless them
- On the other hand Jotham, his successor, was a weakling and could not save them from the danger that loomed from the East.

D. What did he see and its meaning

i. **He saw the Lord sitting on his throne.**

- At that time only kings sat on the throne
- As such Isaiah learnt that God was the king of kings
- Therefore he should not despair because of the death of King Uzziah

ii. **God's robe filled the whole Temple**

- This symbolized God's greatness

iii. **He saw flaming creatures (i.e. angels) around the Lord.**

- Each creature had **six wings**
- **Used two wings to cover the face:** This shows that God is Holy and no one can see him face to face and be alive
- **Used two wings to cover their bodies:** As a sign of respect to God
- **Used the other two wings for flying:** To show how swift / fast angels carry God's message to the people

iv. **Smoke filled the whole Temple**

- Smoke symbolized the presence of God
- In other words Isaiah realized that God was present in the Temple

Reaction of Isaiah to God's presence as found in Is. 6: 5

Isaiah said

- There is no hope for me
- I am doomed
- Every word that passes my lips is sinful
- I live among people whose every word is sinful
- Yet with my own eyes I have seen the King, the Lord Almighty.

v. One of the flaming creatures flew down to him and touched his lips with a burning coal taken from the altar

- Fire is a symbol of purification
- Therefore the action showed that Isaiah's sins had been cleansed/ purified/ forgiven

E. What Isaiah heard and its meaning?

i. The choir of the angels i.e. "Holy, Holy, Holy! The Lord Almighty is Holy! His glory fills the world"

- From this Isaiah learnt that **God is Holy** and **God is glorious**.
- **To say that God is Holy means** that God is set apart from creatures.
 - He is not like men for in him there is no trace of evil.
 - He thinks differently from people.
 - In his presence human beings realize their sinfulness.
 - For example, when Isaiah noticed that he was in the presence of God, he became aware of his own sinfulness. Isaiah 6:5
 - Likewise, when Peter became aware of God's presence before Jesus, he too realized his own sinfulness Luke. 5:8
- As such people should not question God nor try to control him through child sacrifice, magic, etc
- **To say God is glorious** means that He is always **victorious**.
- And God's victory is seen when all sufferings and oppression cease or come to an end
- Three events are known in history whereby people were saved from their sufferings. These events are
 - The first exodus i.e. when Moses led the oppressed slaves in Egypt to freedom
 - The second exodus i.e. when Cyrus allowed the Jews to return to Judah
 - The third exodus i.e. when Jesus passed through death to life and saved mankind from the oppression of sin and death

ii. God's call: Whom shall I send? Who will be our messenger? Verse 8

- From this Isaiah realized that God was calling him to be his prophet
- Thus he immediately volunteered to do God's work saying: "I will go! send me"
- His response showed courage , generosity and spontaneity

iii. God announcing Isaiah's mission. Verses 9 – 10

- In these verses God was telling Isaiah his mission
- His mission will be to call upon the Jews to repent their sins and come back to the worship of one God.
- However, the result of his preaching will be turning away the Jews farther from God. This is because:
 - their minds will be dull,
 - their eyes will be blind and
 - their ears will be deaf
- As such people will not understand , see or hear his message
 - This shows that the mission of Isaiah will be a difficult one since people will not listen to his teaching.

iv. God announcing the period of Isaiah's mission. Verse 11

- Isaiah asked the Lord for how long would he teach the people without listening to him
- God told him that he would remain his prophet **until the land of Judah was destroyed**

Note

- The land of Judah will be destroyed and the Jews will be taken into exile as God's punishment on them for their sins and stubbornness to repent
- However this will not be the end of the Jews and their land
- A few faithful Jews shall remain and return to Judah through whom God's promise and plan of saving mankind shall be fulfilled

Relationship between God and the people of Israel as per the story

- In this story, we learn that Isaiah realized that he was a sinner and that he lived among sinners
- This shows that the Jews had been unfaithful to their covenant relationship with God
- They disobeyed God and did not trust him anymore
- Possibly they trusted their wisdom and political shrewdness i.e. they depended on alliances rather than the wisdom of God

- Here we see that Isaiah himself repents and is forgiven but for the people, there seems to be a little hope that they will repent
- To them what will come is destruction as God's punishment (6: 10 – 13)

Themes

- God is Holy
- God is glorious
- God is merciful
- God is the king of kings
- Judgement
- Hope

2. Social, religious and political sins of Israel (Isaiah 1: 1 – 31, 3: 1- 26, 4:1, 5: 1 – 7)

Isaiah Chapter 1: 1 - 31

- This chapter contains a collection of oracles from different times of Isaiah's ministry and it sums up the main teachings of the prophet
- An **Oracle** is a wise and authoritative proclamation of God's will and purpose
- The oracles contained in this chapter have a common theme namely **Judah's sins and their punishment**
- The main sin of the Jews as per this chapter is **their rejection of Yahweh**
- All other sins mentioned in the chapter like religious formalism, social injustice, idolatry and superstition are consequences of Judah's main sin

Commentary

Title. 1:1

- Verse 1 might have been intended to introduce chapters 1 – 35
- It mentions the name of the **author** of these oracles i.e. **Isaiah son of Amoz**
- It mentions the **people** to whom these oracles were addressed i.e. the **people of Judah and Jerusalem**
- It also mentions the **time** when these oracles were uttered i.e. between **742 & 687 BC**
- Below are the meanings of the names mentioned in the verse as well as their period of reign.

Name	Meaning	Period of reign
Uzziah	My strength is Yahweh	783/1 – 742/0 BC
Jotham	Yahweh is perfect	742 - 735 BC
Ahaz	Yahweh grasps the hand	735 - 715 BC
Hezekiah	Yahweh is my strength	715 - 687 BC
Isaiah	Yahweh is my salvation	742/0 - 687 BC

NB: Isaiah carried out his ministry as a prophet at the time when Jotham, Ahaz and Hezekiah were kings of Judah. **Isaiah did not prophesy at the time of Uzziah**

Yahweh's complaint. 1: 2 – 4

- These verses speak of Israel's ingratitude towards God
- God made a covenant with the Israelites
- However the Israelites have broken the covenant
- They have disobeyed the Lord by worshipping idols and relying on foreign countries
- God complains about their rebellion against Him
- God cannot even compare their disobedience to animals such as donkeys and cattle

Israel is sick. 1: 5 – 9

- Due to Israel's rebellion against God, Jews committed many more sins politically, socially, morally and even religiously
- The prophet describes their sinfulness in terms of sickness
- Thus the wounds, sores and bruises refer to the sins of the Israelites
- They were full of sins
- And yet they did not want to repent their sins as the prophet said, "their wounds are not bandaged, no ointment is put on their wounds"
- Note that Judah has ever been punished for her sins and it seems she is seeking for more punishment as she goes on disobeying God. (Do you want to be punished even more?)
- The first punishment could possibly be when she was invaded by Israel during the reign of Jotham and Ahaz
- The other punishment could possibly be when Sennacherib invaded 46 fortified cities of Judah in 701 BC

- Only the city of Jerusalem was spared and Isaiah says that the city was as defenseless as a guard's hut in a vineyard or a shed in a cucumber field
- Isaiah meant that the city was weak and powerless
- The city was not special to be spared
- The city was as sinful as Sodom and Gomorrah and so could have likewise been destroyed but was spared by God's mercy so as to keep his promise
- Survivors in verse 8 refer to those who were spared by God's mercy from the destruction of 701 BC

The religious corruption and its cleansing. 1: 10 – 17

- In this passage God rejects as worthless not the sacrifices nor the rituals but hypocrisy of the Jews whose sins and refusal to repent render their sacrifices unacceptable to God
- Jews had several religious festivals or feasts such as
 - New Moon Festivals
 - Religious gatherings
 - Sabbath
 - Holy days

New Moon Festival

- This was a day of rest at the beginning of each month
- On this day, Jews had a "Holy convocation" and offered sacrifices to Yahweh (Numbers 28: 11 – 15)
- This was held on the first day of the new moon

Sabbath

- This is the seventh day of the week in the Hebrew calendar whose first day is Sunday
- Jews observed the Sabbath day as a day of rest and worship of Yahweh

Religious gatherings and Holy days

- These included: Passover, Pentecost and Ingathering

Passover

- This was a Jewish feast commemorating Jews' deliverance from Egyptian slavery

Pentecost

- This was a Jewish wheat harvest festival held on the fiftieth day after the feast of Passover

Ingathering

- This was a fruit harvest festival

Note that Jews used to offer sacrifices for various reasons such as:

- homage of God
- thanksgiving
- expiation of offenses
- sin offering
- mode of asking for something from God

Note also that their prayers involved

- tramping about
- burning sacrifices
- lifting up their hands
- clapping hands

Reaction of the prophet to their festivals, prayers and sacrifices.

- The prophet says all these sacrifices, festivals and Sabbath observations have lost their value because of their sins and their refusal to repent
- The people pretended to worship God and yet outside the Temple they led sinful lives
- Some of their sins were
 - Murder (their hands were covered with blood)
 - Injustice
 - Oppression
 - Unrighteousness
- Due to such sins, their sacrifices did not satisfy God
- Thus God says, "When you lift your hands in prayer I will not look at you. No matter how much you pray, I will not listen"
- However for God to receive their prayers, Jews were asked to repent sincerely and see to it that their exterior worship of God reflects their interior disposition
- In this case God wants them
 - to stop doing evil
 - to learn to do what is right
 - to be just
- Their justice and righteousness will be seen by
 - helping those who are oppressed
 - giving orphans their rights
 - defending widows

A case against Jerusalem. 1: 18 – 20

- In these verses, God calls upon the people of Israel to avoid a national disaster by true repentance
- "Now let us settle the matter" means let us discuss as if we were in court
- During the discussion, God reminds the people that he has power to forgive them all their sins
- Thus he said, although you are stained red with sins, I will wash you as clean as snow
- Thus he begs his people to stop sinning and repent truly so that they may be forgiven and escape a national disaster

God's lamentation. 1: 21 – 23

- This passage contains God's lamentation over the condition of Jerusalem.
- God laments because Jerusalem has changed from the once faithful and loyal city (as was the case at the times of kings David and Solomon) to a city characterized by unrighteousness and injustice
- Isaiah describes this change by using three different images namely

i. Whore

- Isaiah compares Jerusalem with a whore
- Note that the prophets in the Old Testament used to describe the relationship between God and His people in terms of the relationship between a husband and his wife
- Israel is, therefore, seen as God's wife.
- Since she is no longer faithful to God alone, she has become like a whore vs. 21
- Israel has deceived her loyal husband
- All the righteous that lodged in the city is gone and only murderers are left

ii. silver and dross; pure wine and wine mixed with water

- Isaiah says, at first Jerusalem was like pure silver or pure wine referring to her purity, faithfulness and obedience to God's will.
- Now she has become like worthless silver or like wine mixed with water i.e. she is impure and worthless
- Jerusalem's life is now mixed up with all sorts of injustice and other sins

iii. rebels (friends of thieves)

- Finally Isaiah uses the example of leaders who have become rebels and companions of thieves to explain the change in Jerusalem
- Leaders are symbols of justice and righteousness
- However, leaders of Jerusalem have become friends of thieves in the sense that they love bribes and accept gifts even from the poor
- In addition they do not defend widows and orphans
- This is injustice and unrighteousness which would mislead all people

Judgement on Jerusalem. 1: 24 – 31

- The Jews have become God's enemies as seen above
- And God will treat them as such i.e. He will punish them as they deserve
- In Verse 25, God says He will purify Jerusalem just as metal is refined
- He will put Jerusalem in a smelting pot and clean it of all impure and unclean elements
- This means that God will bring judgement over the city through suffering in order to clean and remove the injustice and unrighteousness from it.
- **The purpose of the punishment is**, therefore, not to destroy completely but **to purify**
- Once the city has been purified, good leaders (rulers and advisers) will be put in charge as it was long ago
- The expression long ago probably refers to the time of David and Solomon when Jerusalem was known as the city of justice and righteousness.
- Verses 27 – 28 describe the result of God's judgement
- i.e. God's judgement will bring about division
- All righteous people will be grouped on one hand and be saved
- While all wicked people will be grouped on the other hand and be destroyed
- To be saved means to be rescued from the danger of sin and its consequences (i.e. death)
- In verses 29 – 31, the trees, gardens and oaks refer to the pagan worship whereby gentiles celebrated the fertility of soil, beasts and human beings
- Jews who participated in these celebrations were adulterers i.e. unfaithful to their covenant relationship with God

- Isaiah said that they will be ashamed of these practices when the judgement day comes and they will wither as oak leaves and gardens without water. Verse 31

Chaos and Evil in Jerusalem due to poor leadership 3: 1 – 12

- **This passage mentions various types of leaders such as**
 - Social/ civic leaders e.g. heroes, soldiers, military leaders
 - Political leaders e.g. politicians, statesmen
 - Religious leaders e.g. prophets
 - Judges
- **The leadership of these people was very poor and misleading because**
 - They accepted bribes
 - They worshipped idols
 - They oppressed the poor
 - They openly insulted God
- **These led the people of Judah to sin against God**
- In Isaiah 3: 1 – 8, Isaiah says as a way of punishing the people of Judah **God will take away from them:**
 - **everyone they depend upon** like heroes, soldiers, judges, prophets, fortune tellers, military leaders, civilian leaders, politicians and magicians
 - **everything they depend upon** like food, water and clothes
- **As a result there will be**
 - a breakdown of law and order
 - a breakdown of responsible leadership
 - anarchy (i.e. a total or complete chaos or disorder)
- **In this chaotic situation, the following will happen**
 - people will deny responsibilities even those who will be well dressed and look respectable
 - people will be governed by immature boys
 - everyone will take advantage of everyone else
 - young people will not respect their leaders
 - worthless people will not respect their superiors

- In verses 8 and 9, the prophet says all **these will happen because of the sins of the Jews**
 - They sin like the people of Sodom and Gomorrah
 - As such the people themselves are responsible for the punishment that will come upon them
 - The punishment is completely just
 - The expression **their prejudice** in verse 9 probably refers to the injustice of the leaders in their treatment of people i.e. they protect the rich while they oppress the poor and the weak.
 - This injustice behaviour will bring their punishment and destruction
 - However the righteous need not fear evil / punishment
- **Judgement on the leaders 3: 13 – 15**
 - Here Isaiah pictures God in His court
 - He judges the people
 - And the ones He blames most for the injustice behaviour are the selfish and corrupt leaders and elders of Jerusalem
 - These oppressed the poor and enriched themselves by **plundering whatever belonged to the poor. Verse 15**
- **In this passage**
 - The people are somehow excused, the blame goes mainly to the leaders
 - Clothes and food in verse 7 symbolize responsibility a man shoulders. The one who hasn't food and clothes will be exempted from taking responsibility
 - The passage could refer to the period when Jews were led by Ahaz; a young and inexperienced man, a frightened and weak leader in 735 BC.

The Women of Jerusalem 3: 16 – 4:1

- The well to do women of Jerusalem were not innocent either
- This passage is dealing with their sins and punishment

Their sins or vices were

Pride and arrogance

- This was shown by walking with their noses in the air

Flirting

- They were seducing or tempting men to unchastity by taking little dainty steps and letting the bracelets on their ankles jingle.

Robbery (excessive desire for wealth)

- They conquered with their husbands to rob the poor so as to enjoy luxuries

Their punishments were

Baldness

- God will shave their head / hair and leave them bald
- This could mean either the real shaving of the hair which was a disgrace or
- It meant that the Lord will smite them with a skin disease which will make them lose their hair of which they were so proud

Poverty (God will take away from the women everything they were so proud of like :)

- **the ornaments**: they were wearing on their ankles, heads, necks and wrists
- **the veils and hats**: they were wearing on their heads
- **the magic charms**: they were wearing on their arms and waists
- **their robes, gowns, purses, handkerchiefs, scarves**

Shame (rape)

- The Lord will lay bare their secret parts
- This could mean their flirting would cause them to be raped by their captors

Bad smell

- Instead of using perfume, they will stink

Instead of fine belts, they will wear coarse ropes

- This possibly meant that they will lose their freedom

Spinsterhood and widowhood / childlessness

- Many men will be killed during the war
- As a result, there will be many widows and spinsters which was regarded as a great misfortune in Jewish society
- Thus seven women will ask one man to marry them so as to give them the status of being wives just because of difficulties in marrying

The Song of the Vineyard 5: 1 – 7

- This song is a parable because it has got all characteristics of a parable

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- A parable is an imaginary or fictitious story taken from everyday life to explain the spiritual truth not yet recognized. Or
- A parable is an earthly story with a hidden spiritual meaning
- This parable is about a man (farmer) who had a vineyard on a very fertile hill
- The man gave to it all the care it needed to produce good grapes. For example
 - He dug the soil
 - He cleared it of stones
 - He planted the finest vines
 - He built a tower to guard them
 - He built a fence around it
 - He weeded or hoed the ground
 - He pruned the vines
 - He watered the garden
- Thus he was expecting good grapes
- However the grapes were sour
- **Disappointed the man decided to**
 - take away the hedge round it
 - break down the wall that protects it
 - let wild animals eat it and trample it down
 - let it be overgrown with weeds
 - let briars and thorns cover it
 - stop prune the vines or hoe the ground
 - forbid the clouds to let rain fall on it
- The explanation of the parable is found in Verse 7
 - The farmer stands for God and the vineyard stands for Israel
- The story shows that
 - God chose the people of Israel as his own people
 - He protected them from their enemies throughout their existence as a nation
 - He revealed himself to them
 - He made a covenant with them i.e. I am your God and you are my people
 - He gave them laws and commandments to follow as God's people
 - He even gave them prophets to guide them
 - These were some of the privileges the Israelites enjoyed as God's chosen people
 - They can be compared to the good care the farmer gave to the vineyard

- Thus the farmer (God) was expecting good grapes from the vineyard (Israelites) i.e. He was expecting them to be faithful and obedient to Him as well as to be just and righteous in their lives
 - Instead they produced sour grapes i.e. they were unfaithful, disobedient, unjust, unrighteous and in addition they were committing murder
- As a result God will punish them in the following ways:
- He will let other nations invade, conquer and destroy their land
 - Their land will be left in ruins / desolation
 - There will be drought since God will forbid the clouds to let rain fall on it
- The message of the passage is that the people of Judah would be punished if they do not practice justice and righteousness

3. The meeting between Isaiah and Ahaz (Isaiah 7: 1 – 25, 8: 1 – 4, 16 – 22, 9:1)

Historical background

- Isaiah and Ahaz met because of the Assyrian power and threat
- In the middle of the 8th Century BC, Assyrians under Tiglath Pileser III (nicknamed Pul) were the world super power
- By 745 BC, the Assyrians planned to extend their territory as far as Egypt
- Their aim was to control the trade routes around the Mediterranean Sea
- The way to Egypt led through Syria, Israel and Judah
- At that time; Rezin was the king of Syria, Pekah was the king of Israel and Ahaz was the king of Judah
- When Rezin, Pekah and Ahaz learnt about the plan the Assyrians, they were all terrified
- This was so because they knew that the way to Egypt led through their nations as such they were to be the first victims before the Assyrians attack Egypt.

Their reaction

- Rezin and Pekah asked Ahaz to form an alliance against Assyria
- This happened just when Ahaz had succeeded Jotham in 735 BC

Ahaz's response

- He refused to join their alliance
- As a result Rezin and Pekah declared war on Ahaz which is known as the Syro- Ephramite war of 735 BC

Aim of the war

- To conquer Judah and then oust Ahaz
- Replace king Ahaz with one of Tabeel's sons
- **Then force Judah to remain in the alliance**

NB: If what Rezin and Pekah had planned succeeded, Nathan's prophesy that King David and his descendants would rule over Judah forever would have not been fulfilled. This was because Tabeel was not a descendant of David

Reaction of Ahaz to the crisis

- He burnt his son as a sacrifice to the Lord. (2Kings16:3)
- He planned to make an alliance with the Assyrians because
 - Like his father Jotham he was pro Assyria
 - He was afraid of the combined power of Israel and Syria
 - He believed the alliance would give him 100% assurance of protection
 - He trusted men's power more than God's power
- He went on the highway to inspect the water supply of Jerusalem in preparation of a possible siege

Yahweh sends Isaiah to Ahaz 7: 1 – 9

- Syria (Rezin) and Israel (Pekah) attacked Judah (Ahaz)
- All the people of Judah were so terrified that they trembled like trees shaking in the wind
- God said to Isaiah
 - Take your son Shear Jashub and go to meet King Ahaz
 - You will find him on the road where the clothes makers work, at the end of the ditch that brings water from the upper pool
- God sent Isaiah to advise Ahaz on what to do.
- The advice was given to Ahaz through words and actions

Words: Isaiah told Ahaz

- to keep alert
- to stay calm
- i.e. Ahaz was advised to remain neutral of political alliances; He should not join the Assyrians or the Syria and Israel league
- not to be disturbed
- not to be frightened

- instead he should put his trust in God's protection
- Isaiah told Ahaz that there was no need for him to fear Syria and Israel because they were like **smoke from two smouldering sticks** i.e. they were weak and not harmful.

Action

- Isaiah went with his son Shear Jashub when conveying the message
- Shear Jashub is a symbolic name which Isaiah gave his son
- The name contains a message of warning and hope for Ahaz and his people

Warning

- Ahaz was warned that if he would not take Isaiah's advice and instead rely on the power of men like the Assyrians, God will punish them by taking them into exile where many people will perish and die

Hope

- In exile, not everybody will die there
- A few faithful Jews shall remain and return to Jerusalem
- God's purpose of saving mankind will be fulfilled through the remnants
-

NB: The name Shear Jashub literary means "a few remnants shall remain and return"

The dire consequences of Ahaz's policy

A. The sign of Immanuel 7: 10 – 17

- Isaiah asked Ahaz to ask for any sign from God **to assure him that God would protect him from his enemies.**

Ahaz's response

- Ahaz refused to ask for a sign

Reasons

- His seemingly reason was that he did not want to put the Lord to the test
- His real reason was that he had already made up his mind to ask the help of the Assyrians
- By putting his trust on earthly king after he was invited to trust God, he shattered the whole idea of covenant (i.e. I will be your God and you will be my people)

- Although Ahaz refused to ask for a sign, God went ahead and **gave him a sign of Immanuel.**
- God said
 - a young woman who is pregnant will have a son
 - she will name him Immanuel
 - by the time he is old enough to make his own decisions
 - people will be drinking milk and eating honey
 - even before that time comes, the lands of those two kings who terrify you will be deserted

Messages contained in the name “Immanuel”

- First, the name contains the message of **encouragement** to Ahaz and his people.
 - Immanuel means God is with us
 - This shows that God will be with Ahaz and his people
 - God will never abandon or desert them
 - God will protect them from their enemies
- The second message is that
 - Syria and Israel were weak
 - They will be destroyed before the child will be able to discern between good and evil (i.e. within five years)

Fulfillment of the prophecy

- The prophecy was finally fulfilled with the birth of Jesus (Mt. 1: 23)
- The fact that Jesus was born, is a proof that God – is – with – us till the end of time
- In Jesus, therefore, the symbolic name of Immanuel found its fulfillment
- This is why this passage is often read in Christian churches at Christmas times when Christians commemorate the birth of Jesus

NB: A sign is an event (or anything observable) which manifests God's will.

B. The four oracles of doom 7: 18 – 25

- Ahaz's unwillingness to trust God even after being given the sign of Immanuel, led Isaiah to give him four oracles of doom.
- Each oracle opens with the phrase, **“When that time comes ...”** i.e. when Ahaz makes an alliance with Assyria the following will happen:

Oracle 1. 7: 18 – 19

- When that time comes
- The Lord will whistle as a signal for the **Egyptians** to come like **flies** and for the **Assyrians** to come like **bees** on the land of Judah
- Flies stand for Egyptian soldiers and Bees stand for Assyrian soldiers
- The oracle means that Judah will be used as a battle field between Egyptians and Assyrians
- As such Judah will be humiliated for making an alliance with Assyria

Oracle 2. 7: 20

- When that times comes
- The Lord will hire a barber from across the Euphrates i.e. the Emperor of Assyria
- He will shave off your beards, and all the hair on your heads and on your bodies
- The oracle means that the Assyrian king will be like a barber or a razor
- Instead of doing good to Judah, he will bring them harm
- This happened when the Assyrian king demanded the people of Judah to pay them heavy annual tribute as a sign that they were subject to the Assyrians.

Oracle 3. 7: 21 – 23

- When that time comes
- Even if a farmer has only one cow and two goats,
- They will provide abundant milk for him
- As a result survivors will have enough milk and honey to eat
- The oracle means that time will come when Jews will be taken into exile
- In the process, they will have no time to cultivate their fields
- As such people will have to live on milk and honey
- Yet milk and honey were traditional food for nomads
- This implies that people will live like nomads which will be a step backwards

Oracle 4. 7: 24 – 25

- When that time comes
- Their fertile and fine agricultural land will be overgrown with thorn bushes and briars

- No one will go there
- The land will not be conducive for growing crops
- Instead the land will only be good for grazing and hunting animals
- This means that the invading Assyrian army will turn their land into a wilderness, full of wild animals and hence good for hunting and grazing animals

How the oracles were fulfilled

- Because of the help Assyrians gave Ahaz, Judah became a subject to Assyrians and paid them heavy annual tribute
- In addition, worship of idols was introduced
- Thus Judah was humiliated by asking the Assyrians help
- In 701 BC Judah was severely damaged by the Assyrians led by Sennacherib
- In 586 BC Jerusalem was destroyed by Babylon and many Jews were taken into exile as captives
- On their way they fed on milk and honey, and their land was abandoned

C. Ahaz was given the sign of Quick – Loot – Fast – Plunder. 8: 1 – 4

- God gave another sign through Isaiah to signify the destruction of Syria and Israel
 - Isaiah had to give a symbolic name to his child
 - He named him Quick – Loot – Fast – Plunder
 - The name refers to the quick looting and plundering of Syria and Israel led Assyrian soldiers
 - Before the child would old enough to say “mummy” and “daddy” all the wealth of Damascus and all the loot of Samaria will be carried off by the king of Assyria (i.e. within two years).
 - This shows that Quick – Loot – Fast – Plunder was three years younger than Immanuel
- Isaiah made this prophecy solemn because the prophecy was
- put in writing
 - attested by two eye witnesses namely Uriah and Zechariah
 - dedicated to Isaiah's second son

Fulfillment of the prophecy

- In 734 BC the Assyrians fought against Israel and weakened them so much so that they contained no more threat for Judah. In 722 BC Israel was completely destroyed by the Assyrians
- On the other hand, Syria was completely destroyed by the Assyrians in 732 BC

D. Isaiah withdrew from his public ministry temporarily 8: 16 – 19

- Isaiah withdrew temporarily from prophesying and preaching
- He built up his testimony and sealed the teaching among his **disciples** and gave it to them to be preserved
- These disciples might refer to
 - Isaiah's real followers or
 - God's people (i.e. those who do the will of God)
- These had to guard and preserve the testimony

Why did Isaiah stop prophesying?

- The main reason was because **his prophetic work** for the good of his country was **fruitless** since the faithless king Ahaz made it impossible for him to influence the public
- He was wearied out by the king's attitude
- He wanted to pay more attention to his disciples and spend more time with them
- He wanted God to act and to fulfill the prophecies already made (7: 1 – 7; 8: 1 – 4) while he himself and his sons were acting as living signs of the prophecies

What will happen during the prophetic silence?

- People will tell you (disciples) to ask for messages from fortunetellers and mediums, who chirp and mutter, i.e. people who forecast a rosy future so as to lease their audience
- They will say
- After all, people should ask for messages from the spirits and consult the dead on behalf of the living
- You are to answer them
- Listen to what the Lord is teaching you
- Don't listen to mediums
- What they tell you, will do you no good
- Thus people will wander through their land

- They will be discouraged and hungry
- In their hunger and anger, they will curse their king and God
- They may look up to the sky or stare at the ground
- But they will see nothing apart from trouble and terrifying darkness into which they will be driven

Reasons why Isaiah was against alliance with Assyria

- By making an alliance with Assyrians, Ahaz would show that he was relying on them rather than on God which was a sign of lack of faith in God's protection
- Isaiah believed that history is made by God and not men. As such Ahaz should not be afraid of men's power and threats
- The alliance had bad results such as
 - more corruption and harder oppression of the poor
 - consulting mediums and fortunetellers to know about their future
 - practicing sacred prostitution and fertility rites

4. The Messiah and the New Jerusalem (Isaiah 2: 1 – 4, 4: 2 – 6, 9: 2 – 7 and 11: 1- 9)

Jerusalem Centre of peace of the world in latter days 2: 1 – 4

- Isaiah 2: 1 is a title of this passage which speaks of certain events which will take place in days to come i.e. the last phase of world's history started with Christ's ascension and which will end with his second coming
- Isaiah says **the mountain on which the temple stands will be the highest in the last days**
- Possibly Isaiah was referring to **Mount Zion**, the hill in Jerusalem on which the temple was built
- The **mountain**, therefore, **symbolizes the worship of Yahweh**
- At first the worship of Yahweh was limited to the Israelites only
- But in days to come, Isaiah says it shall happen that this worship will be extended to all other nations
- Isaiah describes this by saying the mountain where the temple stands will be the highest one of all
- Isaiah added that many nations will come streaming to it
- This means that people of all nations will join in worshipping the God of Israel

- They will all want to be taught God's ways and will walk in his paths.
Verse 3

The result of this will be that

- The Lord will be acknowledged as the judge among all nations.
Verses 3 – 4
- People will turn their instruments of war into instruments for cultivating crops
- Thus Peace will flourish among all nations

The New Jerusalem 4: 2 – 6

- This message was written ,probably, at a time when the people of Jerusalem suffered greatly, possibly around 597 BC or 587BC when they were taken to Babylon

Aim of the passage

- To show that the purpose of God's judgement was not merely to destruct or destroy everything as they could have concluded in chapter 3
- But the aim is to clean and purify
- The nation will be purified through the punishment whereby the wicked people will be destroyed and the faithful ones known as the remnant will remain

Remnant

- This refers to the Jews who will survive all God's punishment (disaster) and remain faithful to the covenant
- In verse 5, clouds, smoke and bright light symbolize God's presence
- Just as the cloud and pillar of fire led the people of God in the time of exodus, God will again lead the remnant
- He will also create a shed, refuge and a shelter for the people to protect them against disaster and evil

The Prince of Peace (The Future King) 9: 1 – 7

- This is a messianic passage
- The land of Zebulun and Naphtali were the Northern tribes of the Northern kingdom
- The region was raided by the Assyrians under Tiglath Pileser III in 732 BC and some people were taken as captives (2 Kings 15:19)
- This is known as Galilean captivity in the time of the New Testament

- The people who walked in darkness in 9:2 refer to the people of Israel and in particular the people Zebulun and Naphtali
- They walked in darkness because they
 - were defeated by the Assyrians (pagans)
 - were exiled in Assyria (a pagan nation)
 - were exposed to and adopted pagan way of living like worshipping idols
 - left their land in ruins
- These people have seen a great light i.e.
 - their liberation by the ideal king
- these people will be joyful because
 - their **yoke** and **rod** will be broken (i.e. their **slavery** and **oppression** will come to an end)
 - God will save them with great power just as He protected the Israelites from the Midianites during the time of king David
 - weapons of war will be destroyed by fire indicating an end to warfare and the beginning of a time of peace vs. 4
 - the ideal king (child) will be born to them

Titles given to the child

1. Wonderful counselor i.e.

- one who is able to give wonderful advice
- one who is exceptionally wise in his plan and purpose
- a ruler with unparallel wisdom

2. Mighty God

- By giving this name to the king, Isaiah showed that he did not have an ordinary human being in mind. Such a name cannot be given to a human being
- The name shows that the king would be a great warrior and would not be defeated
- Mighty God can be translated as hero God

3. Everlasting father

- Again this name shows that the king will be a divine person
- As a king, he will take care of his people like a loving father
- He will be immortal

4. Prince of peace

- Under the government of this king, there will be complete peace and harmony
- His reign will be characterized by peace

Note

- Possibly Isaiah sang this poem in the temple when either Ahaz (735 BC) or Hezekiah (715 BC) was enthroned
 - As such the king refers to either Ahaz or Hezekiah
 - However it is possible that Isaiah sang about the future king (Messiah) since neither Ahaz nor Hezekiah fulfilled the expectations expressed in the song
 - To rule with justice and righteousness means fair, just and impartial treatment
- This poem is often used in the liturgy of Christian churches on Christmas day because they believe that the prophecy of the poem was perfectly fulfilled in the birth and mission of Jesus

The Future Ideal King (The Peaceful Kingdom) 11: 1 – 11

- This is again a messianic passage
- Verse 1 states that branches will grow from the stump
- Here the branches refer to the new king (i.e. Messiah)
- While the stump symbolizes the line of David
- The future king will be called the Messiah
- Messiah is a Hebrew word. In Greek it is Christos from which comes the English word Christ
- Messiah (Christos / Christ) means the anointed one
- According to verse 1 it shows that the Messiah will be a descendant of king David
- Verse 2 shows that the Spirit of Lord will equip the king for his task
- The Spirit of the Lord refers to the power of God acting in nature creating order
- The Holy Spirit is also described as the third person in the Holy Trinity

Fruits of the Holy Spirit

- Because the ideal king will be filled with the Spirit of the Lord, he will do the following
- He will have the knowledge and skill to rule his people

- He will know the Lord's will and honour him
 - He will find pleasure in obeying God
 - He will not judge by appearance or hearsay
 - He will judge the poor fairly
 - He will defend the rights of the helpless
 - He will punish evil people
 - He will rule his people with justice and integrity
-
- Through this king, there will be peace and harmony in nature and among the nations i.e. **universal peace**
 - This peace will start in Judah (Mt. Zion) and will come from the true knowledge of God
 - The universal peace is symbolized by different types of animals staying together in peace which cannot happen under normal circumstances. For example
 - wolves and sheep will live together in peace
 - leopards will lie together with young goats
 - calves and lion cubs will feed together
 - little children will take care of calves and lion cubs
 - cows and bears will eat together
 - calves and cubs will lie down in peace
 - lions will eat straw as cattle do
 - babies will play with poisonous snakes and never be harmed

Prophet Isaiah and King Hezekiah

The prophet Isaiah resumes his ministry

- Isaiah resumed his public ministry soon after Hezekiah had succeeded his father Ahaz as the king of Judah
- Unlike Ahaz, Hezekiah was a man of faith as demonstrated by
 - removing the altar to the Assyrian gods which his father installed in the Temple so as to please Tiglath Pileser III
 - making Jerusalem the centre of worship again
- Possibly Isaiah resumed his work because of Hezekiah's faith

Political background to the meeting between Isaiah and Hezekiah

- Tiglath Pileser III was succeeded by Sargon in 725 BC
- In 722 BC Egypt and Israel instigated a revolt against Assyria
- However the revolt was put down by Sargon in the very same year

- To punish Israel, the Assyrians destroyed Samaria (i.e. in 722BC)
- This marked the end of the Northern Kingdom
- In 712 BC Egypt and Palestine declared war on Assyria again
- As Sargon was busy defending his nation, Hezekiah took his chance to make Judah independent
- It was at this moment that Hezekiah
 - removed the Assyrian altar from the Temple
 - stopped paying annual tribute to Assyria
 - constructed the Siloam tunnel in preparation of a possible siege by Assyrian army
- King Sargon was assassinated in 705 BC and Assyria became weak
- Merodach Baladan of Babylon used this opportunity to revolt and make his country independent

Weaknesses of Hezekiah

- Merodach Baladan sent ambassadors to Hezekiah to seek his support on fighting for independence
- At the same time (705 BC), Tirhakah of Egypt sent ambassadors to Hezekiah to persuade him to join the alliance of Egypt and Babylon against Assyria
- Hezekiah agreed and even tried to force the Philistines to join
- Hezekiah accepted to join the alliance because
 - he hated being subject to Assyria; paying them a heavy tribute and worshipping their gods
 - a strong pro – Egyptian party persuaded him
 - he trusted the alliance against Assyria
- Note that Isaiah had always advised the kings against political alliances and did not agree with the alliances because:
 - By joining the alliance, the kings weakened the faith that it is not the kings but Yahweh who controls history
 - The kings should put their trust in God rather than in alliances
 - Their alliance with foreigners would tempt God's people to adopt foreign religion and their way of life

The Assyrian threat to Jerusalem 36: 1 – 37: 38

- This happened in the fourteenth year of the reign of Hezekiah i.e. in 701 BC
- Sennacherib destroyed 46 fortified cities of Judah and captured them

- Only the city of Jerusalem was left
- Yet Hezekiah did not want to surrender
- Thus Sennacherib ordered his chief official to go from Lachish to Jerusalem with a large military force to demand that King Hezekiah should surrender
- The official (Rabshakeh) occupied the road where the cloth makers work in Jerusalem
- The official delivered his message of threat to the people of Jerusalem through Hezekiah's officials namely:
 - Eliakim (the official in charge of the palace)
 - Shebna (the court secretary) and
 - Joah (the in charge of records)
- The official delivered the speech in the people's own language i.e. in Hebrew
- The purpose of the speech was to undermine the morale, courage, discipline and self confidence of the inhabitants of Jerusalem
- **He did this in the following ways (summary of his speech)**
 1. You are good at talking but you lack power. Mere words are not substitute to military skill and power (36: 5)
 2. Your ally Egypt is weak. Relying on her would be like using a reed as a walking stick (36: 6)
 3. You should not even have confidence in God's protection since your own king has done away with him. (36:7). (They misinterpreted what Hezekiah had done by removing idol gods in the Temple so as to purify the Jewish worship)
 4. Your army is weak compared to ours. (36: 8 – 9)
 5. Your God is using us as his instrument to punish you for your sins (36: 10)
 6. You should not trust Hezekiah or God. Hezekiah deceives you when he tells you to rely on God. (36: 14 – 15)
 7. Our god is stronger than the gods of other nations including your God. We will defeat you just as we had done with other nations and their gods. (36: 18 – 20)
 8. Surrender to Sennacherib and he will treat you well in your own land giving you everything that you need. (36: 16 – 17)

- During the speech, Hezekiah's officials protested that the official should not use Hebrew and asked him to speak Aramaic i.e. the official language
 - They did this because they did not want the people who were sitting around the wall to get the message of threat
 - However the official said he had to speak in Hebrew since the message was for everybody in Jerusalem
- **Reactions of the officials of Hezekiah to the message of threat**
 - They asked the official to speak in Aramaic as seen above
 - They tore their clothes in grief
 - They reported the speech to Hezekiah
- **Reactions of the people to the speech**
 - they all kept quiet as Hezekiah had advised them
- **Hezekiah's reaction to the message**
 - He tore his clothes in grief
 - He put on sack clothes
 - He went to the temple to pray
 - He sent Eliakim, Shebna and senior priests to the prophet Isaiah for an advice

Note

- The first two reactions are signs of sorrowfulness and humility
- The last two reactions are signs of faith in God's protection

Hezekiah's message to Isaiah 37: 3 – 4

- Today is a day of suffering
- We are being punished and are in disgrace
- We are like a woman who is ready to give birth but is too weak to do it
- The Assyrian Emperor through his official has insulted the living God
- May the Lord hear these insults and punish those who spoke them
- Pray to our God for those of our people who survive

Isaiah's answer 37: 5 – 7

- He encouraged Hezekiah not to be afraid of the Assyrian threat; God will save them
- He assured Hezekiah of God's protection by telling him that
- The Lord will cause Sennacherib to hear a rumour that will make him to go back to his own country

- While there the Lord will have him killed

Sennacherib's second message

- At this time Sennacherib's attention was diverted from Judah
- This was so because Tirhakah (a Sudanese / an Ethiopian but king of Egypt) attacked the Assyrians
- Thus Sennacherib and his soldiers decided to go back to defend their nation
- However, before he left, he sent a letter to king Hezekiah to convince him that he should surrender

Message of the letter 37: 10 – 13

- The God you are trusting in has told you that you will not fall into my hands
- But do not let that deceive you
- You have heard what an Assyrian Emperor does to any country he decides to destroy
- Do you think you can escape
- My ancestors destroyed the cities of Gozan, Haran, and Rezeph, and killed the people of Betheden who lived in Telassar
- None of their gods could save them
- Where are the kings of the cities of Hamath, Arpad, Sepharvaim, Hena and Ivvah?

In the letter Sennacherib

- boasted about the Assyrians victories
- tried to undermine Hezekiah's faith in God's protection by saying
 - you cannot rely on Yahweh your God as the gods of Assyrians have proved to be more powerful than any other gods
 - no nation, no god could stop the advance of our great nation; Assyria

Note: This was arrogant. By saying this Sennacherib openly defied / insulted Yahweh, comparing him with idols

Hezekiah's reaction 37: 14 – 20

> When Hezekiah read the letter

1. He took it and went to the temple

2. He placed the letter there in the presence of the Lord

3. Then he prayed saying

- Almighty Lord, God of Israel, enthroned above winged creatures
 - You alone are God, ruling all the kingdoms of the world
 - You created the earth and the sky
 - Now, Lord, hear us and look at what is happening
 - Listen to all the things that Sennacherib is saying to insult you, the living God
 - We all know, Lord, that the emperors of Assyria have destroyed many nations and made them desolate
 - And burnt up their gods; which were not gods at all, but only images of wood and stones made by human hands
 - **Now, Lord, rescue us from the Assyrians so that all nations of the world will know that you alone are God**
- In the prayer Hezekiah pleaded with God to rescue him and his people from Sennacherib

Basis of his plea

- Hezekiah wanted God to rescue them so that all nations of the world may know that only Yahweh, the God of Israel is the true God
- The final reaction of Hezekiah to the message of the letter was that he asked the advice of Isaiah

Isaiah's answer to Sennacherib's message 37: 21 – 30

- The Lord says, the city of Jerusalem (i.e. the chosen people) laughs at you Sennacherib and despises you
- Whom do you think that you have been insulting and ridiculing?
- You have been disrespectful to me, the Holy God of Israel
- You sent your servant to boast to me that
- You had conquered the highest mountains of Lebanon
- You cut down the tallest cedars and finest Cypress trees there
- You reached the deepest parts of the forest
- You dug wells and drank water in foreign lands
- The feet of your soldiers trampled the river Nile dry

BUT

- Have you never heard that I planned all this long ago? And now I have carried it out
- I gave you the power to turn the fortified cities into piles of rubble
- The people who lived there were powerless; they were frightened and stunned

- They were like grass in a field or weeds growing on a roof when the hot east wind blasts them
- But I know everything about you, what you do and where you go
- I know how you rage against me
- I have received reports of that rage and that pride of yours
- Now I will put a hook through your nose and a bite in your mouth and will take you back by the road on which you came 9 referring to Sennacherib)
- All these will happen to show that God is the one who controls history

Signs to prove that the Assyrians will go back to their homeland 37: 30 – 35

- a. After three years, the land of Jerusalem will be cultivated, and Jews will be planting and reaping as if nothing had happened. Vs. 30
- b. Judah will never be destroyed. Some people will survive (remnant). Vs. 31 – 32
- c. Sennacherib will not enter Jerusalem or even shoot a single arrow against it. Vs 33
- d. Sennacherib will go back by the road on which he came. Vs. 34
- e. God himself will defend and protect the city for the sake of his own honour and **because of the promise he made to his servant David**

Fulfillment of the signs given to Hezekiah 37: 36 – 38

- a. An angel of the Lord went to the Assyrian camp and killed 185,000 soldiers. At dawn the next day there they lay, all dead
 - This could very likely be a plague of some kind
 - It happened after Sennacherib had defeated the Egyptians and had come to besiege Jerusalem
 - b. Due to the outbreak of the plague, Sennacherib withdrew and returned to his capital city Nineveh
 - c. One day, as he was worshipping in the temple of his god Nisroch, two of his sons, Adrammelech and Sharezer killed him with their swords and they escaped to the land of Ararat
- Sennacherib was then succeeded by another of his own sons; Esarhaddon

- Note that there are two explanations given as to why Sennacherib went back to his nation
- a. Sennacherib heard a rumour which made him to go back to his own country. 37:7
- b. Sennacherib decided to go back after his soldiers (185, 000) were killed by an angel of the Lord. 37: 36
- Both explanations must be accepted as correct.

Hezekiah's Illness and Recovery 38: 1 – 6, 21 – 22, 7 – 8

- Verse 6 shows that Hezekiah suffered just before or during the Assyrian invasion i.e. 701 BC
- Hezekiah was suffering from **Boils**
- While he was suffering, he received the message from the Lord through Isaiah that
 - he should put everything in the house in order
 - he will not recover
 - he should get ready to die

Reactions of Hezekiah to the message 38: 2 – 3

- He turned his face to the wall
- Then he prayed
 - Remember Lord
 - I have served you faithfully and loyally
 - I have tried to do what you wanted me to do
- And he began to cry bitterly
- NB: Hezekiah appealed to God to extend his life for these reasons. Others add that by that time Hezekiah was still young and had no children

God's reply to Hezekiah's appeal 38: 4 – 6

- Then the Lord commanded Isaiah to go back to Hezekiah and say to him
 - I, the Lord, the God of your ancestors David, have heard your prayer
 - I have seen your tears
 - I will let you live fifteen years longer
 - I will rescue you and this city of Jerusalem from the Emperor of Assyria
 - I will continue to protect this city

Signs to prove that Hezekiah would live fifteen years longer 38: 7 – 8

- The shadow of the declining sun would go back ten steps on the stairway built by King Ahaz, while the sun will not change its position
- Note that the stairway functioned as a sundial

Medication prescribed for Hezekiah 38: 21

- Hezekiah was asked to open the boil
- And then put on it a paste of fig tree

A Visit of Ambassadors from Babylon 39: 1 – 9

- Merodach Baladan was a king of Babylon before Babylon became the world super power
- He sent his envoys to Judah with a letter and presents

Reasons

- His apparent reason was to congratulate Hezekiah on his recovery from illness and give presents
- His real reason was to ask Hezekiah to join him against Assyria

How did Hezekiah receive the ambassadors?

- He welcomed them with joy
- He showed them everything i.e. all his wealth such as
 - His silver and gold
 - His spices and perfume
 - All his military equipment
- There was nothing in his store rooms / kingdom that he did not show them

Reasons for doing this

- He felt flattered by the visit of ambassadors from a great nation
- He hoped to impress the ambassadors by showing off his wealth and weapons
- He wanted to gain favourable terms for the alliance

Isaiah's reaction to what Hezekiah did 39: 5 – 7

- He was against what Hezekiah had done
- And predicted that due to what Hezekiah had done the Lord says
 - Everything in your palace, everything that your ancestors have stored up to this day will be carried off to Babylon
 - Some of your own direct descendants will be taken away to Babylon in exile

- While in exile, some of your own direct descendants will be made Eunuchs to serve in the palace of the kings of Babylon

Hezekiah's reaction to Isaiah's prediction / prophecy 39:8

- Hezekiah understood this to mean that there would be peace and security during his lifetime, so he replied, **"The message you have given me from the Lord is good"**
- Its meaning is ambiguous since it could mean
 - I accept the will of God **or**
 - I am happy that it will not happen during my lifetime but after my death

* Note that this prophesy was fulfilled in 587 BC; more than 100 years after it was made

Main message of First Isaiah

- Rebuked sins: Isaiah rebuked the sins of Judah and Israel such as rebelling against God, injustice
- Call for repentance: God, through Isaiah repeatedly called upon the people to repent their sins so that they should walk in God's ways
- Predicted judgement: Isaiah told them that because of their disobedience to God, they will be taken as captives in a foreign land
- Gave a message of hope: Although the people will be taken as captives in a foreign, there will be a few who will come back (Remnants)

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Bible Knowledge

form 3

Chapter 3

THE WORK OF PROPHET ISAIAH - SECOND (DEUTERO) ISAIAH

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THE WORK OF PROPHET ISAIAH - SECOND (DEUTERO) ISAIAH

OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, the student should be able to:

- Describe the work of Second Isaiah
- Examine the main messages of Second Isaiah

CONTENTS

- analyse the work of Second (Deutero) Isaiah
 - discussing the work of Second (Deutero) Isaiah
 - message of hope for the exiles
 - Cyrus as an instrument of salvation
 - God's condemnation of idolatry
 - judgement on Babylon
 - the servant songs
 - God's invitation
 - identifying the main message of Second (Deutro) Isaiah
 - call for the return
 - attack on idolatry
 - the Lord's Servant

Background Information

- Towards the end of the 8th Century BC, Isaiah predicted that one all the treasures and the people of Judah would be sent to Babylon Is. 39:6
- The prophecy was fulfilled some 100 years later i.e. in 587 BC
- When Isaiah made this prophecy, **Hezekiah** was the king of Judah
- During the reign of Hezekiah the Assyrians failed to capture Jerusalem (refer to the events of 701BC)
- Hezekiah was succeeded by **Manasseh**
- It was during the reign of Manasseh that the Assyrians got control of Judah and made it a vassal state
- Manasseh ruled from 687 – 642 BC
- Later the Jews were ruled by **Josiah** i.e. 640 – 609 BC
- During Josiah's reign the Babylonians and Sythians combined their forces and defeated the Assyrians
- The Babylonian Empire then became the world super power
- Note that as the Assyrians were fighting against the Babylonians, Josiah had the opportunity to make his country independent
- He stopped paying tribute to the Assyrians and at the same time purified the Jewish religion (2Kgs 22: 8 - - 13; 23: 1 – 8)
- As the Babylonians were extending their power, the Egyptians decided to join forces with the Assyrians against the Babylonians. (Up to this time the Egyptians and Assyrians were enemies)
- Judah was on the side of Babylon
- AS they were fighting (i.e. **Egypt & Assyria** against **Babylon & Judah**), Pharaoh Necho II of Egypt defeated Judah's army and killed Josiah in 609 BC

- Necho made Josiah's son **Jehoiakim** king of Judah to take the side of Egypt
- In 605 BC Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon defeated Necho at Carchemist

- To punish Judah for siding with Egypt, Nebuchadnezzar forced Jews to pay a heavy tribute to him
- In 601 BC, the Egyptians gained power and defeated Babylonians in Palestine
- Following this Judah stopped paying tribute to the Babylonians again
- Jehoiakim was killed during the battle in 598 BC and was succeeded by **Jehoiachin**
- In 597 BC, Nebuchadnezzar regained his power and sent an army to Jerusalem to punish her for stopping to pay tribute to her
- To avoid total disaster, Jehoiachin surrendered and was taken into exile with all men of military age and all skilled craftsmen
- In exile, Jehoiachin was treated very well, his status as the king was respected
- In Jerusalem Nebuchadnezzar made **Zedekiah** (Josiah's third son) king to replace Jehoiachin
- Unfortunately, Zedekiah asked Egyptians help against Babylon so as to rescue his relatives
- When Nebuchadnezzar learnt about this he punished Zedekiah by destroying Jerusalem and its Temple, and took many Jews into exile
- Only the poorest were allowed to remain behind
- This happened in 587 BC
- Note that the prophecies of Deutero Isaiah were uttered in Babylon towards the end of exile in 540 BC.

Religious life of the Jews in exile

- The prophecies contained in Isaiah 40 -55 were addressed to the Jews, many of whom were questioning the adequacy and relevance of their religious faith
- Their faith was based on the event of exodus
- From this event Jews knew God as the one who
- chose them and delivered them from Egypt
- made a covenant with them at Mount Sinai
- had given them the land of Canaan as their own
- had chosen Jerusalem and its Temple as his dwelling place
- made a covenant with the line of king David that they should rule over the kingdom forever
- controls history

- The exile of many Jews to Babylon was, therefore, a challenge to their faith and belief. For instance
 - How could God abandon his chosen people and let them be defeated by a nation who worshipped other gods?
 - How could God let Jerusalem and its temple (the place he had chosen as his dwelling place) be in ruins and all the Temple treasures plundered?
 - In this situation, some Jews felt that their own religious tradition was inadequate or even irrelevant
 - Thus such people felt that they were taken into exile just because either
 - Their God was weak compared to the god of Babylonians. Or
 - their God had abandoned them

Despite the challenges, Jews' faith in Yahweh did not die out. Their faith was kept and maintained because of the following reasons

i. Community life

- While in exile the Babylonians allowed them to stay together
- This enabled them to follow their rituals and customs such as; observing the Laws of Moses, circumcision, observing the Sabbath, abstaining from unclean food etc

ii. The experience their ancestors had

- While in exile, the Jews retold the traditional stories of their ancestors such as Abraham, Moses, David etc and they put them in writing
- The writings were arranged and edited (**This was the birth of the Bible**)
- The stories encouraged the Jews in exile to maintain their faith in God

iii. Prophets

- Their faith was also maintained because they had prophets like Ezekiel and Deutero Isaiah who encouraged them not to lose their faith in God

Note

- As regards the Sabbath observation, Jews simply used to gather at one place every Sabbath Day to worship the Lord. (They were missing the temple)
- This marked the **origin of the Synagogue** which means **gathering together**

Social life of the Jews in exile

- In Babylon Jews were allowed to stay together in communities
 - They were not free to leave the country but were not slaves as such
 - They enjoyed freedom of movement and association (thus they learned Aramaic the language of their captors)
- The Jews were also free to earn their living in any way they wanted
 - As a result, some of them became good farmers and business people
 - Others got jobs at Kings' palaces (These were the ones that were made eunuchs)
 - Others became scribes, tinsmiths etc
- however at times, they were treated cruelly by the Babylonians (Is. 47 : 16)

1. The return to Jerusalem/ (Deutero Isaiah's vision and ministry) 40: 1 – 11

- This passage describes the experience Isaiah had when he had a vision of God's heavenly court and heard God speaking to him
- God's message to Isaiah can be summarized into five main points namely

a. To comfort the Jews 40: 1- 2

- These verse describe the specific mission given to Isaiah
- His mission was to comfort the Jews (as the Lord said, comfort the Jews, comfort them)
- They had to be comforted because God had punished them in full for their sins by
 - sending them into exile
 - letting them be treated harshly, at times, by the Babylonians
 - missing their Temple
- As a result, God has forgiven all their sins
- This shows that the exile was a punishment, a sin that Yahweh was concerned about his people just like parents punish their children which shows that they care about them

b. To prepare the Jews for their return 40: 3 - 5

- The other mission was to announce the imminence / nearness of salvation for the exiled Jews in Babylon
- That is, to announce that their return to Judah was near
- A way was prepared in the desert to make their return easy
- A smooth, straight and level highway was built to allow Jews return easily and surely
- This meant that God will lead his people and as such no opposition will prevent God's plan of saving the Jews

c. To announce that their return will manifest God's glory 40 : 5

- God's glory is seen when suffering and oppression cease or come to an end
- For example, in the first exodus God's glory was seen when God delivered his people from Egyptian slavery
- Similarly, when the Jews will be led out of Babylonian captivity, Jews oppression by the Babylonians will come to an end and hence reveal God's glory

d. To announce that their return will also reveal God's greatness in contrast to man's weakness 40: 6 – 8

- A voice from heaven asked Isaiah to proclaim that all human beings are like grass
- They last no longer than wild flower
- Grass withers and fades but God and his word endure forever

Note

- In exile Jews thought that history was controlled by men
- The voice of Cyrus to set them free from Babylonians confirmed this
- However, here, they were told that even Cyrus was like grass that passes away (He is mortal)
- Instead it was God who acted in him.
- As such Jews will be set free by God Himself and not Cyrus

e. To announce that the exiles will be led home by God himself 40: 9 – 11

- Isaiah was asked to tell the people to proclaim that their sovereign Lord was coming with the people he has rescued
- On their way, he will take care of them like a good shepherd
- He will lead them with power (strength) and gentleness

Strength and gentleness

- These are qualities of a good shepherd
- A shepherd must be strong enough to protect the flock from wild animals
- At the same time, he must be gentle towards the young, the weak and those that have strayed
- God will lead them like a good shepherd
- And Jesus identified himself with such a good shepherd

Verses 12 – 17

- These point out the picture of Yahweh as the incomparable God
- That is to say God has no equal
- His majesty cannot be measured
- From these verses one can conclude that the return of the Jews will surely happen because God is always all wise and all mighty
- In addition, He is the Lord of all nations
- No might of nation or human wisdom can thwart his plan to bring the exiles home

Note

- Creation is a proof that God is great
- God does not need instructions or advices
- The glory and power of earthly nations like Babylon are nothing as compared to God's glory and power
- Yahweh is so great that He is never praised enough even when all trees and animals of Lebanon are sacrificed to honour Him

2. The rise of Cyrus to power (Historical Background)

- While the Babylonians were ruling the Southern part of the Old Assyrian empire, the Medes were in control of the North
- For about 70 years, these two empires existed side by side without openly fighting each other
- The kings of Medes; **Xerxes** and **Astrages** were too busy to gain power over neighbouring nations to be concerned with affairs in the Babylonian empire
- Yet the Babylonians did not usually interfere in the affairs of the Medes Empire except in **585 BC** when Nebuchadnezzar prevented the Medes from seizing the kingdom of Syria in the area now known as Lydia

- However, in **550 BC** major changes came
- Astrages led the Medes army against the Elamites who were ruled , at that time, by a Persian king Cyrus
- The attack was disastrous for Medes since Cyrus was too popular and powerful to be defeated. Thus he drove off the Medes and conquered them in their own territory
- Then Cyrus claimed authority over the Median Empire at **ECBATANA** their capital
- Nabonidus, king of Babylon, feared that Cyrus would go on to attack his empire as well
- Thus he formed a defense league with Amasis of Egypt and Croesus of Lydia (who were friendly to Babylon)
- Cyrus first captured Sardis, capital of Lydia, in **547 BC**
- Then he turned eastwards and captured large areas of territory including the country now known as Afghanistan
- In **539 BC**, Cyrus made a direct attack on Babylon
- By this time, Nabonidus had become very unpopular because of the following reasons
 - He was not a descendant of the Chaldeans from Haran
 - He failed to give supreme honour to the god Marduk since he preferred to worship the moon goddess whose Temple was in Haran
- **Cyrus defeated the Babylonians at OP's on the river Tigris in 539 BC**
- The Babylonians welcomed Cyrus as a great hero and as a servant of the god Marduk
- Cyrus himself had a story of his victory recorded on a stone Cylinder known as "**Cyrus Cylinder**"
- According to this inscription Marduk has "scored all the lands for a friend seeking for the upright prince whom it would have taken his hand." He called Cyrus king of the Ashan. He nominated him to be ruler

Note

- When Cyrus conquered the Babylonians in 539 BC **he gave a decree that**
 - Jews were free to go back to their homeland
 - They should rebuild the city and its Temple
 - They should take back the Temple treasures plundered by Nebuchadnezzar

- They should get some money from the royal treasury for rebuilding the city and its temple
- The Jews who were unwilling to return should contribute a certain amount of money
- The Jews should be led by Shesh - bazzar

The question is, if Cyrus did not know Yahweh, why did he allow the Jews to go back to their homeland?

- He wanted to encourage people to worship their local gods
- He was possibly an outstanding good person
- He had a vast empire and felt that he could keep it together if he was considered a friend
- He believed that the gods of other nations would protect him if he encouraged their worship

The lord appoints Cyrus 45: 1 – 8

- In this passage Isaiah says
- The Lord has chosen Cyrus to be king
- He has appointed him to conquer nations
- He sends him to strip kings of their power
- The lord will open gates of cities for him

To Cyrus the Lord says

- I myself will prepare your way, leveling mountains and hills
- I will break down bronze gates and smash their iron bars
- I will give you treasures from dark, secret places
- Then you will know that I, the Lord, the God of Israel has chosen you
- I appoint you to help my servant Israel although you do not know me
- I am the Lord, there is no other God
- I will give you strength you need although you do not know me
- I do this so that everyone from one end of the world to the other may know that I am the Lord and there is no other god
- I create both light and darkness, I bring both blessing and disaster
- I will send victory from the sky like rain, the earth will open to receive it and will blossom with freedom and justice

Fear of the Jews and God's Assurance Isaiah 41: 1 – 20

- **Cyrus victories under God's control 41: 1 – 7**

- The one from the east is Cyrus (vs.2) just because Persia lies to the east of Jerusalem
- It is Yahweh who has raised up Cyrus to be his agent for delivering his people, Israel
- To achieve his goal, God made him victorious and triumphant over kings and nations
- Thus his sword strikes them down as if they were dust
- And his arrows scatter them like straw before the wind
- He marches safely on, so fast that he hardly touches the ground

Note

- God says he has raised Cyrus to show that he controls history
- He has done so in the past,, he does so now and will do so in the future
- Distant lands i.e. all nations of the earth saw Cyrus becoming powerful and conquering nations vs. 5

Reactions of the nations to Cyrus victories

- They were frightened and trembled with fear
- They all assembled i.e. made alliances against Cyrus
- They also made idols and offered sacrifices to them so as to protect them from Cyrus

➤ **Israel should not be afraid of Cyrus 41: 8 – 13**

- In this passage Yahweh expresses his favour towards the Jews by telling them that in the past he had chosen Abraham their ancestor and now has chosen Abraham's descendants as his own people (or as his servant)
- As such, Israel (Jews) should not be afraid; God is with them and will defend them
- God will do this because
 - He chose them as his own people
 - He keeps his promise made to their ancestors (I am your God)
 - He does not abandon his people in their exile
 - He will make them stronger than any adversary

➤ **Isaiah 41: 14**

- In this verse God says although Israel is weak, small and defenseless, God will make her strong and powerful
- Thus God will even use her to fulfill his plan of salvation

➤ **Isaiah 41: 15**

- God will use Israel like a threshing board i.e. a heavy wooden board studded with sharp metal teeth on one side and used for crushing the grain separating it from the chaff
- As such the expression means that God will use Israel as his instrument for separating the good people from the bad ones on earth

In Isaiah 44: 21 – 28, the Lord says “Israel remember this You are my servant”

- In this passage Isaiah says that Yahweh is the all – wise creator
- His wisdom are wise and have to be trusted
- He has chosen Cyrus so as to fulfill his purpose of releasing the Jews

Reasons that God gives for Israel to return to God are as follows:

- They are a servant of God
- God created her
- God has forgiven their sins
- God has saved her

God’s reaction to false beliefs to show that He alone is all wise

- He makes fools of fortunetellers
- He frustrates the prediction of astrologers
- He refutes the words of the wise
- He turns their wisdom into foolishness

Concerning Jerusalem God predicted that

- People will live there again
- Cities of Judah will be rebuilt
- Cities of Judah will raise from ruins
- Cyrus will order Jerusalem to be rebuilt

Jews reaction to the choice of Cyrus as God’s instrument 45: 9 – 13

- The Jews found it difficult to accept God’s decision
- They asked each other as to why Yahweh chose a gentile and not a Jew
- They could hardly accept that God
 - chosen a pagan as is instrument
 - given him a mission, calling his name

- anointed a pagan as his agent
- given him power to conquer nations
- made him a shepherd

- In this passage, Isaiah condemns sternly those who doubt or question God's wisdom
- Isaiah uses two images to show that it is foolish or improper to question God's decision
- The images or comparisons are: the clay pot and the potter & the child and its parents
- **The clay pot and the potter**
- First Isaiah compares God to a potter making an earthly vessel or a jar
- The potter is absolutely free to make any kind of jar he wishes
- The clay /pot (i.e. people) he uses has nothing to say about it

- **The child and its parents**
- Secondly, Isaiah says God is like parents
- Just as children cannot ask parents why they were made like that, so too with people to God
- God is like parents and so his plan for Israel and the world cannot be questioned

- In addition **the prophet says God is holy** i.e. He is totally different from human beings
- His thoughts are not like those of human beings; as such no one can question him
- God has chosen Cyrus to fulfill his purpose and put things right

Chapters 40 – 55 mention Cyrus in various ways like

The conqueror from the east	Since Persia lies to the east of Jerusalem
A man who attacks from the North	As he was active in the North against Media & Lydia
The one who will rule for me	Since God uses Cyrus to save his people
Chosen to be king	Cyrus is God's anointed as he fulfills God's purpose

Appointed to conquer	Yahweh gave him power to fulfill his plan
Grass	To prove that Cyrus too was mortal and will pass away

3. God condemns Idolatry (Isaiah 44:9-20, 45:20 – 25)

IDOLATRY

- Idolatry is the practice of worshipping false gods i. e. idols
- Idols are images of gods fabricated by human beings and used as objects for worship

Reasons why some Jews started worshipping idols in exile in Babylon

- **Lack of faith**
 - Some Jews felt that their God was weak as compared to Marduk the god of the Babylonians
 - As a result they wanted to worship a stronger god
- **Intermarriages**
 - Possibly some Jews married Babylonians and as a result they were forced by their spouses to worship Marduk
- **A visible god**
 - Possibly they wanted to worship a god whom they could see since their God was invisible
- **Attraction**
 - The temple of the Babylonians' god was well decorated and their temple processions were attractive

In Chapters 40 – 55 Isaiah says Yahweh alone is the only true God; idols are not gods at all. Reasons

- **In Isaiah 41 : 21 – 29**
 - Only Yahweh knows past and future events
 - Only Yahweh knows the meaning of events
 - Only Yahweh performs signs and wonders (miracles) which inspire admiration and awe
 - It is Yahweh and not any other god who controls Cyrus

- Idols cannot predict Cyrus' victories
- Idols cannot speak, hear, see, etc
- Idol worship is disgusting
- Idols are weak and powerless

➤ **In Isaiah 44 : 6 – 8**

- Only Yahweh claims that He alone is God
- Only Yahweh foretells the future and makes it pass
- Only Yahweh controls history

➤ **In Isaiah 45 : 20 – 25**

Yahweh alone is God. Thus Jews are asked not to follow Marduk. Isaiah says

- There is no god but Yahweh
- Yahweh keeps his promise to save
- All nations will come to Him
- Those who cling to Yahweh will be honoured; but all those who hate him will suffer disgrace

Thus Isaiah says to worship idols is foolish / nonsense / stupid / ridiculous/ meaningless

Reasons as found in Isaiah 44: 9 – 20

- Idols are man made: Can a human being (a creature) create a God (a creator)?
- Some idols are made from the same piece of wood which one uses as firewood or other furniture
- Idols are made from the very same things which were created by God Himself
- Thus worshipping such things is blasphemous and absurd

How were idols made?

➤ **Through a metal worker**

- The metal worker takes a piece of metal and works with it over fire
- His strong arm swings a hammer to pound the metal into shape of a desired idol god

➤ **Through a carpenter**

- The carpenter measures the wood
- He outlines a figure with chalk
- He carves it out with his tool and makes it in the form of a man, a handsome human figure to be placed in his house

Reasons why Isaiah strongly condemned Idolatry

- Idolatry hurt his personal love for God
- He did not want the Jews to believe in the idols of Babylonians
- To comfort the Jews by letting them know that their God is still the only living God

Examples of idols worshipped today include:

- Charms - items - witchcraft
- Wealth - individuals - amulets
- Spouses - fashion - etc

Reasons why some people today are afraid of abandoning idolatrous practices

- Fear of losing their status in society
- Fear of losing wealth
- Fear of losing life
- Fear of being lame
- Fear of being disturbed
- Fear of going mad

4. Babylonian Pride and Humiliation 47: 1 – 15

Babylon

- This is a name of a place
- This is also a symbol of people who are proud and self – righteous
- Is expressed as a **virgin because**
 - She had never been conquered
 - God was using her as His agent to punish His people for their sins

Note

- In this passage God is announcing the downfall of Babylon
- This happened at a time when Babylon was still rich and strong
- The prediction possibly inspired the exiles with hope and gave them comfort

Charges against Babylon (their sins / accusations)

- **Cruelty** in the sense that they over-punished the Jews especially the aged

- **Pride** in the sense that they were boasting about their civilization and thought that none of the nations would reach their standard
- **She thought that she was as everlasting as Yahweh Himself.** (This was an insult to God who alone is everlasting)
- **Seeking a life of pleasure**
- **Sorcery and divination:** They believed in the power of the magicians and astrologers

Her punishment

- She will be conquered by Cyrus
- She will be ashamed to lose her wealth and freedom
- Most of her members will die during the war
- Some parts of Babylon will be in ruins
- The magicians and astrologers will no longer help them

1. Servant Songs

- These are poems sang by Isaiah of Babylon concerning the Servant and his mission
- These poems are; 42: 1 – 7 ; 49: 1 – 6 ; 50: 4 – 9 and 52: 13 – 53 : 12

Aims of the songs

- To answer the questions of faithlessness and hopelessness of the Jews in exile
- While in exile, Jews lost their faith in God as the one who could save them
- Jews felt that their God was weak as compared to Marduk, hence they were tempted to abandon their God
- In the songs, Isaiah shows that God has still got the power to save his people
- However, He saves his people not in the way earthly kings save their people by using weapons of war
- Instead he saves people through the suffering of his servant

Identities of the servant and reasons

- **Israel**
- Some scholars feel the servant refers to Israel as a nation but personified as an individual
- This is because Deutero Isaiah refers to God's people as servant

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- For example in 41: 8 Isaiah says, "You, Israel, my servant; in 44:1 Isaiah says, "Listen now Israel my servant" and in 49:3 he says, "Israel you are my servant
- The servant is the one who suffers. And the exiled Jews did suffer. Thus as a group they may well stand for the suffering servant
- **The remnant**
 - Other scholars identify the servant with the remnant i.e. the faithful Jews who survived wars and exile
 - This is because in Isaiah 49: 6 (i.e. second servant song), the servant is told to bring the scattered people back to Yahweh
 - The faithful Jews must bring back those who have become unfaithful
 - As such the servant is part of God's people, the faithful ones or the remnant
- **An individual**
 - Other scholars (NJBC pp 1169) feel the servant is a historical person
 - This is because his characteristics are so personal that they appear to refer to a person rather than a community
 - This person could be a representative of the Jews such as an unknown person who lived before second Isaiah or a contemporary of Second Isaiah, Second Isaiah, Cyrus Shesh bazzar etc
- **The Messiah**
 - Others feel the servant refers to the Messiah, someone still to come
 - Christians identify this messiah with Jesus.
 - This is because most of what was said about the servant happened to Jesus. For Instance
 - He was filled with the Holy Spirit
 - God was pleased with him
 - He brought light (salvation) to all nations
 - He was flogged, mocked, spat upon and pulled his beard
 - He was sentenced to death and died like a criminal through crucifixion
 - He rose from the dead

The first Servant Song

- **Speaker**

- In this song the speaker is Yahweh
- **Description / characteristics / qualities of the servant**
 - He is filled with the Holy Spirit vs. 1
 - He will not shout or raise his voice i.e. he will not complain when he faces problems
 - He will not break off a bent reed or put out a flickering lamp i.e. He will be kind to the weak and poor vs. 3
 - He will not lose hope or courage vs. 4
 - He will be gentle , non- violent
- **Mission /task of the Servant**
 - **To bring justice and righteousness to all nations.** In addition
 - To bring light to all nations
 - To set free those who sit in dark prison
 - To open eyes of the blind
- **How did God prepare the servant for his mission?**
 - God poured His Spirit on him
 - God gave him power and strength
- **What is astonishing in the song?**
 - The servant does not complain about his condition
- **Comparison of the Servant with Jesus**
 - Like the servant, Jesus was filled with the Holy Spirit
 - Like the servant, God was also pleased with Jesus
 - Like the servant, Jesus was kind to the poor and the weak
 - Like the servant, Jesus did not complain when he faced problems
 - Like the servant, Jesus did not lose hope or courage

The Second Servant Song 49: 1 – 6

- **Speaker**
 - In this song the speaker is the servant himself
- **Description / characteristics / qualities of the servant**
 - He expresses himself powerfully
 - He is a pillar of strength because of His faith in God

- He knows the goal of his life

- **Mission / task of the Servant**
 - **To bring light to all nations i.e. to save all people (Jews and Gentiles alike).** In addition
 - To bring the scattered Jews back to the Lord

- **How did God prepare the servant for his mission?**
 - God chose him before he was born i.e. from the very beginning of Israel's history which is the call of Abraham
 - God made his word as sharp as a sword
 - God made him like an arrow sharp and ready for use
 - God protected him

- **What is astonishing in the song?**
 - He believes salvation is universal including for the Babylonians their oppressors

- **Comparison of the Servant with Jesus**
 - Jesus too was chosen before he was born
 - Jesus too proclaimed the good news of salvation to both Jews and gentiles

The Third Servant Song 50: 4 – 9

- **Speaker**
 - In this song the speaker is the servant himself

- **Description / characteristics / qualities of the servant**
 - He listens to God every morning so as to know his will
 - He is obedient to God even if it is the will of God that he suffers
 - He is strong, determined and fearless

- **Mission / task of the servant**
 - **To strengthen the weary (i.e. those who have lost their faith in God because of suffering) through his own suffering**
 - The servant will suffer in the following:

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- he will be beaten / flogged
- he will be insulted
- he will be pulled his beard
- he will be spat in his face

Note: Such sufferings will enable the servant to strengthen others because sufferings make one a good master

➤ **How did God prepare the servant for his mission? The sovereign Lord**

- taught him what to say
- made him eager to listen to the word of God
- defended him
- gave him a spirit of understanding
- gave him help
-
- protected him

➤ **What is astonishing in the song?**

- He suffers pain and shame without resisting
- Despite the suffering he considers himself innocent saying
 - i. he cannot be disgraced
 - ii. nobody can prove him guilty
 - iii. his accusers will disappear

➤ **Comparison of the servant with Jesus**

- Like the servant, Jesus too was flogged
- Like the servant, Jesus too was insulted
- Like the servant, Jesus too was pulled his beard
- Like the servant, Jesus too was spat in his face

The Fourth Servant Song 52: 13 – 53: 12

➤ **Speaker**

- In 52: 13 – 15 and 53: 10 – 12, the speaker is Yahweh while
- In 53: 1 – 9 it is the people (i.e. Jews or gentiles) who are speaking

➤ **Description / characteristics / qualities of the servant**

- He does not look attractive or successful
- Affliction puts its stamp on him
- He does not complain or defend himself
- He is honest
- He is sincere
- He is truthful / trustworthy

➤ **Mission / task of the servant**

- **To accept to be looked upon as a sinner so as to save true sinners**

- **His sufferings**

- He was ignored / despised to death
- He was treated harshly
- He was beaten
- He was arrested
- He was sentenced to death
- He was led off to die
- he was crucified

➤ **How did God prepare the servant for his mission?**

- God never abandoned him
- God was near him
- God strengthened him

➤ **What is astonishing in the song?**

- He does not complain about his suffering
- He rose from the dead and was given the dignity next to God himself

➤ **Comparison of the servant with Jesus**

- Jesus too was despised and rejected by his fellow Jews
- Jesus was treated harshly before Pilate
- Jesus was beaten
- Jesus was arrested
- Jesus was sentenced to death
- Jesus was led off to die
- Jesus was crucified
- Jesus rose from the dead

Note:

➤ **The servant songs portray the following themes**

i. Justice

- i.e. there is need to be truthful and obedient to God's law by protecting the poor

ii. Universalism

- i.e. God offers salvation to both Jews and gentiles

iii. Suffering

- i.e. God will save his people through the suffering of his servant

iv. Triumphant glory

- i.e. After death, the servant will be glorified and given the dignity next to God himself

Purpose of suffering

- To save sinners
- To strengthen the weary
- To show that suffering is not necessarily a result of sin (s)

Why was the idea of the suffering servant relevant to the Jews in exile?

- It encouraged them to accept their sufferings with the hope that other people would benefit salvation out of that
- It prepared them to accept the Messiah as a suffering one and not triumphant
- It made them believe that suffering is not necessarily a sign of sins as they had believed before

2. God's invitation; "Come for all is ready" 55: 1 – 9

- This passage contains the last recorded words of Isaiah of Babylon
- It must have been composed in 540 BC shortly before Persian conquest of Babylon in 539 BC
- The style is triumphant i.e. it is a joyful invitation addressed to the Jewish exile in Babylon to accept the gift of salvation offered to them by Yahweh

Summary of God's invitation

- Come everyone who is thirsty; here is water
- Come you that have no money; buy corn and eat
- Come buy wine and milk; it will cost you nothing
- Why spend money on what does not satisfy? Why spend your wages and still be hungry?
- Listen to me and do what I say, and you will enjoy the best food of all
- Come to me and you will have life! I will make a lasting covenant with you and give you the blessings I promised to David
- And foreign nations will come running to join you

Who are invited?

- The Jews in exile

- The gentiles who will come to Jerusalem to learn from the Jews about God and his plan for them
- People of all generations

To what are the people invited

- To God's banquet
- The people are invited to buy water, corn, milk and wine: **these refer to salvation**
- The fact that the people will buy them without money shows that God offers salvation to people as a free gift
- Therefore God's banquet refers to God's care for his people / necessities of life
- As such the people are invited to God's salvation

Note

- The salvation is a free gift from God to his people and the salvation is meant for all people : Jews and Gentiles alike

What should one do so as be saved?

- One should listen to the Lord
- One should repent and obey the Lord
- One should establish a lasting covenant with God
- One should always be near God and pray to him
- One should do these without hesitation or delay since delay is fatal

The main message of Second Isaiah

- Calls for the return of the exiled Israelites
- Attacks idol worshipping of the exiled people
- Describes Yahweh's servant
- Assures people of God's fulfillment of his promises

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Chapter 4

THE WORK OF PROPHET ISAIAH - THIRD (TRITO) ISAIAH

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THE WORK OF PROPHET ISAIAH - THIRD (TRITO) ISAIAH

OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, the student should be able to:

- Analyse the work of Third Isaiah
- State the main message of Third Isaiah



CONTENTS

- The work of Third (Trito) Isaiah
 - universal salvation
 - bad leadership
 - people's complaint and God's answer
 - the good news of deliverance
- identifying the main message of Third (Trito) Isaiah
 - universal salvation
 - conditions for the return of the exiles
 - message of restoration

Historical background

- It is believed that Trito – Isaiah was written after the return from Babylon until after rebuilding the Temple

Their return

- When Cyrus came to power and controlled Babylon in 539 BC he gave a decree that Jews were free to go back to their land and rebuild the city and its Temple (refer notes on page 32)
- Following the decree Jews returned in two groups
 - **First return:** This happened in 538 BC and they were led by Shesh bazzar
 - **Second return:** This happened in 522BC. They were encouraged by prophets Haggai and Zechariah and were led by Zerubbabel

Note

- In total only about 50,000 Jews returned

Why only so few Jews returned? There are so many possible reasons like

i. Distance

- Palestine was too far away (700 miles i.e. 1,500 km) from Babylon
- It was a long journey for the aged and young ones

ii. Intermarriages

- Some of the Jews married Babylonians and so had lost their faith in God and hence were unwilling to leave their spouses

iii. Riches

- Most of the Jews were well established and had become very rich as a result were unwilling to leave their riches

iv. Unknown land

- Most of the Jews who lived at that time were born and brought up in Babylon
- They did not know Jerusalem as such they were unwilling to go to a land which was unknown to them

v. Uncertain future

- Most Jews were unwilling to go to Jerusalem and rebuild its city and temple while its future was uncertain

Life in Jerusalem after the exile

- Life was not as glorious and joyful as Deutero Isaiah had announced in Babylon.
- They faced many problems like
 - i. Jerusalem and Judah were in ruins
 - ii. There was shortage of food. (Haggai says this was so as a punishment from God since people were unwilling to rebuild the Temple. Hag. 1: 9 – 11; 2: 15 – 17)
 - iii. The Jews found the Samaritans unfriendly and so refused their help in rebuilding the Temple. Ezra 4: 1 – 3
 - iv. The native Jews were hostile and looked upon the land as theirs Ezra 4: 4 – 5
 - ii. The Jews from Babylon were proud; they regarded themselves as the true Israelites and looked upon the resident Jews and Samaritans as unclean
 - iii. The Jews from exile were divided. Some understood God's plan as fulfilled in the punishment of the exile. Others did not. Hence lack of leadership, idolatry and social injustice
 - iv. Politically the Jews were not fully independent. They only had semi – independence under a governor appointed by Cyrus (Is. 56: 9; 57: 13)
 - v. Religious syncretism. The majority of the resident population mixed the worship of pagans with that of Yahweh (Nehemiah 13: 23 ff)
 - vi. Resident Jews were speaking Hebrew while Jews from exile spoke Aramaic
 - vii. Judah was very poor

Note

- Jews from exile faced many problems as seen above
- This was contrary to what Second Isaiah had promised them
- Thus they questioned God why this was the case
- Hence the topics of Isaiah 56 – 66 deal with the disappointments, fear, doubts and challenges of the Jews after exile.

1. The problem of admission of foreigners and eunuchs in the Temple 56: 1 – 8

- **When did this problem arise**
 - As soon as the Jews had completed rebuilding the Temple and was ready for the worship to take place in it i.e. in 515 BC

- The problem was whether foreigners and eunuchs should be welcomed into the community and be allowed to worship God with the pious Jews who had returned from exile in the Temple or not

➤ **Who were foreigners?**

- These were non – Jews / gentiles / uncircumcised people
- According to the Jewish Law, non – Jews residing in Palestine could become Israelites through adoption after some years;
- For example, three years for Egyptians and Edomites, ten years for Ammonites
- While Canaanites were simply excluded

➤ **Who were eunuchs?**

- These were castrated Jews
- They might have been servants in the royal household in Babylon (Isaiah 39: 7)

➤ **Why was it a problem to accept them into the Temple?**

- This was because foreigners were considered as unclean
- The eunuchs were considered as

- i. Unclean according to the prophet Haggai (Haggai 2 : 10 – 14)
- ii. Useless (dry trees) since they could not contribute to God's population
- iii. People who had no respect for body integrity / wholeness since they mutilated part of their bodies

Due to these, the pious Jews felt their presence in the Temple would make the Temple worship unclean and unacceptable to God

➤ **How did God (the prophet) solve the problem? 56: 1 – 8**

- The prophet said that foreigners and eunuchs had to be accepted into the Temple because
- Salvation is universal i.e. it is meant for Jews as well as gentiles and sinners
 - The Temple is a house of prayer for all nations (people: sinners or not)

Note

- However, Isaiah said that such foreigners and eunuchs should be ready to follow the following rules and regulations

Rules for the foreigners

- They should honour God by observing the Sabbath
- They should do what pleases God

- They should faithfully keep God's covenant

Rules for the Eunuchs

- They should do what is just and right
- They should avoid evil at all times
- They should observe the Sabbath day
- They should faithfully keep God's covenant

➤ **Rewards for observing such rules and regulations**

- God will bless them
- Their names will be remembered in God's Temple
- God will add more members to their group and will be joyful
- God will accept their sacrifices
- God will protect them

➤ **Note that according to this passage, God's people are, therefore, those who do the will of God whether Jews or gentiles.**

2. Bad Leadership 56: 9 – 12

- In this passage the prophet condemns two types of leaders namely:
 - **Religious leaders** expressed as "**watchdogs that do not bark**"
 - **Social / civil leaders** expressed as "**greedy dogs**"
- These were condemned because they were
 - **Corrupt:** they accepted bribes
 - **Blind:** they had no vision. They did not see / know what was happening
 - **Greedy:** they were only concerned about enriching themselves
 - **Lazy:** they could only lie about and dream
 - **Irresponsible:** they were not concerned with the affairs of others
 - **pleasure seeking:** they were drunkards

Note

- Religious leaders such as prophets were dumb in the sense that they did not speak out against superstition, idolatry and immorality
- Due to their poor leadership, God will punish them by letting them be defeated by their enemies

3. Israel's idolatry is condemned 57: 1 – 13

Death

- The death of a wicked person is bad luck
 - This is because when they die, they are tortured by the thoughts of all evil deeds they had done
 - In addition after death they are enclosed in the sheol (i.e. the underground world) where they suffer for eternity
- The death of a righteous person is good luck
 - This is because when they die, **they are taken away from calamities**
 - In addition they die a peaceful death and rest in peace

Isaiah 57: 3

- In this verse, the Jewish sinners are compared to the following groups of people
 - Sorcerers
 - Adulterers
 - Prostitutes

Below are some of their sins

- **Lies:** they were not telling the truth
- **Sacred prostitution:** This was a prostitution done in the name of religion and was a continuation of Canaanite nature worship (Jer. 44: 15 – 23; 2Kgs 16: 3 – 4)

They used to have sex under sacred trees and on mountain tops when offering sacrifices

- **Valley customs:** they used to go into valleys and look for fine and smooth stones and considered them as gods. To such gods they offered wine and cereal offerings
- **Idolatry:** they worshipped the god Molech
- **Child sacrifice:** they used to offer their children as a sacrifice to the god Molech
- **Sexual immorality :** they were having unlawful / immoral sexual practices in their homes

Summary of the idolatrous practices which are condemned here

- Worshipping the fertility gods by having sex
- Offering children as sacrifice
- Worshipping smooth stones as gods
- Worshipping the god Molech
- Setting up idols in front of doors
- Offering of wine and grain sacrifices

Reasons why the Jews committed such sins

- They broke the covenant they made with God
- They forgot God and His covenant love
- Religious syncretism: some Jews mixed the worship of Yahweh with those of pagans due to their intermarriages with Samaritans

God's reaction to their idolatrous practices

- God will make the idols not able to help them
- God will destroy the idols: a puff of wind will carry them off

Why did the Lord condemn these idolatrous practices?

- They forsook their living God, Yahweh
- They wear themselves through these activities
- They make people fear the unknown
- Their lust is never satisfied
- They tell lies

Possible reasons why people today are afraid of abandoning idolatrous practices

- Fear of losing their status in society
- Fear of losing wealth
- Fear of losing life
- Fear of becoming lame
- Fear of being disturbed
- Fear of going mad

4. The people's complaint and Yahweh's answer 59: 4 – 9

(a) The people's complaint

- The complaint of the Jews is not written down in this chapter, but it can easily be deduced from Yahweh's answer
- From Yahweh's answer one can conclude that Jews complained that
 - their God was too weak to save them
 - their God was too deaf to hear and answer their prayers
 - their God was blind to see the sufferings of his people
 - their God had abandoned them
 - their God did not love them

(b) Reasons for these complaints

- None of the promises given to them in exile by Second Isaiah was fulfilled

- No foreign nation worshipped their God despite rebuilding the Temple
- They faced problem of famine
- Righteous people were being oppressed by wicked people
- There was no sign of universal peace and salvation

(c) Yahweh's (the prophet's) reply

- The Lord is not too weak to save you
- The Lord is not too deaf to hear your call for help
- It is because of your sins that he cannot hear you
- Your sins separate you from God when you try to worship Him

(d) Nature of people's sins (Acts of injustice)

- **Lies:** they were not telling the truth
- **Violence:** they indulged themselves in behaviour that used to hurt others
- **Murder:** killing innocent people
- **Injustice:** lawyers were passing false judgement
- **Corruption:** leaders used to accept bribes from the people
- **Plan to hurt others**
- **Crooked deeds**

3. The prophet's inspired message or the coming deliverer 61: 1 – 11

(a) To whom does this refer?

- The prophet himself or
- The servant of Yahweh / the coming deliverer

Thus some scholars consider this as another servant song

(b) Preparation of the servant for his task

- The servant will be anointed by the Spirit of the Lord
- To be anointed means to be chosen or set apart
- The Spirit of the Lord refers to the power of God acting in human beings or nature

(c) What will be his mission / task 61: 1 – 3

- To bring good news to the poor i.e. those who recognize the need of God for their salvation
- To heal the broken – hearted i.e. those who have lapsed in their faith
- To set prisoners free i.e. to liberate sinners
- To comfort the mourners i.e. to give joy to those saddened
- To announce that time for salvation has come i.e. to associate his coming with salvation

(d) Consequences of his mission (restoration to Jerusalem) 61: 4 – 9

- Cities will be rebuilt
- Foreigners will serve them by working in their farm and taking care of their flock. (This never happened)
- They will be known as priests of the Lord
- They will enjoy wealth of other nations
- Their shame and disgrace will come to an end
- They will live in their own land
- Their wealth will be doubled
- Their joy will last forever
- They will be famous among nations
- God will make an eternal covenant with them
- Everyone will know that they have been blessed

(e) Relating Isaiah 61: 1 – 3 to Luke 4: 16 – 21 and Jesus himself

- Jesus applied Isaiah 61: 1 – 3 to himself
- In Luke 4: 16 – 21 Jesus says the passage of Isaiah 61: 1 – 3 had been fulfilled implying that he was the Promised Messiah
- In addition, he interpreted his coming with time for salvation

Fulfillment

- At his baptism, (Luke 3: 21 – 23) Jesus received the Holy Spirit and was anointed by his father
- In his mission, he preached to the poor, the outcasts and sinners
- His preaching and miracles of healing brought comfort and consolation to many

Note



- Jesus turned Isaiah 61: 1 – 3 into his own manifesto for his ministry.

The main message of Third Isaiah

- Universal salvation
- Conditions for the return of the exiles
- Message of restoration
- deliverance

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Chapter 5

THE GOSPELS

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THE GOSPELS

OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, the student should be able to:

- define the term Gospel
- identify the synoptic gospels
- examine the synoptic gospels



CONTENTS

- Meaning
- The synoptic Gospel
 - identifying the Synoptic Gospels
 - explaining the Synoptic Gospels
 - authorship
 - similarities
 - differences

Definition of Gospel

The word gospel is from anglo-Saxon word "god- spell" and means good news / tidings

Use of the word Gospel

- In the **Old Testament**, the salvation of the afflicted and the release of captives were considered as the good news.
- In **Roman times**, the news of the birth of an heir of Caesar as well as the accession of Caesar on the throne was regarded as the good news.
- In **New Testament**, the birth of Jesus and his mission are regarded as the good news.

Gospels are therefore written documents of what Jesus did, taught and achieved. There are four Gospels namely Matthew, Mark, Luke and John. They all tell of the birth, mission death and resurrection of Jesus.

The four gospels present Jesus' life differently. For example, Mark is most concerned with what Jesus did focusing on his actions, miracles, death and resurrection. Matthew and Luke both include birth stories of Jesus and more about what Jesus said and taught than Mark. John, however, is not just interested in what Jesus did or taught. His main focus is on Jesus' identity, that is, who Jesus was.

Synoptic Gospels

- The word synoptic comes from a Greek word '*syn – optic*' meaning side by side. Literally it means together sight (The three gospels see together the life of Jesus with a common view)
- Matthew, Mark and Luke are called synoptic gospels because of their common approach to the subject, life and work of Jesus.
- They give a similar account of the work of Jesus and see it from much the same point view

Authorship of the Gospels

Mark

- The identity of the writer of Mark is not disclosed anywhere in the Gospel.
- However Papias, one of the church fathers referred to John Mark mentioned in Acts of the Apostles as the author of Mark.
- He wrote the book in Rome and designed it for Roman believers
- It is dated in the late 50s and 60s AD

Matthew

- There is no direct evidence about its author
- However the testimony of the early Church fathers is that this gospel was written by Matthew one of Jesus' 12 disciples.
- The gospel was written for the Jewish believers
- It was written before 70 AD

Luke

The third gospel is believed to have been written by **Luke**.

Who was Luke?

- A gentile from Syria
- A well educated man and a good historian
- A medical doctor by profession
- A convert to Christianity
- A good preacher
- A companion of Paul

NB: Luke was not an apostle because he was not an eye witness of Jesus' life, ministry, death and resurrection.

- It is generally agreed that the book was written after 70 AD and before 90 AD.

Luke wrote his gospel for the gentiles thus he dedicated his book to Theophilus.

Who was Theophilus?

- A Roman gentile
- A convert to Christianity
- His name means God's lover or a friend of God

Luke dedicated his book to him because he was a believer in God and his aim included

- To give Theophilus and other gentile readers an orderly account of Jesus' life, ministry, death and resurrection
- Making Theophilus and other gentile readers to have faith in Jesus as the son of God
- Illustrating that salvation is universal

John

Scholars attribute this gospel to John the son of Zebedee and the most beloved apostle of Jesus.

Similarities and Differences of the synoptic gospels

Similarities

- They all tell of the story of Jesus: his birth, ministry, death and resurrection
- They were all written by the disciples of Jesus. (They all believed in Jesus and His word)
- They were all written for Christian believers
- The content and the arrangement of the synoptic materials are closely related. For example, John the Baptist is linked to the Baptism and temptation of Jesus
- Items of similar content are placed together e.g. the Sabbath stories and the parables
- The style and the language used in all the synoptic gospels is similar e.g. in the eschatological conversation
- About 95 % of what Mark has is included in Matthew and Luke, and in some cases with very similar and identical wording

Differences

- They were written at different times with each author relying on different sources or witnesses
- They were written for different audiences: Matthew for the Jews, Mark for the Romans and Luke for Gentiles
- Luke introduces the concept of the Holy Spirit that is different from the other two
- They tell the story of Jesus differently depending on the source of their original information
- The way some events are presented are different e.g. resurrection story.
- There are some events that are totally missing in some but are present in others for example the genealogy story of Jesus in Matthew and Luke are different and Mark does not have that.

Sources

- The similarities show that there must have been some connection among the three books
- The differences show that they must have been written independently

The following solutions are given to sources of information for writing the gospels

- 'oral hypothesis' : that each writer was dependent simply on oral tradition

- Writing Independently: they used similar language and kept the same order because they adhered faithfully to the oral account
- The source theory: Matthew and Luke used a collection of Jesus' teaching, this document is called Q (from a German word Quelle meaning source) and they also might have used what Mark had written since the current view is that Mark was the first of the three Gospels

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Chapter 6

INFANCY NARRATIVES

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INFANCY NARRATIVES

OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, the student should be able to:

1. narrate the birth of John the Baptist
2. narrate the birth of Jesus



CONTENTS

- John the Baptist
 - discussing the birth of John the Baptist
- Jesus Christ
 - discussing the birth of Jesus Christ
 - Jewish birth rituals that Jesus's parents followed

The birth of John is announced Luke 1: 5 – 25

- The birth of John was announced by the angel Gabriel to Zechariah
- His wife was Elizabeth
- Zechariah was one of the numerous priests (between 7000 and 20000) in Israel
- The priests were divided into 24 groups
- Each group was named after the leader of the priestly family
- Zechariah belonged to the eighth group which was named after Abijah
- Each group was to carry out its duties at the Temple of Jerusalem for a period of 2 weeks per year
- The Temple staff included the priests and Levites who were assistant priests

Duties of the priests (Priests were members of the Sanhedrin)

In the Temple

- To lead people in prayers
- To offer sacrifices
- To burn incense during prayers
- To take care of the Temple treasures

In the synagogue

- To give blessings
- To advise on matters of clean and unclean
- To admit Jews who were cured from leprosy back into the community

Duties of the Levites (i.e. assistant priests)

- To judge minor cases
- To lead the singing / praying
- To guard the gates (in the Temple)

Note

- The priest to carry out a particular duty was chosen by lots
- When Zechariah's group was on duty, Zechariah was chosen by lots to burn incense during the morning and evening prayers
- As he was performing his duties, an angel of God appeared to him at the right side of the altar
- When Zechariah saw him he was alarmed and afraid

The angel's message to Zechariah

- Do not be afraid, Zechariah
- God has heard your prayer
- Your wife Elizabeth will bear you a son
- You will name him John

The angel's description of John

- He will be a great man in the Lord's sight
- He will be filled with the Holy Spirit (i.e. he will be chosen and anointed by God)
- He will not drink wine or any strong drink

The angel's description of John's mission

- He will bring back Israel to the Lord (i.e. he will make them repent)
- He will bring back fathers and children together again
- He will turn disobedient people back to the way of thinking of the righteous
- He will get the Lord's people ready for him. (i.e. he will prepare the way for the coming of the Lord / Messiah)

Zechariah's reaction

- How shall I know if this is so?
- I am an old man
- My wife is very old

The angel continued

- I am Gabriel
- I stand in the presence of the Lord
- He sent me to speak to you and tell you this good news
- But since you have not believed my message, which will come true at the right time
- You will become unable to speak
- You will remain silent (become dumb) until the day this promise comes true

Note

- People realized that Zechariah had a vision when they saw that he could not speak and instead used signs
- Zechariah went back home
- After sometime, Elizabeth became pregnant
- Elizabeth was very happy and said
- **The Lord has taken away my public disgrace, referring to removing the humiliation felt for being childless**

How John is like other prophets in the Old Testament

- John was born from an aged and barren woman like Isaac
- John was born in answer to the parents' prayer like Isaac and Samuel
- John's birth was announced by the angel like Samuel's and Samson's
- His name was given by God like that of Isaac
- He abstained from any strong drink as a sign that he was dedicated to God like Samuel, Samson
- His work was like Elijah's; he prepared the way for the Lord
- Like Elijah John, preached in the wilderness

Meanings of the names

- Gabriel = God is my warrior
- Elizabeth = Yahweh has sworn
- Zechariah = Yahweh has remembered
- John = God's gift or God is gracious

The birth of Jesus is announced Luke 1: 26 – 38

- The birth of Jesus was announced by the angel Gabriel to Mary

Mary

- She was a virgin
- She was betrothed to Joseph but did not have any sexual relationship with him
- She was a relative of Elizabeth (possibly cousins)
- Mary means beloved or excellence

The angel's message to Mary

- Peace be with you
- The lord is with you and has greatly blessed you
- Do not be afraid, Mary
- God has been gracious to you
- You will become pregnant and give birth to a son
- You will name him Jesus

What did the angel say about Jesus?

- He will be great
- He will be called the son of the most High God
- God will make him a king as his ancestor David was

- His kingdom will never end

Mary's reaction

- Mary was surprised
- She was deeply troubled by the angel's message and wondered what the angel's words meant
- This was because she was a virgin (I am a virgin. How then can this be?)

The angel's message to convince Mary of her pregnancy

- Everything will happen through the power of the Holy Spirit
- Elizabeth's conception despite barrenness and old age
- The name of her son was given before hand

Mary's final response

- I am the Lord's servant, may it happen to me as you have said
- Her response was a sign of faith, obedience and courageous

Note

- Jesus was linked with King David through Joseph who finally married Mary thereby adopting the child and offering them material security. Thus people regarded Jesus as the son of Joseph and Mary. This would eventually show to the people that Jesus is the real Promised Messiah.

Mary visits Elizabeth Luke 1: 39 – 45

- When Mary heard about Elizabeth's conception, she went to see her
- Possibly to help her in domestic work
- When Mary greeted Elizabeth, the baby in her womb leaped with joy
- Filled with the HS, Elizabeth said the following about Mary
 - You are most blessed of all the women
 - Blessed is the child you will bear
 - Why should this great thing happen to me
 - That my Lord's mother comes to visit me
 - How happy you are to believe that the Lord's message to you will come true

Mary's Song of Praise Luke 1: 46 - 56

Then Mary sang a song of praise known as the **Magnificant**

In the song, Mary expresses her joy to the Lord for

- lifting her up from lowliness to greatness
- lifting the nation of Israel from lowliness to greatness
- the birth of the Messiah to come who will bring forth peace and prosperity in Israel

Note

- The fact that Mary quoted the OT phrases like 1 Sam. 2:1 – 10 in her song shows that Mary was a pious Jew. She knew the scriptures very well and used them as a prayer. Mary stayed with Elizabeth for about three months and then went back to her home.

The birth of John Luke 1: 57 – 66

- The time came for Elizabeth to have her baby
- She gave birth to a son
- All her neighbours and relatives rejoiced with her
- When the baby was one week old, they circumcised him
- On the same day they named him
- People were expecting the boy to be named Zechariah or to be given a name of any of his relatives according to their customs, but Elizabeth told them that his name was John.
- Zechariah confirmed it in writing
- Then Zechariah began to speak

Note

- The people were greatly surprised because the boy was given a name which was not from any of his relatives

The song of Zechariah Luke 1: 67 – 79

- Zechariah started speaking on the day his son was named
- Zechariah then sang a song of praise called the **BENEDICTUS**
- In the song, Zechariah expresses his joy because he believed that
 - The birth of his son would mark the beginning of salvation
 - His son would prepare the way for the Messiah / the hope of many Jews

Note

- The Benedictus like the Magnificant is full of OT phrases which show that Zechariah like Mary knew the scriptures very well.

The hidden life of John Luke 1: 80

- Possibly John grew up as an essene
- Essenes are people who believed that ordinary community life was evil and as a result withdrew themselves from society and stayed in the desert in order to attain purity.

Note

- The name **Joseph** means **let God add**

The birth of Jesus Luke 2: 1 – 7

- Jesus was born during the Roman census which was held every 14 years
- The aim of the census included the following
 - counting the number of people in the country
 - assessing the ages of people with the aim of recruiting some young people for military services
 - assessing the wealth of the people so as to revise tax

When the census took place

- Augustus (which means vulnerable) was the Roman Emperor
- Quirinius was the governor of Syria
- Herod the Great was the governor of Palestine

Mode of conducting the census

- People followed the Jewish way of conducting a census
- All the Jews had to go to their home town or village to register
- Thus Joseph and Mary went to Bethlehem
- Bethlehem was known as David's city just because David was born there
- Joseph went there because he was a descendant of David
- Mary went there because she followed her husband as per patrilineal system of marriage

Note

- While they were in Bethlehem time came for Mary to have her baby
- Because there was no room for them to stay in an inn, they went into a manger
- There, Mary gave birth to a son
- She wrapped her in strips of clothes and laid him there

Note

- Jesus was born in manger in Bethlehem i.e. he was born like a poor person
- Jesus and John were born during the reign of **Herod the Great;**

son of Antipater an Edomite. He was a half Jewish and made king by Roman Emperor in 40 BC but ruled from 37 BC to 4 BC.

The angels and the Shepherds Luke 2: 8 – 20

- The news of Jesus' birth was first announced to the shepherds by the angel
- The shepherds were taking care of their flock and spent most of their time in the field
- The angel of the Lord appeared to them and the glory of the Lord shone over them

The angel's message to the shepherd

- Do not be afraid
- I am here with good news for you
- The news will bring joy to all the people
- This very day in David's town your **Saviour** was born, **Christ** the **Lord**
- You will find the baby wrapped in stripes of clothes and lying in a manger

Then

- The other angels appeared with the angel and sang a song of praise called the **Gloria**
- In the song, the angels praised God for the baby; who would bring joy and peace to all those pleased with him
- The shepherds went to Bethlehem and found everything as the angel had said
- They told Joseph and Mary what the angel said about Jesus
- Mary deeply thought about them
- Then the shepherds went back praising God

Status of the Shepherds

- They were considered as untrustworthy, very humble and ordinary people
- They were suspected of being thieves
- They were treated as sinners since they could not keep all the religious rules and regulations such as Sabbath observation
- They were not allowed to give testimony in the court
- For the shepherds to be chosen to be the first to receive the good news of Jesus' birth shows that

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- Jesus was born in poverty voluntarily
- Jesus wanted to associate himself with the poor
- God's message will often be accepted by humble people, outcasts and sinners like shepherds
 - Shepherds represent those who are humble enough to recognize and accept God's will
- **Titles given to Jesus by the angel and their meaning**
- **Saviour** = Jesus will bring about salvation to all people; Jews and Gentiles alike
- **Christ** = Jesus will be the anointed one
- **Lord** = Jesus will rule like a king

Note

- Jesus was born in the line of King David
- This shows that Jesus was indeed the Promised Messiah
- This fulfils the prophecy of Micah 5:2 concerning a ruler who was to be born in Bethlehem

Jewish birth rituals Luke 2 : 21 – 24

- When Jesus was born, his parents followed three Jewish birth rituals namely
 - Circumcision
 - Purification
 - Presentation / dedication / redemption

Circumcision

- This was a removal of the foreskin of a man's penis or it is a minor surgical operation performed on private parts of male babies for medical reasons

To the Jews

- This was a sign of covenant God made with Abraham
- It was a mark that one belonged to God's chosen people
- It was done on the eighth day after the child's birth
- It was also known as the **Naming Ceremony** since on the same day the child was given a name

Note

- Joseph and Mary had their baby circumcised on the eighth day and they named him Jesus. The name Jesus means God saves or Yahweh is my salvation.

Purification

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- After giving birth, a woman was considered unclean either for 7 / 40 days if she gave birth to a son or for 14 / 80 days if she gave birth to a girl
- While in the state of uncleanness, the woman had to undergo the ritual of purification
- Rich women offered a lamb for purification
- Poor women offered two doves or pigeons

Note

- On her purification day, Mary offered a poor woman's offering.

Presentation / Dedication / Redemption

- According to Exodus 13: 2 – 16, all first born of human beings and animals belonged to God
- First born animals were offered as a sacrifice to God
- While first born sons were dedicated to serve God in the Temple since human sacrifices were forbidden
- This is the origin of dedicating or presenting the first born sons to God
- If the parents did not want their sons to serve in the Temple the whole of their lives, parents had to pay five shekels in order to redeem the son (i.e. the ritual of redemption)
NB: Luke does not separate the rituals of purification and redemption. i.e. when Mary was purified, on the same day they dedicated their child to God.

The Nunc Dimittis Luke 2: 29 – 32

- While Joseph and Mary were dedicating their child to God, Simeon arrived
- Who was Simeon?
- A good God fearing man
- He was filled with the Holy Spirit
- He was waiting for Israel to be saved
- He was assured by the Holy Spirit that he would not die before he had seen the Promised Messiah

Note

- He was led by the HS to go to the Temple to meet Jesus. Holding the child in his hands (arms), he sang a song of praise called the Nunc Dimittis

Significance of the song: The song teaches that

- Jesus is the Promised Messiah
- Jesus came to save all people i.e. Jews and Gentiles alike (He is a light to all nations)

Simeon's words to Mary

- This child is chosen by God for the destruction and salvation of many in Israel i.e. people will be judged according to their faith in Jesus and his teaching. (Those for Jesus will be saved and those against Jesus will be destroyed).
- He will be a sign from God which many people will speak against i.e. not all people will recognize Jesus as the Messiah. (He will be a suffering Messiah / servant since some people will turn against him)
- Sorrow like a sharp sword will break your own heart i.e. through Jesus the nation will be divided as if by a sword. (Some will be for Jesus while others will be against Jesus. Or Mary will suffer while witnessing the suffering of her own son)

Occasions when Mary was sad to see her own son (Jesus) suffering

- When the Jews rejected Jesus before Pilate
- On his way to Golgotha, carrying the cross
- On the cross

Note

- At the Temple there was also another woman called Anna

Who was Anna?

- A daughter of Phanuel
- A prophetess
- From the tribe of Asher
- Had been married for only seven years and was then 84 years old
- Never left the Temple
- Day and night she worshipped God, fasting and praying

Note

- She also confirmed that Jesus would save the people.

The boyhood of Jesus Luke 2: 41- 51

- The Jewish Law required that all Jews should go to the Temple three times a year to attend the following feasts: Passover, Pentecost and Ingathering / Tabernacles

Passover

- This was a feast whereby Jews commemorated their deliverance from Egyptian oppression and looked forward to their final deliverance by the Messiah

Pentecost

- This was a Jewish wheat harvest festival held at the end of wheat harvest
- It was held on the fiftieth day after the feast of Passover hence the name Pentecost

Ingathering / Tabernacle

- This was a Jewish fruit harvest festival
- It was celebrated at the sanctuary

Note

- It was not possible for all the Jews to attend the three occasions in a year
- Most of them tried to attend at least one of the feasts
- Joseph and Mary used to attend the Passover feast yearly

Jewish Boys

- They started their religious education at the age of two
- At 12 years old, they underwent an oral examination on religious education, law and tradition
- After passing the exam, the boy
 - received the prayer Shawl Deut. 6: 4 – 6
 - became an adult and was allowed to read in the synagogue
 - could make decisions and take responsibilities
 - became a Bar- Mitzvah i.e. son of the Law responsible for living as a Jew by observing all the Jewish Laws

Note

- The ceremony was known as Bar – Mitzvah ceremony

When Jesus was twelve years old

- He went to the Temple, with his parents, in order to attend a Passover celebration
- After the celebration, Jesus stayed behind in Jerusalem Temple
- His parents did not know because
 - The pilgrims traveled in large groups
 - In addition, boys did not have to travel with their parents till evening

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- when families got together
- Joseph and Mary started looking for him among his relatives and friends but in vain
- Thus they went back to Jerusalem
- On the third day, they found him in the Temple, sitting with the Jewish teachers, listening to them and asking questions
- All who heard him were amazed at his intelligent answers
- His parents were astonished when they saw him
- and his mother said
- "My son, why have you done this to us? Your father and I have been terribly worried to find you"
- Jesus answered them, "Why did you have to look for me? Didn't you know that I had to be in my father's house?"
- Jesus' answer shows that at this stage (12 years old), he was already aware of his special relationship between him and God – his father
- God and not Joseph was his real father
- It was more important for him to be in God's house than to be with his parents (i.e. Joseph and Mary)
- Yet this was not an attitude of pride
- Despite this, he went back with his parents

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Chapter 8

THE MINISTRY OF JESUS CHRIST—MIRACLES PERFORMED BY JESUS CHRIST

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THE MINISTRY OF JESUS CHRIST—MIRACLES PERFORMED BY JESUS CHRIST

OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, the student should be able to:

CONTENTS

Unit 8: THE MINISTRY OF JESUS Miracles performed by Jesus Christ

Objectives

By the end of this unit Students must be able to

- explain what miracles mean
- identify types of miracles
- explain why Jesus performed miracles

Meaning of the term miracle.

- Miracles are happenings in nature which transcend the capacity of natural causes to such a degree that they are attributed to the direct intervention of God's power. Or
- Miracles are the work of God's power.

Types of miracles

- **Healing miracles:** These were miracles which happened when one was sick and Jesus prayed for them and they got healed
- **Exorcism:** These were the miracles which happened when Jesus prayed and demons were cast out of the individual
- **Nature miracles:** These were the miracles that happened when Jesus reversed nature for example walking on water
- **Raising from the dead:** These were the miracles in which Jesus raised the dead

Reasons why Jesus performed miracles.

- To draw people to God
- To satisfy people's needs

- To make people have faith in God

(a) Healing miracles

Jesus heals Simon's mother in law and many people and then states his aim Luke 4: 38 – 44

- After healing a man with evil spirits, Jesus went to Simon's house
- Simon's mother – in – law was sick with a high fever
- Jesus went and stood at her bed side
- He ordered the fever to leave her
- The fever left her
- And she got up at once
- Then after sunset many people who were sick were brought to Jesus
- Jesus placed his hands on them and healed them all
- Jesus also cast out demons from many people
- As demons went out they screamed, "You are the son of God" i.e. he was the Messiah
- Then Jesus went to a lonely place
- The people started looking for him
- When they found him, they tried to keep him from leaving
- However, Jesus told them that **"I must preach the good news about the Kingdom of God in other towns also, because that is why God sent me to do"**

The cure of a man suffering from a dreaded - skin – disease Luke 5: 12 – 16

- In Jewish society anybody suffering from any skin disease was regarded as unclean
- The Jews also believed that the disease was contagious
- As a result, the victim was isolated from the community and lived in the bush
- **For easy identification, the victim was required**
 - to put on torn clothes
 - to cover the upper lip with a piece of clothes
 - to shout "unclean!" whenever he senses somebody approaching him
- After the victim had been cured of the disease, he / she had to go and show him / herself to the priests

Reasons

- To be **examined** by the priests (who were also medical doctors) if he / she was really cured
- To be **purified** e.g. killing a bird and sprinkle its blood on the victim for seven times, washing clothes, shaving the hair and bathing
- To be **given a certificate** to show the relatives that he / she was really healed and purified

Note

- After receiving the certificate, the victim had to wait outside the village for seven days

Read Luke 5: 12 – 16 and see how Jesus healed such a man. From this one can conclude that

- Jesus violated the Jewish Law by touching the untouchable in order to heal him
- Jesus followed the Jewish Law by ordering him to go and show himself to the priest (for reasons as seen above)
- Note also that Jesus ordered him not to tell anyone about it

Reasons for the demand of Messianic secret

- He did not want to attract people to himself through miracles but their faith
- He feared the Jews would regard him as a political leader who would liberate them from the Roman rule – a thing which would have made the Romans to arrest and put him to death before accomplishing his mission
- He wanted, first of all, to teach and convince his disciples that he was a suffering and not a political messiah

The cure of a paralytic man Luke 5: 17 – 26

- This happened at a certain house at Capernaum
- Jesus was there teaching the people
- The house was overcrowded with the people
- Among them were **Pharisees** and **Teachers of the Law**
- Four men arrived carrying a paralyzed man on a bed
- They tried to take him into the house in front of Jesus
- Because of the crowd they could not find the way
- So they carried him up on the roof
- They made an opening in the tiles
- and let him down on his bed in front of Jesus
- Looking at their faith, Jesus told the paralyzed man that
- Your sins are forgiven my friend
- The Pharisees and the teachers of Law became angry

Reasons

- To them only God had power to forgive sins
- Thus Jesus' claim, to them was blasphemy i.e. an insult to God
- And the penalty for that was death
- Secondly they were angry because Jesus healed the man on the Sabbath which was regarded as work and hence breaking the Sabbath

Jesus' response to their reactions

- Jesus asked them, "Which is easier to say, your sins are forgiven or to say get up and walk?"
- Note that it is easier to say your sins are forgiven
- This is because forgiveness of sins takes place in one's secret heart
- Nobody can check it up
- While to say get up and walk can be checked
- Then Jesus forgave the man's sins and ordered him to get up and walk
- The man was healed and the people praised God

Lessons

- Jesus had power to forgive sins
- Jesus healed the man because of his friends' faith
- Jesus healed the man out of need

Differences between the Pharisees and the Sadducees

Pharisees

- The name Pharisee means separated
- Pharisees kept themselves separated from gentiles, Samaritan and unclean Jews
- The group of Pharisees originated in 2nd Century BC
- At that time, the Syrian tried to impose the Greek culture in Palestine
- The Jews resisted; some used violence and others by just remaining faithful to the Law
- The non – violent group developed into the Pharisee movement

Note

- At the time of Jesus, Pharisees were spiritual leaders
- They were religious purists and model Jews
- They controlled **religious affairs**
- Their main concern was the Law
- Thus most of the teachers of the Law were Pharisees
- They believed in the scriptures (i.e. the books of Moses, the prophets and writings), the oral tradition, the angels, spirits and life after death or the resurrection

Sadducees

- This originated in the 2nd Century BC from the time of Maccabees
- They claimed to be descendants from the old Zadokite priestly family
- This claim is supported by their name “Sadducees” from “Zadokites”
- They belonged to the rich, powerful and almost all of them were priests
- They were rich land owners
- Note that the High priest and all chief priests were all Sadducees
- They were not very much interested in religion
- Instead they controlled **political affairs**
- They believed in the Torah only (i.e. the Law or the Pentateuch / the first five books of the Bible)
- Thus they did not believe in the angels, resurrection, prophets and writings, oral tradition and spirits

Jesus Heals the Roman Officer's Servant Luke 7:1-10

- The officer was the in charge of 100 soldiers
- This is why he is sometimes called a centurion
- He was residing in Capernaum
- He had a positive attitude towards the Jews and their religion
- He loved the Jews as evidenced by building them a synagogue (vs. 5).
- Usually the Jews and the Romans were bitter enemies
- **To show that he respected the Jewish laws;**
- He sent the elders of the synagogue to ask Jesus to heal his servant
- He sent a message to Jesus asking him not to come to his house but just to say a word to heal his servant

Note

- When his servant was sick and had asked Jesus to cure the servant, the Jews expected Jesus to help the officer's servant because the officer was a **good man**
- He loved them and built them a synagogue
- However, Jesus helped him because of his **faith** and not his goodness

Lessons

- Salvation is universal
- Jesus had power to heal even at a distance
- Faith is needed for a miracle to take place
- **Faith** is believing certain truth with certainty **or**
- **Faith** is total trust in God and his plan of salvation

Jesus heals a woman with a flow of blood and raises the daughter of Jairus (Luke 8: 40 – 56)

- **The woman with a severe flow of blood (Haemorrhage)**
- The woman suffered for twelve years
- She spent all she had on doctors but no one cured her
- As Jesus was passing, she came up in the crowd behind Jesus
- And touched the edge of Jesus' cloak
- And her bleeding stopped at once
- Jesus asked who had touched him
- Everyone denied it
- Peter said, "Master, the people are all around crowding in on you"
- Jesus said, "Someone touched me, for I knew it when power went out of me"
- The woman saw that she had been found out
- She came trembling, and threw herself at Jesus' feet
- She explained why she touched him and how she had been healed
- Jesus said to her my daughter your faith has made you well go in peace

Possible reasons why she touched Jesus secretly

- She was ashamed of her disease.
- The disease made her unclean and unfit for any human contact. By touching Jesus she would make him unclean also.
- She had faith she could be cured even without asking Jesus.

- **The raising of Jairus' daughter from the dead**

- Jairus was the ruler of the synagogue (the in charge of a synagogue's public worship)
- He was a father of only one daughter
- His only daughter died while he had already asked Jesus to cure her because she was sick
- Jesus told him not to worry about his daughter's death
- Upon arrival, Jesus told the mourners that the daughter was not dead but just sleeping
- The mourners laughed at Jesus, just because they believed what their eyes saw
- To them the daughter was dead thus they had no faith in what Jesus said
- As such Jesus prevented them from witnessing the miracle since they could have attributed Jesus' power to heal to Beelzebub
- Thus Jesus took only Peter, James and John and the parents into the house
- Jesus took the child by hand and called out, "Get up, my child"
- Her life returned
- And she got up at once
- Jesus ordered them to give her some food
- Jesus commanded them not to tell anyone what had happened

Jewish mourning customs

- The corpse was washed
- The corpse was wrapped in clothes
- Then it was laid in the house
- Relatives, friends (mostly women) would sit around the corpse
- There was loud weeping and lamenting by professional mourners
- People were not allowed to eat any food from the bereaved family because the corpse made food unclean instead people brought their own food
- The hair and part of the beard were shaven
- The mourners dressed in sack clothes and mourned for 3 to 30 days; although usually 7 days

Reasons for recording these two stories together

- **Sex:** Both stories concern females
- **The number twelve:** The woman suffered for 12 years and the daughter was 12 years old
- **Faith:** The woman was cured because of her own faith while the daughter was raised because of her father's faith
- **Physical contact:** The woman touched Jesus' cloak and Jesus touched the daughter
- **Kneeling before Jesus:** The woman knelt before Jesus and Jairus knelt before Jesus
- **Attitude of Jesus:** Jesus was gentle and kind to both the woman and daughter

Reasons why the stories have a Jewish setting

- The mention of the synagogue
- The use of the Jewish symbols like
 - the **number 12** symbolizing the 12 tribes of Israel
 - the mention of **daughter (s)** which refers to the daughters of Jerusalem i.e. **God's chosen people**
- **Demand for Messianic secret:** He told the parents not to tell anyone about it unlike in Gerasa.

The cure of ten men suffering from a dreaded skin disease Luke 17: 11 - 17

- Jesus performed this miracle when he was going to Jerusalem through Samaria and Galilee
- He had just entered a certain village when he was met by ten men (i.e. 9 Jews and 1 Samaritan) suffering from a dreaded skin disease
- The men stood at a distance (for fear of making Jesus unclean)
- They shouted; "Have pity on us!" i.e. heal us
- Jesus told them to go and show themselves to their priests (so as to be examined, purified and given a certificate)
- Jesus implied that by the time they reach their priests they would have been healed
- The men did it i.e. they had faith that they would be healed before reaching their priests
- Indeed on their way, they were all healed
- The Samaritan went back and thanked Jesus

Possible reasons why only the Samaritan returned and thanked Jesus

- The Jews might have considered their salvation for granted while the Samaritan did not
- The Jews might have rejected the Samaritan after being healed, thus the Samaritan decided to go back and thank the one who had healed them all
- The Samaritan was naturally aware of the need of giving thanks and praising God for being saved

Lessons

- Faith is necessary for a miracle to take place
- Jesus had power to heal even from a distance
- Salvation is universal i.e. to the Jews and gentiles alike
- There is need to love one's enemies
- There is need to be grateful to God for any gift given

Jesus heals a blind beggar Luke 18: 35 – 43

- This happened on the road near Jericho
- The beggar was known as Bartimeus
- He was given sight because of his amazing faith

Signs of his faith

- He addressed Jesus as son of David; i.e. he recognized Jesus as the Promised Messiah
- He asked Jesus to have pity on him; i.e. he recognized Jesus' power of healing
- When the people scolded him to be quiet; he did not give up asking for help
- When Jesus called him he did not delay or hesitate; i.e. he was ready to follow Jesus and suffer with him in Jerusalem which was only 25 km away

Possible reasons why Jesus did not demand Messianic secret

- The time for secrecy is over i.e. his life is nearly over and people had to know the truth
- He himself would finally openly declare that he was the Messiah during his trial before the Jewish rulers

Lesson

- Faith is needed for a miracle to take place

Exorcism

Jesus heals a man with evil spirit Luke 4: 31 - 37

- Jesus went to Capernaum and there he taught people on the Sabbath
- The people were amazed at the way he taught
- This was because Jesus **taught with authority**
- Unlike other teachers (rabbis) who usually quoted the sayings of well respected prophets and then deducted their own statements from what had been said before; Jesus taught his own knowledge concerning God.
- The people were also amazed because Jesus **acted with power**
- This was noted when Jesus healed a man with evil spirits
- The man screamed in a loud voice, Ah!
- What do you want to do with us, Jesus of Nazareth?
- Are you here to destroy us?
- I know who you are; you are God's Holy messenger.
- Then Jesus ordered the spirit,

- Be quiet and come out of the man
- The demon threw the man down in front of them and went out of him without doing him any harm
- Upon seeing this, the people were amazed
- Normally the people of those times were used to practices of exorcists (i.e. people who pretended to cast out demons)
- The exorcists usually subjected the patients to long series of strange and weird treatment
- Thus to see Jesus just saying a word / statement in a calm way and having immediate success was surprising to the people

Note

- When Jesus exorcised demons, he was always recognized by them as God's Holy Messenger or the son of God
- These were titles used by the Jews whenever they talked about the Messiah
- This shows that Jesus was recognized as the Messiah by the demons
- By exorcising demons, Jesus shows that he had power over the forces of evil

Jesus heals a man with demons Luke 8: 26 – 39

- This miracle happened at Gerasa (a gentile city extended to the sea of Galilee)
- When Jesus stepped ashore, he was met by a man from the town
- The man was apparently a mentally disturbed person. **Reasons**
- He could go about without clothes
- He did not stay at home
- He spent his time in the burial caves
- He could break chains which fastened his hands and feet (i.e. he was abnormally strong)
- He was very aggressive
- When Jesus asked his name, he answered, "My name is Mob", because many demons were in him

Take note of the following

- The story expresses the Jewish belief that demons have close links with the dead: (The mad man lives in burial caves)
- The story expresses the demons attitudes towards Jesus namely that:
 - They recognize Jesus as the son of God and his power as an exorcist Vs 28
 - They subject themselves to Jesus' power of exorcism as proved by giving the name Vs 30
- They fear to be locked away in the underground world / abyss and so asked Jesus not to send them there but into the pigs Vs 31
- The miracle had a gentile setting as evidenced by the following:
 - **Gerasa:** The miracle happened at Gerasa a gentile city
 - **The presence of pigs:** To the Jews pigs were unclean animals as such they were not allowed to tame them. Thus pigs could not be found in Jewish society
 - **No demand for Messianic Secret:** After the miracle Jesus did not command the people to keep it secret. This was so because Jesus knew that in gentile territory there was no danger of misunderstanding messianic mission which would risk his life
 - **He did not allow the new disciple to join the other disciples:** This was because gentiles could not mix with Jews. Thus he was sent to proclaim the good news among

his fellow gentiles

Lessons

- Jesus' healing miracles are also victories over Satan. Jesus is more powerful than evil spirits.
- Salvation is universal i.e. Jesus came to save all people. Note that by healing the man, Jesus paradoxically saved the people of Gerasa from his aggressiveness.
- Gentiles too are called to preach the good news.

The cure of a boy with an evil spirit / epileptic boy Luke 9: 37 – 43

- One day as Jesus went down from the hill, a large crowd met him
- A man shouted from the crowd
- Teacher ! I beg you, look at my son my only son!
- A spirit attacks him with a sudden shout and throws him into a fit so that he foams at the mouth
- It keeps on hurting him and will hardly let him go
- I begged your disciples to drive it out, but they couldn't
- Jesus answered
- How unbelieving and wrong you people are!
- How long must I stay with you?
- How long do I have to put up with you?
- Then he said to the man
- Bring your son here
- As the boy approached Jesus
- The demon knocked him to the ground and threw him into a fit
- Jesus gave a command to the evil spirit , healed the boy, and gave him back to his father
- All the people were amazed at the mighty power of God

Note

- The Jews believed that epilepsy was the result of being possessed by the devil
- The disciples of Jesus failed to cure the boy because of lack of faith

Lesson

- Faith is needed for any healing miracle to happen
- This is because through faith;
- Healing can be understood as a sign that Jesus defeats evil and establishes the Kingdom of God
- One can enter the Kingdom of God and hence share in Jesus' power over evil

Nature miracles

Jesus Calms the storm Luke 8: 21 – 25

- Wild water symbolizes chaos and death
- It is the influence of Satan's power which opposes God
- i.e. as Jesus and his disciples were going to the other side of the lake, the devil wanted to oppose their mission

- Jesus fell asleep
- A strong wind blew down on the lake
- The boat began to fill with water
- They were all in great danger
- Disciples woke Jesus up while in peril of their lives
- Jesus got up and gave an order to the wind and stormy water
- They died down and there was a great calm
- Jesus said to his disciples, “Where is your faith?”
- They were all amazed and afraid

Lessons

- Jesus had power over nature. (Note that this is a **nature miracle**)
- Jesus had power to overcome the evil spirits i.e. Jesus’ kingdom is stronger than that of Satan
- Jesus was a truly human being who could feel tired and get asleep
- Faith is needed for one to enter the kingdom of God. (The disciples had to wake up their master Jesus because they were not at peace and that they lacked faith)

Jesus feeds 5, 000 men Luke 9: 10 – 17

- This miracle took place at Bethsaida (meaning house of fishing)
- Bethsaida was the village of three apostles: Peter, Andrew and Phillip
- Jesus took his disciples there because he wanted them to rest after their mission
- However, when Jesus and his disciples arrived there, they found that a large crowd had already gathered waiting for them
- Then, Jesus began to teach them
- In the evening the disciples asked Jesus to disperse the crowd to look for food and lodging
- Jesus told the disciples to give the crowd food
- Yet they had only two fish and five loaves of bread
- Jesus ordered the people to be in group of fifty each
- Jesus took the loaves of bread and fish, looked up to heaven, thanked God for them and broke them and gave them to the disciples to distribute to the people
- They all ate and had enough
- The disciples took up 12 baskets of what was left over

Lessons

- Jesus was concerned with people’s spiritual and physical needs
- The account is a reminder that God can miraculously feed his people just as he fed the Israelites with manna
- The meal symbolizes the fullness of salvation at the end of time when mankind’s hunger for the truth and love will be fully satisfied

Note

- The number twelve refers to the twelve tribes of Israel and the twelve apostles; the foundation of new God’s chosen people who will later distribute food of life i.e. Jesus’ good news of salvation
- This is a nature miracle and marks the climax of Jesus’ ministry in Galilee
- The miracle has the language connected with the institution of the Lord’s supper i.e.

took, looked up, blessed, broke and gave

Raising of the Dead

The widow of Nain Luke 7: 11 - 17

- Nain was a day's journey from Capernaum
- It was situated between Endor and Sharon
- It was the same place where Elisha raised another mother's son (2 Kings 4: 18)
- Upon entering the gate of Nain, Jesus raised the only son of the widow of Nain

How?

- Jesus met a funeral procession
- The dead man was the only son of the woman who was a widow
- She was crying for her only son
- When Jesus saw her, he was filled with pity and said,
- "Do not cry"
- He walked over and touched the coffin
- The men carrying it stopped
- Jesus said, "Young man! Get up. I tell you
- The dead man sat up and began to talk
- And Jesus gave him back to his mother
- **People's reactions**
- They were all filled with fear and praised God and said
- A great prophet has appeared among us.
- God has come to save his people.
- **Lessons**
- Jesus performed the miracle out of pity
- Jesus has compassion with the poor and those who mourn
- Jesus is the Lord over both life and death
- Jesus acted with power and authority when performing the miracle
- (Note that he touched the bear / coffin i.e. he was not afraid of the crowd and of becoming unclean)

Raising of Jairus daughter

Refer to the healing miracle above on page 68

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Bible Knowledge form 3

Chapter 9

THE MINISTRY OF JESUS CHRIST-PARABLES IN JESUS'S TEACHINGS

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THE MINISTRY OF JESUS CHRIST-PARABLES IN JESUS'S TEACHINGS

OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, the student should be able to:

CONTENTS

Unit 9: THE MINISTRY OF JESUS Parables in Jesus's teachings

Objectives

By the end of this unit, students must be able to

- Explain the meaning of the term Parable
- Identify parables in Jesus' teaching
- Explain why Jesus used parables

The parable of the Good Samaritan Luke 10: 25 – 35

- Jesus narrated this parable to answer the question "Who is my neighbour?" posed to him by a teacher of the Law
- Teachers of the Law are the same as scribes
- They were judging cases on grounds of the Laws of Moses
- Here the lawyer was trying to trap Jesus into making wrong statement
- In the parable Jesus speaks of a man who was wounded on the road between Jerusalem and Jericho
- This was an isolated road running through deep gorges with many caves and mountains where robbers were hiding
- The priest and the Levite did not attend to the wounded man
- The Samaritan assisted the man. **How?**
 - He cleaned his wounds
 - He put oil on the wound

- Ha bandaged them
- He put him on his animal
- And took him to inn
- He paid two coins
- And promised to pay all other expenses on his way back

Possible reasons why the priest and the Levite passed by the man

- They feared to be delayed especially if they were going to Jerusalem because it was their division turn to serve in the Temple
- They feared to be attacked as well by the robbers who might have been hiding nearby
- They were afraid to get involved in an unpleasant incident
- They were afraid of being contaminated. The man looked dead and had blood. In Jewish society, to touch blood and / or a corpse would make a Jew unclean; a thing which would make them not to carry out their duties at the Temple

Possible reasons why the Samaritan helped the wounded man

- He acted out of compassion (pity)
- His help is prompt, efficient, generous and loving
- He fulfils the greatest commandment of Love (Mt. 25) although he might have had no idea about it

Lesson

- A neighbour is anyone in need of your help
- Love of neighbour knows no boundary of colour, religion, sex, race, language, class etc
- Not all Samaritans are bad as Jews believed. Jesus portrays a Samaritan as the good man in the story.
- This posed as a challenge to the James and John who suggested that the Samaritans should be destroyed in Luke 9: 52 – 56.

The Parable of the rich fool Luke 12: 13 – 21

- A fool is someone who lives and acts as if there is no God. Psalm 14: 1
- A certain man asked Jesus to tell his brother to divide with him the property their father left for them
- Although Jesus was regarded as one of the teachers responsible for judging such cases, he refused to act as a judge over them
- Possibly he did so to show that he came to preach the good news

about the Kingdom of God which had nothing to do with earthly riches

- Thus Jesus told the people who are concerned with earthly riches not to be fools
- In the parable of the rich farmer, **read 12: 16 – 20**, **the farmer is a fool because**
 - He thinks he has secured a good future through his bumper yield forgetting that only God assures one's future
 - He is self – centered (egocentric). He is so preoccupied with his own interests that the idea of caring for his needy neighbours does not enter his mind (Take note of the numerous "I"s and "my"s.)
 - He lives and acts as if there is no life after death. He does not even think of what will happen to his goods after his death

Lessons

- Life does not mean riches and riches cannot save anyone
- Do not covet wealth as if it could assure your future
- Make yourself rich in God's sight by using wealth to help the needy

Parables on the lost Luke 15: 1 -32

- **Verses 1 – 3**
- Many tax collectors and other outcast came to listen to Jesus
- The Pharisees and teachers of the law started grumbling;
- "This man welcomes outcasts and even eats with them"
- **Reasons why the Pharisees and teachers of the law were angered by Jesus' friendliness towards outcasts and sinners**
- Pharisees kept themselves separated from outcasts and sinners. Thus Jesus' closeness to them was an indirect attack on this practice and on the teaching of the teachers of the law that any contact with such people was defiling
- They also felt that Jesus' contact with outcasts and sinners would make the pious Jews less sure of themselves
- The Pharisees were afraid that they would lose the respect of the people when Jesus showed respect for sinners
- In order to explain why Jesus was associating himself with sinners and outcasts he told them parables of the lost sheep, coin and son.

The lost sheep and coin Luke 15: 3 – 7; 8 - 10

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- In these parables God is like the Shepherd or the woman
- He goes after the lost ones and rejoices when he or she is found
- As such the pious Jews should not murmur when Jesus shows love for sinners and outcasts
- God sent him on earth to seek and save sinners

The lost son Luke 15: 11 – 32

- It is also known as the prodigal son, the parable of the elder son or the parable of the forgiving father
- The parable teaches that God is like the father in the story
- God is all merciful: He forgives and forgets completely
- Thus sinners who repent truly (like the younger son) will be forgiven their sins and be welcomed in the kingdom of God
- This is what Jesus symbolized when he welcomed sinners and outcasts

▪ The Elder Son

- The **elder son** in the third parable symbolizes the **Pharisees**.

Reasons

- He was **self righteous**; "I have never disobeyed your orders." The Pharisees too posed as the ones who followed the Jewish laws
- He **does not accept the sinful young man as his brother**; he judges and condemns him. The Pharisees also condemn sinners and outcasts
- He is **angry that his father still loves that son and has made a feast for him**. Thus he **refused to join the celebration**. Likewise Pharisees were angry to see Jesus among sinners and outcasts and they could not join the celebration of repentant sinners

Note

- The father does not cut the elder son off. He still loves him too. He begged him to come in and join in the celebration.

▪ Similarities and contrasts(differences) of the three parables

- **Similarities (What they have in common).** In all three
- Sinners are regarded as the lost that must be found
- God takes the initiative; he goes after the sinners
- There is a great joy when a sinner returns / repents
- The joy over a repentant sinner is always shared

- Taking great pains; carrying the sheep, sweeping, waiting along time / running after the son

- **Differences**

- In the first two, it is God who searches for sinners while in the third parable the sinner searches for God
- The reason for the loss of each is different
- The third parable, unlike the first two, shows the Pharisees' self – righteousness and their lack of love for their brothers (sinners)
- The third parable also shows God's goodness, love and mercy

- **Relevance of the parables on the lost for the early church**

- The parable guided the Christians not to exclude anyone from their preaching
- Like the Shepherd and the woman, there is need for Christians to go after lapsed members
- Care for just one person who is lost is not a waste of time as it is exemplified by that Shepherd and that woman
- No one in the Christian community must think of him / her self more deserving of God's love and favour than those who seem less good
- In case "Pharisees" oppose the church, her members must yet remain open to them

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Bible Knowledge form 4

Chapter 1

THE BIRTH OF THE CHURCH

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CHAPTER 1: **The birth of the church**

Objectives

By the end of this chapter, the students must be able to:

1. Describe the authorship of the book of Acts of Apostles
2. Explain the birth of the early church

Contents

- The authorship of the book of Acts
- The birth of the early Church
 - Ascension
 - Pentecost

A. Authorship of the book of Acts of Apostles

The third gospel and the book of Acts of Apostles are believed to have the same author i.e. Luke

Proofs for This

- i. Both books are dedicated to the same person namely, Theophilus
- ii. The beginning of the Acts of the Apostles is both the continuation and an expansion of the book of Luke
- iii. Both books have the same interest e.g. in the universal salvation, prayer, the Holy Spirit etc.

- iv. The author of both books defends the Romans. The Romans show that they found nothing wrong in Jesus as well as in the apostles' activities
- v. Both books have similar expressions and / or vocabulary

Who was Luke?

- He was a Roman gentile from Syria
 - He was a medical doctor by profession
 - He was a very good historian
 - He was converted to Christianity
 - He was a very good preacher
 - He was a companion of Paul
-
- He was not an apostle because he was not an eye witness of Jesus' public life ministry, death and resurrection
 - Note that the book of Acts of the Apostles is also known as the book of the Holy Spirit. This is because all the activities written in the book were guided by the Holy Spirit. The Apostles were told to wait for the Holy Spirit before they started witnessing

Who was Theophilus to whom the books are addressed?

- He was a Jew from Alexandria
- He was probably a Roman official since Luke referred to him as the most excellent (Luke 1:3)
- In an academia tradition, it is referred to as an honorary title and that Theophilus was not a living person. The word in Greek means friend of God or God's love. As such the name refers to anyone who is a friend of God

- He was possibly Paul's lawyer during his trial period in Rome
- He was Theophilus ben Anamus who was a High priest of the Temple in Jerusalem
- A person who was a converted Roman Official, probably Titius Flavius Sabinus. (Some people teach that Luke was Sabinus' slave: Luke cured him of an illness. In return Sabinus set Luke free and travelled with Paul to Antioch dedicating the book of Acts to Sabinus)

B. The birth of the early church

Acts 2: 1-2, talk of how the early Christian church was born. The appearance of Jesus to his disciples, his ascension, the choice of the replacement of Judas and the Pentecost are major events before the birth of the Church

Jesus' appearances

- Jesus appeared to his disciples for forty days after his resurrection which proved beyond doubt that he was alive
- During the 40 days he talked with them about the kingdom of God
- Finally before he was taken up to heaven, Jesus promised to send them the gift of the Holy Spirit who would give them power to witness for Jesus all over the world.
- This shows that Jesus works through the HS and that the HS guides the church

Jesus' ascension of 1: 6 – 11

- Jesus talked with his disciples for the last time on the day of his ascension
- They all went to Mount Olives
- The apostles asked him, "Lord will you at this time give the kingdom back to Israel?"

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- These words show that the Apostles still looked at Jesus as a political Messiah
- Thus, they asked him, after having defeated death, are you going to act politically by fighting for the independence of Israel
- Jesus said, "Everything is set by my father's own authority, and it is not for you to know when they will be. But when the HS comes upon you, you will be filled power and you will be witnesses for me in Jerusalem, in all Judea and Samaria, and to the ends of the earth"
- These words imply that the kingdom of God has already been established through Jesus' own sufferings, death and resurrection
- The disciples themselves will have a role to play in this kingdom
- However, they will carry out their mission through the HS
- Their mission will extend from Jerusalem to the ends of the world i.e. Rome according to Acts

Note

- After saying this, Jesus was taken up to heaven as they watched him and a cloud hid him from their sight.
- They still had their eyes fixed at the sky, when two men dressed in white (i.e. angels) appeared and said to them
"Why are you standing looking up to the sky? This Jesus who was taken away from you will come back in the same way you saw him go there."
- these words indicate that Jesus' second coming is real or true
- and Jesus will come again on the clouds as he predicted in Luke 21: 27

Significance of the ascension of Jesus

- it signaled the end of Jesus' earthly ministry
- it signified the success in His earthly work
- it marked the return of His heavenly glory
- it symbolized his exaltation by the Father
- it allowed Him to prepare a place for us.
- it indicated the beginning of His new work as a High priest and mediator of the New Covenant

- it set the pattern for His return. He will return just as he left literally, boldly and visibly

The choice of the replacement of Judas 1: 12 – 16

- After Jesus' ascension, the disciples went back from Mt Olives stayed together in the upper room in Jerusalem (possibly the same room where Jesus had his last supper)
- While there several things happened like

They used to pray vs. 12 – 14

- The apostles and other disciples about 120 in all used to pray while waiting for the HS
- This shows that prayer is vital in the life of the church

They chose the replacement of Judas vs.15 – 26

- Peter told his fellow disciples that Judas had betrayed Jesus according to the prophesy of David (Ps. 69: 25)
- After that he hanged himself
- He fell down, burst open and all his bowels split out
- All the people in Jerusalem heard about it and so in their language they call that field **Akeldama** which means **field of blood**
- They used the money he was given to buy that field as the grave yard
- Peter went on to say that it was also prophesied that his seat should not remain vacant
- Thus, peter suggested that they should choose someone to take the place of Judas

Qualifications of the right candidate

- **Someone from their group who witnessed Jesus' public life** from the time John preached his message of baptism until the day Jesus was taken up to heaven
- Two men qualified namely: Joseph (also known as Barsabbas or Justus) and Matthias
- They prayed and drew lots to choose between the two men
- **And the one chosen was Matthias**, who was added to group of eleven apostles
- This shows that prayer is vital in the life of the church and the HS guides the church

The coming of the Holy Spirit 2: 1 – 13

Pentecost

- The word **Pentecost** literary means the **fiftieth day**
- **To the Jews**, Pentecost was a **wheat harvest festival** which was held on the fiftieth (50th) day after the feast of Passover
- **To the Christians**, Pentecost is **a day when they commemorate the outpouring of the HS** on the disciples enabling them to witness for Jesus

Events on Pentecost day

- Ten days after Jesus' ascension was the day of Pentecost
- Many Jews from various places gathered in Jerusalem for wheat harvest festival
- The disciples about 120 in all were hiding in the upper room
- While their God filled them with the Holy Spirit

Signs of the coming of the Holy Spirit

- There was **a noise from the sky which sounded like a strong wind blowing** which filled the whole house
- Something like **tongues of fire** which spread out and touched each person there
- After these everyone in the room was filled with the Holy Spirit

Effects of receiving the Holy Spirit

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- The disciples began to speak in other languages as the Holy Spirit enabled them to speak

Significance of speaking in other languages (in tongues)

- it ensured the fulfillment of God's promise in Joel 2: 28 – 29, to pour out His Spirit on people
- it meant that the gospel is universal
- it meant that the HS brings about unity among people
- it meant that the disciples were ministers of the HS

Reactions of the people

- Upon hearing the noise, a large crowd gathered around the disciples
- When they heard them speaking in tongues, they were all **excited** and **amazed** because each one of them heard the believers speaking in his or her own language
- However, other people made fun of the believers saying, "These people are **drunk!**"

Peter's Pentecost Sermon 2: 14 – 41

As some people thought that the disciples were drunk, Peter and the eleven apostles stood up and peter said to the crowd:

- Listen to me and let me tell you what this means
 - i. These people are not drunk as you suppose; **it is nine o'clock in the morning**, too early for one to be drunk
 - ii. Instead **what has happened is the fulfillment of the prophesy**

of Joel

- "In the last days I will pour my spirit on young and old people. Your sons and daughters will proclaim my message, young men will see visions, and older people will have dreams..." Joel 2: 28 – 29
 - iii. Listen to these words fellow Jews, you saw all the miracles and wonders which God performed through Jesus which proved beyond doubt that **Jesus was God's beloved son**
- However, you did not believe him
- God handed Jesus to you and you killed him by letting sinful people crucify him as God had planned
- But God raised him from death, setting him free from its power

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- The **resurrection of Jesus was foretold by King David** when he said the Lord will not let his faithful servant to rot in the grave in one of his **psalms**
- We are all witnesses to this fact of Jesus' resurrection
- After the resurrection, Jesus ascended to heaven and is seated at the right-hand side of God his father
- God gave him the HS as he had promised and Jesus has given that HS to us
- What you now see and hear is the work of that HS
- You must realize that Jesus, whom you crucified, is the one that God made Lord and messiah
- **The people were deeply troubled and said to Peter and the other apostles, "what shall we do brothers?"**
- iv. Peter said to them, "each one of you must turn away from your sins and be baptized in the name of Jesus, so that your sins will be forgiven and receive the gift of the HS also..."
- v. This promise (HS) is for all whom God has called to be his followers i.e. you yourselves, your children and to all who are far away (pagans)
- vi. Save yourselves from the punishment coming on this wicked people
- vii. Many of them believed his message and were baptized
 - About 3,000 people were added to the group that day
 - This marked the birth of the early church
 - The key messages during the birth of the church were about
 - The life, ministry, death and resurrection of Jesus Christ
 - The divine plan of salvation through the Messiah was written in the Old Testament

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Chapter 2

THE WORK AND GROWTH OF THE CHURCH

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CHAPTER 2: The work and growth of the church

Objectives

By the end of this chapter, the students must be able to:

1. Describe the life of the early church in Judea
2. Explain how the early church spread or grew

Contents

- The work of the early Church in Judea
 - Performing miracles
 - Praying preaching
 - Sharing belongings
- The growth of the early Church
 - preaching
 - miracles
 - persecution of the church

The life of the early church in Judea 2: 43 - 47

The church that was born in Judea grew and spread to the other parts of the Roman Empire. The presence of the Holy Spirit assisted in the spread of the church. After being filled with the Holy Spirit, the Apostles performed many miracles and wonders and all who listened to them wondered. Life of the early believers was as follows:

- They spent their time in learning from the apostles
- They shared in fellowship prayers
- They shared in fellowship meals (breaking of the bread; echoing the Eucharist or the Lord's supper)
- They shared their belongings with one another

- They would sell their property and possessions and then share the money according to each one's needs
- They listened to the teachings of the apostles, received and acted on the principles as was desired.
- They recognized each other as equals and were united in the way they lived
- They praised God everyday

The work of the early church in Judea (Acts 3: 1 – 26; 4: 1 – 47; 5: 1 – 16)

The work of the early church in Judea was characterized by performing miracles, praying, preaching and sharing.

1. Performing miracles (The cure of a lame man at the beautiful Gate (Acts 3: 1 – 26)

- One day Peter and John went to the Temple at three o'clock in the afternoon
- They found a lame man at the Beautiful Gate
- The man was carried to the gate every day to beg for money from people who were going into the Temple for prayer
- When he saw Peter and John, he begged them to give him something
- They looked straight at him, and Peter said, "Look at us!"
- So, he looked at them expecting to get something from them
- Peter said to him, "I have no money at all, but I give you what I have:
- In the name of Jesus Christ of Nazareth, I order you to get up and walk"
- Then he took him by his right hand and helped him up
- At once the man's feet and ankles became strong
- He jumped up, stood on his feet, and started walking around
- Then he went into the Temple with them; walking, jumping and praising God
- When the people saw him and recognized him as a beggar, they were surprised and amazed at what had happened

Peter's answer (Peter's second sermon) Acts 3: 11 – 26

- Peter said to the people, "Why do you think we healed this man with our power?"
- This is the way God glorified Jesus in whose name we healed him
- You denied him in front of Pilate, the gentile, who wanted to release him
- You said he was guilty and asked for a murderer to be released
- You killed the giver of life (Jesus) whom God raised from the dead
- By faith in this Jesus, this man was healed
- I know that you acted in ignorance but remember that the prophets said that Christ must suffer
- Repent therefore that your sins can be forgiven
- Then God will send the messiah back to you but in the meantime, he must wait in heaven
- Moses as well as the prophets from Samuel onwards prophesied that Jesus would come and all people would be blessed
- Now you must accept the messiah or be destroyed
- As a result many people repented and the number of the believers increased up to 5, 000.

2. Praying (Peter and John before the council (4: 1 – 31))

- Peter and John were arrested by the Sadducees and chief priests mainly because **they healed the lame man in the name of Jesus**
- In addition, the Sadducees and the Chief priests were angered because
 - Peter and John preached about the resurrection (against Sadducees' belief)
 - They feared Peter's and John's teaching would cause riots and disturbances in the city
 - Peter and John interfered with the Temple affairs by preaching in the Temple
 - Peter and John were blaming them for the death of Jesus

Their trial before the Sanhedrin (Jewish Council)

- Peter and John were asked in whose name they had healed the lame man
- Peter replied that it was done in the name of Jesus, whom they had crucified but whom God raised from the dead
- Jesus was the rejected stone which became the corner stone (1 Peter 2: 7 – 8)
- Peter also said salvation can be found in no other name but Jesus Christ

Reactions of the members of the Jewish council

- They were amazed to see how bold Peter and John were, yet they were ordinary men of no education
- They realized that Peter and John had been companions of Jesus
- However there was nothing that they could say because they saw the man who had been healed standing there
- Finally the members of the council warned them not to speak in Jesus' name
- This was because they did not want the matter to spread

Peter's response to the warning

- Peter asked them whether it was right to obey God or men (implying that they were against God)
- Then Peter told them that they would continue speaking in Jesus' name
- After that they were released because the Jewish leaders feared the people

Note: The man who had been healed was 40 years old.

The believers pray for boldness 4: 23 – 31

- After joining their fellow believers, Peter and John told them everything that had happened
- They pointed out that, Herod, Pilate and other gentiles were allowed by God to kill Jesus. Now they are threatening us
- The whole group prayed to God to protect them so that they could spread his word with all boldness.
- They also prayed to God to stretch out His hand to heal , and ensure that signs and wonders are done in the name of his son Jesus Christ

- As they prayed, the place where they were meeting was shaken
- They were all filled with the HS again and continued preaching boldly

3. Preaching and sharing (Barnabas vs. Ananias and Sapphira)

Joseph (Barnabas) 4: 32 – 37

- The believers were united. They shared their belongings amongst themselves and witnessed to the resurrection of the Lord Jesus and God blessed them. Many people joined them
- This passage gives an example of good early believers who contributed whole heartedly to the common fund of the early church
- For instance, this Joseph, a **Levite born in Cyprus, sold a field he owned**
- Then **gave all the money to the apostles**
- Thus, he was also named Barnabas by the apostles
- **Barnabas** means **one who encourages**

Ananias and Sapphira 5: 1 – 11

- This passage gives an example of bad early believers
- Ananias and his wife sold some property that belonged to them
- But with his wife's agreement, he kept part of the money for himself
- And handed the rest of the money over to the apostles
- Peter said to him
- Ananias, why did you let Satan take control of you and make you lie to the H S by keeping part of the money you received for the property?
- Before you sold the property, it belonged to you
- After you sold it, the money was yours
- Why did you decide to do such a thing? – You have not lied to men but to God
- As soon as Ananias heard this, he fell down dead
- All who heard about it were terrified
- The young men came in, wrapped up his body, carried him out and buried him

- About three hours later his wife, not knowing what had happened, came in
- Peter asked her, "Tell me, was this the full amount you and your husband received for your property?"
- "Yes", she answered "the full amount"
- Peter said to her, "Why did you and your husband decide to put the Lord's Spirit to the test?"
- The men who buried your husband are now at the door, they will carry you too
- At once she fell down and died. – the men buried her besides her husband
- All those who heard about this were terrified

Apostles in Solomon's Porch 5: 12 – 16

- They preached to people who gathered there
- Many people were converted and added to the group
- They also performed many miracles and wonders
- On this occasion Peter healed people even through his shadow

Arrest and imprisonment of the Apostles 5: 17 – 32

- When the chief priests, his companions and Sadducees noticed that the people were attracted to the teaching of the apostles, **they became jealousy of the apostles** and as a result they arrested the apostles
- They put them in public jail
- But at night the angel of God opened the prison gates and led the apostles out
- The angel said, "Go and stand in the temple and tell the people about the new life."
- The apostles did so and they entered the temple and started teaching
- When the Jewish council gathered and sent some officers to bring the apostles, they did not find them
- When they learnt that the apostles were at the temple, they sent the officers to take them to the council
- They were brought to the council without force because they were afraid that the people might stone them
- The chief priest asked them, "We gave you strict orders not to teach in the name of this man, but see what you have done! You have

spread your teaching all over Jerusalem, and you want to make us responsible for his death.”

- Peter replied
- We obey God rather than man
- The God of our ancestors raised Jesus from death, after you had killed him by nailing on the cross
- God raised him to his right-hand side as leader and saviour
- This gives the people of Israel chance to repent and have their sins forgiven
- We are witnesses to these things and so is the HS whom God gives to those who obey him

Gamaliel's advice 5: 33 – 42

- Following Peter's reply, the council wanted to kill all the apostles
- But a Pharisee named Gamaliel, and a highly respected teacher of law (e.g. of Saul) ordered the apostles to be taken out for a while, and said to the council
- Be careful what you want to do to these men
- Remember what happened to Theudas and Judas
- They claimed to be great and some people followed them
- But when they were killed, their followers were scattered and their movements died out
- Therefore, leave these apostles alone, do not take any action against them
- If what they have planned and done is of human origin, it will disappear naturally
- But if it comes from God, you cannot possibly defeat them. You could find yourselves fighting against God
- The council considered Gamaliel's advice
- They called the apostles in and whipped them
- They warned the apostles again not to preach in Jesus' name
- But as the apostles left, they were very happy because they had suffered for the sake of Jesus. They continued preaching in the Temple and people's homes

Spread of the early Church (through persecution)

The choice of seven deacons 6: 1 – 7

Background

It is usual that in some small Christian communities, there might be some disagreements. These could be due to leadership wrangles, discrimination or neglect of some kind. However, people of God should always find solutions to their problem

- Early believers comprised of converts from Hellenists and Hebrews
- Hellenists were Greek speaking Jews who were born outside Palestine but returned and lived in Jerusalem because of their faith
- Hebrews were native Jews i.e. Jews who were born and brought up in Palestine

Problem

- The Greek speaking Jews claimed that their widows were being neglected in the daily distribution of funds

Solution to the problem

- Peter proposed that they should choose seven helpers (i.e. deacons) to help in the daily distribution of funds
- This would enable the apostles to concentrate on preaching the good news which was their main work

Qualities of helpers to be chosen

- Must be full of the Holy Spirit
- Must be full of wisdom
- Must be full of faith
- Must be Hellenists

Seven men were chosen namely

- Stephen, Phillip, Prochorus, Nicanor, Timon, Parmenas and Nicolaus (a gentile from Antioch who had earlier been converted to Judaism)
- Stephen and Phillip were also good preachers
- The apostles prayed and placed their hands on them

The arrest of Stephen 6: 8 – 15

- Stephen was a good preacher
- He also performed many miracles and wonders
- However he was opposed by members of the synagogue of the freedmen
- That is
- Jews from Cyrene & Alexandria and Jews from Cilicia & Asia
- However Stephen was never refuted because he was filled with the HS
- Nevertheless Stephen was arrested and brought before the Jewish Council

Before the Jewish Council, **Stephen was accused of the following**

- Speaking against the Temple
- Speaking against the Laws of Moses
- Speaking against Moses himself
- Speaking against God

All those sitting in the council had their eyes fixed on Stephen and saw that his face looked like the face of an angel

The speech of Stephen 7: 1 – 53

- In his speech of defense to the accusations against him, Stephen gave a summary of the history of the Israelites. In his speech he indicated that
 - **God's presence cannot be localized in one place (like the Temple) but is meant for the whole world, thus**
 - God called Abraham in Mesopotamia
 - God was with the Jews in Egypt and in the desert for many years
 - The Tabernacle, which symbolized the presence of God, was taken around many places
 - Isaiah said God does not dwell in the house made with human hands since heaven is his throne and earth is his footstool and so what kind of a house can you build for him
 - **At all times the Jews have rejected their saviours (leaders) and thus failed to keep the law. For example**
 - Joseph was rejected by his own brothers and sold into Egypt
 - Moses was forced to flee into Midian when his fellow Jews turned against him

- Almost all the prophets were persecuted by their own people
- Finally, Stephen remarked, you rejected and killed Jesus – the saviour

Note

- This speech infuriated the Jewish council and they ground their teeth in anger
- But Stephen, full of the HS, looked up to heaven and said
- Look, I see heaven opened and the son of man standing at the right – hand side of God

Reactions of the crowd to this? / How Stephen died

- The members of the council covered their ears with their hands
- They all rushed at him at once
- They threw him out of the city
- And stoned him
- As they stoned him, Stephen said, “Lord Jesus receive my Spirit”
- He knelt down and cried out in a loud voice
- Lord! Do not remember this sin against them! He said this and died
- (same prayer as Jesus’ while on the cross)

Note: Stephen was the first martyr (i.e. a person to die because of his / her faith in Jesus). And Saul approved of Stephen’s death

Persecution by Saul 8: 1 – 3

- Under Saul cruel persecution broke out against the way of the Lord in Jerusalem
- All the believers, except the apostles, were scattered throughout the provinces of Judea and Samaria spreading the good news there.

Note: The persecution of the early believers was a blessing in disguise since it led to the spread of the good news and the early church. The believers who were scattered to various places spread the good news wherever they were given asylum.

The Gospel is preached in Samaria 8: 4 – 25

- Phillip, one of the seven helpers, fled to Samaria
- **While in Samaria, Phillip**
 - preached the Messiah to the people
 - performed many miracles
 - cast out evil spirit
 - healed many paralyzed men
- **As a result, many Samaritans were converted and baptized**
 - One of the converts there was **Simon the magician (Simon Magus)** named **the Great power of God** just because he astonished the people with his magic
 - Note that when Simon was converted and baptized, he stayed close to Phillip and was astounded with the miracles and wonders of Phillip
- **When the apostles heard that the Samaritans had been converted,** they sent **Peter** and **John** to them
 - Peter and John prayed and laid their hands on the Samaritan converts and they received the Holy Spirit
 - Then Simon the magician **offered money to Peter and John** and said, "Give this power to me too, so that anyone I place my hands on will receive the HS." (He wanted to buy the power of giving the HS)
- But Peter severely rebuked Simon saying**
 - May you and your money go to hell for thinking that you can buy God's gift with money
 - You have no part or share in our work
 - Your heart is not right in God's sight
 - You are full of bitter envy
 - You are a prisoner of sin
 - Repent and pray so that God will forgive you
- Simon repented and belonged to the way of the Lord
 - Then Peter and John went back to Jerusalem
 - On their way they preached the good news in many villages in Samaria

Phillip and the Ethiopian Eunuch 8: 26 – 40

- An angel of the Lord sent Phillip to the desert road near Gaza
- Then on the way, the HS asked him to join the Ethiopian Eunuch in his carriage
- The Ethiopian Eunuch was an important official in charge of the treasury of the queen of Ethiopia
- He was coming from Jerusalem where he had gone to worship God
- He was reading the book of the prophet Isaiah (53: 7 -8)
- Phillip asked him if he was understanding the passage
- The Eunuch in turn invited Phillip into his carriage to explain the passage
- Phillip then told the good news of salvation through Jesus who was described in the passage
- The Eunuch believed and was baptized, then the Spirit took Phillip away
- He found himself in Azotus and then went to Caesaria

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Chapter 3

PAUL'S MISSIONARY JOURNEY

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CHAPTER 3: Paul's missionary journey

Objectives

By the end of this chapter, the students must be able to:

Contents

- Paul's conversion
- Paul's first missionary journey
- meeting in Jerusalem
- Paul's second missionary journey
- Paul's third missionary journey
- Paul's arrest and trial
- Paul's appeal to the Emperor and the journey to Rome

Conversion of Saul

Who was Saul?

- He was a Jew from Tarsus
- He went to Jerusalem to study the Jewish law under Gamaliel
- He became a Pharisee
- He was a fanatic supporter of Judaism
- He inherited Roman citizenship from his father
- He learnt Greek culture and language

The conversion of Saul 9: 1 – 19

- Saul got permission from the High Priest to persecute believers at Damascus
- He left for Damascus with his group
- On the road near Damascus, Saul had a vision
- It was about noon

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- He saw a bright light from the sky flashing round him
- He fell to the ground and heard a voice saying to him
- Saul! Saul! Why do you persecute me?
- Who are you Lord? Saul asked
- I am Jesus whom you persecute, the voice said
- But get up and go into the city where you will be told what you must do
- Saul's followers heard the voice but did not see anyone
- Saul got up from the ground and opened his eyes but could not see a thing
- So they led him into the city of Damascus
- He stayed at the house of Judas in Straight Street for three days without eating or drinking anything
- As he was praying God said to him that he was going to preach to the Jews and gentiles with much suffering
- Then God told Ananias, a local believer to go and pray for Saul
- Ananias, at first, objected to go for fear of being persecuted
- After God's assurance of Saul's repentance and new mission, Ananias went to Saul, prayed for him
- He placed hands on Saul and said brother Saul, Jesus who appeared to you has sent me so that you might see again and be filled with the Holy Spirit
- At once something like a fish scale fell from Saul's eyes and was able to see again
- He stood up and was baptized
- After he had eaten his strength came back

Saul preaches in Damascus 9: 19b – 25

- Saul went to the synagogue and began to preach that Jesus was the son of God
- All who heard him were amazed and asked
- Isn't he the one who in Jerusalem was killing those who worshipped that man Jesus? And didn't he come here to persecute the believers
- But Saul's preaching that Jesus was the Messiah was so convincing that the Jews who lived in Damascus could not answer him
- Thus some unbelieving Jews plotted to kill him
- Saul's own followers rescued him by lowering him in a basket through a window at night

Saul in Jerusalem 9: 26 – 31

- From Damascus Saul went to Jerusalem and tried to join the believers / disciples
- However the disciples were afraid of Saul
- Then Barnabas took Saul to the apostles and reassured them of Saul's conversion
- Saul was accepted
- He began to preach in Jerusalem boldly until the Greek speaking Jews plotted to kill him
- When the believers learnt about this, they sent Saul to Tarsus through Caesarea

Note: At that moment the church enjoyed peace and multiplied

Peter at Lydda 9: 32 – 35

- Peter met Aeneas
- Aeneas was paralyzed and had not been able to get out of bed for eight years
- Peter said to Aeneas, "Jesus Christ makes you well, get up and make your bed"
- At once Aeneas got up

Peter at Joppa 9: 36 – 43

- In Joppa there was a woman named Tabitha or Dorcas (which means Deer)
- She was a believer
- She spent all her time doing charitable works e.g. making clothes for poor widows
- She became ill and died
- Her fellow believers sent two men to Lydda to invite Peter to assist them
- When Peter arrived, he was taken to the room upstairs
- The widows crowded round him crying and showing him all the shirts and coats that Dorcas made for them while she was alive
- Peter put them all out of the room and knelt down and prayed
- Then he turned to the body and said, "Tabitha! Get up"
- She opened her eyes, and when she saw Peter, she sat up
- Peter reached over and helped her get up
- Peter presented her to them alive

- When the news spread, many people believed in the Lord and were baptized

Note: At Joppa Peter stayed at the house of Simon the tanner of leather

Cornelius 10: 1 – 2

- He was from Caesarea
- He was a captain in the Italian Regiment
- He worshipped God (a God – fearer)
- He was a benefactor (doing charitable work like helping poor Jews)
- He was a prayerful man

Vision of Cornelius 10: 3 – 7

- It happened at three o'clock one afternoon
- He saw the angel of God
- The angel told him that God was pleased with his prayers and works of charity and was ready to answer him
- Thus Cornelius was asked to send some men to Joppa to invite Simon Peter who was staying at the house of Simon the tanner of leather
- Thus Cornelius sent two of his servants and a soldier

Peter's vision 10: 9 – 21

- Peter went on the roof, to pray, about noon
- He was hungry and wanted something to eat
- While the meal was being prepared he had a vision
- He saw heavens opened and something like a sheet being lowered by its four corners
- In it were all kinds of animals, reptiles and birds
- Peter then heard the voice, "Get up Peter, kill and eat"
- Peter denied on account that he had never eaten anything ritually unclean
- The voice said, "Do not consider anything unclean that God has declared to be clean"

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- This happened three times and then everything was taken up to heaven
- While wondering about the meaning of the vision, three men sent by Cornelius arrived at the gate looking for Peter
- The Holy Spirit told Peter about the visitors and asked him not to hesitate to go with them for God had sent them.

Note: The men were gentiles; Therefore from the vision Peter learnt that he should not consider gentiles as unclean

Thus the next day Peter went to Caesarea accompanied by some believers from Joppa

Peter at the house of Cornelius 10: 24 – 33

- Cornelius had invited his friends and relatives
- When Peter arrived, Cornelius fell at his feet, and bowed down before him
- But Peter made him rise: "Stand up, I myself am only a man"
- Peter kept talking to him as they went to where the people had gathered
- Peter said to the crowd and Cornelius: You know very well that a Jew is not allowed to mix with gentiles. But God has shown me that nobody is ritually unclean or defiled. That's why I am here. Why did you call me?
- Cornelius explained to Peter why he had sent for Peter basing on the vision he had about three days ago (Read 10: 30 – 33)
- Cornelius asked Peter to tell them any good news

Peter's speech 10: 34 – 43

- Peter pointed out that from the visions he had realized that God treats everyone on the same basis
- God has no favourite nation or race
- God accepts anybody who is righteous and worships Him
- God sent his son to save his people
- This Jesus did good and healed all those who were under the power of the devil: be it Jews or gentiles
- He was, however, crucified and died, but God raised him from the dead three days later
- After the resurrection, he appeared to those who ate and drank with Him i.e. to us
- We are witnesses

- He commanded us to preach the good news to all nations so that those who believe may have their sins forgiven

Note: 10: 44 – 48

- While Peter was still speaking, the HS came down on all those who were listening to his message and they began to speak in tongues too
- When Peter and other believers saw this, Peter baptized them since God had already approved of their conversion by giving them the HS

Peter explains his action 11:1 – 18

- Back to Jerusalem, Peter was criticized by members of Circumcision Party i.e. those who were in favour of circumcising gentiles if they were to be saved.

These accused Peter for

- going to the house of uncircumcised gentiles
- eating with uncircumcised gentiles
- and possibly for baptizing gentiles

Peter defended his action by telling them that everything was planned by God as he gave them a report about

- his own vision at Joppa
- Cornelius vision at Caesarea and
- The events that happened at the house of Cornelius i.e. how they received the HS

Note: When they heard Peter's report, they stopped criticizing Peter and admitted that God had also saved the gentiles and they praised God

The Church at Antioch 11: 19 -30

- At first the scattered believers preached only to the Jews
- However in Antioch, **believers from Cyprus and Cyrene proclaimed the good news to the gentiles**
- Many gentiles were converted and baptized
- **When the apostles in Jerusalem learnt that the gentiles at Antioch had been converted, they sent Barnabas(Joseph) to them**

- When Barnabas found out that many had believed, he invited **Saul** from Tarsus for an assistance
- They taught the converts for one year
- When **Agabus prophesied a world – wide – famine**, the believers at Antioch **sent relief (help)** to their fellow believers in Jerusalem through Barnabas and Saul
- It was at **Antioch in Syria** that the **believers were first called Christians**

The Third Imprisonment of Peter 12:1 – 19

- Herod Agrippa I killed James (brother of John) by the sword
- Many Jews were happy with this so Herod went on to arrest Peter so as **to please the Jews**
- This happened during the time of the festival of unleavened bread
- Thus Peter, after being arrested, was put in jail and guarded by four groups of four soldiers each waiting for the Passover celebrations to be over so that he can be tried
- Note that Jews were not allowed to hear any case during the week of the celebration of Passover
- While Peter was in jail the people of the church were praying earnestly to God for him
- The night before Peter was to appear for trial, angel of God rescued Peter from prison. (Read 12:6- 11 carefully)
- When Peter found himself out of the prison, he went to the house of Mary, the mother of John Mark, where people had gathered praying for him
- Peter knocked at the outside door, and a servant named Rhoda came to answer it
- She recognized Peter's voice and was so happy that she ran back without opening the door.
- She told the people that Peter was standing at the door
- At first the people told her that she was mad, but when she insisted they said it was his angel
- Peter kept on knocking and when they opened the door and saw that it was indeed Peter, they were amazed
- Peter explained to them how he had been rescued and he commanded them to tell that to James and the rest of the believers then he went somewhere else

- In the morning there was a great confusion among the guards as to what had happened to Peter
- Herod ordered the guards to fetch for Peter
- After they had failed to find Peter, he questioned the guards and ordered them to be put to death

The death of Herod 12: 20 – 25

- Herod was very angry with the people of Tyre and Sidon
- The people of Tyre and Sidon made an appointment with Herod through Blastus so that they should make peace with Herod since they were getting food supplies from Herod
- As he was addressing the people while seated on his throne on the chosen day, the people shouted, "it isn't a man speaking, but a god"
- At once the angel of God struck Herod down, because he did not give honour to God
- He was eaten by worms and died

a. Paul's first missionary journey (Acts 13 1- 52)

Paul and Barnabas are chosen and sent 13: 1 – 3

- The HS told the believers who were serving the Lord and fasting at Antioch in Syria that they should set apart Barnabas and Saul to do the work of preaching
- They fasted and prayed , placed their hands on them and sent them off
- As they left they were also accompanied by John Mark the cousin of Barnabas

On the Island of Cyprus 13: 4 – 12

- First they stopped at Salamis and preached the word of God in the synagogue
- Then they went to Paphos where they met Sergius Paulos the governor of the island with his friend a Jew Elymas the magician also known as Bar Jesus
- Sergius Paulos wanted to listen to the word of God proclaimed by Barnabas and Saul
- But Elymas opposed the governor from listening to the word of God
- Then Saul also known as Paul filled with the HS looked straight at the magician and said

- You son of the devil
- You are the enemy of everything that is good
- You are full of all kinds of evil tricks
- You always keep trying to turn the Lord's truth into lies
- The Lord's hand will come down on you now and you will not see the light of the day for a time
- This indeed happened to Elymas
- When the governor saw this he believed and was greatly amazed

At Perga 13: 13

- From the island they went to Perga where John mark left them and went back to Jerusalem

In Antioch in Pisidia 13: 14- 52

- At Antioch in Pisidia Paul was asked to preach in synagogue
- He told the history of the people of Israel i.e. their stay in Egypt; their wilderness experience for 40 years; their conquest of Canaan; the period of Judges and king; he also talked about king David and the promise of a saviour preceded by John the Baptist
- He then continued that the saviour had already come i.e. Jesus Christ
- The Jews did not recognize him and so they fulfilled the prophesy by killing him
- But God raised him from the dead
- He appeared to those who had traveled with him from Galilee to Jerusalem for many days. (They are now witness to all people in Israel)
- We now bring the good news that through faith in Jesus forgiveness of sins is possible to all (which the law of Moses could not do)
- But those who scoff at this news will perish
- Many people Jews and gentiles alike believed
- They agreed to meet the following Sabbath day for more teaching
- The next Sabbath nearly everyone in the town came to hear the word of the Lord
- When the Jews saw the crowd, they became jealousy; they disputed what Paul was saying and insulted them
- Paul and Barnabas said, **"It was necessary that the word of God should be spoken first to you. But since you reject it**

and do not consider yourselves worthy of eternal life, we will leave you and go to the Gentiles ...”

- When the gentiles heard this, they were glad and praised the Lord
- Later on some Jews stirred up the leading men of the city and the Gentile women of high social standing who worshipped God
- They started a persecution against Paul and Barnabas and drove them out of that region
- Paul and Barnabas shook the dust off their feet in protest against them and went on to Iconium

In Iconium 14: 1 – 7

- Like in Antioch in Pisidia, Paul and Barnabas preached in the synagogue and many Jews and gentiles believed
- But the unbelieving Jews stirred up the Gentiles against the apostles; they decided to ill – treat the apostles and stone them
- When the apostles learnt about it, they fled to Lystra

In Lystra 14: 8 – 20

- There was a man who had been lame since his birth
- He sat there and listened to Paul’s words
- Paul saw that he believed and could be healed, so he looked straight at him and said in a loud voice
- Stand up straight on your feet
- The man jumped up and started walking around

Reactions of the people to the miracle

- They started shouting in their own Lycaonian language
- The gods have become like men and have come down to us
- They gave Barnabas the name Zeus and Paul the name Hermes because he was a chief speaker
- The priest of the god Zeus and other people brought bulls and flowers so as to offer sacrifice to the apostles

Reactions of the apostles to what people wanted to do

- They tore their clothes and ran into the middle of the crowd, shouting
- Why are you doing this? We are only human beings like you!

- We are here to announce the Good news, to turn you away from these worthless things to the living God the creator of everything
- God has always given evidence of his existence by the good things he does
- He gives you rain from heaven and crops at the right time; he gives you food and fills your hearts with happiness
- Then some unbelieving Jews arrived from Antioch in Pisidia and Iconium and won the crowd over to their side
- They stoned Paul and dragged him out of the town, thinking he was dead
- When the believers gathered round him, he got up and went back into the town
- The next day he and Barnabas went to Derbe

In Derbe 14: 21a

- Paul and Barnabas preached the good news in Derbe and made many disciples
- This shows that God saves mankind through Jesus Christ

The return to Antioch in Syria 14: 21b – 28

- They went back to Lystra, to Iconium and on to Antioch in Pisidia
- They strengthened the believers and encouraged them stressing that suffering (tribulation) is part of the price of salvation (entering the Kingdom of God)
- They also appointed leaders to lead the believers
- Then they returned to Antioch in Syria via Perga and Attalia
- In Antioch in Syria they reported to the church and stressed that a door of faith had been opened to the gentiles

b. The meeting in Jerusalem

The problem of Circumcision of Gentile converts

- Upon arrival in Antioch in Syria, Paul noticed that the problem of circumcision of Gentile converts was waiting for him to solve
- Some Christian Jews from Jerusalem taught the gentile converts that they could not be saved unless they were circumcised and followed the laws of Moses
- This was contrary to Paul's teaching
- Paul debated with the Christian Jews for a long time

- To solve the problem, they decided to go to the Church in Jerusalem for enlightenment

The meeting of Jerusalem Council

- The Council included the apostles, elders, Barnabas & Saul and some believers from Antioch

Aim of the meeting

- To settle / discuss whether the circumcision of the Gentiles was necessary for them to be saved or not
- Some believers who belonged to the party of the Pharisees or members of the Circumcision Party taught that gentiles must be circumcised and told to obey the law of Moses

Contributions made during the discussion

Peter said

- A long time ago God chose me from among you to preach the Good News to the Gentiles (cf. Cornelius' conversion)
- God, who knows the thoughts of everyone, showed his approval of the Gentiles by giving them the HS, just as he had to us
- He made no difference between us and them; he forgave their sins because of their faith
- So then, why do you now want to put God to test by laying a load on the backs of the believers which neither our ancestors nor we ourselves were able to carry
- (This refers to the numerous laws which Jews had to keep in order to be saved and which drove them to despair because they knew they were failing)
- No! we believe and are saved by the grace of the Lord Jesus, just as they are

Paul and Barnabas

- They gave an account of all the miracles and wonders that God enabled them to perform among the Gentiles on their journey proving that God accepted the gentiles as they were i.e. without Jewish laws

James (possibly the brother of Jesus and leader in Jerusalem) **said**

- Simon has just explained how God first showed his care for the Gentiles by taking among them a people to belong to him
- This was foretold by prophets like Amos and Isaiah
- I recommend that we do not trouble the gentiles with the Jewish laws

- Instead we should ask the gentile converts to follow these rules
 - Not to eat meat of an animal offered to idols
 - Not to eat meat of an animal that has been strangled
 - Not to eat blood
 - To keep themselves from sexual immorality
- The council accepted this recommendation
- They wrote a letter to gentile converts at Antioch indicating that
 - The Judaisers had insisted on gentiles' circumcision without authority from Jerusalem
 - Paul and Barnabas are the only recognized Apostles to you gentiles
 - The Holy Spirit and we have agreed not to put any other burden on you besides these four rules (then they outlined the rules as seen above)
 - The letter was taken by Barnabas and Saul. However, they were also accompanied by Silas and Judas / Barsabbas who were appointed to deliver the same message in person

Note:

- The four rules were old injunctions (Lev. 17: 10 – 15; 18: 6 – 18 , 26) which in the past had been imposed upon Gentiles living with the Jews in the same land
- By following these "holiness" rules out of respect for God's people they made it easier for the Jews to accept them on the same soil
- Likewise, acceptance of council rules will make it possible for Christian Jews and Christian Gentiles to live together as communities sharing the same bread

Paul's second missionary journey

Paul and Barnabas Separated 15: 36 – 41

- When Paul suggested that he and Barnabas should visit the churches founded during their first missionary journey, Barnabas wanted to take John Mark along
- Paul refused because John Mark did not stay with them to the end of their mission
- There was a sharp argument, and they separated
- Barnabas departed for Cyprus with John Mark, whilst Paul departed with Silas

Churches visited 16: 1 – 8

- Paul visited the churches at Derbe and Lystra
- At Lystra Paul met a Christian named Timothy, a native of Lystra itself
- Timothy's father was a Greek and his mother (Eunice a Christian also) was a Jew
- All believers spoke well of Timothy
- Paul decided to take Timothy along with him, so he circumcised him
- Paul circumcised him so as to increase his influence on the Jews
- Later, Timothy became the bishop of Ephesus
- From Derbe Paul continued his journey through Iconium, Antioch Pisidia, Phrygia and Galatia to Troas
- Note that as he passed through the provinces of Asia the HS told them not to preach the good news there (The HS guides the church)

In Troas 16: 9 – 10

- At Troas Paul had a vision; He saw a Macedonian standing and begging him
- "Come over to Macedonia and help us"
- This was a clear indication that God called him to Macedonia (Greece) and so we went there without hesitation. Luke joined Paul (use of **we**)

In Philippi 16: 11 – 40

Conversion of Lydia

- From Troas they went to Philippi, and on a Sabbath day they went to the river bank where they thought there would be a place where Jews gathered for prayer
- There they met some women praying and among them was Lydia
- Lydia was from Thyatira and was a dealer in purple clothes
- After listening to the word of God preached by Paul, she was converted and baptized and then she invited Paul and his companions to stay at her house

The imprisonment of Paul and Silas

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- One day as Paul and his companions were going to the place of prayer, they met a slave girl with a spirit of divination
- The evil spirit enabled her to predict people's future and the owners of the girl profited from her soothsaying. She was called a **Python girl**
- She followed them and shouted, "These men are servants of the Most High God! They announce to you how you can be saved"
- She did this for many days until Paul was so upset and turned round and said to the spirit, "In the name of Jesus Christ I order you to come out of her"
- The spirit went out of her that very moment
- When her owners realized that their chance of making money was gone, they seized Paul and Silas and dragged them to the Roman officials

Accusations against Paul and Silas before the Roman officials (Magistrate)

- these men are Jews
- they are causing trouble in our city
- they are teaching customs that are against our law
- (we are Roman citizens and we cannot accept these customs or practice them)

Reaction of the officials

- They tore the clothes of Silas and Paul
- Ordered the two to be beaten (whipped)
- After a severe beating they were thrown into jail and the jailer was ordered to lock them up tight

In the prison

- The jailer threw them into the inner cell and fastened their feet between heavy blocks of wood
- About midnight Paul and Silas were praying and singing hymns to God
- Suddenly there was a violent earthquake which shook the prison to its foundation
- At once all the doors opened and the chains fell off all the prisoners
- The jailer woke up and when he saw the doors opened he was scared and thought that all the prisoners had escaped

- Thus he pulled out his sword and was about to kill himself
- Paul stopped him from committing suicide since everybody was there
- The jailer called for a light, rushed in and fell trembling at the feet of Paul and Silas

At the jailer's house

- He led them out and asked, "Sirs, what must I do to be saved?"
- Paul told him to believe in Jesus and then he and his family would be saved
- After preaching the good news he and his family believed and were baptized
- Note that at the house, the jailer washed their wounds

The next morning

- The Roman officer (magistrate) learnt about what had happened and so he sent police officers with the order, "let those men go"
- The jailer informed Paul that the officer has sent an order for them to be released and that they may leave and go in peace
- Paul said to the police officers, "we were not found guilty of any crime, yet they whipped us in public- and we are Roman citizens! Then they threw us in prison. And now they want to send us away secretly. Not likely! The Roman officials themselves must come here and let us out."
- When the Roman officers learnt that Paul and Silas were Roman citizens they were afraid, went there, apologized and then led them out of prison.
- They went to the house of Lydia and spoke words of encouragement to them and then left

In Thessalonica 17: 1 – 9

- Paul preached in the synagogue for 3 weeks
- He held discussion with the people; quoting, explaining and proving from the scriptures that the Messiah had to suffer and rise from death
- Many Jews and Greeks believed and joined Paul and Silas
- But some unbelieving Jews gathered worthless loafers from the street and formed a mob

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- They set the whole city in an uproar and attacked the house of Jason who kept them, they wanted Jason to let out Paul and Silas to the people
- When they did not find Paul and Silas, they arrested Jason and other believers and brought him before the city authorities where they were accused of
 - Receiving rebels who have caused trouble everywhere
 - Breaking the laws of the emperor, saying that there is another king whose name is Jesus
 - Jason paid a fine and the believers were released and they sent Paul to Berea at night.

In Berea

- Paul preached the good news in the synagogue
- The people of Berea were open minded; they listened to the word of God eagerly and studied the scriptures to see if what Paul said was true
- Many Jews, Greek women of high social standing and many Greek men believed
- However, when the unbelieving Jews from Thessalonica arrived at Berea, they started exciting and stirring up the mob against Paul and Silas
- The believers sent Paul away and he went to Athens while Silas and Timothy remained behind

In Athens 17: 16 – 34

- Athens was a centre of learning where many different religions were found
- When Paul preached Jesus and the Resurrection, they thought he was preaching about many gods
- Thus they asked Paul to speak at the Aeropagus i.e. a place where religious matters were discussed

Paul said

- There are many altars, a sign that you are prayerful people
- However God does not live in temples since he is God and creator of the whole universe
- He is near to each one of us; as someone said, **"in him we live, move and exist"**
- He made us so that we will look for Him and worship Him

- We must not think that such a God can be represented by gold or stone idols
- God will ignore this ignorance if you repent because he will judge the world through Jesus (a man) who died and was raised by God
- Some mocked him but a few believed e.g. Dionysius and Damaris
- He then left Athens for Corinth

In Corinth 18: 1 – 28

- At Corinth, known for its immorality, Paul stayed with Aquila and Priscilla since they had the same interest of making tents
- Paul worked with them while he taught in the synagogue every Sabbath
- After sometime, Silas and Timothy arrived from Berea and joined Paul
- This enabled Paul to dedicate his whole time to preaching while they made tents
- When the Jews opposed him, he left them, dusted his feet and said, "If you are lost, you yourselves must take the blame for it! I am not responsible. From now on I will go to the Gentiles"
- He then continued teaching in the house of Titius Justus, next to the synagogue
- Crispus, ruler of the synagogue, and his household believed

Paul's vision at Corinth

- He had a vision in which the Lord said to him
- Do not be afraid
- Keep on speaking and do not give up, for I am with you
- No one will be able to harm you, for many in this city are my people (An example that God saves mankind through Jesus directly)

- Paul taught there for a year and a half
- **Then the Jews brought him before Gallio the Roman governor of Achai**
- They accused Paul of persuading people to worship God in a way that was against their law
- Gallio said if Paul had committed a crime, he would have been patient with the Jews and judged the case

- But since it was an argument about words and names and their own law, he refused to judge the case and told them to settle it among themselves

(This is an example that the author has got sympathy to the Romans)

Reaction of the Jews

- They seized Sosthenes, the leader of the synagogue and beat him in front of the court

Possible reasons why Gallio refused to judge the case against Paul

- Possibly he regarded Christianity as a branch of Judaism and so the case was not a matter of Roman but of Jewish law and therefore outside his jurisdiction
- Possibly he regarded Christianity as a legal movement
- Possibly he felt that the Christians had not done anything against the state and so were innocent according to the law

Note

- Aquila and Priscilla were banned from Rome with all Jews living there by emperor Claudius because the preaching of Christianity caused so many disturbances there
- Paul stayed on with the believers for many days and then left for Syria
- At Cenchreae Paul shaved his head because of the vow he had taken
- Then he left Aquila and Priscilla in Ephesus and went to Caesarea and then to Jerusalem

Apollos in Ephesus 18: 24 – 28

Apollos

- He was a Jew born in Alexandria in Egypt
- He was an eloquent speaker
- He had a thorough knowledge of the scriptures
- He was taught about the way of the Lord and consequently he proclaimed and taught facts about Jesus correctly
- However he knew the baptism of John only
- Aquila and Priscilla took him home and explained to him more correctly the way of God
- Then Apollos went to Corinth (Achai) where he was able to convince many Jews that Jesus was the Messiah in public debates

- Believers in Corinth eventually described themselves as his followers, but Paul pointed out that all believers were followers of Jesus Christ (1 Cor. 3: 4 – 6)

d. Paul's third missionary journey 19: 1 – 41

In Ephesus 19: 1 – 20

- From Antioch in Syria, Paul traveled overland to Ephesus
- **12 Disciples of Apollos**
- He found 12 disciples who had received John's baptism of repentance
- (They were probably disciples of Apollos)
- Paul preached Jesus to them and they were baptized in the name of the Lord
- And after he had placed his hands on them they received the HS and spoke in tongues and proclaimed God's message
- **He argued with the Jews in the synagogue for three months**
- But they were stubborn so he left then and continued teaching in the hall of Tyrannus for two years where many Jews and Gentiles were converted
- **Paul's miracles in Ephesus**
- God was performing unusual miracles through Paul
- Even handkerchiefs and aprons he had used were taken to those who were ill and placed on them and they were healed or evil spirits were driven away
- **Seven sons of Sceva**
- Sceva was a Jewish High Priest and had seven sons
- These sons tried to drive out evil spirit in the name of the Lord Jesus
- They said to the evil spirit, "I command you in the name of Jesus, whom Paul preaches"
- But the evil spirit said to them, "I know Jesus, and I know about Paul; but you - who are you?"
- The man who had an evil spirit attacked and wounded them all
- They ran away from his house wounded with their clothes torn off

Reactions of the people (Jews and Gentiles)

- They were all filled with fear and the name of the Lord Jesus was given greater honour
- Many people publicly admitted and revealed what they had done

- Those who practiced magic brought their books together and burnt them in public
- They added up the price of their books and the total came to 50,000 silver coins
- **The Riot in Ephesus**
- After these Paul made up his mind to leave the place and go to Jerusalem
- "After I go there I must also see Rome" he said
- It was at this time that there was serious trouble in Ephesus because of the way of the Lord
- A certain silver smith named Demetrius made silver models of their goddess Artemis and his business used to make a great deal of profit
- When many people believed in Paul's teaching, many of them stopped buying the silver models of Artemis. **In other words Paul teaching jeopardized his business**

Demetrius Speech

He called for a meeting of all silver smiths and said

- Men you know that our prosperity comes from this work
- Now you can see and hear for yourselves what this fellow is doing
- He says that gods made by human hands are not gods at all and many people have believed him both here in Ephesus and in the province of Asia
- There is the danger, then, that this business of ours will get a bad name
- There is also the danger that the temple of the great goddess Artemis (also known as Diana) will come to mean nothing
- And the greatness of our goddess Artemis will be destroyed

Reaction of the crowd to the speech

- They became furious and started shouting, "Great is Artemis of Ephesus"
- The uproar spread throughout the whole city
- They seized Gaius and Aristarchus who were traveling with Paul and rushed with them to the theatre
- Believers prevented Paul to go there although he himself wanted to
- While there some people shouted one thing other people were shouting something else because most of them did not even know why they came together
- Some Jews asked Alexander to address the Mob

- He motioned with his hand for the people to be silent and started to speak
- When they recognized that he was a Jew, they all shouted together the same thing for two hours: **"Great is Artemis of Ephesus"**

The speech of the town clerk of Ephesus

- Fellow Ephesians everyone knows that the city of Ephesus is the keeper of the temple of the great Artemis and of the sacred stone that fell down from heaven
- Nobody can deny these things; so you must calm down
- You have brought these men here although they have not robbed temples or said evil things about our goddess
- If the silversmiths have an accusation against anyone, we have courts where charges can be made
- If there is something more , it can be settled in a legal meeting of citizens
- If the uproar continues we will be accused of a riot and we will not be able to give a good reason for it
- After saying this he dismissed the meeting

Paul's journey through Macedonia and Greece to Troas (Acts 20:1 – 38)

- Paul left Ephesus and spent 3 months in Greece where he strengthened the believers
- But when some Jews plotted against him, he went to Troas

Paul's last visit to Troas

- On Saturday evening believers including Luke gathered for the fellowship meal
- Paul gave a very long farewell speech
- A young man named Eutychus who was sitting in the window of the third storey got sleepier and sleepier and finally fell down dead
- Paul went down and threw himself on him and hugged him and was raised
- Then they broke the bread and ate it
- Paul continued preaching until day break and he then left

The Elders of Ephesus 20: 13 – 38

- Paul left Troas and sailed for Jerusalem where he wanted to be for Pentecost
- But at Miletus he stopped to meet the elders of Ephesus and addressed them

Paul's farewell speech at Miletus

➤ **Past effort**

- Paul recalled what he had done among them
- He stated that while I lived among you I served God humbly despite troubles and plots by the Jews
- I taught in public and privately to the Jews and Greeks alike that repentance and faith in Christ is necessary

➤ **Future plan**

- He pointed out clearly that the Holy Spirit has urged him to go to Jerusalem
- Although he would suffer while there since the HS had warned him that prison and troubles wait for him, Paul expressed that he was prepared not only to suffer but also to die there
- His wish was to be a true witness

➤ **Advice**

- Paul pointed out clearly that the elders would no longer see him
- As such they were to be responsible for the church at Ephesus
- The HS has made them overseers
- They had to take care of the flock and stand on their feet to guard the flock against wolves i.e. false teachers
- Finally he advised them to take his example as leaders
- **i.e. there is more happiness in giving than in receiving**
- thus instead of begging I worked for my own living so that I could help others
- As leaders do likewise

➤ **Finally Paul knelt down with them and prayed**

- they hugged him and kissed him goodbye
- they were very sad just because Paul had made it very clear to them that they will never see him again

e. Paul goes to Jerusalem 21: 1 – 16

- During his return, he stopped at Tyre and Caesarea and said goodbye to the believers

At Tyre

- Paul stayed with the believers for a week
- By the power of the Holy Spirit they told Paul not to go Jerusalem for fear of persecution but Paul did not take their advice (The Holy Spirit guides the church)
- Finally they prayed and Paul including Luke sailed to Caesarea (Prayer is vital in the life of the church)

At Caesarea

- Paul and his companions stayed at the house of Phillip the evangelist, one of the seven deacons
- He had four unmarried daughters who also proclaimed the good news
- Whilst there the prophet **Agabus** arrived from Judea and **prophesied that Paul would be arrested in Jerusalem**
- **He took Paul's belt and tied up his own hands with it and said;** "This is what the HS says: The owner of this belt will be tied up in this way by the Jews in Jerusalem, and they will hand him to the gentiles."
- When the people learnt about this they asked Paul not to go to Jerusalem
- But Paul said that he was ready not only to suffer but also to die there for the sake of Jesus
- Then Paul left Caesarea together with Mnason in whose house they were to stay in Jerusalem. Originally Mnason was from Cyprus.

f. The arrest of Paul in the Temple 21: 17 – 40

- Paul addressed the believers at the house of James
- The Jewish Christians in Jerusalem warned Paul that he was suspected of telling Jewish believers in Gentile regions **to abandon the Law of Moses i.e. not to be circumcised and not to follow the Jewish customs**
- Paul was advised to undergo the ritual of purification (together with the four other believers) because of having been in contact with gentiles and to shave his hair.

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- This would convince the Jewish believers that Paul did speak against the Jewish laws apart from telling the gentile converts the decision of the Jerusalem Council
- Note that Paul had to go under the ritual of purification for seven days and was expected to pay for all the cost of the ritual of purification
- Towards the end of the days of purification days, some Jews from Asia came to the Temple
- They recognized Paul and then stirred up the crowd by saying
- Men of Israel help
- **This is the man who goes everywhere teaching everyone against the people Israel, the Laws of Moses and this Temple.**
- **In addition he has defiled the Temple by taking the gentiles into it (i.e. Trophimus)**
- They dragged Paul out of the temple and the mob was trying to kill Paul
- When the army commander (Lysanias) learnt about it he went there with some soldiers
- When the mob saw the soldiers they stopped beating Paul
- The soldiers arrested Paul and the commander asked the people what crime Paul had committed
- When he failed to get a clear explanation from the excited crowd, he took Paul to the barracks
- The commander thought that Paul was an Egyptian rebel

Paul's defence

- As they were going to the barracks, Paul in Hebrew asked the commander to speak to the crowd
- This surprised the army commander who up to this point thought that Paul was an Egyptian rebel who started a revolution and led four thousand armed terrorists out into the desert
- Paul told the commander that he was a Jew born in Tarsus
- Upon hearing this the commander gave Paul the permission to speak to the people
- Paul said to the crowd:
 - My fellow Jews listen to me as I make my defence before you

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- I am a Jew, born in Tarsus in Cilicia, but brought up in Jerusalem as a student of Gamaliel
- I received strict instruction in the law of our ancestors and was just as dedicated to God as are all of you who are here today
- I persecuted to death the people who followed this way
- I arrested men and women and threw them into prison
- The high priest and the whole council can prove that I am telling the truth
- As I was traveling to Damascus to persecute the believers, I met God on the way
- He converted me (22: 6 – 12)
- Ananias came to me and returned my sight after confessing my sins and calling or believing in God
- I returned to Jerusalem and in a vision in the Temple God told me that he would send me to the Gentiles
- When he mentioned the word Gentiles, the people started shouting at the top of their voices, "Away with him! Kill him! He's not fit to live!"
- They were screaming, waving their clothes, and throwing dust up in the air
- Then the army commander took Paul into the fort

In the Fort

- The army commander (Claudius Lysias) ordered the soldiers to whip Paul so as to find out why the Jews were screaming against Paul
- When they had tied up Paul to be whipped, Paul said to the officer standing there, "Is it lawful for you to whip a Roman citizen who hasn't even been tried for any crime?"
- The commander asked Paul, Tell me are you a Roman citizen?"
- "Yes," answered Paul
- "I became one by paying a large amount of money." The commander said
- "But I am one by birth," Paul said
- The commander was frightened when he realized that Paul was a Roman citizen and that he had put him in chains

Paul before the Jewish Council 22: 30 – 23: 11

- The commander wanted to find out for certain what the Jews were accusing Paul of

- So the next day he called for the Jewish council to give their accusations against Paul in his presence
- When the council convened the army commander took Paul and made him stand before them
- Paul looked straight at the council and said
 - My fellow Israelites! My conscience is perfectly clear about the way in which I have lived before God to this very day
 - The high priest (Ananias) ordered those who were standing close to Paul to strike him on the mouth.
 - Paul said to Ananias
- God will certainly strike you – you whitewashed wall! You sit there to judge me according to the law, yet you break the law by ordering them to strike me
- Some men told him that he was insulting God's high priest
- And Paul answered, "My fellow – Israelites, I did not know that he was the high priest. The scripture says, "You must not speak evil of the ruler of your people"

Saul noticed that the council comprised of the Pharisees and Sadducees and so he called out

- "Fellow- Israelites! I am a Pharisee, the son of Pharisees. I am on trial here because of the hope I have that the dead will rise to life"
- This made the Pharisees and Sadducees to start quarreling and the group was divided. (Sadducees didn't believe in the resurrection, angels and spirits while Pharisees believed in all three)
- The argument became so violent that the commander was afraid that Paul would be torn to pieces
- So he ordered his soldiers to take Paul away from them and keep him in the fort again

Jesus saves Paul directly 23: 11

- That night the Lord stood by Paul and said
- Do not be afraid! You have given your witness here in Jerusalem, and you must also do the same in Rome.

The plot against Paul's life 23: 12 – 22

- More than 40 Jews took a vow that they would not eat or drink anything until they had killed Paul
- They disclosed their plan to the chief priests and elders

- They asked for their favour saying, you and the council send word to the Roman commander to bring Paul down to you, pretending that you want to get more accurate information about him
- We will be ready to kill him before he gets here
- Fortunately the son of Paul's sister heard about the plot
- So he went to the fort and told Paul
- Paul referred the young man to the Commander
- When the commander learnt about the plot, he told the young not to tell anyone that he had reported it to him and then he sent the boy away

Paul sent to Governor Felix 23: 23 – 35

- The commander sent Paul to the governor Felix at Caesarea under strong escort at night.
- The commander wrote a letter to the governor that went like this:
 - Claudius Lysias to His Excellency, the governor Felix: Greetings
 - The Jews seized this man and were about to kill him
 - I learnt that he was a Roman citizen, so I went with my soldiers and rescued him
 - I wanted to know what they were accusing him of, so I took him down to their council
 - I found out that he had not done anything for which he deserved to die or be put in prison
 - The accusation against him had to do with questions about their own law
 - And when I was informed that there was a plot against him, at once I decided to send him to you
 - I have told his accusers to make their charges against him before you
- The governor read the letter and when he found out that Paul was from the province of Cilicia, he said I will hear you when your accusers arrive
- Then he gave orders for Paul to be kept under guard in the governor's headquarters (apply themes)

Accusations against Paul before Felix 24: 1 – 9

- The accusations of the Jews, against Paul, **were presented by their lawyer Tertullus**
- The lawyer said Your Excellency! Your wise leadership has brought to us a long period of peace, and many necessary reforms are being made for the good of our country.
- We welcome this and are deeply grateful to you
- So I beg you to be kind and listen to our account
 - **we found this man to be a dangerous nuisance**
 - **he starts riots among the Jews all over the world**
 - **he is a leader of the party of Nazarenes (a faction of Judaism which operates without government's permission)**
 - **he also tried to defile the Temple, and we arrested him**
- If you question this man, you yourself will be able to learn from him all the things that we are accusing him of.
- The Jews present consented that it was true

Paul's defence before Felix 24: 10 – 21

- Paul said, "I know that you have been a judge over this nation for many years and so I am happy to defend myself before you.
- I know my accusers cannot prove their allegations
- You, Felix, can easily investigate this, because it all happened within the last twelve days.
 - I went to Jerusalem to worship
 - The Jews did not find me arguing with anyone in the Temple, nor did they find me stirring up the people, either in the synagogues or anywhere in the city
 - I do admit this to you: I worship the God of our ancestors by following that way of the Lord which they say is false
 - But I also believe in everything written in the Law of Moses and the books of prophets
 - I have the same hope in God that these themselves have i.e. all people both good and bad will rise from death.
 - After being away from Jerusalem for many years, I went there to take money to my own people who were undergoing the ritual of purification and to offer sacrifice to God
 - I did not defile the Temple
 - It was while I was doing this that they found me in the Temple
 - There was no crowd with me and no disorder

- Some Jews from Asia were there; let them come before you and present their accusations if they have anything against me
- Or let these who are here tell what crime they found me guilty of when I stood before the council – except for the one thing I called out when I stood before them : “I am being tried by you today for believing that the dead will rise to life”
- Felix, who was well informed about the way of Lord, realized that Paul was not guilty
- Thus he brought the hearing to an end and kept Paul in prison for two years
- He did this because he feared the Jews and so preferred to postpone the verdict buying time
- While in prison, he ordered the officer in charge of Paul to keep him under guard, but also to give him some freedom and allow his friends to provide for his need. (This shows that the author has got sympathy to the Romans)
- Note that Felix and his wife Drusilla often listened to Paul. As Paul talked about goodness, self- control and the coming Day of Judgement, Felix was afraid.
- **As Felix listened to Paul , he hoped that perhaps Paul would bribe him by giving him some money in order to be released**
- Paul never did that until Felix was replaced by Festus

Note:

- Felix was the governor of Palestine from 52 – 59 AD.
- He was an ex – slave
- He lured away Drusilla from her former husband and married her as the third wife

Paul before Festus 25: 1 – 12

- Soon after Felix had succeeded Felix, he went to Jerusalem where the Jewish authorities informed him of Paul’s case.
- They asked him for a favour to have Paul’s case heard at Jerusalem
- They still had the intention of killing him on the way
- Festus replied that Paul was being kept a prisoner in Caesarea, and he would be going back there soon
- Let your leaders go to Caesarea with me and accuse the man if he has done anything wrong
- After eight or ten days, Festus went to Caesarea

- On the next day, he sat down in the court of Judgement and ordered Paul to be brought in

Accusations against Paul before Festus

- They brought many accusations against him which they could not prove including
 - doing things against the Law of the Jews
 - speaking against the Temple
 - speaking against the Roman Emperor
- Paul defended himself: "I have done nothing wrong against the Law of the Jews or against the Temple or against the Roman Emperor."

g. Paul appeals to the Emperor

- Festus wanted to gain favour with the Jews, so he asked Paul, "would you be willing to go to Jerusalem and be tried on the charges before me there?"
- Paul said, "I am standing before the Emperor's own court of judgement, where I should be tried
- I have done no wrong to the Jews as you yourself know
- If I have broken the law and done something for which I deserve the death penalty, I do not ask to escape it.
- But if there is no truth in the charges they bring against me, no one can hand me over to them. I appeal to the emperor.
- As a Roman citizen he had the right to lay his case before the Emperor Nero himself
- Thus after conferring with his advisers, Festus allowed Paul to go to the Emperor

Paul defends himself before Agrippa 25: 13 – 26: 32

- Before Paul was taken to Rome, various leaders and kings of the country arrived in Caesarea to pay their respect to the new governor (Festus)
- Amongst these were King Agrippa II and his sister Bernice.
- Festus saw the opportunity of consulting a Jew regarding the charges brought against Paul
- He asked Agrippa II to listen to Paul and help him find information for his covering letter to the Emperor since Paul was innocent
- The next day Agrippa came with Bernice and Paul said:
 - I am glad to be able to speak before someone who knows Jewish laws and customs so well as you do.

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- I hope you will understand
- I was brought up to be a strict Jew and became a Pharisee
- I persecuted the believers until God met me on the Damascus road and told me to preach to both Jews and Gentiles
- I teach only what is contained in the law and prophets and for that I am accused: that the Messiah would suffer and die and rise from the dead, so that all people can repent and receive forgiveness of sins and prove it by doing good deeds.
- Jesus proved that he is the messiah by his resurrection
 - Festus shouted that Paul's great learning had made him mad
 - Paul denied it and said to Agrippa that he knew he believed in the prophets
 - Agrippa replied that there wasn't enough proof to make him a believer
 - Both Festus and Agrippa agreed that Paul was innocent
 - However, since Paul had already appealed to the Emperor, they decided to send him there in Rome instead of releasing him

Paul's journey to Rome 27: 1 – 44

- A Roman officer named Julius was appointed to escort Paul to Rome
- Julius was the officer in the Roman Regiment called "The Emperor's Regiment"
- Paul was accompanied by Aristarchus from Thessalonica
- Julius was very kind to Paul. For example, he allowed him to go and see his friends to be given what was needed at Sidon
- They sailed with difficulty up to the Island of Crete.
- Paul advised them to stay there to avoid danger and loss of Cargo until after the winter but he was ignored
- When they continued, the North – Easter wind started blowing and they couldn't control the ship
- They threw everything overboard, including Cargo and completely lost hope of surviving
- Then God told Paul to re-assure them that no one would lose his life and as he himself, he assured that he would stand before Caesar (Jesus saves directly)
- After 14 days they were near the land and some sailors tried to leave the ship by a small boat but Paul prevented them
- He told them to eat and he thanked God for it

- At day break they saw land and as they approached it, the ship struck a rock and it broke up
- The soldiers wanted to all the prisoners, fearing that they would escape, but Julius prevented them from doing so as to save Paul (Theme 9)
- Thus everyone on board (276 in all) reached the board safely

Miracles in Malta, journey to Rome and Paul's preaching 28: 1 – 31

- When they were safely ashore, they learnt that they were on the Island of Malta
- The natives were very friendly to the prisoners as evidenced by
 - welcoming them and making fire for them since it was raining and very cold
 - giving them many gifts which they needed for the voyage
- Note that Paul joined the natives of Malta
- He gathered up a bundle of sticks and put them on fire
- As he was doing that, a snake came out on account of the heat
- And fastened itself to Paul's hand
- The natives saw the snake hanging of Paul's hand and said to one another
- This man must be a murderer, but his fate will not let him live, even if he escaped from the sea
- But Paul shook the snake off into the fire without being harmed at all
- Natives were expecting two things to happen to Paul either
 - To swell up or
 - To suddenly fall down dead
- After waiting for a long time and not seeing anything unusual happening to Paul, they changed their minds and said, "He is a god"

Paul heals Publius father 28: 7 – 9

- Publius father was in bed
- He was sick with fever and dysentery
- Paul went into his room
- Prayed
- Placed his hands on him

- And healed him
- When the people saw this happened, all other sick people on the island came and were healed
- After three months we sailed away on a ship from Alexandria called the Twin Gods
- We arrived in the city of Syracuse and stayed there for three days
- Then we went to Rhegium and in two days we came to the town of Puteoli. The believers asked us to stay there with them for a week
- The believers in Rome heard about us and came as far as the towns of Market of Appius and Three Inns to meet us.
- When Paul saw them, he thanked God and was greatly encouraged

In Rome 28: 16 – 30

- Paul was allowed to live by himself with a soldier guarding him
- After three days Paul called the local Jewish leaders to a meeting
- He said to them
- "My fellow- Israelites, even though I did nothing against our people or the customs that we received from our ancestors, I was made a prisoner in Jerusalem and handed over to the Romans
- After questioning me, the Romans wanted to release me, because they found that I had done nothing for which I deserve to die
- But the Jews opposed this
- I was forced to appeal to the Emperor even though I had no accusation to make against my own people
- I am bound in chains like this for the sake of him for whom the people of Israel hope."
- They agreed to a fix a day when they would hear more about the party of Paul which many people everywhere speak against
- On the agreed day, many people went to where Paul was staying
- From morning till night he explained to them his message about the kingdom of God
- He tried to convince them about Jesus by quoting from the Law of Moses and writings of the prophets
- Some of them were convinced by his words, but others would not believe
- Then Paul said,

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- How well the Holy Spirit spoke through the prophet Isaiah to your ancestors! For he said
- Go and say to this people:
- You listen and listen, but not understand
- You look and look, but not see
- Because this people's minds are dull
- They have stopped up their ears and closed their eyes
- Otherwise, their eyes would see, their ears would hear, their minds would understand, and they would turn to me, says God, and I would heal them.
- Then Paul said, "You are to know, then, that God's message of salvation has been sent to the gentiles. They will listen."
- This shows that salvation is universal.
- Then Paul continued to proclaim the good news for two years

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Chapter 4

THE THEMES IN THE BOOK OF ACTS

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CHAPTER 4: The themes in the book of Acts

Objectives

By the end of this chapter, the students must be able to:

1. State the 9 themes in the book of acts
2. explain the meaning of each theme
3. analyze and relate the themes to stories in the book of acts

Contents

Discussion of the book of acts according to nine themes:

1. God saves mankind through Jesus Christ
2. Jesus works through the Holy Spirit
3. Jesus uses the Church as an instrument of salvation
4. The power of the Holy Spirit is irresistible
5. The Holy Spirit guides the Church
6. The Church shares in the sufferings of Jesus Christ
7. The importance of prayer in the life of the Church
8. Salvation is offered first to the Jews and then to the Gentiles
9. The author's sympathy for the Romans

Meanings of the themes

1. God saves mankind through Jesus Christ

- This means God, the creator, took the initiative and made a plan so that people of this world may be saved or rescued from the danger and consequence of sin (i.e. death)

- This plan was carried out through Jesus Christ by means of his death and resurrection

What did Jesus do so that mankind can be saved?

- Jesus was handed over to ruthless men
- He was crucified and died on the cross
- However, he rose from the dead after three days
- The Apostles were witnesses to these

Read Acts 5: 30 – 32; 3: 13 – 15; 13: 30 – 31 etc

NB: Through Jesus' suffering and death, Jesus suffered for people's sins.

- And through his resurrection, Jesus conquered death which is a result of sin.

Significance of Jesus' death and resurrection

- Jesus' death is important because by doing so he took the punishment for all people's sins upon himself
- His resurrection is important because
 - i. it is a sign that he had conquered death
 - ii. it shows that Jesus is able to raise to life those who believe in him when they die. (Read Acts 10: 40 – 41; 5: 30 – 32; 4: 2; 2: 28)
 - iii. it shows that what he taught was real

What should mankind do so as to be saved?

- People should repent their sins
- They should believe and trust Jesus fully
- They surround their lives with Jesus (Read Acts 16: 13; 26: 19 – 20; 3:19 – 20)
- This is because Jesus himself is directly involved in saving mankind

Key words: Witness and Repentance

2. **Jesus works through the Holy Spirit**

- The theme means Jesus' mission of saving mankind is continuing through the Holy Spirit who works in the hearts and lives of people. Acts 1:8

Who or what is the Holy Spirit?

- This refers to the power of God acting in human beings or nature. Or
- This refers to the third person in the Holy Trinity

a. In the **Old Testament** we see the Holy Spirit doing many things e.g.

- being a creative force
When you give them breath (i.e. HS) they are created Ps 104: 30
- The HS existed before the creation of the world Gen. 1: 1- 5
- Through the HS God is found everywhere (Ps.139: 7 – 12, Is 41:1, Ezekiel 11:1 – 15)
- The Holy Spirit temporarily transforms people into supermen Isaiah 16: 13
- The HS gives power to mankind to do extra ordinary things e.g Jephthah, Samson Elijah, David etc
- The HS rests on certain men permanently Isaiah 1:2

b. In the **Gospel of Luke** we see

- The HS descending on Jesus and guiding him e.g.
 - at his baptism Luke 3: 22
 - during his temptation Luke 4: 1 -2
 - at the beginning of his public ministry Luke 4 : 14
 - his claim in the synagogue at Nazareth Luke 4:18

c. In **Acts of Apostles** we see Jesus working through the HS e.g.

- The HS enabled the disciples to witness for Jesus
- Again and again the HS was given to those who believed. Read Acts 2: 38; 5:32; 15: 1
- The HS transforms the hearts of people

- The HS gives faith, courage
- The HS proves itself visible and active in the life of the Christians
e.g. Acts 4: 23 – 31

Key words: Change and repentance

3. Jesus uses the church as an instrument of salvation

- The theme means that those who believe in and follow Jesus Christ are being used by him to bring salvation to others.
- Thus in Acts we see

a. Jesus using men to spread salvation through words and actions e.g.

- Peter and John prayed and laid their hands on the Samaritans and they received the HS Acts 8: 14 – 18
- Paul laid his hands on disciples of Apollos and they received the HS Acts 19: 6

b. Jesus' healing mission continues through men e.g.

- The healing of the lame man at a beautiful gate Acts 3: 1 – 10
- Peter healed many people through his shadow Acts 5: 15 – 16

c. Jesus uses the church's prayer to enable people do the miracles e.g.

- Peter prayed and Tabitha was raised from the death Acts 9: 40
- The church prayed and Peter was released Acts 12: 1 – 12
- Paul prayed and Publius' father was healed Acts 28: 8

Note that salvation has got **two** aspects namely

- **Physical** salvation
- **Spiritual** salvation

Key words: Refer to all stories where people are **converted** and **healed**.

4. The power of the Holy Spirit is irresistible

- The theme means that where the Holy Spirit is at work nobody or nothing can stop him from carrying out his work
- Thus the disciples of Jesus, in spite of the attempts to stop them from doing so, continued to witness for Jesus because they were filled with the HS who gave them power to witness.
- Indeed the apostles were imprisoned, threatened and even persecuted by their opponents in order to stop them from witnessing for Jesus but the Apostles' mission succeeded.

Examples to show that the power of the HS is irresistible are

- Gamaliel's advice Acts 5: 33 – 39
- Stephen's hearers could not withstand the wisdom with which he spoke Acts 6: 10
- Paul was allowed to preach while waiting for his trial Acts 28: 30 – 31

Key words: Refer to all stories **where disciples witnessed for Jesus** despite **opposition, imprisonment, persecutions, threats etc.**

5. The Holy Spirit guides the church

- > The theme means that those who belong to the Lord (as a group or individuals) are guided by the Holy Spirit in their choices, decisions, actions etc.
- Note that those who are filled with the HS are also sensitive to his guidance.

How is this shown in Acts of Apostles?

a. The HS guides the choice of leaders

- In Acts, leaders were chosen under the guidance of the HS
- And those chosen were filled with the HS e.g. The seven deacons 6: 1 – 13 and Barnabas and Saul 13: 1

b. The HS controls the decision of leaders e.g.

- The meaning of Peter's vision at Joppa Acts 10
- The decision of Jerusalem council Acts 15

c. The HS directs the activities of leaders e.g.

- The HS told Phillip to join the Ethiopian Eunuch Acts 8: 29
- The HS sent Barnabas and Saul off to Cyprus Acts 13:4
- The HS forbade Paul and Silas to preach in the Roman province of Asia Acts 16: 6

Key words: Refer to stories where the HS **controls**, **guides** and **directs** the disciples

6. The church shares in the suffering of Jesus

- The theme means the following
 - The church is Jesus continued on earth
 - Yet Jesus was the suffering servant of Yahweh as expressed in the servant songs of Isaiah
 - Thus the church as Jesus continued on earth should also be the suffering servant
 - Suffering is part and parcel of the church's mission

Note that suffering is not willed by God, however in God's plan of saving mankind Jesus' sufferings were part of his mission of bringing about salvation

Examples in Acts showing how the church continued Jesus' role as the suffering servant

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- The arrest of Peter and John 4: 14
- The council whip the apostles 5: 40
- The death of Stephen 7: 54
- The persecution of the early church 8: 1 – 3; 12: 1 – 4
- Paul is stoned at Lystra
- Etc

Whatever happened to the disciples i.e. their suffering was predicted by Jesus as found in Luke e.g.

- In Luke 6:22 Jesus speaks of the blessedness of those who suffer for his sake
- In Luke 14:27 Jesus says his disciples will have to carry their cross daily

Key words: Refer to all stories where disciples **suffer** in one way or the other

7. Prayer is vital in the life of the church

- The theme means that without prayer the church cannot live or exist
- Prayer refers to spending time with God alone or with others

Illustration of the theme in Acts

a. Christians are those who call on the name of the Lord e.g.

- Peter and John healed a lame man in the name of Jesus 3: 1 – 10

b. The Christians prayed together as a group e.g.

- In the upper room between the ascension and the day of Pentecost 1: 12
- They met regularly for prayer 2: 42
- They prayed for Peter's release 12: 1- 12

c. Christians took part in the Jewish liturgical prayers i.e. in Jewish public worship e.g.

- They prayed together in the Temple 2:46
- Peter and John went to the Temple 3:1

d. The Christians had Eucharistic prayer

- i.e. breaking bread together, eating it and drinking wine during their prayers

e. The Christians prayed at the times when they had important decisions to make e.g.

- when they were selecting a replacement of Judas 1:24
- before sending off Barnabas and Saul on the first missionary journey 13: 3

Key words: Refer to all passages where disciples **pray**

8. The church's mission is universal but first to the Jews and then to the gentiles

Meaning of the theme

- According to Mt. 28: 16 – 20 and Acts 1:8, the church has the task of
 - spreading the gospel
 - witnessing for Jesus
 - making disciples
- This task has to be carried out among the Jews first because
 - Jews were chosen as a light to other nations Acts 3: 26
 - Jesus himself was first sent to the Jews
 - Jesus indicated that the Jews were the first invited in his teaching e.g.
 - i. in the parable of the great banquet Luke. 14

ii. in the parable of the wicked tenants Luke 20

- After preaching the good news to the Jews, the believers preached the same news to the gentiles
- The theme explains how the church witnessed first to the Jews and how the emphasis changed from Jews to the gentiles

Illustration of the theme in Acts

a. To the Jews

- On the day of Pentecost, Peter preached to the Jews of many different countries 2:5 and 3,000 of them became Christians on that day.
- Later the number increased to 5,000

b. The Samaritans (Half Jews)

- As a result of the persecutions after the death of Stephen, Christians in Jerusalem were scattered throughout Judea and Samaria 8:1
- This led Phillip to preach to the Samaritans 8: 4 – 5 with great success 8:8

c. A man who was a student to Judaism

- Phillip met and converted the Ethiopian Eunuch 8:38, who was a follower of Judaism

d. Jews outside Palestine

- When Saul was converted, he preached in the synagogue in Damascus 9: 20
- Many people were converted

e. An individual Roman (The first real gentile convert)

- Peter converted Cornelius 10: 48
- This is given a special place because of the writer's interest in the Romans

f. The gentiles generally

- The first general preaching to the gentiles was done when believers from Cyprus and Cyrene went and preached to the gentiles in Antioch 11: 20.

g. A special mission to the gentiles was established under Barnabas and Saul.

NOTE: Jesus, through the Holy Spirit, guided the apostles to the understanding that salvation is for everyone and that gentiles should not be bound by the Jewish laws Acts 15

Thus in any city, Paul always preached first to the Jews and then to the gentiles. The gentiles, however, made up the majority e.g. in Antioch in Pisidia 13: 46

Key words: Refer to stories where disciples preach first to the Jews and then to the gentiles

9. The author's sympathy to the Romans

- The theme means that the writer of Acts (i.e. Luke) defends the Romans or takes their side
- This is seen in three different ways namely:
 - a. He does not blame the Romans for Jesus' death**
 - It was the will of the Jews and not the Romans to kill Jesus
 - Pilate wanted to release Jesus Luke 23: 13 – 21

b. He speaks well of the Romans e.g.

- The words of the centurion Luke 23: 47
- Cornelius is prayerful and charitable Acts 10: 1 – 4; 21 – 22
- Sergius Paulos, the governor of Cyprus, wants to hear the word of God Acts 13: 4 – 12
- The town clerk of Ephesus saved Paul Acts 19: 23 – 40

c. The Romans treated the Christians better than the Jews treated Christians e.g.

Gallio refused to judge the case of Paul on the ground that it was a private religious matter

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Chapter 5

JESUS FULFILLING OF THE OLD TESTAMENT

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CHAPTER 5: **Jesus fulfilling of the Old testament**

Objectives

By the end of this chapter, the students must be able to:

1. Analyse the concepts of Messiah, Lord and Servant as used in the Old and New Testaments
2. Explain how Jesus Christ fulfils the concepts of Messiah, Lord and Servant

Contents

- The concepts of Messiah, Servant and Lord
 - meaning of the concepts
 - significance of the concepts
- How Jesus Christ fulfils the concepts of Messiah, Lord and Servant
 - comparing the characteristics of Messiah, Lord and Servant as used in the Old and New Testaments
 - discussing how Jesus Christ fulfils the concepts of Messiah, Lord and Servant

Messiah (Isaiah 61: 1 -3 vs. Luke 4: 16 – 22)

The term Messiah is derived from the Hebrew word *Mashiah* which means the Anointed One. In Greek Christos from which derives the English name Christ also means the Anointed One. Note that priests used to anoint (pour oil on) the heads of people who were appointed by God for some special mission.

The name Messiah points to the expected deliverer and is a title that gives hope of salvation. The name Messiah was used by the prophets among

the Jews to point to the one who would come to save the people of Israel from bondage. They perceived the Messiah as the warrior – king like David, a hero chosen by God to bring forth universal peace. In fact they expected the Messiah to be a descendant of David.

Both in the Old and New Testament, the name Messiah has been used in many ways. In Old Testament, it was used by the prophets to refer to a descendant of David who would come to deliver God's people from sin and to bring hope to the world.

For example, in Isaiah 61:1 -3 Isaiah foretold the coming of a deliverer who would save the people of Israel from bondage. This deliverer was the Messiah.

This prophecy came to fulfilment in the New Testament when Jesus read this passage (Luke 4: 16 – 22) at the beginning of his public ministry. Then he told the people that the prophecy in the book of Isaiah had been fulfilled as they heard it being read. By saying this Jesus implied that he was the Messiah who would save the human race from sin and other bondage. The people did not believe him and so they rejected him saying that he is just the son of Joseph the carpenter. They rejected him because they expected a special messiah who would expel the Romans from Palestine and give the Jews their freedom.

Characteristics of the Messiah

- ✓ He is chosen by God
- ✓ He is sent by God
- ✓ He heals the sick
- ✓ He protects the people
- ✓ He gives freedom to prisoners
- ✓ He announces time for salvation

Lord (Psalm 110:1vs. Acts 2 :21; Psalm 16: 8 – 11 vs. Acts 2: 21 – 28)

The word Lord refers to someone who is righteous and dignified. In the Bible the word is used to refer to either God or Jesus.

In Psalm 110:1 the Psalmist says *the Lord said to my Lord, sit here at my right side until I put your enemies under your feet*. This indicates that God himself refers to Jesus as Lord and that Jesus is the Lord over our lives. The Lord is superior to King David and is there to protect us.

In Acts, the Lord is the saviour and it is referring to Jesus. He was killed, buried and rose from the dead on the third day fulfilling what the psalmist said that the faithful servant of God will not rot in the grave. Jesus is therefore superior and divine. He is always present to protect his people (Psalms 16: 8 -11)

Characteristics of the Lord

- ✓ Provides protection
- ✓ Saves people
- ✓ He is present everywhere

Servant (Isaiah 52: 13 – 15, 53: 1 -12 vs. Luke 22-24)

A servant is a person who works for another person, for example one who is employed in a house to perform domestic duties.

In the Old Testament, Israel was viewed as a servant of God in bringing a light to the nations. (Isaiah 49: 3). This implied that Israel was chosen by God to save other nations. In addition, all individuals who were in close relationship with God were called his servants, for example Abraham, Moses David and prophets. In the fourth servant song, there is a description of how the servant (Jesus) will save other nations. He will be mocked, insulted, disfigured and punished and even put to death for doing

no wrong but in the end, He will highly exalted and worshipped by men for He is their saviour.

In the New Testament in Luke chapters 22 – 24, the sufferings of Jesus have been well expressed. He was falsely accused, rejected, bruised, despised and beaten. Later he was killed and buried but after three days in the grave he rose again and ascended into heaven.

Through the death of Jesus, the humanity was saved and forgiven sins. The suffering servant in Isaiah was therefore fulfilled through Jesus' ministry, death and resurrection.

Characteristics of the servant

- ✓ He is rejected and despised
- ✓ He is wounded
- ✓ He is bruised
- ✓ He is devoted
- ✓ He suffers wilfully for the sake of others
- ✓ He is disfigured

Significance of the concepts of Messiah, Lord and Servant

- Jesus is the fulfilment of the Old Testament prophecies
- The broken relationship between God and human beings has been restored through Jesus the Messiah, Lord and Servant
- The concepts of the Messiah, Lord and Servant, strengthened the Christian faith in God and His promises
- Christians are assured of protection from God against their enemies
- The believers are anointed by Holy Spirit as Jesus was, to guide and comfort them in their lives

- Jesus is the redeeming sacrifice on the cross
- Christians acknowledge Jesus as Lord
- Through the concepts of Jesus as Lord, Messiah and Servant, Christians confess their sins and forgive those who do wrong to them.

How Jesus Christ fulfils the concepts of Messiah, Lord and Servant

➤ **Messiah**

- In Isaiah 61:1 it was said, “the spirit of the Lord has filled me with his spirit.” This was fulfilled during Jesus’ baptism when the Holy Spirit anointed him
- At the beginning of his ministry Jesus proclaimed himself as the Messiah as it was predicted in Isaiah 61; 1- 3
- The Messiah was God’s son as the words expressed during Jesus’ baptism
- The Old Testament revealed that the Messiah would be a descendant of David and indeed Jesus was a descendant of David as he was born from the line of Joseph
- Prophet Isaiah said the messiah would have many titles like Immanuel. This is fulfilled in Matthew 1: 22 – 23.

➤ **Lord**

- The Psalmist in Psalms 110:1 refers to Jesus as Lord
- Jesus is Lord because he had power to perform wonders and signs
- Jesus is the Lord because he defeated death and was given a place of honour

➤ **Servant**

- Isaiah predicted the suffering of the servant in the manner Jesus suffered as expressed in Luke chapters 22 – 24.



- He was rejected, sentenced to death, led off to die, crucified, died, buried and rose after three days.
- All these were means of saving mankind from their sins

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Chapter 6

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CHAPTER 6: **Biblical beliefs**

Objectives

By the end of this chapter the students must be able to:

1. Discuss the following Biblical beliefs
 - a. Second coming
 - b. Salvation and judgement
 - c. Life after death
2. Explain the significance of the following Biblical beliefs
 - a. Second coming
 - b. Salvation and judgement
 - c. Life after death

Contents

- Meaning of biblical beliefs
- Second coming
- Salvation and judgement
- Life after death

Meaning of Biblical beliefs

Biblical beliefs are basic Christian beliefs that are central to all Christians. They are based on the Bible and the life and teaching of Jesus. Some of the Biblical beliefs are:

Second coming of Christ (Luke 17: 20 – 37, Luke 21: 25 – 28, Acts 1: 11)

Christians believe that there will be a second coming of Jesus Christ in the future. The second coming of Jesus is the return of Christ as a conquering king. It will be the fulfilment of Christ's own promise and the promises made about Him.

Note that the actual date is not given. Even Jesus himself does not know the day or the hour of his second coming. "No one knows, however, when that day or hour will come – neither the angels in heaven nor the Son, only the Father knows" (Mk. 13: 32).

However, Jesus pointed out that his second coming will be preceded by signs such as: there will be strange things happening to the sun, the moon and the stars. People will be afraid of the roar of the sea and their raging tides. This will make some people faint as they wait for what will happen to them next. After these signs the son of man will appear coming in the clouds with great power and glory.

Salvation (John 3: 16, Acts 4:12)

Salvation is defined as deliverance from things that limit, confine or restrain us. It is freedom from sin and consequences that come with sin. Christians believe that salvation is through believing in Jesus. "Salvation is to be found through him alone, in all the world there is no one else whom God has given who can save us." In Jesus' death and resurrection, Christians are saved.

Life after death (1Thessalonians 4: 13 – 18, John 5: 28 – 29)

In the African tradition, there was a strong belief in the life after death. As a result, the dead were buried with their belongings, a practice that symbolised life after death.

Christians believed in life after death. The Bible clearly talks about life after death. For example, John said a time is coming when all the dead will hear the voice and come out of their graves. Those that died while doing good things will rise and live a happy life while those that did evil will rise and be condemned.

As regards life after death Paul taught the following to the Thessalonians

- Jesus died and rose from dead and God will take back with Jesus those who have died believing in Him
- Those who are alive on the day when the Lord comes will not go ahead of those who had died
- There will be a shout of command, the archangel's voice, the sound of God's trumpet and the Lord himself will come down from heaven
- Those who have died believing in Christ will rise first
- Those who are living at that time will be gathered up together with those raised, in the clouds to meet the Lord in the air
- The two groups will always be with the Lord

Significance of the Biblical beliefs

- Christians are encouraged to face death without fear
- The death and resurrection of Jesus gives hope to the Christians for eternal life
- The belief in judgement day enhances obedience to God
- The beliefs strengthen the faith of Christian in God
- The beliefs confirm the destruction of Satan's kingdom and the establishment of God's kingdom.
- Christians have to be alert because the second coming of Jesus is not known
- Salvation is a gift from God given to us through Jesus Christ

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Chapter 7

BIBLICAL PRACTICES

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CHAPTER 7: Biblical practices

Objectives

By the end of this chapter, the students must be able to:

1. Identify Biblical symbols
2. Explain what the Bible teaches about marriage

Contents

- Meaning of the term symbol
- Describe biblical symbols
 - baptism
 - Holy Communion
- Bible teaches about marriage
 - composition of marriage
 - characteristics of marriage

Biblical practices

These are practices of the Bible that are done by the people that believe in them. Biblical practices include the following:

- baptism
- Holy Communion
- marriage

A. Baptism (Romans 6:3 – 4, Acts 13: 24, Luke 3: 21 – 23)

Water is used for washing and making things clean in our day to day life. Christians use water for baptism as a symbolic act to show that one has turned away from a sinful life and has started a new and cleansed life. One comes of water as a new born. It is a beginning of a new beginning of a sinless life

What happened during Jesus' baptism?

- The heaven was opened
- The Holy Spirit in the form of a dove descended on Jesus
- A voice came from heaven saying "You are my own dear son, I am pleased with you"

Lessons Christians learn about Jesus from his baptism

- Jesus was consecrated to God and officially approved by God for his mission which is shown by the Holy Spirit which came in form of dove with words from his father
- Jesus was a peaceful leader
- Jesus was the son of God
- Jesus' mission was to save mankind
- Jesus identified himself with the sinful human race
- Jesus was a vicariate messiah in the process of saving mankind in fulfilment of God's plan

Importance of baptism to the Christians today

- Baptism strengthen the faith of Christians
- Through baptism, one becomes a child of God
- Baptism enables someone to become a member of the Christian community
- Baptism empowers Christians with the Holy Spirit
- Baptism unites Christians into one body with Christ
- Baptism enables believers share in Jesus' full life
- Baptism is a symbol that people's sins are washed away

Reasons why Christians undergo baptism today

- To follow the example of Jesus
- As a symbol of their repentance
- To identify themselves with Jesus
- A symbol of Jesus death and resurrection
- It enables believers to receive the power of the Holy Spirit

B. The Holy Communion (Mark 14: 22 – 26, Luke 22: 14 – 20)

The Holy Communion is another practice of the Christians celebration. It is symbolised by bread and wine. Just before Jesus was arrested, he had had his last supper with his disciples. It symbolised a new covenant between Jesus and the Christians.

As they were eating, Jesus took a piece of bread, gave a prayer of thanks, broke it, and gave it to his disciples. He asked them to take it, as was his body. He then took a cup gave thanks to God and handed it to them to

drink as blood. They all drank from it. He said the blood would seal God's new covenant.

Note that the bread is the symbol of his body while the wine symbolises his blood which was shed on the cross when he was crucified, it therefore symbolised his death. The disciples were asked to be doing that in memory of Him.

The significance of the Holy Communion to Christians today

- It allows the Christians to have fellowship with one another as they share the meal. It unites Christians.
- It allows the Christians to symbolically share in the death and resurrection of Jesus
- Eating the bread reminds them of the body of Christ and drinking wine reminds them of His blood which was poured out for many
- It gives the Christians hope for eternal life
- It is seen as a thanksgiving meal where Christians renew and rededicate themselves to Jesus
- It renews the faith of the Christians
- It is a symbol of the heavenly banquet which will be shared by the people of God in God's kingdom

C. Bible teaching about marriage

Marriage is a legal union between a man and a woman who are thus referred to as husband and wife.

The Bible teaches that

- Marriage is an important union between a man and a woman
- Marriage is sacred
- Marriage is for procreation (Genesis 1:28)
- Marriage is for companionship (Genesis 2:18)
- Marriage was instituted by God
- Sexual relationship should only take place within marriage
- God condemns same sex marriage (Romans 1: 25 – 27)
- Both husband and wives are responsible for each other (1 Corinthians 7: 4)

Composition of marriage (Romans 1: 25 – 27)

It is composed of a man and a woman. God put Adam and Eve together in a marriage relationship. "That is why a man leaves his father and mother and is united with his wife, and they become one."

Characteristics of marriage (Matthew 5:32, Romans 7:2 -3, Hebrews 13: 4, Matthew 19:3 – 6, Malachi 2: 10 – 16)

- Christian marriage should be permanent. Divorce is not allowed.
- Christian marriage must be monogamous
- Marriage is an institution that is ordained by God.
- Marriage is sacred and that is why people get married in church to get protection and blessings from God
- Marriage is meant for procreation
- Marriage is meant for life long companionship
- A Christian marriage has its foundation in mutual love
- Couples should practice faithfulness and forgiveness. They should pray together, communicate openly and show gratitude to each other.



- Couples should exercise congeal rights to avoid fornication and adultery

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Chapter 8

CHRISTIAN RESPONSE TOWARDS CONTEMPORARY ISSUES

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CHAPTER 8: Christian response towards contemporary issues

Objectives

By the end of this chapter, the student must be able to:

1. Explain the term environmental degradation
2. Explain the role of Christians in conserving the environment
3. Analyse Christian teachings on the relationship between the church and the state
4. Outline indicators of moral decay that lead to the spread of HIV and AIDS
5. Outline Biblical teachings that help to prevent the spread of HIV and AIDS



Contents

- Environmental degradation
 - o Meaning of the term 'environmental degradation'
 - o Role of Christians in conserving the environment
- The church and state
 - o The Christian teaching on the relationship between the Church and state
 - o The role of the Church in the society
- HIV and AIDS
 - o Indicators of moral decay that lead to the spread of HIV and AIDS
 - premarital sex
 - multiple sexual partners
 - prostitution
 - extra-marital sex
 - polygamy
 - same-sex marriages
 - pornography
 - drug and substance abuse
 - o Biblical teachings that help preventing the spread of HIV and AIDS



Environmental Degradation

The term **environment** can be defined as the surroundings or conditions in which a person, animal, or plant lives or operates in.

Environmental degradation refers to the deterioration of the surroundings through depletion of resources, which are essential to human life such as clean water, air and soil. It is the destruction of ecosystems and the extinction of wildlife.

Types of environmental degradation

Some of the ways in which the environment can be degraded include:

1. **Deforestation**

This refers to the wanton cutting down of trees for domestic or commercial use.

2. **Soil erosion**

This is the destruction of the top layer of soil as a result of natural or human activities

3. **Landslides**

This refers to the downward sliding of land on hilly slopes

4. **Floods**

This is the overflow of water from rivers / streams into nearby lands. Flooding is a result of silt that is banked in water water sources which causes water overflow into nearby lands as flood.

5. **Pollution**

This can be defined as an undesirable change in our air, water and ;and resources, which directly or indirectly cause harm to human beings.

Effects of environmental degradation

- Desertification
- Deforestation
- Air pollution
- Climate change
- Loss of biodiversity
- Soil and water pollution

Benefits of conserving of the environment

- Food security
- Clean air
- Elimination of waterborne diseases
- Preservation of indigenous crops
- Fertile soil for conservation

The role of Christians in conserving the environment

(Genesis 1: 1 -2, 31, 2: 15, 3: 1 -24)

In Genesis we are told that God is the creator of the universe. He created the earth and all that is in it. When God looked at all that He had created, He was very happy with His work. He was satisfied that he had created something good.

He then put Adam in the Garden of Eden which had everything that a human being could need, to be in – charge of it by cultivating and gardening it. Adam was supposed to take care of the environment in order to support him and every other living thing He had created. However, Adam disobeyed God and all that privilege was removed from him. Note that evil was not part of as evil and is punishable.

Christians as partners in creation with God have a duty to protect and care for God's environment. Christians use the environment for their survival. There are also other wild animals that live in this environment such as lions, hares, elephants etc. If the environment is destroyed, these wild animals will have no home and that will create chaos in the environment.

The roles Christians can play to conserve the environment include the following:

1. They have to provide civic education to the people on how to protect the environment since it is part of God's creation
2. They should participate in environmental conservation programmes within their communities
3. They should give financial support to the agencies that deal with environmental conservation
4. They should report cases of those who destroy the environment to relevant authorities
5. They should advise on alternative sources of energy for example instead of using charcoal or firewood, they can use biogas.
6. They should protect the water catchment area by practicing afforestation and reforestation programmes
7. They should lobby with the government to come up with strict environmental rules and policies
8. They should practice proper waste disposal

Christian teachings on the relationship between the church and the state (Romans 13: 1 – 14)

The church is a group of believers who have been called out from the world by God to live as his people under the authority of Jesus who is the head of these believers.

The state is an organised political community living under one government

The people in the church and those in the state are both God's people and therefore difficult to separate them. The state is a divine institution because those in leadership positions in government assumed their powers with God's help. As such every Christian has the obligation to respect and obey these lawful authorities. Christians who oppose lawful authority show disobedience to God and they will be judged. Those in the state are working to help those in the church, the church should also work towards helping those in the state.

For example Christians have a duty to pay taxes to the authorities. The authorities use taxes to fulfil state duties. Christians should take the state authorities as God's servants. They should respect and honour them.

The role of the church in the society

- i. To ensure that the society is built on the law of God and that the government of the time rules its people in a Godly way
- ii. To preach the good news to all people through the mass media
- iii. To teach people on the importance of monogamous marriages
- iv. To set up homes to help orphans and HIV and AIDS victims
- v. To educate people about their constitutional rights
- vi. To encourage its members to pay taxes to be used to improve the political, social and economic infrastructure of the nation
- vii. To help in providing health care services
- viii. To promote literacy in the nation by providing education services
- ix. To eradicate poverty through creation of employment and provision of vocational skills such as carpentry
- x. To encourage Christians to exercise their civil rights by voting in an election
- xi. To assist in the rehabilitation of those who break the law by visiting prisoners to give them spiritual and moral guidance.

- xii. To advice politicians on the best ways of dealing with the welfare of the people.
- xiii. To fight against corruption and poor governance
- Etc

Indicators of moral decay that can lead to the spread of HIV and AIDS (1 Thessalonians 4: 4 – 7, Romans 1: 25- 27, Leviticus 20: 10 – 20, Malachi 2: 10 – 16)

Moral decay can be defined as people's lack of understanding of what is good and what is bad. The following are some of the examples of the factors that can help to define a society as having moral decay. These factors can also help in the spreading of HIV and AIDS

A.Premarital sex

This refers to sexual intercourse between unmarried people. It is also known as fornication

Causes of pre – marital sex

- Sexual curiosity where one wants to know what sex is like
- Testing fertility where a man would like to know if he would make his future wife pregnant
- Human weakness
- Girls tolerate it for fear of being left by their boyfriend
- Due to the availability of contraceptives, young girls have no fear of getting pregnant
- Due to unemployment, school leavers engage in premarital sex in order to secure jobs or to make a living
- Negative influence from mass media

Consequences of engaging in pre- marital sex

- Unplanned pregnancies
- Loss of self – esteem and dignity

- Forced early marriages
- Abortion so as to allow one to continue with education
- Contracting sexually Transmitted Infections ((STIs) and HIV and AIDS

B. Multiple sexual partners

This is the practice of having more than one intimate (sexual) relationship at a time

Causes of multiple sexual partners

- Alcoholism and drug abuse
- Uncontrollable desire for sex
- Lack of self control
- Permissiveness in modern society
- Pornography
- Lack of guidance and counselling

Effects of multiple sexual partners

- Infertility among women and high affinity to contracting diseases such as cervical cancer
- It causes anxiety and depression
- It makes one to lack interest in marriage

C. Prostitution

This is the exchange of sex for money. It is also known as commercial sex work. It involves giving one's body for sexual relations to get money or any other form of favour.

Causes of prostitution

- Pornography
- Peer influence

- Women who lavish may practice prostitution to get money for expensive items
- Men who are not sexually satisfied by their wives may turn to prostitution for satisfaction
- Some children who are raised by prostitutes become prostitutes

Effects of prostitution

- It leads to misuse of family resources by married men
- It can cause divorce or separation
- The youth who indulge in the practice may drop out of school
- It lowers one's self – esteem
- It weakens God's purpose of the gift of sex which is for procreation and companionship
- It leads to wide spread of STIs including HIV and AIDS.

Note: Those who engage in prostitution can be helped through guidance and counselling on the dangers of engaging in prostitution.

C.Extra- marital sex

This is when a married person engages in sexual activity with someone other than his or her spouse or partner. It can also refer to a single person having sex with a married person. This act is also known as adultery. This is unacceptable both in Christianity and in the Traditional African set up. In African communities, those who committed adultery faced punishment such as

- Being stoned to death
- Payment of fines
- Loss of leadership position
- Ridicule and mockery in society

- Being excommunicated from the community

Causes of extra – marital sex

- Marital conflicts which may cause violence in a family
- Poverty and unnecessary marital wants by some marriage partners
- Separation for long period due to career demands and imprisonment
- Lack of self control
- Sexual dissatisfaction between married partners
- Poor health of a partner
- Alcoholism and drug abuse

Reasons against extra- marital sex

- It breaks the unity between the a husband and a wife and denies one of his or her congeal rights
- It may lead to unplanned pregnancies
- It makes a wife or a husband to divert their energy elsewhere instead of building the family
- It can lead to the spread of STIs and HIV and AIDS

D.Polygamy

This is a marriage in which a husband has more than one wife at a time. In some cultures, polygamy is tolerated because of reasons such as

- It ensured that every woman got a chance to marry because marriage was compulsory
- It raised the status of a man
- It enabled the man to have children if the first one had none
- It reduced unfaithfulness on the side of the man
- It extended kingship ties
- It was allowed for economic reasons

Christians do not condone polygamy. Reasons

- It is a limitation to the wife's right to sexual relations with her husband
- Faithfulness in polygamous marriage is at stake, and that makes those practicing it to be at risk of contracting and spreading HIV
- The children in polygamous marriage do not enjoy the love of the father
- A wife is usually sexually dissatisfied; urging her to commit adultery and contract STIs including HIV and AIDS
- The supply of basic needs is limited

E.Same – sex marriage

These are marriages of people of the same sex. It includes gay and lesbian relationships which are sexual unions between men and women respectively. The Bible condemns such marriages and the people involved are supposed to be punished by death. The same applies with people having sex with animals.

Causes of same – sex marriages

- Permissiveness in modern society
- Influence of pornographic materials; print and electronic
- Breakdown of traditional African values
- Urbanisation
- Lack of guidance and counselling on proper sexual orientation

Reasons against same- sex marriages

- It cannot lead to procreation as God commanded
- It is only with the opposite sex that sexual intercourse is complete as willed by God.
- It is viewed as an abnormal act because God ordained marriage to be between a male and a female.
- It can cause psychological problems like depression and stress to those involved.
- Those in the same sex marriage may contract diseases such as HIV and AIDS

F.Pornography

This is the explicit portrayal of sexual subject matter for the purpose of sexual arousal. They are either printed or visual materials. The pornographic industries produce sexually explicit materials such as: Books, movies, magazines and video cassettes, paintings, graphics, drawings, sculptures etc

The Bible does not condone such acts because they result into sin which deserves punishment from God. In addition the sin can make the people to contract and spread HIV.

Effects of pornography

- It makes people to turn into masturbation in order to fulfil their sexual desires. this is a sin to God
- It enables men to view women as mere sex objects
- It destroys the beauty of a real woman

- It makes real sex boring
- Spouses view it as infidelity
- Pornographic viewing leads to loss of interest in good family relation
- It alters sexual attitude and behaviour hence a threat to marriage.
- It causes negligence of school work among the youth
- It lowers one's self – esteem
- It may lead to lead irresponsible sexual behaviour like rape and child abuse leading to the spread of STIs and HIV.

G. Drug and substance abuse

A drug is any substance which when taken alters the way the body functions either positively or negatively. To abuse is to put a drug or substance to wrong use other than the intended purpose. The Bible does not allow believers to abuse drugs and substances because doing so can easily lead someone into sin or contracting HIV

Types of drugs commonly abused are

- **Medical drug:** These are drugs prescribed by doctors for varied purposes eg. Sedatives
- **Soft drugs:** These include stimulants and volatile drugs. The volatile drugs cause intoxication in a person. Examples are, glue, valium, Stimulants are drugs that stimulate the brain and central nervous system. They give one more energy and alertness. For example caffeine and tobacco
- **Hard drugs:** These drugs give people false ideas , are strong and are likely to cause addiction. They include bhang, heroin and cocaine

Reasons for drug and substance abuse

- Accessibility and affordability; They are readily available and most people can manage to buy them
- Peer influence
- Print and electronic media influence
- Poverty and unemployment. Those who are poor and unemployed abuse drugs to seek solace out of their frustrations
- Idleness. An idle mind is the workshop of the devil
- Permissiveness in modern society
- Men have abdicated their role as mentors
- Lack of parental care and guidance

Effects of drugs and substance abuse

- It reduces one's reasoning capacity and making him or her prone to making wrong decisions
- It leads to addiction
- It negatively affects the health of the users
- It weakens a person's immune system
- The users become ineffective at their place of work and school too
- Those who drive while under the influence of the drugs may cause road accidents leading to the death of innocent people
- It makes people aggressive
- They are expensive
- They may cause depression, withdrawal and suicide among addicts
- The use of drugs can lead to poor performance in school due to lack of concentration and absenteeism. It can also lead to dropouts.

Biblical teachings that help prevent the spread of HIV and AIDS (1Thessalonians 4:4 -7, Romans 1: 25 – 27, Leviticus 20: 10 – 20,

Malachi 2: 10 – 16, Proverbs 5: 15 – 23, 1 Thessalonians 4: 2 – 8)

There are many ways through which HIV can spread. However most of the people contract the HIV through sexual intercourse with an infected person.

To avoid moral decay and contracting HIV in reference to 1 Thessalonians 4: 4 -7 one has to

- Live a holy life
- Avoid lustful desires
- Avoid adultery

In Romans 1: 25 – 27 people are warned not to value sex more than God. Otherwise doing so is idolatrous in people's lives. Other acts that are undesirable in God's sight are drunkenness, fighting , jealousy, theft, greed etc

In Genesis 1:27 – 28, God condemns the practice of homosexuality

In Leviticus 20: 10 – 20, God condemns incest, adultery and bestiality. Those who practice these acts will face the following judgements:

- They will be put to death
- They will be stoned
- They will be burnt in fire
- They will be excommunicated from the community
- They will bear their sins
- They will die without children



In Malachi 2: 10 – 16 and Mark 10:2 – 11, God

- Condemns divorce
- Approves monogamy as the rightful marriage practice
- Condemns unfaithfulness

In Proverbs 5: 15 – 16, God condemns adultery. Instead He encourages husbands and wives to be faithful to their spouses